ABSTRACT

Title of Dissertation: THE DISTRIBUTION OF BARE NPS IN RUSSIAN: A DYNAMIC ACCOUNT

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Bare nominals in many articleless languages present an interesting case within the typology of (in)definiteness. On one hand, they pattern with indefinites in that they can be used to talk about a discourse-novel individual that non-uniquely satisfies their descriptive content. At the same time, they pattern with definites in that one cannot felicitously use two identical bare nominals in the same context to talk about different individuals. This behavior of bare nominals is challenging for the theory of nominal meaning, as the null hypothesis is that such nominals, lacking any (in)definite counterparts, should freely be used in definite and indefinite contexts.

In this dissertation, I provide a novel account for this phenomenon. Developing my analysis from a case study on Russian, I argue that the null hypothesis is in fact right, and semantically, bare nominals are neutral in terms of (in)definiteness (or, alternatively, they are indefinites that do not convey any “anti-

definite" content); the observed definite-like behavior of bare nominals is due to an independent discourse-level principle that I call Unambiguity Constraint: a nominal cannot be used to introduce or pick out a discourse referent *i* if there is a familiar discourse referent *j* that maps onto another satisfier of that nominal. I show that this constraint not only manages to explain the observed "definiteness effects" but also makes independent predictions leading to novel generalizations about the distribution of introductory and anaphoric uses of bare nominals. I also compare my analysis with previous approaches to bare nominals, arguing that it manages to balance out between different extremes that make the latter either underpredict or overpredict the distribution of bare nominals. Finally, I show that my analysis has a cross-linguistic potential: judging from preliminary data, bare nominals in at least five more articleless languages are compatible with it. I also discuss challenging cases of indefinites that can be used twice in the same sentence to talk about different individuals, and argue that with certain assumptions made, the UC-based approach can account for them as well.

THE DISTRIBUTION OF BARE NPS IN RUSSIAN:
A DYNAMIC ACCOUNT

by

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Dedication

To my family — my mother, my father, my uncle Vitya and my granny Raya — and to my best friend Clara, who became like a sister to me during this PhD journey.

Acknowledgements

My linguistic journey started a long time ago — at the end of middle school, when I got my hands on my first problem set from a linguistic olympiad. After further investigation (going to actual linguistic olympiads, visiting linguistic classes and summer schools for school students), I realized very quickly that this is exactly what I want to do in the future: do research on how this beautiful thing called language works. That Fedya couldn't even imagine that one day he would go to *America* and complete his PhD there. In fact, even when I got an offer from the University of Maryland in March 2021, I still couldn't believe it.

And yet, this journey has led me to this exciting moment, where I am completing my PhD in linguistics at the University of Maryland, College Park. The voice of the impostor syndrome, my frequent guest, is luckily silenced, for the time being, by a much louder sound of gratitude.

I want to begin by warmly thanking my dissertation committee for their incredible level of guidance and for constant academic and personal support.

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more confident and inspired after meetings with you. I have learnt a lot from you and would have struggled way more with organizing my research agenda without your lessons.

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and your constant support helped me feel more secure, validated and seen! I also really liked working as a TA with you; I was really inspired by how you manage to strike a balance between being very nice, kind and friendly to your students and providing them with just the right amount of disciplinary rules so that they can safely learn; I tried to follow your example when I taught my own class for the first time, and hope to continue doing so in the future. And I really hope we will play Catan someday!

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List of Abbreviations

1, 2, 3	persons
ABL	ablative
ACC	accusative
ADD	additive
APPL	applicative
ASP	aspect
ATT	attested evidential
AUG	augment
AUX	auxiliary
CG	common ground
CONJ	conjunctive
COP	copula
D:EXO	exophoric demonstrative
DAT	dative
DEIC	deictic
DEM	demonstrative
DET	determiner
DIM	diminutive
DIMIN	diminutive
DIST	distal
DKP	Derived Kind Predication
DP	Determiner Phrase
DR	discourse referent(s)
DU	dual
EP	epistemic
ERG	ergative
EVID	evidential
EX	existential
EXPL	expletive
F	feminine
FOC	focus
FUT	future
GEN	genitive
IMP	imperative
IMPF	imperfective
IND	indefinite
INF	infinitive
KN	known
LF	Logical Form
LOC	locative
M	masculine
NC	negative concord

NEG	negation
NFIN	non-finite
NOM	nominative / nominalizer
NP	Noun Phrase
NPST	non-past
NSP	non-specific
OOC	out-of-control
PART	particle
PAST	past
PFV	perfective
PL	plural
PNI	pseudo-noun incorporation
POSS	possessive
PR	proximal
PREP	preposition
PRES	present
PRF	perfect
PROG	progressive
PROP	proprietive
PRS	present
PST	past
Q	question
QR	Quantifier Raising
QUD	Question Under Discussion
QUOT	quotative
RECIP	reciprocal
RECIPROC	reciprocal
REL	relative
REP	reportative
S	singular
SE	reflexive / se-clitic
SG	singular
SM	subject marker
SP	subject prefix
SUBJ	subjunctive
TAM	tense–aspect–mood
TOP	topic
UC	Unambiguity Constraint
UKN	unknown
VP	Verb Phrase

Chapter 1. Introduction

1. Research Problem

Sometimes, we use nominal expressions to refer to an entity that we assume the speaker can identify; sometimes, we use nominal expressions without such an assumption. In English, a distinction along these lines is morphologically expressed by the use of articles, *the* and *a.* Nominals with *the*, the *definite* article, are used when the speaker expects the addressee to identify the meant entity on the basis of the property expressed by the nominal; for instance, in (1a), the DP *the dog* is used to refer to a dog that the speaker can identify. In contrast, nominals with *a,* the indefinite article, are used when the speaker does not expect the addressee to identify the meant entity; for instance, in (1b), the DP *a dog* is used to talk about a dog whose identity is not necessarily recoverable from the preceding discourse.

(1) a. *I saw* ***the dog*** *yesterday.*

b. *I saw* ***a dog*** *yesterday.*

Not all languages express this contrast formally, however. For instance, Russian, my native language, does not have articles like *a* or *the*, and nominals can occur *bare* in argumental positions, without any audible determiner. Such bare nominals (in Russian and in other articleless languages) can sometimes be used like definites and sometimes — like indefinites, as illustrated in (2). In (2a), the bare NP *sobaka* 'dog' is used like a definite, to talk about a concrete dog whose identity is clear from the preceding discourse — that is, the speaker's dog their friend, the addressee, asked about. In contrast, in (2b), the bare NP *sobaka* 'dog' is used like an indefinite, to talk about a dog whose identity is not expected to be known by the speaker: not only has it not been salient in the preceding discourse, but it is also not even a unique dog within the speech act scenario.

(2) a. Scenario. Your friend asks you how your (only) dog is doing.

Sobaka *nakonec-to* *vyzdorovela.*

dog finally recovered

'The dog finally recovered.'

b. Scenario. In the street, there are many dogs that the speaker and the hearer do not know.

Na *ulice* *sobaka* *lajet.*

on street dog barks

'In the street, a dog is barking.'

As bare nominals can be used both like *the*-DPs and *a*-DPs, it is natural to assume, as a null hypothesis, that they are neutral with respect to (in)definiteness. Their semantic analysis, then, should mirror that fact by being as permissible as possible, allowing them to be used in both definite and indefinite contexts. Led by this reasoning, Heim (2011) proposed that bare nominals in articleless languages are semantically existential quantifiers, like in (3), which do not have any semantic restrictions related to the identifiability of their witness. Pragmatically, these existential quantifiers can then be used both like definites — to refer to an individual *i* identifiable by the addressee, or like indefinites — to talk about an individual *i* that the addressee is not expected to identify.

(3) $[\![N_{arg}]\!] = ex([\![N]\!]) = \lambda V_{<e,t>}.\exists x\, [[\![N]\!](x)\ \&\ V(x)]$

There is, however, a serious empirical challenge to this attractively simple analysis: in many articleless languages, including Russian, the distribution of indefinite uses of bare nominals is limited. Namely, while a standalone bare nominal can felicitously be used to introduce a novel entity in the discourse and does not require it to be unique with respect to its descriptive content, two identical NPs uttered within the same local context cannot get witnessed by different individuals, or in other words, they can only be used co-referentially.

This pattern is illustrated in (4-5). First, compare (4a) and (4b). While the bare nominal *sobaka* 'dog' can felicitously be used like an indefinite under the provided scenario (that is, to talk about a dog that has not been already mentioned in the conversation and is not the only dog in the context), like in (4a), another bare nominal *sobaka* cannot be felicitously used later to talk about another dog in the scenario, like in (4b); only cases like in (5), where the two bare nominals are used to talk about the same dog, are felicitous.

(4) Scenario. There are two dogs in the street unknown to the speaker and the hearer, one of them is barking, the other one is sleeping.

a. *Na ulice lajet sobaka.*
on street dog barks
'In the street, a dog is barking.'

b. #*Na ulice lajet sobaka i ryčit sobaka.*
on street dog barks and growls dog
Expected: 'In the street, a dog is barking and a dog is growling.'

(5) {—How is your dog doing?}

Sobaka	*zdorova,*	*s*	*sobakoj*	*vsë*	*xorošo.*
dog	healthy	with	dog	all	good

'The dog is healthy, everything is ok with the dog.'

The contrast like in (4-5) is cross-linguistically common: at least bare NPs in **Hindi** (Dayal 2004), **Kazym Khanty** (Golosov 2024b; Tiutiunnikova et al. 2025), **Xhosa** (Carstens et al. 2026), **Cuzco Quechua** (Sánchez et al. 2026) and **Cabo-Verdean Creole** (Baptista & Dayal 2026) are known to behave the same way.

2. My proposal

The observed limitation of the indefinite uses is challenging for the simplistic existential quantifier analysis of bare nominals in (3), according to which sentences like (4b) should be fine, just like sentences as in (4a). Does this mean that we need to abandon it?

In this dissertation, I will argue that no, we need not. Namely, I will argue that the Heim-style semantic analysis of bare nominals, according to which they are existential quantifiers, is in fact correct, and that their indefinite uses are limited by an independent dynamic pragmatic principle of reference resolution, which I call the Unambiguity Constraint. Simplifying a bit, the UC requires that the discourse referent the bare NP is used to pick out or introduce must be the only available one satisfying the descriptive content of the NP; a more formal version of this is provided in (6).

(6) **The Unambiguity Constraint (Generalized Informational Uniqueness)**

In the context c, a (bare) NP that lexicalizes a predicate P can be used to pick out a discourse referent i iff there is no j distinct from i such that j is entailed by c to also satisfy P.

The UC is a generalized version of the informational uniqueness constraint proposed by Roberts (2003) to account for the distribution of anaphoric definites in English: the only difference is that while English definites can only pick out given discourse referents, Russian bare NPs can also be used to introduce novel ones if they will be informationally unique (that is, if no given discourse referent satisfies the descriptive content of the bare NP).

As I will argue, the proposed two-fold analysis, which I will call the UC-based approach from now on, accounts for the challenging behavior of bare NPs demonstrated by the contrast(s) in (4-5). First, it correctly predicts that a bare NP can felicitously be used to introduce a novel discourse referent as long as there are no discourse referents already given in the context that also meet the bare NP's descriptive content. This is exactly the case in (1a): a bare NP *sobaka* 'dog' is felicitously used to introduce a novel discourse referent representing a dog individual because there are no given discourse referents representing some other dogs (there are other dogs in the scenario, but they are not introduced as discourse referents, so the UC is not violated). Second, it correctly predicts that if two identical bare NPs are uttered within the same context, they can only be understood as picking out the same discourse referent. This accounts for the contrast between (1b) and (2). In (1b), the use of the second bare NP *sobaka* 'dog' violates the UC: the context already has a discourse referent representing another dog individual, so the same bare NP cannot be used the second time to introduce a new discourse referent that represents another dog. In (2), on the other hand, the second bare NP is used to pick out the same discourse referent as in the first case, so the informational uniqueness requirement is not violated.

Thus, in short, my account represents the following idea: bare nominals are semantically indefinite, and their apparent definite-like behavior in cases like (1b-2) is just a side effect of a general pragmatic principle that dictates that an introduced or picked discourse referent must be informationally unique with respect to the descriptive content of the used nominal.

3. Roadmap

My dissertation is structured as follows.

First, here in Chapter 1, I outline the goals, preliminary results and the plan of my thesis.

After that, in Chapter 2, I will, building on previous studies of Russian bare NPs, provide their semantic analysis, arguing that they are variable-scope island-sensitive indefinites. I will show that they can be used to introduce novel discourse referents and do not require the context to have a unique satisfier of their predicate, although, in absence of a definite competitor, they can also be used to pick out familiar discourse referents and appear in contexts where there is a unique individual meeting their descriptive content. I will also show that they have variable scope but, in contrast to, for instance, *a*-indefinites in English, cannot escape islands.

Then, in Chapter 3, I will provide the pragmatic part of my analysis, arguing that the indefinite uses of bare NPs are subject to the dynamic pragmatic principle of reference resolution, the Unambiguity Constraint. I will show that in addition to the data in (4-5), this pragmatic analysis correctly predicts the distribution of anaphoric and introductory uses of bare NPs more generally. I will also discuss some cases where two bare NPs uttered within the same sentence can nevertheless get witnessed by different individuals. I will pursue a hypothesis that in all such cases, each of the bare NPs is interpreted within its own domain of evaluation/local context and hence does not violate the UC which is also applied locally.

After discussing my analysis in Chapters 2 and 3, in Chapter 4 I compare it with previously proposed approaches to the (in)definiteness of bare nominals. Those can be clustered into two groups: "restrictive semantics" approaches which analyze bare nominals as semantically (weak) definites, and "loose pragmatics" approaches which analyze them as unrestricted indefinites. I will show that the UC-based analysis incorporates the key theoretical insights from both lines of approaches and puts them together in a compatible way. More specifically, it follows definiteness-based analyses in acknowledging that bare nominals in Russian are subject to a uniqueness requirement, but, in contrast to the previous proposals, implements this requirement as an independent discourse-level constraint rather than as a part of their truth-conditional meaning. At the same time, it follows indefiniteness-based analyses in assuming that bare nominals are semantically indefinite. Thus, the analysis implements the two key insights from previous proposals: bare nominals are indefinite semantically, but are subject to a pragmatic constraint, which also restricts definites, and is responsible for their definite-like properties.

In Chapter 5, I will address the cross-linguistic implications of my analysis. I will start with showing that the UC-based approach, according to which bare nominals are indefinites but are subject to the informational uniqueness constraint on reference resolution, is applicable not only to Russian, but also to bare NPs in five other articleless languages (Kazym Khanty, Hindi, Xhosa, Cuzco Quechua and Cabo-Verdean Creole). After that, I will address challenging data from indefinites that can form anti-unique sequences, like *a*-indefinites in (4a). I will suggest that such indefinites do not, in fact, violate the UC; instead, they covertly restrict their domain to a single individual, making it informationally unique regardless of the preceding discourse. As I will show, this is not an ad-hoc stipulation: all the observed indefinites that "violate" the UC also feature so-called "exceptional scope" readings (Fodor & Sag 1982 et seq.), and a covert domain restriction analysis has been independently proposed for such indefinites to account for their ability to "escape" islands without postulating an actual movement (e.g. Reinhart 1997; Winter 1997; Kratzer 1998; Schwarzschild 2002). I will then discuss whether, in contrast, indefinites that *cannot* "violate" the UC also cannot get "exceptional scope" readings, as we would expect in this case; I will show that this generalization is compatible with the data from Russian, Hindi, Cuzco Quechua and Cabo-Verdean Creole, but there are certain challenges from Kazym Khanty and Xhosa that need to be addressed.

Finally, in Chapter 6, I will summarize the conclusions of this study and outline directions for future research, as well as challenges for the proposed account that need to be resolved.

Chapter 2. Bare NPs in Russian: semantics

In this chapter, I will provide the semantic part of my account of bare NPs in Russian, arguing that they are variable scope island-obeying indefinites that do not have anti-uniqueness or anti-familiarity restrictions.

The structure of the chapter is as follows. I will start with Section 1, where I will set the stage for my study, that is, report the relevant basic facts about the grammar of Russian and define and motivate the scope of my research. After that, in Section 2, I will argue that Russian bare NPs are unrestricted indefinites: they can introduce novel discourse referents and do not have a uniqueness/maximality presupposition but also can be used anaphorically and can be used to talk about individuals that are known to be unique or maximal with respect to their descriptive content. This will be followed by Section 3, where I will argue that bare NPs in Russian can take variable scope but obey island constraints. Finally, in Section 4, I will summarize the findings and propose to analyze Russian bare nominals as existential quantifiers over individuals. At the end of this section, I will discuss a new data point that does not follow from the proposed semantic analysis: a co-reference requirement posed on a chain of identical bare NPs uttered within the same local context. I will argue, however, that this requirement is dynamic in nature, and will announce my pragmatic analysis that awaits in the next chapter.

1. Setting the stage

1.1. Relevant basic information

In this section, I will overview basic aspects of Russian grammar relevant for the current study. I will start with showing that Russian features the classic number and count-mass distinctions in the nominal domain in Section 1.1.1. In Section 2.1.2, I review the determiner system in Russian, showing that it is an articleless language. Finally, in Section 2.1.3, I will discuss how the word order and focus structure of a sentence in Russian affects the interpretation of nominals.

1.1.1. Number and count/mass distinctions

Just like in English, nouns in Russian have two numbers: singular and plural. There are no separate number morphemes: the number is encoded together with the case, as shown in (6).

(7) ***sobak-a*** [dog-NOM.SG] ‘dog’ — ***sobak-i*** [dog-NOM.PL] ‘dogs’

Russian does not morphologically mark the distinction between count and mass NPs. As in English, mass nouns are morphologically singular and can only get the plural form under sortal readings (if available), (8).

(8) ***vod-a*** [water-NOM.SG] ‘water’ — ***vod-y*** [water-NOM.PL] ‘waters (sorts of water)’

The singular number in Russian, when used with count NPs, marks that the number of the NP’s satisfiers is exactly one. The plural number marks that the cardinality of the NP’s satisfiers is not necessarily one, which in most cases, due to competition with the singular number, means ‘more than one’, as in (9a). In the context where the competitor with the singular form does not appear to be a stronger alternative, the plural form is understood as ‘number-neutral’, as in (9b), where the sentence is only true if the speaker saw no dogs whatsoever (in particular, if the speaker saw a single dog, this sentence is still false)[1].

(9) a. *Na ulice lajut sobaki.*

on street bark dogs

'In the street, dogs (more than one) are barking.'

b. *Ja ne videl sobak na ulice.*

I NEG saw dog on street

'I didn't see (any) dogs in the street.'

To sum up, while there are some differences in the morphological marking, the singular and plural numbers in Russian are interpreted the same way as their English counterparts.

1.1.2. Determiner system

The determiner system in Russian comprises various kinds of definite and indefinite markers: see, for instance, the determiner *odin*[2] that forms specific indefinite DPs (10a), the series of pronouns with *-to* and *koe-* expressing different sorts of epistemic indefinite readings (10b, 10c), anaphoric uses of demonstratives *etot* 'this' and *tot* 'that' (10d).

(10) a. *Maša vyšla zamuž za* ***odnogo*** *lingvista.*

Masha went in_marriage for one linguist

[1] There is an extensive amount of literature concerning the essence of number-neutral uses of the plural morpheme (Sauerland 2003; Sauerland et al. 2005; Spector 2007; Zweig 2009; Ivlieva 2013, a.m.o.). While most of this work is based on English data, to the best of my knowledge, the plural number in Russian behaves the same exact way.

[2] The same word is used as a numeral 'one': *daj mne* ***odin*** *apel'sin* 'give me ***one*** orange'.

‘Masha married a specific linguist.’ (Ionin 2012: 77)

b. ***Kakoj-to*** *student* *spisyval* *na* *ekzamene.*

which-*to* student cheated on exam

‘Some student [not known to the speaker] cheated on the exam.’ (Geist 2008: 154)

c. ***Koe-kakoj*** *student* *spisyval* *na* *ekzamene.*

koe-which student cheated on exam

‘Some student [known only to the speaker] cheated on the exam.’ (Geist 2008: 154)

d. *Ja* *kupila* *knigu* *včera.* ***Éta*** *kniga* *byla* *dorogaja.*

I bought book yesterday this book was expensive

‘I bought a book yesterday. The book was expensive.’ (Ahn 2019: 37)

The list of determiners mentioned above is far from being exhaustive. What matters, however, is that all the determiners in Russian are optional and have a quite specific meaning and hence narrow distribution. Russian does not have classic articles like *a* or *the*, and argumental NPs can appear determiner-less (henceforth *bare*), as in (11).

(11) *Devočka* *smejots’a*

girl laughs

‘A/the girl is laughing.’

Given that articles are usually defined as obligatory markers of the NP’s referential status (see e.g. Becker 2021 for an overview), Russian is an instance of a language without articles, or an **articleless** language.

1.1.3. Information structure

Russian is famously a language with free word order. However, differences in the word order, combined with differences in the focus placement, affect the informational structure of the sentence. In this section, I will discuss a subset of the word order and the focus structure patterns that directly concern the interpretation of arguments, bare NPs in particular.

A famous observation mentioned and discussed in (Pospelov 1970; Fursenko 1970; Chvany 1973; Dayal 2004; Geist 2010; Seres & Borik 2018, a.m.o.) is that the linear position of the argumental NP with respect to the verb affects its interpretation. Namely, pre-verbal NPs tend to receive definite interpretation, while post-verbal NPs typically receive indefinite interpretation, as in (12).

(12) a. ***Kniga*** *ležit* *na* *stole.*

book lies on table

'**The book** is on the table.' (Seres & Borik 2018: vi)

b. *Na* *stole* *ležit* ***kniga***.

on table lies book

'There is **a book** on the table.' (Seres & Borik 2018: vi)

This difference in the interpretation is an instance of a more general pattern of the Russian informational structure: the constituents occurring pre-verbally are typically interpreted as topics, while post-verbal elements are typically a part of the comment (Geist 2010; Jasinskaya 2016; Seres & Borik 2018). Topicality requires familiarity and comment normally brings about new information, hence topic NPs are definite and the ones within the comment are indefinite.

The correlation with the word order discussed above is not a rule, however. In particular, pre-verbal NPs can be indefinite. This is possible if the topic position is either occupied by another constituent[3] or wholly absent (Geist 2010). The first case is illustrated in (13a): in this sentence, the topic position is occupied by a spatial adverbial, and the subject NP is naturally interpreted as indefinite. The second case comprises *thetic statements*, that is, utterances containing only new information, and is exemplified in (13b).

(13) a. *Na étoj kartine* ***devuška*** *čitajet pis'mo.*

on this painting lady reads letter

'On this painting, **a lady** is reading a letter.' (Geist 2010: 204)

b. ***Meteorit*** *upal!*

meteorite fell

'**A meteorite** came down!' (Geist 2010: 204)

To sum up, what we learn in this section is that in Russian, the interpretation of argumental bare NPs, in particular their ability to get an indefinite reading, is restricted by the information structure of the sentence. Namely, bare NPs can get indefinite readings only if they do not occupy the topic position in the sentence, which is located at the left periphery of the clause. When they do occupy the topic position, only the definite interpretation is available.

[3] Geist (2010) argues that only frame adverbials (that is, adverbials situating the described event in space or time) can be topics preceding pre-verbal indefinite subjects. According to my own data, other types of constituents can also occupy this slot. For instance, in (i), the topic position is occupied by the object, but the pre-verbal subject still receives an indefinite interpretation.

(i) *Pet'u* ***sobaka*** *pokusala!*

P. dog bit

'**A dog** bit Petya (Petya was bit by a dog).'

Thus, the informational structure of the sentence is an important control parameter in testing the (in)definiteness of bare NPs. In doing so, I will only use examples where bare NPs do not occupy the topic position, to avoid the "definiteness effect" this position provides.

1.2. Scope of the study

Bare nominals in Russian can function as **names** (like in (14a), where the bare NP *Moskva* 'Moscow' is used as a name associated with the capital city of Russia) and can denote **kinds** (like in (14b), where the bare NP *čelovek* 'human' is used to talk about the human species as a whole) and **masses** (like in (14c), where the bare NP *kaša* 'porridge' is used to talk about an object represented as a non-atomic substance). In this dissertation, however, I set such uses of bare NPs aside and focus exclusively on **object-level count bare nominals**, exemplified in (14d), where the bare NP is used to talk about an individual represented as an atomic object.

(14) a. *Ja* *rodils'a* *v* ***Moskve**.*

I be.born in Moscow

'I was born in Moscow.'

b. ***Čelovek*** *proisošël* *ot* *obez'jany.*

human evolved from ape

'The human evolved from the ape.'

c. *Pet'a* *jest* ***kašu**.*

P. eats porridge

'Petya is eating (the) porridge.'

d. *Vas'a* *sjel* ***jabloko***.

V. ate apple

'Vasya ate the/an apple.'

This limitation of the research scope is guided by practical considerations. Namely, the studies on (in)definiteness and reference in general are mostly based on the data from nominals lexicalizing predicates over atomic object-level individuals, and it is easier to start developing a novel analysis by working on the most well-understood type of data. Of course, the data on the other uses of bare nominals mentioned here should be taken into consideration in the future research.

2. Russian bare NPs: indefiniteness

In this section, I will argue that bare NPs in Russian are unrestricted indefinites: they can introduce novel discourse referents and do not require their referent to be maximal/unique with respect to its descriptive content, but also can pick out already given discourse referents and do not mind if their referent happens to be unique/maximal with respect to their predicate. I will start with theoretical background on (in)definiteness in Section 2.1 and then will discuss the Russian data in Section 2.2.

2.1. What is (in)definiteness?

The category of (in)definiteness was developed as a theoretical response to explain the semantic contrast between English articles *a* and *the* and their counterparts in other languages. The core difference between definite and indefinite NPs can be informally stated in terms of recoverability of their reference (Dawson & Jenks 2023). The referent[4] of a definite NP must be identifiable from the context: by the time of utterance, the addressee should have no problem mapping the DP with the meant individual or entity. For instance, in (15), the definite NP *the moon* has a clearly identifiable referent: the Earth's only natural satellite.

(15) *John looked at the moon and smiled.*

In contrast, an indefinite NP does not necessarily have recoverable reference. The speaker can use it to speak about a referent non-identifiable by the addressee, or even to speak about a particular type of entity in general. For instance, in (16), the indefinite NP *an American* can be understood either as referring to a specific American the addressee does not know or cannot unambiguously identify or as just mentioning the type of person the speaker wants to marry.

(16) *I want to marry an American.*

In the next two sections, I will discuss the key semantic properties and different types of definites and indefinites cross-linguistically.

2.1.1. Definites

There is disagreement between different approaches on how exactly the key feature of definites, recoverability of the reference, should be characterized in stricter terms. One family of accounts argues that definiteness is maximality/uniqueness of the denoted individual with respect to the definite's descriptive content (Frege 1892; Russell 1905, a. o.). In contrast, another group of approaches insists that definiteness is familiarity of the NP's referent to the speech act participants:

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[4] Hereafter, unless otherwise stated, I use the term *referent (of an expression)* informally, as a short way of saying 'an entity the speaker meant to map the expression onto'.

the addressee is expected to know what the speaker means to refer to (Strawson 1950; Kamp 1981; Heim 1982, a. o.). Finally, more recent approaches suggest that definites are in fact semantically ambiguous (Schwarz 2009 et seq.): so-called *weak definites* require maximality, and so-called *strong definites* require familiarity. These last approaches, initially proposed for classic *the*-definites in English, have been proven useful in cross-linguistic perspective: while English definite article *the* forms both types of the definites, many languages feature definiteness markers that only lexicalize one of the meanings. Let me now elaborate on what exactly these two types of definites are.

Weak definites[5], also known as **unique definites** (Dawson & Jenks 2023), pose a maximality requirement on their referent. Namely, they require that their referent should be the maximal entity satisfying the predicate of their restrictor (that is, the NP). Some English *the*-NPs behave as weak definites, as illustrated in (17). In (17a), the definite NP *the girls* refers to *all* the girls from John's class: the sentence is false[6] if John saw only some of his female classmates. Likewise, in (17b),

[5] Note that the term "weak definite" has another common use in the linguistic tradition: it is used to describe special uses of definites that occur inside VPs denoting well-established activities, as in (i), where such definites appear to lack the uniqueness requirement (Carlson et al. 2006). For instance, the sentence (i) is still felicitous even if there are multiple windows in the room.

(i) *Someone needs to open the window.* (Dawson & Jenks 2023: 115)

Most accounts of such definites defend the view that apparent lack of the uniqueness requirement is in fact an illusion, see (Schwarz 2009) for the discussion.

[6] In fact, predications involving definite plurals sometimes allow non-maximal interpretations. Such readings arise when it is irrelevant for the main point of the utterance whether all members of the set participated in the event or not. For instance, in the provided context, (i) is still true even if only some of the windows are open: the point the speaker makes is that opened windows make the house vulnerable for the storm, even if there are other windows that are closed. For more discussion, see (Malamud 2012; Magri 2014; Bar-Lev 2018; 2021; Križ 2016; Križ & Spector 2021, a.m.o.).

(i) {Mary has a large house with over a dozen windows in different rooms. She locks up and leaves to go on a road trip with her friend Max, forgetting to close just a few of the many windows in various rooms. A few minutes into the ride, Max says, "There is a thunderstorm coming. Is the house going to be OK?" Mary replies:}

*Oh my, we have to go back — **the windows** are open!* (Malamud 2012: 4) *the water* refers to all the water John had in his bottle: this sentence is infelicitous if some of the water was of a different color.

(17) a. *John saw the girls from his class yesterday.*

b. *The water in John's bottle was green.*

In the case of weak definite (count) singulars, the maximality requirement is realized as the *uniqueness* requirement: the referent of a weak definite singular should be the only individual available in the context that satisfies the NP's predicate. For instance, the sentence in (18) implies that the girl John saw yesterday is his only female classmate. It would be infelicitous in a context where there are other girls in his class.

(18) *John saw the girl from his class yesterday.*

Of course, the maximality/uniqueness requirement is not always global: in many cases, it is bound by the contextually salient domain. For instance, in (19a), the speaker of course does not mean that the dog they mentioned is unique in the whole world: they simply mean that the dog is unique in whatever 'there' is, likely someone's house or backyard. After Hawkins 1978, such uses of definites are called *immediate situation uses*, contrasted with the *large situation uses* where the domain of the maximality requirement is global[7], as in (b): the sun is a globally unique object.

(19) a. *Don't go in there, chum.* ***The dog*** *will bite you.* (Hawkins 1978: 112)

b. ***The sun*** *is shining.*

[7] Of course, strictly speaking, even larger situation definites do not always refer to the entities that are unique/maximal within *the whole universe*. For instance, even the referent of *the sun* in (19b) is not the unique object satisfying the predicate: there are many other suns in other galaxies. However, what still differs larger situation definites from immediate situation ones is that their domain restriction is not defined by the local situation in which the speech act takes place. For instance, while English Prime Minister is not the only prime minister in the whole world, the sentence in (i), uttered in the UK, does not require any local contextual knowledge to understand who you are referring to.

(i) *The Prime Minister has just resigned.* (Hawkins 1978: 116)

Strong definites, also known as **anaphoric definites**, do not always have a maximality requirement as their weak counterparts, but their referent must be *familiar* to the addressee. Namely, it should be introduced by another NP in previous discourse or at least be salient in the speaker and the addressee's common ground. Consider, for example, the behavior of the strong definite *di* in Fering dialect of Frisian (Germanic). As shown in (20a), having the uniqueness requirement met is not enough for its licensing: even though it's common knowledge that the (contextually recoverable) store has just one grocer, this grocer was not mentioned in the prior discourse. In contrast, the strong definite is licensed in (20b) because its referent was introduced in the previous sentence, by an indefinite *an hingst* 'a horse'.

(20) a. *Ik skal deel tu a/* ****di*** ***kuupmaan**.*

I must down to the$_{\text{weak}}$ the$_{\text{strong}}$ grocer

'I have to go down to **the grocer**.' (Schwarz 2009: 13, Ebert 1971:161)

b. *Oki hee <u>an hingst</u> keeft.* ***Di hingst*** *haaltet.*

Oki has a horse bought the$_{\text{strong}}$ horse limps

'Oki has bought <u>a horse</u>. **The horse** limps.' (Schwarz 2009: 13, Ebert 1971:161)

Once again, strong definites do not require their referent to be the maximal or the unique individual meeting their descriptive content, as long as it is the most salient one in the discourse. Consider an example from German, where the difference between weak and strong uses of the definite article is marked by the possibility of contraction (Schwarz 2009). In this short narrative, a discourse referent for the book about topinambur is introduced in the first clause and then is referred to by the strong definite *dem Buch*. The uniqueness requirement is clearly not satisfied (there are many other books in the library), which makes the use of the weak article here infelicitous, as predicted.

In contrast, the use of the strong definite is possible: even though there are many books in the context, only one of them is salient and introduced in the prior discourse.

(21) *In der New Yorker Bibliothek gibt es ein Buch über Topinambur.*
in the New Yorker library exists EXPL a book about topinambur
Neulich war ich dort und habe #***im/*** ***in dem Buch*** *nach*
recently was I there and have in-the$_{weak}$ in the$_{strong}$ book for
einer Antwort auf die Frage gesucht, ob man Topinambur grillen kann.
an answer to the question searched if one topinambur grill can

'In the New York public library, there is a book about topinambur. Recently, I was there and looked **in the book** for an answer to the question of whether one can grill topinambur.'

(Schwarz 2009: 240)

Thus, cross-linguistically, definite NPs are presented in two forms, sometimes lexicalized within the same marker: weak definites whose recoverability of the reference is ensured by the maximality requirement, and strong definites whose recoverability of the reference follows from the familiarity of the referent to the speaker. Of course, the cross-linguistic typology of definites is not limited to the familiarity vs. maximality contrast. For example, languages with articles differ in whether a definite article can be attached to a proper name, and if yes, whether it is a special article or not. Articles that can only accompany (or form) proper names are called *proprial articles*. For instance, Māori (an Eastern Polynesian language) has a proprial article *a* that is different from the "usual" singular definite article *te*, as shown in (22).

(22) *kātahi rā anō* ***a Puhihuia*** *ka whakaaro,* ***te kotiro*** *o*
then DIST again PROP Puhihuia TAM decide the girl of
te rangatira*…*

the chief

'… then Puhihuia, the daughter of the chief… decided…'. (Bauer 2003: 142-144)

In addition to that, some languages lexicalize dedicated *exophoric definites*, that is, definites that require the speaker to point to their referent. For instance, the exophoric demonstrative *míi* in Marka-Dafing (a Mande language) is obligatorily accompanied with the pointing gesture.

(23) *wúrú dog !míi*

dog D:EXO

'this/that dog' (pointing) (Jenks & Konate 2022)

Even more different types of definites are distinguished in typology-oriented works (Becker 2021; Dawson & Jenks 2023, a.m.o.). However, the two types of definites we dedicated most of the time in this section to, weak and strong ones, form the conceptual core of the definites as a category.

In the Section 2.2, I will show that bare NPs in Russian can behave like both weak and strong definites, that is, they can denote individuals maximal with respect to their descriptive content and can pick out already introduced and salient discourse referents. I will argue, however, that they do not have the definite *meaning*: I will analyze them as unrestricted indefinites that can simply "tolerate" contexts that typically license definite NPs. To see how this is possible, we now need to proceed with discussion of indefinites.

2.1.2. Indefinites

As we discussed in the previous section, definites typically require either maximality or familiarity of their referent to ensure its recoverability. In contrast, indefinites do not have these requirements.

First, indefinites can be used to talk about individuals that are not maximal or unique with respect to their descriptive content. For instance, the sentence in (24a) is perfectly fine even if there are more dogs in the street, as long as one of them is barking. Likewise, the sentence in (24b) is fine even if there are other dogs in the street that are not barking.

(24) a. *Mom, a dog is barking in the street!*

b. *Mom, dogs are barking in the street!*

Second, indefinites can introduce new discourse referents. We already saw an example of this when we talked about strong definites: in (20b), repeated here as (28), the indefinite *an hingst* introduces a new horse referent, not necessarily known by the hearer. This referent is then picked out by the strong definite *di hingst*, as we discussed in the previous section. Looking at the translation in English, you can see that English *a*-indefinites behave the exact same way.

(25)	Oki	hee	**an**	**hingst**	keeft.	Di	hingst	haaltet.
	Oki	has	a	horse	bought	the_{strong}	horse	limps

‘Oki has bought **a horse**. The horse limps.’ (Schwarz 2009: 13, Ebert 1971:161)

The properties of indefinites we just discussed are usually referred to as *non-uniqueness* and *novelty* correspondingly. According to the most influential view of Heim (2011), these semantic features are not necessarily a part of lexical meaning of indefinites but can instead be pragmatically induced implications arising due to competition with their definite counterparts. For instance, the fact that the indefinite article *a* cannot be attached to predicates whose extension consists of a unique individual, like in (26), is usually explained as pragmatic dis-preference of using a weaker alternative where a stronger one (in this case, the definite article *the*) would be suitable.

(26) *The/#a sun is shining.*

This pragmatic view is supported by the evidence from languages that do not lexicalize the contrast between definites and indefinites. A famous example is St'at'imcets (Salish group). This language does have articles, but it does not have a dedicated definite article, and articles that clearly have indefinite uses (27a, 27b) can occur in typical definite contexts as well (Matthewson 1998): that is, they can refer to the entities unique/maximal with respect to their descriptive content (27c) and can pick out salient old referents (27d).

(27) a. {There are five puppies in the room. One of them is sleeping.}

cw7áoz-as kw-á-su wenácw-ts! wa7 guy't

NEG-3CONJ DET-PROG-2SG.POSS true-mouth PROG sleep

ta sqéqx7-a

DET dog(DIMIN)-DET]

'Be quiet! **A** / *The **puppy** is sleeping.' (Matthewson 1998: 107)

b. *ka hál'h-a* ***ta nkakúsent-a***

OOC show-OOC DET star-DET

'**A star** appeared.' (Matthewson 1998: 107)

c. *ka hál'h-a* ***ta nkakúsent-a***

OOC show-OOC DET star-DET

'**The sun** appeared.' (Matthewson 1998: 109)

d. *húy'-lhkan ptakwlh, ptákwlh-min lts7a*

going.to-1SG.SUBJ tell.story tell.story-APPL here

ti smém'lhats-a*…*

DET woman(DIMIN)-DET

… *wa7* *ku7* *ílal* *láti7* ***ti*** ***smém'lhats-a***

PROG QUOT cry DEIC DET woman(DIMIN)-DET

'I am going to tell a legend, a legend about **a girl**… **The girl** was crying there.'

(van Eijk & Williams 1981: 19, Matthewson 1998: 108)

Such indefinites are often called *unrestricted indefinites*: they are available in typically indefinite environments but also can occur in contexts where we would expect definites. Alternatively, of course, one could analyze unrestricted indefinites as an instance of ambiguity, where the same expression has a separate (restricted) indefinite reading and a separate definite reading. Such an approach, however, would not be preferable: there is no need to postulate two readings where one would suffice. In this case, we can think of unrestricted indefinites as having no semantic restrictions on familiarity/novelty of their referent (one way to think about this is that they always introduce a new discourse referent, but it can be contextually understood as identical to an old one) and its (non-)maximality with respect to the NP's descriptive content.

At the same time, some indefinites do obligatorily require non-uniqueness as a part of their lexical meaning. For instance, Spanish *algún*-indefinites can only occur in contexts where the meant individual is not the only one meeting the descriptive content of the restricting NP (Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2010). This is shown in (28a), where the use of *algún* conveys strong implication that there are other linguistic students, and in (28b), where the use of this determiner is infelicitous because the predicate it combines with can only be true of a single individual. Note that the use of the indefinite article *un*, synonymous to English *a*, is fine in this case (even though Spanish has a definite article): this contrast in distribution shows that the non-uniqueness constraint posed by *algún* is indeed not pragmatic in nature.

(28) a. *María* *se* *casó* *con* ***algún*** *estudiante* *del*

M. SE married with ALGÚN student of.the

departamento *de* *lingüística.*

department of linguistics

'Maria married a linguistic student (one of the many).'

(Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2010: 18)

b. *Pedro* *contrató* *a* *un/*#***algún*** *candidato* *que* *era*

P. hired to UN/ALGÚN candidate that was

el *más* *incompetente* *de* *los* *que* *se* *presentaron.*

the most incompetent of the.ones that SE applied

'Pedro hired a candidate that was the most incompetent of the ones that applied.'

(Alonso-Ovalle & Menéndez-Benito 2010: 17)

While tolerance to novelty of the referent and its non-uniqueness or non-maximality are the defining properties of indefinites, many of them come with additional semantic requirements, differing in such parameters as specificity and epistemic status. Let me briefly overview the key contrasts in these domains.

First, indefinites can differ in terms of **specificity**[8], that is, whether they can be used to talk about a particular referent or not. **Specific indefinites** convey that a particular individual is selected meeting their descriptive content, while **non-specific indefinites** convey the opposite. The difference between the two types of indefinites is illustrated by the contrast between two Russian

[8] An important problem with the notion of the specificity is that it is very vague, and details of its definition can vary in different terminological traditions (Farkas 2002a; von Heusinger et al. 2011, a.o.). In this paper, I follow von Heusinger et al's general definition of specificity as "referential anchoring" (von Heusinger et al. 2011).

determiners: specific indefinite *koe-kakoj* (29a) and non-specific indefinite *kakoj-nibud'* (29b). Crucially, (29a) implies that there is a specific book Vasya wants to read, while (29b) suggests that Vasya wants to do book-reading, but does not have a particular book in mind.

(29) a. *Vas'a xočet pročitat' koe-kakuju knigu.*
V. wants read which-SP.KN book
'Vasya wants to read a certain book.'

b. *Vas'a xočet pročitat' kakuju-nibud' knigu.*
V. wants read which-NSP book
'Vasya wants to read any book.'

Some specific indefinites additionally convey the information about their **epistemic status**, that is, whether the speaker can identify their referent or not. **Specific unknown indefinites** convey the implication that the speaker is ignorant with respect to their referent's identity. Russian *to*-indefinites belong to this group (Geist 2008; Kagan 2011, a. o.), as illustrated in (30). The sentence in (30a) entails that the speaker does not yet know the identity of the student that cheated; the sentence in (30b) sounds contradictory: the speaker cannot know the Swede well and do not know his identity at the same time. The only context where (30b) would be (somewhat) felicitous is when the speaker has suffered a memory loss and makes some detective work to recover the set of people they know.

(30) a. ***Kakoj-to*** *student spisyval na ekzamene.*
which-EP.UKN student cheated on exam
'Some student [not known to the speaker] cheated on the exam.' (Geist 2008: 154)

b. #*Ja xorošo znaju* ***kakogo-to*** *šveda*

I well know which-EP.IND Swede

'I know some Swede [not known to me] very well.' (Kagan 2011: 59)

In contrast, **specific known indefinites** convey the information that the speaker knows the identity of their referent. Consider an illustration with *koe*-indefinites in (31). The sentence in (31a) implies that the speaker knows exactly which student cheated; furthermore, this implication cannot be cancelled, as shown by the contradiction in (31b).

(31) a. ***Koe-kakoj*** *student spisyval na ekzamene.*

EP.KN-which student cheated on exam

'Some student [known to the speaker] cheated on the exam.' (Geist 2008: 154)

b. *Dima razrabatyvajet* ***koe-kakoj*** *projekt,*

D. develops EP.KN-which project

o kotorom ja ne imeju ni malejšego predstavlenija.

about which I not have NC slightest idea

'Dima is developing a project [known to me] of which I do not have any idea.'

(Kagan 2011: 63)

Not all indefinites are marked in terms of their epistemic status and/or specificity. For instance, sentences like (32) with English *a*-indefinites can have both specific and non-specific interpretations, and the identity of the indefinite's witness can be known and unknown to the speaker, as shown below[9].

[9] Note that the three interpretations of the sentence in (33) are just three types of scenarios where this sentence would be true. I do not intend to treat all of them as representing separate readings of the indefinite itself.

(32) *John wants to marry an American.*

1. John wants to marry a specific American (I know who she is).
2. John wants to marry a specific American (I don't know who she is).
3. John wants to marry any American.

Of course, there are many more types of indefinites with other additional meanings, see, e.g., Becker 2021 and Dawson & Jenks 2023 for more detailed discussion of their typology. What is crucial for us here, however, is that all indefinites share such features as ability to introduce novel discourse referents and tolerance to non-maximality of their referent with respect to their descriptive content.

In the next section, I will show that bare NPs in Russian are **unrestricted indefinites,** similar in that respect to the St'at'imcets NPs we discussed earlier**.** On one hand, they can introduce novel discourse referents and do not require their satisfiers to be maximal or unique with respect to their descriptive content; on the other hand, in contrast to "restricted" indefinites like *algún* in Spanish, they can be used to pick out familiar discourse referents and do not mind if their individual happens to be maximal/unique with respect to their descriptive content.

2.2. Applying the diagnostics to Russian bare NPs

In this section, I will argue, using all the existing substantive evidence coupled with my own crucial findings, that bare NPs in Russian are simple unrestricted indefinites. I will show that bare NPs in Russian are neutral with respect to novelty/familiarity of their referent (Section 2.2.1) and do not require it to be maximal or non-maximal with respect to their descriptive content (Section 2.2.2). I will summarize the findings of this part in Section 2.2.3.

2.2.1. Novelty/familiarity

It has long been known that bare NPs in Russian are neutral with respect to the parameter of novelty/familiarity (Brun 2001; Bronnikov 2004; 2007; Geist 2010; Borik 2016; Seres & Borik 2018, a.m.o.). In this section, I will review the main arguments for this generalization. I will start with demonstrating that bare NPs can introduce novel discourse referents and then will show that they can also be used anaphorically, that is, they can pick out already given referents.

The classic argument for the tolerance of Russian bare NPs to novelty is based on examples like in (33) where the bare NP's referent is introduced into a new, "discourse-empty" stage denoted by a locational adverbial. Indeed, the most natural interpretation of (33a) is that a new girl character is introduced in the story, and the most natural context where (33b) would be uttered is when the speaker does not have a salient book in mind.

(33) a. *Dver' otkrylas', i v dom vošla devočka.*
door opened and in house entered girl
'The door opened, and a girl entered the house.' (adapted from Geist 2010: 195)

b. *Na stole ležit kniga.*
on table lies book
'There is a book on the table.' (Seres & Borik 2018: 344)

While most of the examples in the literature feature bare singulars, bare plurals pass the novelty tolerance diagnostics as well. Consider, for instance, the examples in (34), analogous to the ones in (33) except for the number feature of the NPs. Both sentences are felicitous: in (34a), *devočki* 'girls' is most naturally understood as introducing a plural girl referent; likewise, in (34b), *knigi* 'books' is understood as referring to some new books, unknown for the addressee.

(34) a. *Dver'* *otkrylas',* *i* *v* *dom* *vošli* *devočki*.

door opened and in house entered girls

'The door opened, and (some) girls entered the house.'

b. *Na* *stole* *ležat* *knigi.*

on table lie books

'There are books on the table.'

The examples like in (33-34) are aimed at showing that bare NPs can be used to talk about individuals not discussed or salient in the previous discourse. However, it is equally important to demonstrate that these individuals are actually *introduced as discourse referents*. By definition, a discourse referent must be anaphorically accessible (Karttunen 1976; Heim 1982): an anaphoric expression like a pronoun must, all things being equal, be able to pick it out. Notably, not all expressions that can be used to talk about individuals not given in the context pass this test. Consider, for instance, the contrast between a bare plural *apples* in (35a) and an incorporated noun *apple-* in (35b). Even though both linguistic expressions can be used to talk about a group of apples that John picked, only the use of the former, but not the latter, introduces an actual discourse referent that can then get picked by a following pronoun.

(35) a. *John picked apples$_i$ last night and sold them$_i$ on the market this morning*.

b. #*John did some apple$_i$-picking last night and sold them$_i$ on the market this morning.*

Novel referents of Russian bare NPs are anaphorically accessible (Geist 2010; Borik 2016): as shown in (36), an individual meant by the NP can be referred to by a following pronoun, which means that it has a corresponding discourse referent in the context.

(36) a. *Ko* *mne* *v* *komnatu* *vošla* ***devočka$_i$***.

to me in room entered girl

***Ona**$_i$* *byla očen' napugana.*

she was very scared

'A girl$_i$ came in my room. She$_i$ was very scared.'

b. *Ko mne v komnatu vošli* ***devočki**$_j$*.

to me in room entered girls

***Oni**$_j$* *byli očen' napugany.*

they were very scared

'(Some) girls$_j$ came in my room. They were$_j$ very scared.'

Thus, bare NPs in Russian can introduce novel discourse referents: they can be used to talk about an individual unknown for the addressee, and in such case, a discourse referent representing that individual is introduced. At the same time, bare NPs can also be used anaphorically, that is, to pick out discourse referents that are already given. Consider the examples in (37). In (37a), the NP *devuška* 'girl' refers to the female American introduced in the previous sentence. In (37b), the NP *životnyje* 'animals' refers to the group of tigers introduced earlier. Note that in both cases, the referent picked out by the NP is not unique or maximal with respect to its descriptive content: in (37a), there likely were other girls at the party, and in (37b), the family of tigers were clearly not the only animals at the zoo. This rules out a possibility that the referents of the respective bare NPs just happened to coincide with the previously introduced ones: in the context where the bare NP's predicates have multiple satisfiers, we would expect this necessary coreference implication to disappear.

(37) a. *Ja včera na večerinke poznakomils'a s <u>amerikankoj iz Siétla</u>.*

I yesterday on party got.acquainted with American from Seattle

Devuška	*rasskazala*	*mne,*	*gde*	*kupit'*	*lučšuju*	*rybu*	*v gorode.*
girl	told	me	where	buy	best	fish	in city

'Yesterday at the party, I met a (female) American from Seattle. The girl told me where to buy the best fish in the city.'

b. *Včera*	*v*	*zooparke*	*videla*	*semju tigrov.*			
yesterday	in	zoo	saw	family tigers.GEN			
Životnyje	*spokojno*	*spali*	*v*	*uglu*	*kletki*	*posle*	*obeda.*
animals	calmly	slept	in	corner	cage.GEN	after	lunch

'Yesterday at the zoo, I saw a family of tigers. The animals were calmly sleeping in the corner of the cage after lunch.' (Seres & Borik 2018: 355)

Thus, bare NPs in Russian are indeed neutral with respect to the parameter of novelty/familiarity: they can introduce a new discourse referent or refer to an already given one. While many different formalizations of this generalization are possible, one way to think about it is the following: bare NPs always introduce new discourse referents, but then certain pragmatic clues can help us identify this referent with an older one. For instance, we can argue that the bare NPs in (37) are understood as anaphoric because they are used as topics which are required to refer to given individuals and/or because the previous sentence was about an American girl, so this new girl referent is likely the same as before. In any case, in being novelty/familiarity-neutral, bare NPs in Russian pattern with unrestricted indefinites, like in Salish.

In the next section, I will show that Russian bare NPs are neutral with respect to (non-)uniqueness and (non-)maximality as well.

2.2.2. (Non-)maximality

While it has long been argued for that bare NPs in Russian are indefinites, most of the classic arguments targeted their ability to introduce new discourse referents, and only very recent studies (Borik 2016; Seres & Borik 2018) directly argued that Russian bare NPs are also neutral with respect to maximality/uniqueness, that is, that their referent does not have to be maximal or non-maximal satisfier of their descriptive content. In this section, I will provide the key data supporting this claim: I will first show that bare NPs can denote non-unique/non-maximal individuals and then will demonstrate that they are not "allergic" to unique/maximal individuals either.

There are many diagnostics developed for diagnosing the non-maximality of the individual with respect to the tested NP's descriptive content. The first diagnostic involves uttering a sentence with the NP in a scenario where other individuals satisfying the NP's predicate are provided (Matthewson 1998; Dawson & Jenks 2023) and are ideally as accessible for both the speaker and the hearer as the intended witness of the tested NP, as in (38). As expected, the explicit non-uniqueness of the child in (38) makes the definite NP infelicitous.

(38) Context. There are many children in the house. One of them is sleeping. The others are playing. I enter the house speaking aloud. You admonish me:

*Talk quietly, a child/*the child is sleeping!*

(inspired by Navarro 2024b: 44)

Russian bare singulars and bare plurals pass this test as indefinites, as illustrated in (39a) and (39b) respectively: in both cases, the bare NP is used to refer to a non-maximal individual (a non-unique child in (36a) and a non-maximal group of children in (39b)), even though the other children are visually accessible to the speech act participants.

(39) a. Context. There are many children in the house. One of them is sleeping. The others are playing. I enter the house speaking aloud. You admonish me:

Tiše,	*rebënok*	*spit!*
quiet	child	sleeps

'Quiet, a child is sleeping!'

b. Context. There are many children in the house. Some of them are sleeping. The others are playing. I enter the house speaking aloud. You admonish me:

Tiše,	*deti*	*sp'at!*
quiet	children	sleep

'Quiet, children are sleeping.'

Another diagnostic often used to test whether an NP has a uniqueness presupposition is the so-called *sluicing test* (Matthewson 1998; Dawson & Jenks 2023), where the sentence with the tested NP is followed by a clause with a sluicing like *but I don't know who*, where the embedded question targets the identity of the tested NP's individual. The idea of this diagnostic is that if it is known that the predicate of the tested NP has a unique satisfier *x* in the context, then the addressee will assume that the speaker used this NP to refer to that *x*; hence, if the speaker later admits that they don't actually know the identity of the meant individual, the utterance would sound incoherent. In contrast, using an NP that does not have a uniqueness presupposition does not lead to such a problem, as there could easily be many potential satisfiers of this NP's predicate in the context, and in such cases, the identity of the meant individual can, all things being equal, be unclear[10].

[10] Naturally, specific indefinites do not pass the sluicing test because their referent must be identifiable by the speaker, so following up with a sluice questioning the referent's identity leads to contradiction.

To see this test in action, consider the contrast in (40). As expected, only the indefinite DP *a movie star* can felicitously be used in (40); the use of its definite counterpart, the DP *the movie star*, is infelicitous here because if the speaker knows that there is just one movie star in the context, they cannot not know which movie star Anika met.

(40) *Anika met a/#the movie star, but I don't know who!* (Dawson & Jenks 2023: 139)

Russian bare NPs pass this test as indefinites, as shown in (41): neither of the two sentences is contradictory as we would expect had the bare NPs been definite.

(41) a. *Na stole ležit knižka, no ne pomn'u, kakaja imenno.*
on table lies book but not remember which exactly
'A book is lying on the table, but I don't remember which one exactly.'

b. *Na stole ležat knižki, no ne pomn'u, kakie imenno.*
on table lie books but not remember which exactly
'Books are lying on the table, but I don't remember which ones exactly.'

Finally, a commonly used test distinguishing indefinites from definites is the so-called *contradiction test*. Only two identical indefinites, but not two identical definites, can be subjects of contradictory predicates. This is demonstrated in (42). The sentence in (42a) is a felicitous sentence about two dogs one of which is barking and the other is sleeping. In contrast, (42b) sounds odd as if the same dog is barking and sleeping at the same time.

(42) a. *A dog is barking and a dog is sleeping.*

(i) #*Anika met* ***a certain*** *movie star, but I don't know who!* (Dawson & Jenks 2023: 139)

b. *The dog is barking and the dog is sleeping.*

The idea behind this test is that the consistency of the referent of a definite NP (hence the other name of this diagnostic — *consistency test* (Löbner 1985)) across different uses within the same local context will lead to obvious contradiction or pragmatic oddity if the events this referent participates in are normally incompatible. In contrast, the ability of an indefinite NP to change its reference across different uses will prevent any sort of incompatibility-driven infelicity. Thus, if the same NP can be a subject of two incompatible predicates, it has an indefinite reading, and if not — it is a definite.

When applying this diagnostic, it is important to control for the relevant changes of the context — in particular, for covert and/or non-verbal domain restrictions — otherwise it can return a "false positive" result. This is what can happen, for instance, when this test is applied to demonstratives (Dayal 2004; Moroney 2021; Dawson & Jenks 2023, a.o.). Consider, for instance, an example in (43). If we consider only the verbally pronounced part of the content in (43), it appears that *that*-demonstratives do not require uniqueness of their satisfier: two instances of the same nominal, *that boy*, are arguments of logically incompatible predicates. However, the two nominals are not actually identical: for (43) to be felicitous, each of the two demonstratives must be accompanied by a gesture unambiguously pointing to the intended referent; if the gestural part of the content is controlled for (that is, the speaker points at the same individual uttering each of the nominals), the sentence sounds contradictory, showing that *that*-demonstratives do, after all, have a uniqueness requirement.

(43) *That boy is sleeping and that boy is not sleeping.* (Dayal 2004: 17)

Applying the consistency test to Russian will lead us to a negative result, as we will see at the end of Section 4: bare NPs cannot form anti-unique sequences. However, I will argue there and then in Chapter 3 that this has nothing to do with the semantics of the bare NPs and is instead a result of an independent pragmatic constraint.

In the first half of this section, I argued that bare NPs in Russian do not require maximality or uniqueness of their referent with respect to their respective content, which we would expect from indefinites. Now I will show that they *can* occur in the context where the maximality/uniqueness requirement is met.

First, Russian bare NPs can refer to globally maximal/unique individuals, that is, occur in contexts where *larger situation definites* would be licensed. This is demonstrated in (44). In (44a), the bare singular *solnce* 'sun' refers to the unique sun in our solar system; in (44b), the bare plural *sputniki Marsa*[11] refers to the unique pair of Mars' satellites — Phobos and Deimos.

(44) a. ***Solnce*** *svetit.*

sun shines

'The sun is shining.' (Seres & Borik 2018: xvii)

b. ***Sputniki Marsa*** *očen' malen'kie.*

satellites Mars very small

'The (natural) satellites of Mars are very small.'

[11] I am grateful to Vsevolod Masliukov for pointing out this NP to me as a clear instance of a bare plural that has not just a maximal, but the unique global satisfier.

Second, Russian bare NPs can occur in contexts where *immediate situation definites* would be licensed, that is, when the uniqueness/maximality with respect to their descriptive content is met locally. This is illustrated in (45). In (45a), the bare singular *telefon* refers to the unique phone present in the local context (the speaker and her grandson's house). In (45b), the bare plural *okna* refers to the plurality comprising all the windows in the house (the context of the utterance ensures that granny meant all the windows, since she wants to protect the house from the storm outside[12]).

(45) a. Context. There is just one phone in the house. Granny sits at the armchair and asks her grandson to bring the phone to her.

Prinesi *mne* *telefon!*

bring me cup

'Bring me the cup.'

b. Context. There is a thunderstorm outside, and granny is concerned about the safety in the room. She asks her grandson:

Zakroj *okna!*

close windows

'Close (all) the windows!'

Thus, bare NPs in Russian are neutral in terms of uniqueness/maximality: they do not require their individual to be unique/maximal with respect their descriptive content but also do not require the opposite. In that respect, the pattern with unrestricted indefinites like Salish NPs.

[12] The selection of the context is inspired by the example from Malamud 2012 from English discussed earlier in the paper as a case where the maximal reading is enforced.

2.2.3. Summary

In this section, I showed that bare NPs in Russian are unrestricted indefinites: their referent can be novel and non-unique/non-maximal with respect to their descriptive content, but it is not required: they can pick out referents that are familiar and/or unique/maximal with respect to their predicate.

3. Scopal properties of Russian bare nominals

While most of the approaches to Russian bare NPs agree that those feature indefinite uses, they vary significantly in what their scopal properties are, ranging from claiming that indefinite bare NPs can only take narrow scope (Geist 2010) to assuming that they have essentially unrestricted variable scope and can escape islands (Seres & Borik 2018). In this section, I will defend the view argued for in (Bronnikov 2004; 2007, Shikunova et al. 2023) that bare NPs have the distribution of (generalized) existential quantifiers over individuals: they feature variable scope but cannot escape islands.

The structure of this section is as follows. I will start by showing in Section 3.1 that Russian bare NPs can take both narrow and wide scope with respect to different sentence-internal operators while being indefinite in both cases. After that, in Section 3.2, I will show that bare NPs in Russian cannot escape islands. Then, in Section 3.3, I will discuss what is often treated as a scopal phenomenon but in fact is not: semantic interaction of bare NPs with *for*-adverbials. I will finish by summing up the findings in Section 3.4.

Before turning to the Russian material, I should make an important terminological caveat. Discussing the data provided in this section, I will use the term “scope” primarily in a descriptive sense, as a way of characterizing the relative interpretation of the existential content of the indefinite with respect to a semantic operator in question. For instance, by saying that an indefinite takes a narrow scope with respect to a certain semantic operator, I will mean that its existential content is interpreted within the semantic scope of that operator; analogously, by saying that an indefinite takes a wide scope with respect to a semantic operator, I will mean that its existential content is interpreted outside of the semantic scope of that operator. By using the term "scope" this way, I thus do not commit to any particular compositional mechanism for deriving relevant interpretation (e.g. Quantifier Raising). In my analysis, I will commit to the idea that bare nominals are actually scope-taking expressions (by virtue of being existential quantifiers), but this assumption does not follow from the data and can potentially be replaced by a different one within an alternative framework.

3.1. Variable scope

As I mentioned earlier, it has already been argued for that bare NPs in Russian feature variable scope with respect to different semantic operators (Bronnikov 2004; 2007; Borik 2016; Seres & Borik 2018; Seres 2020; Shikunova et al. 2023). However, the arguments provided as evidence for the scope ambiguity were not fully controlled with respect to the parameter of (in)definiteness, or at least that parameter was not discussed explicitly enough. In addition to that, most of the evidence concerning the variable scope of Russian bare NPs is based on examples with bare singulars, and bare plurals (except for Seres 2020) are either not discussed separately (Borik 2016; Shikunova et al. 2023) or are assumed to not feature the same scope variability (Bronnikov 2007)[13]. In this

[13] Bronnikov (2007) discusses a case where bare plurals take wide scope with respect to the desire predicate *xotet'* 'want', provided in (i). In this sentence, the NP *milicionery* 'policemen' is interpreted as describing people existing in the actual world and moreover not present in Nikifor's desired worlds: this is shown by the right context (provided in Russian in the paper), where it is said that Nikifor actually met this people in real life and moreover does not know they are policemen.

(i) *Nikifor xočet priglasit' k sebe milicionerov.*

section, I will provide novel arguments showing that both bare singulars and bare plurals in Russian feature true wide scope and narrow scope indefinite readings, concentrating on the cases where the wide scope indefinite reading is truth-conditionally distinct from the narrow scope one and cannot be analyzed alternatively as an instance of a definite reading.

The first piece of evidence comes from the scopal behavior of bare NPs with respect to desire predicates like *xotet'* 'want'. Consider the examples in (46). The sentence in (46a) can be understood in two ways depending on whether the bare singular *ital'janka* '(female) Italian' is interpreted within the scope of the intensional operator of *xotet'* (in all Vasya's normal desired worlds, he marries a (potentially different) Italian) or out of it (there is an actual, specific Italian girl whom Vasya wants to marry). These two readings are disambiguated by the provided scenarios. Under Scenario 1, only the narrow-scope reading is true because there is no particular Italian girl that Vasya loves; in contrast, only the wide-scope reading is true under Scenario 2 since Vasya does not want his wife to be Italian, he just wants to marry a particular person who happened to be an Italian. The same ambiguity is observed for bare plurals, as shown by an analogous example in (46b).

(46) a. Scenario 1. Vasya loves Italy and has a dream of marrying an Italian,
but he does not have any specific candidate in mind.

N. wants invite to self policemen
'Nikifor wants to invite (specific) policemen to his house.'
{He does not know that they are policemen, though; he met them on a fishing trip.'
(Bronnikov 2007: 4, modified by me)

This case, however, is treated by Bronnikov as exceptional, and his general conclusion is that bare plurals at least strongly prefer narrow scope with respect to other operators; in particular, he claims that they always take narrow scope with respect to negation. As I will show in the remainder of this section, this is not the case.

Scenario 2. Vasya does not want to have a stereotypically Italian wife, but he wants to marry Chiara, who is an Italian but does not fit in the stereotypes.

vas'a *xočet* *ženit's'a* *na* *ital'janke.*

V. wants marry on Italian

'Vasya wants to marry an Italian.'

b. Scenario 1. Masha loves America and although she does not know any American girls, She dreams of having American girls as friends someday.

Scenario 2. Masha does not have any desires of having friends of a particular nation, but she really wants to make friends with a specific group of American girls.

maša *xočet* *podružit's'a* *s* *amerikankami.*

M. wants befriend with Americans

'Masha wants to make friends with (some/whichever) Americans.'

Importantly, the wide scope readings of both (46a) and (46b) cannot be alternatively analyzed as cases where the bare NP is interpreted as a definite because they do not have the maximality presupposition. In (46a), Chiara does not have to be the only salient Italian girl, and in (46b), there could be other groups of American girls that Masha knows. This is further illustrated in (47), where the non-maximality of the bare NPs is explicitly challenged.

(47) a. *vas'a* *xočet* *ženit's'a* *na* *ital'janke,*

V. wants marry on Italian

no *ne* *na* *frančeske, a* *na kjare.*

but not on F. but on Ch.

'Vasya wants to marry a (specific) Italian, but it's not Franceska, it's Chiara.'

b. *maša*		*xočet*	*podružit's'a*	*s*	*amerikankami,*			
M.		wants	befriend	with	Americans			
no	*ne*	*so*	*svoimi*	*odnoklassnicami,*		*a*	*s*	*devočkami*
but	not	with	self	classmates		but	with	girls
s		*kružka.*						
from		club						

'Masha wants to make friends with (some) Americans from the club.'

Another case where the scopal ambiguity of Russian bare NPs can be shown comprises sentences with covariation-inducing adverbials like *každyj den'* 'every day', as the ones below. The first sentence in (48) has two readings: 1) there is a particular nurse that visits the speaker every day (in this case, the bare NP takes wide scope with respect to the adverbial and thus does not covary) and 2) every day, a (potentially different) nurse visits the speaker.

The two readings are disambiguated by two alternative continuations below. The first one, in (48a), is only compatible with the wide-scope reading: the anaphoric use of the bare NP *devuška* 'girl' requires there to be only one salient referent, which is only possible if the bare NP does not covary. In contrast, the continuation in (48b) implies that the nurse that came today is not the only one that visits the speaker, and this is only compatible with the narrow-scope reading of the first sentence.

(48)	*Ko*	*mne*	*každyj*	*den'*	*zaxodit*	*medsestra,*	*prover'ajet*	*moj*	*pul's.*
	to	me	every	day	enters	nurse	checks	my	pulse

'Every day, a nurse visits me and checks my pulse.'

a. *Očen'*	*milaja*	*devuška,*	*Natašej*	*zovut.*
very	nice	girl	N.	call

'Very nice girl, her name is Natasha.'

b. *Segodn'a vot prišla moja l'ubimaja, Lenočka.*
today here came my favorite L.
'Today, my favorite one came, Lenochka.'

The same ambiguity is observed with bare plurals, as shown in (49) with the bare plural *medsëstry* 'nurses'. Again, the two readings can be disambiguated by alternative continuations. The one in (49a) is only compatible with the wide-scope reading: the fact that the nurses always come all together excludes the possibility that nurses can come in different groups. In contrast, the continuation in (49b) implies that the nurses that visited the speaker earlier were different, which is incompatible with the wide-scope reading since it does not allow covariation.

(49) *Ko mne každyj den' zaxod'at medsëstry, prover'ajut moj pul's.*
to me every day enters nurse checks my pulse
'Every day, nurses visit me and check my pulse.'

a. *Očen' milye devuški, vsegda vse vmeste prixod'at.*
very nice girl always all together come
'Very nice girls, always come altogether.'

b. *Segodn'a prišli kakie-to noven'kie, ja ix ran'še ne videla.*
today came some new I them before not saw
'Some new ones came today; I have never seen them before.'

Just like in the previous case we discussed, bare NPs do not require maximality when they take wide scope, so the corresponding readings cannot be analyzed as ones where the NP is definite.

For instance, the sentences in (48) and (49) can receive continuations as in (50a) and (50b) correspondingly, implying that there are nurses other than the nurse (50a)/the group of nurses (50b) that visit(s) the speaker.

(50) a.

Ko	*mne*	*každyj*	*den'*	*zaxodit*	*medsestra,*	*prover'ajet*	*moj*	*pul's.*
to	me	every	day	enters	nurse	checks	my	pulse
No	*ne*	*Nataša,*		*kak*	*ran'še, a*	*Milana.*		
but	not	N.		as	earlier but	M.		

‘Every day, a nurse visits me and checks my pulse, but not Natasha, as was earlier, but Milana.’

b.

Ko	*mne*	*každyj*	*den'*	*zaxod'at*		*medsëstry,*	*prover'ajut*		*moj*	*pul's.*
to	me	every	day	enters		nurse	checks		my	pulse
No	*ne*	*Maša*	*i*	*L'uba,*	*kak*	*ran'še, a*	*Jul'a*	*i*	*Sveta.*	
but	not	M.	and	L.	as	earlier but	Y.	and	S.	

‘Every day, nurses visit me and check my pulse. But not Masha and Lyuba as was earlier, but Yulya and Sveta.’

Thus, in this section I showed that bare NPs in Russian, bare singulars and bare plurals, can feature variable scope with respect to such semantic operators as desire predicates like *xotet'* ‘want’ and covariation-inducing adverbials like *každyj den'* ‘every day’. While more thorough research on the scopal ambiguity of bare NPs with respect to various types of semantic operators is clearly needed, what we have here is enough to conclude that Russian bare NPs do not have a fixed scope, and moreover, their scopal ambiguity must be explained in terms of actual *taking* of different scope: alternatively, what we treat as the wide-scope reading could have been a “scopeless” definite reading with the illusion of the wide scope due to the maximality inference[14]. However, this possibility is sorted out: as I showed in this section, when Russian bare NPs take wide scope with respect to the operators we discussed, they do not require uniqueness or maximality.

3.2. Obeying scope islands

In the previous section, I have shown that bare NPs in Russian can take different scope. In this section, I will argue that their scope flexibility is limited by island constraints, that is, they cannot escape islands.

To demonstrate this, I will use the data from the two island constructions that received the most attention in studies of quantifier scope: conditional antecedents (*if*-clauses) and complex NPs. Both these constructions are islands in Russian as well (Tiskin 2017; Lyutikova & Gerasimova 2021), as illustrated below.

In (51a), only the interpretation where the universal quantifier falls within the scope of the conditional operator is possible. This sentence unambiguously suggests that the success of the collective documentation depends on everyone's best effort; it cannot be understood as a claim that for any of the authors, their sole hard work would make the collective documentation brilliant (as we would expect if the universal quantifier could scope over the conditional).

Analogously, the sentence in (51b) only has an interpretation where the quantifier is interpreted within the island. Namely, it entails that there was a single rumor about all the speaker's students;

[14] Of course, another theoretical alternative would be to analyze what I call the wide scope reading of bare nominals as a scopeless *indefinite* reading; in that case, the wide scope-like interpretation would be derived via the projection of existential content. While such an approach is applicable here, the existential-quantifier-based analysis is more parsimonious because it predicts the observed scopal ambiguity of bare nominals and their inability to get "exceptional scope" readings without any additional assumptions.

it cannot be used in a scenario where for each student, there was a separate rumor (as we would expect if the universal quantifier could scope out of the complement of the NP).

(51) a.

Jesli	*každyj*	*opišet*	*to,*	*v*	*čëm*	*on*	*razbirajets'a,*
if	every	describes	that	in	what	he	understands
to	v	summe	polučits'a		velikolepnaja		dokumentacija.
then	in	sum	will_result		brilliant		documentation

1. 'If everyone describes what they understand well enough, in sum, a brilliant (collective) documentation will result.'
2. # 'It is true for everyone that if they describe what they understand well enough, in sum, a brilliant documentation will result.'

(adapted from Tiskin 2017: 39)

b.

Do	*men'a*	*došël*	*slux,*	*čto*	*každyj*	*moj*	*učenik*	*spisyvajet.*
to	me	reached	rumor	that	every	my	student	cheats

1. 'I heard a (single) rumor that every student of mine cheats (on tests).'
2. # 'For each student of mine, I heard a rumor that this student cheats (on tests).'

Thus, we can use both conditional antecedents and complex NPs as island constructions to test the scope of bare NPs in Russian. What we will see is that in both the cases, bare NPs obey the island constraint.

Let us start with the conditional antecedents. As shown in (52-53), both bare singulars and bare plurals can only be interpreted within the scope of the conditional operator. The sentence in (52) unambiguously suggests that any nurse that could visit the speaker would make them feel shy. It would be false in a scenario where the speaker will only get shy if one specific nurse (say, Sasha) comes in but is not shy of the other nurses. Had the bare singular been able to scope out of the conditional, the sentence should have been true in this scenario.

(52)	*Jesli*	*ko*	*mne*	*zajdët*	*medsestra,*	*ja*	*budu*	*sil'no*	*stesn'at's'a.*
	if	to	me	enters	nurse	I	will	strongly	be.shy

1. 'If any nurse will visit me, I will be very shy of her.'
2. # 'There is a specific nurse such that if she will visit me, I will be very shy of her.'

The same exact contrast is observed with bare plurals. In (53), the only available interpretation is that the speaker thinks they will get shy if any group of nurses visit them. It is false in a scenario where the speaker is only shy of a particular group of nurses, but not to any others.

(53)	*Jesli*	*ko*	*mne*	*zajdut*	*medsëstry,*	*ja*	*budu*	*sil'no*	*stesn'at's'a.*
	if	to	me	enter	nurses	I	will	strongly	be.shy

1. 'If any nurses will visit me, I will be very shy of them.'
2. # 'If some specific nurses will visit me, I will be very shy of them.'

Thus, bare singulars and bare plurals in Russian cannot scope out of the conditional antecedents. Before moving on, let me briefly discuss a case that might look like a counterexample to this generalization (but is, in fact, not one). Namely, the two sentences above can be felicitous in a scenario where it is clear from the context which nurse(s) the speaker meant, even if there are other nurses in the hospital. At first glance, such cases are incompatible with the narrow-scope readings of the respective sentences and require the bare NP to take the wide scope: it is not true that the speaker would be shy of any nurses, but it is true that they would be shy of a particular nurse (54a) or group of nurses (54b).

(54) a. Scenario. The speaker has feelings for one of the nurses, and the addressee, their

friend, knows that. The speaker is not generally shy around nurses, but they do not want to embarrass the one they like.

Jesli	*ko*	*mne*	*zajdët*	*medsestra,*	*ja*	*budu*	*sil'no*	*stesn'at's'a.*
if	to	me	enters	nurse	I	will	strongly	be.shy

'If the nurse will visit me, I will be very shy around her.'

b. Scenario. The speaker wants to make friends with a group of nurses, and the addressee, their friend, knows that. The speaker is not generally shy of nurses, but they do not want to embarrass the ones they like.

Jesli	*ko*	*mne*	*zajdut*	*medsëstry,*	*ja*	*budu*	*sil'no*	*stesn'at's'a.*
if	to	me	enter	nurses	I	will	strongly	be.shy

'If the nurses will visit me, I will be very shy of them.'

However, the crucial part of the provided scenarios is that the addressee must know unambiguously who the speaker is referring to, while the other potential satisfiers are left as non-existent for the sake of the conversation. In other words, the domain of consideration is contextually restricted to the set of relevant nurses (in this case, to the nurse(s) the speaker has feelings for). Crucially, given the domain restriction, the provided scenarios are compatible with the narrow-scope readings and thus do not present a case of the island constraint violation.

Let us now move on to the complex NP islands. According to my data, bare NPs cannot scope out of them either. Consider first the sentence in (55a). The bare NP *ital'janka* '(female) Italian' can only be interpreted within the scope of the intensional operator of the word *slux* 'rumor'. Namely, (55a) cannot be understood as mentioning a rumor about a specific Italian existing in the actual world: her existence is a part of the rumor. This is further demonstrated in (55b), where adding a continuation implying that the Italian exists in the actual world leads to infelicity. Note that adding the specific indefinite marker *odin* to the NP makes (55b) good: as we will discuss in Chapter 5, in contrast to bare NPs, *odin*-NPs can escape islands.

(55) a.

Do	*men'a*	*došël*	*slux,*	*čto*	*vas'a*	*ženit'sa*	*na*	*ital'janke.*
to	me	reached	rumor	that	V.	marries	on	Italian

1. 'I heard a rumor: "Vasya is marrying an Italian".'
2. 'There is an Italian such that I heard a rumor that Vasya is marrying them.'

b.

Do	*men'a*	*došël*	*slux,*	*čto*	*vas'a*	*ženit'sa*	*na*	#*(odnoj)*	*ital'janke.*
to	me	reached	rumor	that	V.	marries	on	SP.IND	Italian

Posprašivav,	*ja*	*uznal,*	*čto*	*éto*	*nepravda:*
having_asked	I	learned	that	this	false

éta	*italjanka*	*sostoit*	*v*	*sčastlivom*	*brake*	*s*	*drugim*	*mužčinoj*
this	Italian	forms	in	happy	marriage	with	another	man

'I heard a rumor that Vasya married an Italian. After asking (some people), I learned that this Italian is happily married to another man.'

Again, the only scenario when the bare NP in (55a) can be understood as referring to an existing Italian woman is the one where the domain is contextually restricted to a single Italian salient for the speaker and the addressee. In this case, the illusion of the wide scope reading arises due to the combination of the domain restriction to a single Italian (which also affects the possible worlds where the rumor is true) and the fact that this Italian is known to exist in the actual world.

All the generalizations above are true of bare plurals as well. The bare plural *ital'jancy* 'Italians' in (56a) can only be interpreted within the scope of the modal operator of the word *slux* 'rumor'; in other words, existence of the mentioned Italians is a part of the rumor. This is further shown in (56b) where the referent of the NP cannot later be anaphorically accessed in the actual world. As in the previous case, consultants ask to add *kakie-to* 'some (plural)' or some other specific indefinite determiner to the bare NP for (56b) to be felicitous. And once again, the only case where (56a) can be understood as a claim of Italians existing in the actual world is in the one where the domain of Italians under consideration is restricted by the previous discourse and the purposes of the conversation to a particular group (and given these conditions, this scenario is compatible with the narrow scope reading).

(56) a.

Do	*men'a*	*došël*	*slux,*	*čto*	*vas'a*	*podružils'a*	*s*	*ital'jancami*.
to	me	reached	rumor	that	V.	befriended	with	Italians

1. 'I heard a rumor: "Vasya made friends with Italians".'
2. # 'There are Italians such that I heard a rumor that Vasya made friends with them.'

b.

#*Do*	*men'a*	*došël*	*slux,*	*čto*	*vas'a*	*podružils'a*	*s*	*ital'jancami*.
to	me	reached	rumor	that	V.	befriended	with	Italians

No	*éto*	*nepravda:*	*on*	*prosto*	*byl*	*s*	*étimi*	*ital'jancami*
but	this	false	he	just	was	with	these	Italians

na	*obščej*	*tuse.*
on	common	party

Intended: 'I heard a rumor that Vasya made friends with some Italians. But this is not true: he just was on the same party with these Italians.'

Thus, as we saw in this section, bare NPs in Russian obey island constraints, at least the ones that were discussed the most with respect to the quantifier scope restrictions: conditional antecedents and complex NPs. As will be discussed later, in Chapter 5, this distinguishes them from *a*-NPs, and this distinction will play an important role in explaining the key distributional difference between the two types of indefinites.

3.3. Interaction with *for*-adverbials

Regarding the scopal patterns of Russian bare NPs discussed so far, bare singulars and bare plurals behave uniformly. There is one case, however, where a potential misalignment may be seen. Namely, the two types of bare NPs differ in whether they can have a so-called *different object reading* (Champollion 2010) when their VP is modified by a duration adverbial: bare plurals can normally get it, but bare singulars normally cannot. Consider, for instance, the contrast in (57). The sentence in (57a) can be used to describe a situation in which Vasily kept building different houses one after another over the course of twenty years. In contrast, (57b) entails that Vasya kept building the same house for this period.

(57) a. *Vasilij dvadcat' let stroil doma dl'a vojennyx.*
V. twenty years built houses for military_people
'Vasily built houses for the military for twenty years.'

b. *Vasilij dvadcat' let stroil dom dl'a vojennyx.*
V. twenty years built house for military_people
'Vasily built a house for the military for twenty years.'

The contrast between different types of indefinites in accessibility of the different object reading is, of course, not unique to Russian: it has been observed in other languages as well (see e.g. Dayal 2004; Tiutiunnikova 2025). The most detailed empirical coverage of this phenomenon is provided for English data. Consider the contrast between bare plurals and bare masses on one hand, and *some*- and *a*-indefinites and numeral phrases on the other hand, illustrated in (58).

(58) a. *John found fleas on his dog for a month.* (Champollion 2013: 436)

b. *John discovered crabgrass in his yard for six weeks.* (Champollion 2013: 436)

c. ??*John found a flea on his dog for a month.* (Champollion 2013: 435)

d. *John killed (??some) mosquitos for an hour.* (Chierchia 2023: 64)

e. *John saw thirty zebras for three hours.* (Champollion 2013: 435)

In (58a) and (58b), the participants of the repeating events can vary from one instance to another: (58a) is true under a scenario where John found a different group of fleas each time; likewise, (58b) is true if every time within the six weeks, John discovered a different portion of crabgrass. In contrast, the objects in (58c-58e) cannot covary: (58c) sounds odd because it is only true under a scenario where John kept finding the same flea for several times; (58d) sounds even odder because it implies that John kept killing the same group of mosquitoes repeatedly; finally, (58e) entails that John saw the same group of thirty zebras throughout these three hours.

Researchers disagree on whether the contrast in the availability of the different object reading is scopal in nature or can be explained independently. Provided that this is, in particular, the only case where Russian bare singulars and bare plurals do not behave alike, the second approach is preferential for our purposes since it will allow to preserve the scopal uniformity of bare NPs. In the remainder of this section, I will compare the two accounts and show that the "no scope" approach can predict some data on *for*-adverbials that the "scope" approach cannot.

According to the scopal approach (Carlson 1977; Chierchia 1998 et seq.), in which *for*-adverbials are universal quantifiers over minimal subintervals of the event's time, the indefinites from the second group cannot get the narrow-scope with respect to *for*-adverbials due to a type mismatch. Namely, their semantic type, <<e,t>, t>, is non-composable with the verb's type <e, … <v, t>>, and they are obligatorily QRed into a position higher than the one where *for*-adverbials are attached. As a result, only the wide scope reading is available for that group of indefinites. In contrast, bare plurals and bare masses are assumed to undergo some sort of semantic incorporation[15], which allows them to be interpreted within the scope of *for*-adverbials.

The alternative approach, proposed in (Champollion 2010) and then developed in (Champollion 2013), treats this contrast not as a difference in scope, but as a difference in the event structure of the two types of predicates. According to this account, in which *for*-adverbials are simple measure phrases that do not take scope, the apparent "different object" reading observed for bare plurals and bare masses is a side effect of the cumulative relation between subparts of the plural event and the plural/mass individual. Namely, plural and mass individuals[16] are non-atomic, and their parts can distribute across different subevents of a pluralized event. In contrast, singular individuals are

[15] The exact formalization of the incorporation process differs across approaches. In the classic neo-Carlsonian approach (Chierchia 1998; Dayal 2004), bare plurals and bare masses denote kinds, and an existential "instances-of-the-kind" interpretation is derived when they occupy argumental positions of object-level predicates. In other approaches (e.g. Krifka 2003), bare NPs simply denote predicates and compose with the verb's predicate by a version of predicate modification; the individual variable then undergoes local existential closure.

[16] Of course, I assume a covert relativization here: individuals are singular/plural/mass *with respect to the predicate* that they satisfy. Naturally, the same object can often be represented as, say, plural or singular. For instance, Syd Barrett, Nick Mason, Roger Watters, Richard Wright, and David Gilmour can (collectively) be characterized by a predicate over singulars *rock band* or by a predicate over plurals *Pink Floyd members*.

atomic and cannot distribute their parts across the subevents, so they require to be presented "as a whole" throughout the event. This explains the different object readings of (63a) and (63b) and the same object reading of (63c).

But why are the sentences in (63d) and (63e), with plural objects, cannot get the different object reading? Champollion (2010; 2013) argues that this is because *for*-adverbials require that the VP they modify has a subinterval property[17] (Krifka 1989). While VPs of bare plurals and bare masses trivially satisfy this requirement (due to the non-specificity and non-atomicity of the individuals), VPs with specific indefinites like *some mosquitoes* or numerals like *thirty zebras*, where the parts of the plural individuals are distributed across different subevents, do not. To satisfy the requirement of the *for*-adverbials, such indefinites must QR out of the VP, leaving a trace. The adverbial cannot access the QRed binder and treats this trace as a fixed and atomic variable, so the same object reading is derived.

Importantly, in the latter approach, there is no difference in type between the two groups of indefinites: they are uniformly analyzed as existential quantifiers. While Champollion (2010; 2013) does not explicitly discuss the type mismatch issue, it is natural to assume that indefinites just QR into a position lower than *for*-adverbials, and thus their lexical content is a part of the VP's meaning accessible for the subinterval requirement (in contrast to the cases where the indefinite needs to QR again to satisfy this constraint).

[17] Simply put, (the denotation of) a VP has a subinterval property if any event from the VP's extension is dividable into subevents that are also within the VP's extension. For instance, *eat apples* has a subinterval property: assuming that *apples* is semantically number-neutral and *eat* means 'eat completely', any subpart of an event from the extension of *eat apples* is also within its extension. In contrast, *eat the apples* does not have a subinterval property: any subpart of an event from this VP's extension can not satisfy the predicate because it will only include a part of the meant specific group of apples.

An advantage of Champollion's alternative approach is that it is more compatible than the classic approach with cases where indefinites that normally cannot get the same object reading get it with the help of explicitly or implicitly added temporal distributivity operators, lik in (59).

(59) a. *We built a huge snowman in our yard for several years.* (Deo & Piñango 2011: 303)

b. *John found a flea on his dog every day for a month.* (Zucchi & White 2001: 239)

For the scopal approach, these cases are problematic because the existential quantifiers take narrow scope with respect to *for*-adverbials, so a movement of *for*-adverbials themselves needs to be postulated to avoid the type mismatch (and this movement needs to be motivated). In contrast, for Champollion's approach, such cases are not directly threatening because the different object reading is derived not due to narrow scope, but due to cumulativity. To account for the exceptional cases like in (59), Champollion argues that the distributive operators essentially pluralize the single individuals and then the same cumulativity relation as with plural and mass individuals is established, leading to the different object reading.

Crucially, addition of a covert or an overt temporal distributivity operator licenses the different object meaning for Russian bare singulars as well, as shown in (60). The sentence in (60a), in contrast to (57), can be used to say that Vasya kept building different houses throughout the twenty years. In (60b), addition of the adverbial *na zavtrak* 'at breakfast' leads to accommodation of a covert temporal distributivity operator 'every day', and (60b) is true under the (most natural) scenario where Vasya ate different breakfast sandwiches during this time. Without the adverbial *na zavtrak*, (60b) sounds odd: what is asserted is that for five years, Vasya was engaged in eating the same sandwich.

(60) a. *Vas'ilij dvadcat' let #(každyje tri mes'aca) stroil dom vojennym.*

V. twenty years every three months built house military_people

'Vasily built a house for the military every three months for twenty years.'

b. *Vas'a p'at' let el (na zavtrak) buterbrod s syrom.*

V. five years ate at breakfast sandwich with cheese

'Vasya ate a sandwich with cheese at breakfast for five years.'

Thus, while the contrast in the availability of the different object marking between bare singulars and bare plurals can be seen as a difference in their scopal patterns, there is an alternative explanation to it which does not involve scope and has a better predictive power. Given that there are no other cases where one might suspect any scopal difference between bare singulars and bare plurals, I conclude that the scopal properties of Russian bare NPs are uniform.

3.4. Summary

Thus, bare NPs in Russian feature variable scope (based on the data with quantificational adverbials like *každyj den'* 'every day' and desire predicates like *xotet'* 'want'), but do obey island constraints (based on the data from conditional antecedent and complex NP islands). This is the final ingredient that was needed, and we can move on to the final section.

4. Summary and semantic analysis

4.1. Bare NPs as existential quantifiers

Thus, in this chapter, I have argued, compiling and supplementing already existing evidence, that bare NPs in Russian: i) are unrestricted indefinites — they can introduce novel discourse referents and allow their individuals to be non-unique with respect to their descriptive content; ii) feature variable scope — they can take both wide scope and narrow scope with respect to such semantic operators as quantification adverbials or desire predicates; iii) obey island constraints — they cannot scope out of such commonly discussed islands as the conditional antecedent and the sentential complement of an NP.

Following the classic approach to variable-scope island-obeying indefinites, I will argue that argumental bare NPs in Russian are **generalized existential quantifiers over individuals**. In the spirit[18] of the classic account of the interpretation of determiner-less nominals — the neo-Carlsonian approach (Chierchia 1998; Dayal 2004) — I will assume that bare NPs in Russian start as properties, or predicates over individuals, and are type-shifted via the covert operator *ex* (Partee 1986) into existential quantifiers in argumental positions.

Consider, for example, how the interpretation of the sentence in (61a) is derived within the simplistic formal semantics (that is, the one without events, time intervals, possible worlds or assignment functions). The NP *sobaka* 'dog' enters the derivation as a predicate over individuals (61b), the same way as its English analogue would have done. To avoid a type mismatch and compose with the predicate of the verb *lajat'* 'bark', the denotation of the NP is shifted into a generalized existential quantifier via the covert operator *ex* (61c). Having received the quantifier type, the NP can now compose with the verb via Functional Application, deriving the truth conditions for (61a) as in (61d).

(61) a. *Sobaka lajet.*

[18] As discussed in Chapter 4, the arsenal of type-shifters in the classic neo-Carlsonian approach (Chierchia 1998; Dayal 2004) is richer: in addition to *ex*, it includes a type-shifter *iota* that turns nominal predicates into definites and a type-shifter *nom* that turns cumulative nominal predicates (that is, plurals and masses) into corresponding kinds (which are, formally, intensionalized maximal satisfiers). I will argue, however, that at least for Russian, this system with the two additional type-shifters is redundant, and my approach with one type-shifter and the pragmatic constraints postulated in Chapter 3 predicts the data more accurately.

dog barks

'A dog is barking.'

b. ⟦sobaka⟧ = λx_e. dog(x)

c. *ex* ⟦sobaka⟧ = $\lambda V_{<e, t>}$. ∃x [dog(x) & V(x)]

d. ⟦sobaka lajet⟧ = ∃x [dog(x) & bark(x)]

Importantly, the truth conditions in (61d) cover not only the scenarios where the dog is just one of the many in the context, but also the ones where it is unique. This is so because in contrast to, for example, English *a*-indefinites, Russian bare NPs do not have a definite counterpart and are not strengthened into quantifiers over non-unique/non-maximal individuals. Thus, the formula in (61d) is neutral with respect to whether the witness is the unique dog or not.

In one common theory of context update (Stalnaker 1998), existential quantification over an individual leads to introduction of a discourse referent representing that individual into the interlocutors' shared information state. In combination with this assumption, the formula in (61d) predicts that the bare NP *sobaka* 'dog' introduces a discourse referent. At the same time, nothing in the system prevents this referent to be understood as being the same with one of already introduced ones: assuming that information structure clues like topic intonation or simply general reasoning can hint to such an interpretation, the NP *sobaka* in (61a) can be understood as picking out an old discourse referent.

The scope ambiguity of the shifted bare NPs is accounted for via Quantifier Raising. Let us see how the two readings for the toy sentence in (62a) are derived.

(62) a. *Každyj den' sobaka lajet.*

every day dog barks

1. 'Everyday, a (potentially new) dog is barking.'
2. 'The same dog is barking every day.'

b. [everyday [*ex*-dog [bark]]

c. [*ex*-dog$_i$ [everyday t_i [bark]]

d. $\forall t$ [[day'(t)] $\exists e$ $\exists x$ [dog(x) & bark (x, e) & time(e) $\leq$ t]

e. $\exists x$ [dog'(x) & $\forall t$ [[day(t)] $\exists e$ [bark (x, e) & time(e) $\leq$ t]]]

The first, narrow-scope reading has the logical form schematically represented in (62b): the existential quantifier is first composed with the verb and then gets itself interpreted within a quantificational adverbial. This derives the truth conditions as in (62d), where the toy event semantics is used to account for the contribution of the adverbial. According to this formula, (62a) is true iff for any day time interval, there is an event temporally located within that day such that a dog is barking in this event. Crucially, each event can feature a different dog barking, so (62a) is true if different dogs were barking at different days.

To derive the wide-scope reading, the quantifier must QR to arrive at a position higher than the temporal adverbial, deriving the LF as in (62c). The interpretation of this structure results in the formula in (62e), where the quantifier over individuals does not fall within the scope of the adverbial and binds its trace left in-situ. According to this formula, (62a) is true iff there is such a dog that for any day time interval *t*, there is an event temporally located in *t* in which this dog is barking. In contrast to the previous formula, this one requires that the dog is the same across all the barking events. In particular, since the individual does not covary across time intervals, it can be referred back to by a subsequent anaphora.

Finally, the proposed analysis combined with the assumption[19] that the QR is bound by the constraints on local movement (e.g., Ruys & Winter 2011, Dayal 2013a) predicts that bare NPs cannot scope out of islands, as desired. For instance, the bare NP in (63a) cannot scope out of the conditional antecedent as in (63c), so only the structure as in (63b) is available. As a result, (63a) can only be interpreted as in (63d), according to which in any case when whichever dog barks, it is raining. In particular, (63a) is correctly predicted to be false under a scenario where only one of many dogs can cause the rain by barking. This scenario would have been covered by the formula in (63e), corresponding to the LF in (63c), but since such structure is unavailable, this reading is absent.

(63) a. *Jesli* *lajet* *sobaka,* *idët* *dožd'.*

if barks dog goes rain

1. 'If any dog is barking, it is raining.'
2. # 'There is a dog such that if it is barking, it is raining.'

b. [[if [*ex*-dog [barks]]] rain [goes]]

c. *[*ex*-dog$_i$ [[[if [t$_i$ barks]] rain [goes]]]

d. ∀w [∃x [dog'(x, w) & bark'(x, w) => rain'(w)]

e. *∃x [dog'(x, w$_0$) & A∀w [bark'(x, w) => rain'(w)]

[19] While being classic, this assumption is often disputed as too general, see e.g. Farkas 1981 and Barker 2022a for more discussion.

Thus, the observed unrestricted indefiniteness and island-bound variable scope of argumental bare NPs can be accounted for if we treat them as generalized existential quantifiers over individuals. In the next section, however, I will show that there is a constraint on the use of bare NPs in anti-unique contexts that this analysis can not predict on its own.

4.2. Unexpected distributional constraint

The analysis proposed in the previous section predicts that all things being equal, bare NPs in Russian should be freely available in any[20] context where we would expect a classic indefinite like *a*-NPs. This is not the case, however. In contrast to *a*-NPs and many other indefinites attested cross-linguistically, Russian bare NPs do not pass the consistency test (an observation first made in Dayal 2004). Namely, two identical bare nominals uttered within the same local context cannot get witnessed by two different individuals. For instance, the sentence in (64a), where the indefinite reading of both NPs is forced by the fact that the same individual cannot normally bark and sleep at the same time, is infelicitous. This contrasts sharply with the data on English *a*-indefinites: they are available in such cases, as shown in (64b).

(64) a. #*Na ulice sobaka lajet i sobaka spit.*
on street dog barks and dog sleeps
'In the street, a dog is barking and a dog is sleeping.'

b. *A dog is barking and a dog is sleeping.*

[20] That is, of course, except cases where an indefinite escapes islands: *a*-indefinites can do that and Russian bare NPs cannot. This difference will be discussed later, in Chapter 5 — the contrast discussed here is (for now) independent from it.

The infelicity of (64a) is not predicted by the proposed analysis. Since bare NPs are analyzed as existential quantifiers without any restriction on the nominal predicate's restriction's size, the predicted formula for (64a), provided in (65), is compatible with a scenario where the witnesses of the two quantifiers are not identical to each other — and yet, the sentence in (64a) is infelicitous.

(65) $\exists x_e$ [dog'(x) & bark'(x)] & $\exists y_e$ [dog'(y) & sleep'(y)]

Crucially, a sequence of identical bare NPs is nevertheless felicitous if they refer to the same individual. While such an interpretation of (64a) is odd for apparent pragmatic reasons, we have already seen examples where the bare NP can pick out an old discourse referent, introduced earlier by the identical nominal, as in (66).

(66)	*Na*	*tom*	*stole*	*ležala*	*kniga*	*i*	*gazeta.*	*An'a*	*vz'ala*	*knigu.*
	on	that	table	lied	book	and	newspaper	A.	took	book

'A book and a newspaper were lying on that table. Anya took the book.'

(Geist 2010: 194)

Thus, a sequence of identical bare NPs is only felicitous if they are used to talk about the same individual. This generalization led Dayal (2004) to argue that bare NPs (in her case, only bare singulars, although as we will see shortly the same exact issue arises with bare plurals) are what we would call after Schwarz 2009 weak definites: they require that the individual they pick out is unique or maximal with respect to their descriptive content.

We have already seen that such an analysis is inapplicable to Russian bare NPs: regardless of their number feature, they can occur in the context where more than one satisfiers of the nominal's predicate are available. For instance, the sentence as in (64a) becomes felicitous if we drop one of the clauses, as in (67); crucially, both (67a) and (67b) are acceptable (and true) in a context where the other clause would have been true.

(67) Scenario. There are two dogs in the street, one of them is barking, the other one is sleeping.

a. *Na ulice sobaka lajet.*

on street dog barks

'In the street, a dog is barking.'

b. *Na ulice sobaka spit.*

on street dog sleeps

'In the street, a dog is sleeping.'

The contrast between (64a) on one hand and (67a) and (67b) on the other hand shows that the felicity of a bare NP in a context with multiple satisfiers of its predicate is sensitive to what has and what has not been already said in the same context. An example in (68) demonstrates this even clearer: a chain of identical bare NPs used to refer to different individuals can become felicitous if an adjective like *drugoj* 'other' is added, highlighting that the second girl is different from the first one. Crucially, only the second bare NP, not the first one, is required to express the difference in their referents.

(68) *Na ulice plačet devočka, a drugaja devočka jejo uspokaivajet.*

on street cries girl but another girl her comforting

'In the street, a girl is crying, and another girl is comforting her.'

Thus, what we have seen above is that the ability of a bare NP to refer to a non-unique individual is sensitive to whether other individuals meeting its descriptive content have been mentioned in the prior discourse. This means that this requirement is *dynamic* in nature: a static formula, like our analysis of bare NPs in (63c), can not incorporate it.

But is this dynamic requirement a part of the NP's semantics or a side effect of a general pragmatic constraint? The second option is preferable because that would allow us to preserve the simplistic, static existential quantifier semantics for bare NPs; it would be even more attractive if we were able to show that this principle is needed anyway for independent reasons, or, even better, that it has been already postulated.

The constraints on bare NPs in Russian we just observed remind to certain extent the distribution restrictions of anaphoric definites discussed in Section 2.2. Just like Russian bare NPs, anaphoric definites are not sensitive to whether or not their referent is unique/maximal with respect to their predicate (69a) but require it to be the only one updated within the local context prior to the utterance (69b). Had anaphoric definites also been able to introduce novel discourse referents (which they of course cannot do, (69c)) under the same restriction, they would behave identically to Russian bare NPs.

(69) a. Scenario. There is more than one pen on the table, only one of them is red.

The red pen$_i$ that's on the table is my favorite. My grandfather gave me ***the pen***$_i$ *as a birthday present last year.* (Srinivas et al. 2020: 695)

b. *We ate a pineapple$_i$ and a watermelon$_j$ at breakfast.* $^{\#}$***The fruit***$_{i/j}$ *was delicious!*

c. (said out of blue)

$^{\#}$*The student in my class came to office hour today.* (Srinivas et al. 2020: 695)

This familiarity defines the further course of my investigation. In the next chapter, I will show that the observed constraint on the bare NP's reference can be analyzed as a part of the same phenomenon as anaphora resolution, with the only difference that bare NPs can also introduce novel discourse referents. Namely, I will argue that the distribution of bare NPs (and nominal expressions more generally) is constrained by the general pragmatic rule of reference: an NP can be used to pick out a discourse referent *i* in the local context *c* only if there are no other discourse referents given in *c* that meet the NP's descriptive content.

Chapter 3. Bare NPs in Russian: pragmatics

In this chapter, I will provide the pragmatic part of my account of bare NPs in Russian, arguing that their limited distribution in indefinite contexts can be explained by a dynamic constraint on their use. Namely, I will argue that bare NPs obey a generalized version of the *informational uniqueness/maximality* requirement proposed in (Roberts 2003), which I name The Unambiguity Constraint: in a context *c*, a bare NP with a predicate P can be used to introduce a novel discourse referent if and only if there are no familiar discourse referents that are entailed by *c* to also satisfy P; if there are such discourse referents, then the bare NP can only be used anaphorically, picking out the maximal given discourse referent entailed by *c* to satisfy P.

The structure of the chapter is as follows. I will start with Section 1, where I introduce the necessary formal background for the dynamic pragmatic framework in which I will be working in and overview the theory of informational uniqueness requirement for anaphoric expressions proposed in (Roberts 2003). This will allow me in Section 2 to propose the analysis (the Unambiguity Constraint) and show how it, in addition to accounting for the unexpected distribution restrictions of bare NPs observed at the end of Chapter 2, makes more general predictions on the introductory and anaphoric uses of bare NPs, detecting previously unknown empirical contrasts in the data. After that, in Section 3, I will discuss some at first glance challenging cases where the use of the same bare NP introduces multiple discourse referents. I will account for them by showing that they still do obey the Unambiguity Constraint within the local contexts of their interpretation. Finally, I will conclude in Section 4.

1. Theoretical background

1.1. Theory of context update

It is well known that the felicity and interpretation of certain linguistic expressions depend on what was asserted or mentioned prior in the same discourse. Consider, for example, the dynamic nature of the presupposition satisfaction, exemplified in (70). The verb *regret* has a presupposition that its complement is true. For instance, (70a) is only felicitous in contexts where the addressee either knows or is willing to accommodate as given that John left Los Angeles. In contrast, (70b) does not have such a felicity condition: it can (and, in fact, normally should) be said in a context where the addressee does not know that John left Los Angeles. Of course, the informal explanation for this contrast is very clear: by uttering the first conjunct in (70b), the speaker provides the information the addressee needs to be given to interpret the second conjunct. But what it means for the theory of the presupposition is that the context in which it is satisfied must be restricted by the information provided prior in the discourse, not just by the common ground the speakers shared before the speech act.

(70) a. *John regrets that he left Los Angeles.*

b. *John moved out of Los Angeles to study in New York, but now he regrets that he left Los Angeles.*

The classic formal implementation of this intuition, from Stalnaker 1974, involves thinking of the context of evaluation as a set of possible worlds c in which all the propositions the speakers agreed on are true. Whenever a new proposition p is asserted, it is evaluated according to this context c and, if it is accepted as true by the addressee, c gets intersected with the set of possible worlds where *p* is true as well. The intersection becomes a new context of evaluation *c'*, and the next uttered proposition *p'* is already evaluated in *c'*. This process is called *context update*: a proposition *p updates* *c*, turning it into *c'*.

Let us see how such a system accounts for the contrast between (70a) and (70b). Let *c* be the common ground context and *cp* mean "update *c* with *p*". Both sentences in (70) have a clause *John regrets that he left Los Angeles*, which requires that the preceding context consists only of worlds where it is true that John left Los Angeles. However, they differ in which exact context this restriction applies to. In (70a), where this clause contributes to the first and only update, it is applied to the initial context *c* — hence the requirement that John's leaving Los Angeles is a part of the common ground. In contrast, in (70b), the same clause gets interpreted only after the context is already updated with the proposition *p* of the first clause, so the presupposition satisfaction is checked only in the worlds of *c* where *p* is true. Given that *p* is identical to the second clause's presupposition, it is always satisfied. Crucially, in this case, no requirements are applied to *c* itself, so, in contrast to (70a), (70b) does not require anything from the (initial) common ground.

(71) a. $c[\![(1a)]\!] = c \cap \{w \mid \text{John regrets that he left LA in } w\}$, defined iff John left LA in *c*

b. $c[\![(1b)]\!] = (c \cap \{w \mid \text{John left LA to study in NY}\}) \cap \{w \mid \text{John regrets that he left LA } w\}$,

defined iff John left LA in $(c \cap \{w \mid \text{John left LA in } w\})$

Updating the context with new propositions is not the only dynamic tool required to account for some linguistic phenomena. In addition to what has been agreed on to be true in prior context, some expressions are sensitive to what has been brought up as an object of discussion. Such expressions are called *anaphoric*: they can only be used in a context where an entity satisfying their semantic requirements has been mentioned or at least made salient in the prior discourse.

Consider some examples below. In (72a), the use of the pronoun *he* is infelicitous unless a male individual has been brought up in the conversation that it can refer to. In (72b), the adjective *other* requires that an individual different from the one witnessed by its DP was mentioned in the prior discourse. Finally, the felicitous use of *too* in (72c) requires that a proposition with the shared at-issue content was brought up earlier in the conversation.

(72) a. $^{\#}$*(Mary saw **a guy$_i$** at the front door.) **He$_i$** looked really scared.*

b. $^{\#}$(*I told my parents that I finished **"War and Peace"$_i$**.) Mom gave me **another$_{j \neq i}$** book.*

c. $^{\#}$*(My friends **like my husband$_i$**, and) I like Bobby, **too$_i$**.*

Importantly, objects under discussion that license the use of anaphoric expressions do not always correspond to entities in the actual world. Consider, for instance, examples in (73). In (73a), the pronoun *it* refers to a hypothetical bathroom: as evident by the mere use of the first disjunct, the speaker is not sure whether there is an actual bathroom in the house. In (73b), the pronoun *it* refers to a bathroom which does not exist in the actual world, as follows from the first sentence. Such abstract entities are called *discourse referents* (Karttunen 1976).

(73) a. *Either there isn't **a bathroom$_i$** in this house or **it$_i$**'s in a funny place.* (Roberts 1989: 702)

b. *There isn't **a bathroom$_i$**. **It$_i$** would be upstairs.* (Hofmann 2025: 34)

In formal theories that make use of discourse referents, context is represented not just like a set of possible worlds, but as a set of ordered pairs <w, g>, where *w* is a possible world and *g* is an assignment function. While the role of possible worlds is the same as discussed before (to keep track of the common ground propositions), assignment functions are used to store discourse referents available in the context. Namely, a discourse referent is represented as a numeric index within the domain of an assignment function *g* mapped to a certain individual.

Let us consider a toy context that has three discourse referents representing three animals: a dog, a squirrel, and a raccoon. In classic formal approaches to discourse, this context will be represented as an information state in which assignment functions look like in (74a) [21] and possible worlds are restricted to the set in (74b). As you can see, the contribution of the assignment function is that it allows context to accumulate information about a particular discourse referent; this information is later used by anaphoric expressions that search for a discourse referent satisfying their descriptive content.

(74) a. g := {1 → d, 2 → s, 3→ r}

b. {w | dog'(g(1), w), squirrel'(g(3), w), racoon'(g(4), w)}

Introduction of a new discourse referent in the context is represented as change of the assignment functions corresponding to the possible worlds in which the referent's existence is assumed. Namely, each assignment function *g* in this part of the information state is replaced with another

[21] Note that the classic approach to discourse reference is *non-deterministic*: the information state contains many different assignment functions, and the same discourse referent, that is, the same index *i*, can return different individuals in different assignment functions. This is made so to mirror the fact that whenever a discourse referent is introduced by a common noun in an utterance, it can only be clear from the contextual, extralinguistic knowledge which individual it corresponds to — and even then, the hearer or even the speaker might not know the identity of the discourse referent. For instance, the sentence in (i) can be felicitously uttered and understood even if the speaker does not know which exact dog is barking:

(i) *Johny, there is **a dog** barking outside, I can't sleep!*

In that sense, the discourse is only responsible for collecting the knowledge about whoever that individual is and thus cutting out assignment functions incompatible with new properties ascribed to the discourse referent. And of course, the assignment function in (74a) is just one of many available in the context in (74), and the others assign different individuals to the same indices.

function *g'* which differs from *g* only in that it has a new index *i* mapping onto an individual *a*, representing the new discourse referent.

As we discussed in previous sections, introduction of discourse referents is triggered by a use of indefinite. But how exactly this process works? To answer this question, we first need to decide on whether we adopt a semantic or a pragmatic approach to the context update.

Dynamic approaches crucially differ in their assumptions on how exactly the semantic content of an uttered sentence updates the context. *Dynamic semantic* approaches (e.g., Heim 1982,

& Stokhof 1991, Kamp & Reyle 1993) argue that linguistic expressions are semantically interpreted as functions from one context (or discourse representation) to another — in effect, instructions to update; in contrast, *dynamic pragmatic* approaches (e.g., Lewis 2012, Lauer 2013, Stalnaker 2018) assume that the semantic composition per se is static (that is, sentences are interpreted as propositions, not instructions to update the context), and the context update is treated as a purely pragmatic phenomenon, responsive to the communicative actions of the speaker and their audience. In this paper, I will adopt the dynamic pragmatic approach for the reasons of simplicity, assuming that the static approach to the meaning composition is conceptually simpler than the dynamic one[22] (Stalnaker 2018; Lewis 2014). Nothing in my analysis, however, will crucially depend on this choice, so it can be converted into a dynamic semantic account if necessary.

While in dynamic semantics, introduction of a new discourse referent is a direct instruction to the context typically encoded as a meaning of an indefinite (Heim 1982), in dynamic pragmatics, a

[22] See, however, Rothschild & Yalcin (2016) and Stojnić (2019) for the opposing view.

new discourse referent is introduced when use of an expression conveying existential quantification over an individual results in updating the context with a discourse referent whose output is restricted by the indefinite's predicate (Lewis 2012, Mandelkern 2022). An example of introduction of a discourse referent is provided in (75). First, the semantic composition of the indefinite DP results in the existential proposition: there is a dog *x* (75a) in the given world. Once computed, this proposition updates the context set. At this stage, the existential quantification over the variable *x* is interpreted as a signal for the addressee to introduce a discourse referent *7* whose output is a dog individual *a*. This leads to narrowing down the context *c* to the set of world-assignment function pairs <*w*, *g*> such that *g* contains a discourse referent for the individual *a* and *a* is a dog in *w* (75b).

(75) a. **Semantic input**: $[\![\text{a dog}]\!] \Rightarrow \{\text{w} \mid \exists\text{x}\ [\text{dog}\ (\text{x})]\ \text{in w}\}$

b. **Pragmatic output**: $\{\langle \text{w}, \text{g}^{[7 \rightarrow \text{a}]}\rangle \mid \langle \text{w}, \text{g}\rangle \in \text{c}\ \&\ \text{dog'}(\text{g}(7))\ \text{in w}\}$

In contrast to indefinites, (strong) definites and other anaphoric expressions pick out already given discourse referents. In the classic formal semantics (e.g., Heim & Kratzer 1998), the anaphoric component of their meaning is represented as a free variable that gets its evaluation from an assignment function *g* available in the context. While the exact value of the variable is defined by which exact assignment function is chosen from the context, anaphoric expressions often have lexicalized restrictions on what that value could be. For instance, a personal pronoun like *she* requires that the variable it expresses be mapped to something (viewed in the conversation as) female (76a); anaphoric definites like *the cat* require their variable to satisfy their predicate (76b); *other* conveys that the contextually supplied individual *x* is distinct from its core individual satisfier *y* (76c), etc.

(76) a. $[\![\text{she}_i]\!]^g = g(i)$, defined iff *female'*(g(i))

b. $[\![\text{the cat}_j]\!] = g(j)$, defined iff *cat'*(g(j))

c. $[\![\text{other}_k]\!]^g = \lambda y.\ \lambda P.\ P'(g(k))\ \&\ P'(y)\ \&\ y \neq g(k)$

Note, however, that saying that anaphoric expressions like in (76) simply require there to be a contextually provided assignment function that would provide the value for their variable satisfying the associated predicate is not enough. Namely, as we saw already, anaphoric definites require that their discourse referent is not only familiar, but also unique with respect to their descriptive content[23]. Recall (69b), repeated here as (77). The analysis of the strong definite like in (76b) predicts that its use in (77) is felicitous: by the time the second sentence is uttered, the context already has two discourse referents (introduced by indefinites in the first sentence) that satisfy the definite's predicate, so the definite should be able to pick out any of it. In reality, however, the use of *the fruit* is infelicitous since it is not clear which exact fruit among the two given ones the speaker was referring to.

(77) *We ate a pineapple$_i$ and a watermelon$_j$ at breakfast.* #***The fruit**$_{i/j}$ was delicious!*

In the next section, I will review an account of this restriction based on the notion of informational uniqueness.

[23] Hereafter I will, for the sake of simplicity, sometimes say that discourse referents satisfy the predicate/meet the descriptive content of a (certain) nominal. While this is, of course, logically inaccurate (discourse referents themselves are just numeric indices), I adapt this as a short way of saying that discourse referents are *known to map onto individuals* satisfying the predicate/meeting the descripitive content of the nominal.

1.2. Informational uniqueness of anaphoric expressions

At the end of Chapter 2, I mentioned that the observed dynamic restriction on the use of bare NPs in Russian is very similar to an informational uniqueness constraint attributed to anaphoric definites in English (Roberts 2003). Namely, in both cases, the discourse referent that an NP is used to pick out must be the only one satisfying its predicate. In this section, I will discuss the restriction on informational uniqueness in more detail, to argue in the next section that the dynamic constraints on the use of bare NPs can be captured by a generalized version of it.

The informational uniqueness-based analysis of definites in English was proposed in Roberts 2003, as a response to the traditional analysis of definites in which their uniqueness presupposition is treated as a simple requirement on individuals available in the context. As has already been known for some time (at least after Heim 1982), such an analysis is too restrictive: definites can felicitously be used in a context where the individual they pick out is clearly not the unique satisfier of their predicate, even among ones present locally. Consider, for instance, (78). According to Roberts, (78) can be used in a scenario where the mentioned glass is not the only one that was broken last night. This is challenging for the classic approach to the uniqueness presupposition because under such a scenario, the definite *the glass* clearly refers to a non-unique satisfier of its predicate.

(78) *A wine glass broke last night. The glass has been very expensive.*

(Heim 1982; Roberts 2003: 293)

Building upon examples like in (78), Roberts claims that the uniqueness requirement of definites does not apply to the set of all individuals present in the context; instead, it applies only to those that are *represented by discourse referents*. Thus, the use of the definite *the glass* in the provided scenario is not problematic because the other glass was not mentioned or salient in the prior context and hence does not have a corresponding discourse referent.

Using the classic approach to the context as an information state, Roberts postulates a discourse-based analysis of definites, provided here in (79):

(79) **Informational Existence and Uniqueness of Definite NPs**

Given a context *c*, use of a definite NP_i presupposes that it has as antecedent a discourse referent *x* which is:

a) weakly familiar[24] in *c*, and

b) unique among discourse referents in *c* in being contextually entailed to satisfy the descriptive content of NP.

(Roberts 2003: 308)

The new analysis predicts that the uniqueness presupposition of a definite will only get violated if two or more of its satisfiers have been actually *mentioned* in the previous context. This prediction is borne out, as shown in (80): after two indefinite NPs are used to introduce two discourse referents in the context that represent female individuals, the definite NP *the woman* cannot be used to pick out either of them.

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[24] Roberts introduces the notion of *weak familiarity* to account for cases where the discourse referent was not explicitly introduced, but its existence was entailed by the context (cf. Prince (1992)'s 'hearer-old' status). For instance, in (i), the definite NP *the elevator* picks out a discourse referent that was not directly introduced in the prior discourse, but its existence was (somewhat) entailed by the context: a hotel typically has an elevator.

(i) [Hotel concierge to guest, in a lobby with four elevators:]
You're in Room 611. Take ***the elevator*** *to the sixth floor and turn left.* (Roberts 2003: 301)

I will not discuss the notion of weak familiarity in more detail because it will not be relevant for the proposed analysis for bare NPs, as we will see in the next section. For more discussion of the difference between strong and weak familiarity and related issues, see Roberts 2003; Arkoh & Matthewson 2013; Barlew 2014, a.o..

(80) ***A woman***$_i$ *entered from stage left.* ***Another woman***$_j$ *entered from stage right.*

$^{\#}$***The woman***$_{i/j}$ *was carrying a basket of flowers.*

(Roberts 2003: 324)

While Roberts mainly concentrates on data from definite NPs, she argues that the proposed analysis can be extended to other anaphoric expressions. In particular, she claims that pronouns also obey informational uniqueness, although it is restricted to *salient* familiar discourse referents, that is, the given discourse referents that are in the center of the interlocutors' attention. Because of this additional saliency requirement, pronouns can be used in a wider range of contexts than definites, including contexts where there are two or more discourse referents satisfying their descriptive content. For instance, the use of the pronoun *she* is felicitous in (81), where the two female discourse referents are available in the context (compare it with (80), where the use of the definite NP is infelicitous in the same position). In (81), the presence of two potential antecedents for *she* is not problematic. According to Roberts, this is because only the second one is salient when the pronoun is uttered. And indeed, *she* can only refer to the second woman: an attempt to contrast the pronoun with the NP *the second woman* leads to infelicity.[25]

(81) *A woman*$_i$ *entered from stage left.* ***Another woman***$_j$ *entered from stage right.* ***She***$_{j/*i}$ *was carrying a basket of flowers, while the first woman*$_i$/$^{\#}$***the second woman***$_j$ *led a goat.*

(Roberts 2003: 324)

[25] Some native speakers I consulted with do not agree with the judgements Roberts (2003) provided for (81): according to their intuition, *she* can, after all, be understood as referring to the first woman (and then, in such cases, the following use of *the second woman* is felicitous). This, however, does not necessarily contradict Roberts' analysis: the most recently activated discourse referent is not necessarily the most salient one in any context; in particular, a less recently activated discourse referent can be more salient if it is naturally understood as a topic of the utterance (see Roberts 2022 for an overview of factors determining saliency of discourse referents).

For pronouns, the informational uniqueness requirement is only violated when the context has two or more discourse referents satisfying their descriptive content that are equally salient. This is what happens in (82). While the presence of two male discourse referents per se is not a problem for the pronoun *he*, they are also equally salient, so its use is infelicitous.

(82) *I saw* ***John***$_i$ *and* ***Peter***$_j$ *at the bar.* #***He***$_{i/j}$ *was really drunk.*

Thus, according to Roberts (2003), the informational uniqueness is a universal constraint for anaphoric expressions. The only difference between them is in the domain of the considered discourse referents: for definites, it is the set of all given (weakly familiar) discourse referents; for pronouns, it is the set of discourse referents that are salient. In her later works, Roberts (2010, 2011) goes even further and claims that this informational uniqueness requirement is derived from a general pragmatic principle that she calls Retrievability, defined as in (83):

(83) **Retrievability** (Roberts 2010: 20)

In order for an utterance to be rationally cooperative in a discourse interaction D, it must be reasonable for the speaker to expect that the addressee can grasp the speaker's intended meaning in so-uttering in D.

In other words, Roberts (2010, 2011) argues that the informational uniqueness requirement follows from a simple, Gricean-style idea that if the speaker wants to make sure that the addressee knows who they refer to, they would choose an expression that would provide enough information for the addressee to unambiguously identify the intended (discourse) referent.

Thus, in this section, I reviewed the information-uniqueness based analysis of definites (Roberts 2003 et seq.). According to this analysis, definites have a uniqueness requirement, but, in contrast to the classic analysis, it applies not to all contextually available individuals but only to those (weakly) familiar from the prior discourse (and hence represented by discourse referents). In later works, Roberts (2010, 2011) argues that this requirement is not a lexical presupposition of definites, but a general constraint on anaphora resolution derived from the pragmatic principle she calls Retrievability: the intended antecedent of a used anaphoric expression must be recoverable from the prior discourse.

Note, however, that there is no reason to assume that only *anaphoric* expressions should be subject to the informational uniqueness. In fact, the null hypothesis would be that if a nominal expression features anaphoric uses but also can be used to introduce novel discourse referents, then the informational uniqueness requirement should apply to the latter uses as well. The prediction would then be that introductory uses of such a nominal are only felicitous when the prior context has no discourse referents representing other satisfiers of that nominal.

In the next section, I will argue that this prediction resolves the challenge of the limited distribution of bare nominals in Russian. Namely, I will argue that bare nominals in Russian obey a generalized version of the informational uniqueness requirement, which I will dub The Unambiguity Constraint. I will show that in addition to directly capturing the challenging data, the UC makes further correct predictions about the distribution of Russian bare NPs.

2. Analysis

2.1. Proposal

I argue that the limited distribution of Russian bare NPs in indefinite contexts is due to a pragmatic constraint on reference resolution, namely, a generalized version of Roberts (2003)'s informational uniqueness constraint. It is provided in (84):

(84) **The Unambiguity Constraint (Generalized Informational Uniqueness)**

In the context *c*, an NP that lexicalizes a predicate P can be used to pick out a discourse referent *i* iff there is no *j* distinct from *i* such that *j* is entailed by *c* to also satisfy P.[26]

Before turning to its predictions, let me first clarify two important aspects of the proposed analysis.

First, let me clarify what exactly "pick out" means in the context of Russian bare NPs. As I argued in Chapter 2, they are semantically existential quantifiers. As we just discussed, in the classic dynamic pragmatics, existential quantification triggers introduction of the discourse referent in the context. Importantly, however, bare NPs differ from classic indefinites in that they do not require the referent to be novel: it can be interpreted as identical to one of the given ones. The neutrality of bare NPs with respect to the novelty/familiarity parameter can be formally represented in different ways. First, we can assume that bare NPs always introduce new discourse referents (in a sense that their use always triggers addition of a new index to the assignment functions available in the context), but then the new discourse referent can be identified with one of the old ones in an appropriate context. This kind of approach was proposed in earlier works on unrestricted

[26] A discourse referent *j* is distinct from a discourse referent *i* if for at least one assignment function *g* in *c*, $g(\mathrm{i}) \neq g(\mathrm{j})$. A discourse referent *i* satisfies the predicate of an NP iff for any *g* in *c*, $g(\mathrm{i})$ satisfies that predicate.

indefinites (see Sudo 2022 for an overview) and follows from the commonly accepted general approach to reference as introducing new discourse referents regardless of their novelty/familiarity (see, for instance, Kamp & Reyle 1993 et seq.). Alternatively, we can assume that novel and familiar uses of bare NPs are processed as different instructions for the context update. Namely, if the context already contains a discourse referent that is a potential witness to the NP, the use of that bare NP is understood as if it were an anaphoric expression; if the context does not have any discourse referents that are the NP's satisfiers, then the use of the bare NP is interpreted as an instruction to introduce a new discourse referent. The choice between the two options does not affect the predictions of my analysis. For concreteness, I will adopt the first approach, that is, that each use of a bare NP triggers introduction of a new discourse referent, but then it can be understood as identical to one of the discourse referents given in the prior context.

In any case, however, the informational status of the discourse referent a bare NP picks out is always determined within the provided context, due to the constraint in (84). Namely, the picked discourse referent can only be understood as a new one if there are no given discourse referents available in the local context that also satisfy the NP's predicate, or as the same as an old one if this old discourse referent is the only satisfier of the NP's predicate available in the context. In all the other cases, the use of the bare NP is unavailable.

Second, a clarification about the status of the Unambiguity Constraint is in order. As I mentioned in the previous section, I adopt a hypothesis that this principle is a generalized version of the informational uniqueness requirement proposed by Roberts (2003) and thus follow her in assuming that this principle is not a lexicalized requirement, but a general constraint on reference resolution derived from the general pragmatic requirement, Retrievability. Namely, as follows from the name of the principle, I assume here that the UC follows from the general pragmatic consideration: as a cooperative speech act participant, the speaker is interested in providing the addressee with enough information to identify the intended (discourse) referent and, if there is no familiar discourse referent to identify, to infer that a novel one must be introduced[27].

If this assumption is correct, it makes the proposed approach very elegant: the limited distribution of introductory uses of bare nominals simply follows from the general pragmatic principles of cooperation. At the same time, I acknowledge that even if the UC-based approach correctly predicts the data from Russian bare nominals (as I hope to convince the reader in the remainder of this chapter), this would not be sufficient to show that the UC is a general principle of reference resolution. To do so, this analysis should be tested against data from nominals in other languages.

I will discuss the cross-linguistic perspectives of the UC-based approach in Chapter 5, showing that it has a potential to be universal, but there are certain challenges it must address. If further research reveals that the UC cannot be treated as a cross-linguistically applicable principle, then the proposed hypothesis should be replaced with a weaker one: the UC is a discourse-level constraint associated specifically with bare nominals in Russian (and potentially with some classes of nominals in other languages). In either case, my main goal in this dissertation — and especially in this chapter — is to argue that whatever its theoretical status, the UC correctly predicts the distribution of bare nominals in Russian.

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[27] One might worry here that the UC's predictions on when a nominal can be used to introduce a novel discourse referent cannot be derived from the Retrievability because the identity of the intended (discourse) referent cannot be recovered from the common ground. I argue, however, that this is not the case: according to the UC, a nominal can introduce a novel discourse referent only when it does not have any antecedents in the preceding context, which is exactly the case when it follows from the prior discourse that the intended discourse referent must be novel. The fact that the addressee might not know the identity of this novel discourse referent (that is, which individual it represents) is irrelevant here, as the same can easily happen with a familiar discourse referent. Moreover, even the speaker can be unaware of the intended (familiar) discourse referent's identity, as illustrated in (i), where the pronoun *they* is used to refer to a person or a group of people whose identity is unclear to the speaker.

(i) *Someone came to my house yesterday, and they left a note.*

The remainder of the Section 2 is organized as follows. I will start with showing in Section 2.2 how the Unambiguity Constraint accounts for the infelicity of sentences where two identical bare NPs are witnessed by different individuals. After that, I will discuss more general predictions of the proposed account, concerning the distribution of the introductory (Section 2.3) and anaphoric (Section 2.4) uses of Russian bare NPs. Finally, in Section 2.5, I will provide the more accurate formulation of the UC to cover the distribution of anaphoric uses of bare plurals.

2.2. Accounting for the key data

Application of the generalized uniqueness constraint correctly predicts that a bare NP in Russian can be used to introduce a new discourse referent if and only if there are no other discourse referents in the context that do satisfy this NP's predicate. Recall the contrast between (85a) and (85b), on one hand, and (85c), on the other hand, uttered in the same context (let us assume for the sake of argument that all the three sentences are uttered at the beginning of the narrative, and the interlocutors did not know any of the dogs in the scenario).

(85) Scenario. There are two dogs in the street, one of them is barking, the other one is growling.

a. *Na ulice lajet sobaka.*

on street barks dog

'In the street, a dog is barking.'

b. *Na ulice ryčit sobaka.*

on street growls dog

'In the street, a dog is growling.'

c. #*Na ulice lajet sobaka i ryčit sobaka.*

on street barks dog and growls dog

Intended: 'In the street, a dog is barking and a dog is growling.'

The uses of the bare NP *sobaka* 'dog' in (85a) and in (85b) do not violate UC: in both cases, even though there are other dogs in the scenario, none of them has been introduced or given in the prior context as a discourse referent by the time the bare NP was uttered; hence, the discourse referent introduced by the bare NP is the first and only one that satisfies the NP's predicate, that is, it is the discourse referent in the context mapping onto a dog. In contrast, the use of the second bare NP *sobaka* 'dog' in (85c) does violate the UC. Namely, by the moment this NP is uttered to introduce a new referent *i* mapping onto a dog individual, the context already has another discourse referent *j*, introduced by the use of the first bare NP, that is distinct from *i* which was also introduced as mapping onto a dog individual; hence, *i* is not unique with respect to the predicate of the bare NP.

At the end of the Chapter 2, we saw that the sequence of two identical bare NPs can be "made" felicitous if a modifier is added to the second bare NP that restricts the set of satisfiers to ones non-identical to the first bare NP's discourse referent. This is also predicted by the UC approach. Recall (68), repeated here as (86a), where the second bare NP is identical to the first one except that it is modified by the adjective *drugoj* 'other'. This adjective restricts the extension of the second NP to individuals distinct from the referent *i* introduced by the use of the first bare NP. As a result, when the second bare NP is used to introduce a new discourse referent, *j*, it does not violate the UC because *j* is the only referent available in the context that is a girl that is not *i*. Another instance of the same pattern is illustrated in (86b). Here, the second bare NP is modified by a comparative *postarše* 'older' which takes the first bare NP's discourse referent *i* as the standard of comparison.

Since *i* cannot be older than himself, no satisfiers of the second bare NP's restrictor are available in the prior context, so it can be used to introduce a new discourse referent *j* with no risk of violating UC[28].

(86) a. *Na ulice plačet devočka, a* #(*drugaja*) *devočka eë*

on street cries girl and another girl her

uspokaivajet.

comforts

'In the street, a girl is crying, and another girl is comforting her.'

b. *Na ulice plačet mal'čik, a malčik* #*(postarše) ego uspokaivajet.*

on street cries boy and boy older him comforts

'In the street, a boy is crying, and an older boy is comforting him.'

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[28] One may wonder what happens if a disambiguating modifier is added to the second bare nominal that does not entail the distinctness of the two witnesses, as in (i), where the prepositional phrase *v sinej kurtke* 'in a blue jacket' is added to the second bare nominal *mal'čik* 'boy'. The judgements here are split: while some native speakers I asked (including myself) find sentences as in (i) at least quite degraded, some others find them felicitous. Importantly, however, in both cases (i) is infelicitous under a scenario where the crying boy is also wearing a blue jacket. It could be that (i) is not as uniformly felicitous as (86b) because it requires accommodation of the fact that the crying boy is not wearing a blue jacket, while it is clear right away in (86b) that the first boy is not older than himself.

(i) ?*Na ulice plačet mal'čik, a mal'čik v sinej kurtke*

on street cries boy and boy in blue jacket

jego uspokaivajet.

him comforts

'In the street, a boy is crying, and a boy in a blue jacket is comforting him.'

Note, however, that, strictly speaking, the requirements for the felicity of (i) are stronger than what straightforwardly follows from the UC, which merely requires that the crying boy is not *known* to be wearing a blue jacket — in other words, (i) is predicted to be compatible with a scenario where the first boy does wear a blue jacket, but the addressee does not know that yet. The observed additional restriction (that the first boy *does not* wear a blue jacket) likely arises as a pragmatic side effect: it only makes sense to introduce the other boy as wearing the blue jacket if it is relevant for the sake of conversation, and the only sense in which this can be relevant is that it is his distinguishable property — hence, the first boy likely does not wear a blue jacket. A question for future research is whether this inference can be cancelled in the subsequent discourse.

In addition to accounting for the key data contrast discussed above, the UC approach makes more general predictions for the distribution of bare NPs in their introductory and anaphoric uses. I will discuss them in the next two sections.

2.3. Introductory uses of bare NPs

In the previous section, we saw how the proposed dynamic approach accounts for infelicity of two identical bare NPs used in the same context that are witnessed by different individuals. Namely, the use of the second bare NP violates the UC: it is used to introduce a new discourse referent *i* into a context that has a referent *j* distinct from *i* that is also a satisfier of the NP's predicate.

Crucially, for the proposed constraint, the identity of the two bare NPs is irrelevant. Instead, the infelicity of cases like in (85c) follows from a more general prediction: a bare NP can only be used to introduce a new discourse referent if the context does not have any other discourse referents satisfying the NP's predicate. This means, in particular, that an introductory use of a bare NP is blocked not only when another discourse referent was introduced by an identical bare NP in the prior discourse, but also when it was introduced by an NP that is a *hyponym* of the bare NP in question. This prediction is borne out, as shown in (87). In (87a), the bare NP is a hypernym of the first NP: all poodles are dogs. Thus, when the bare NP *sobaka* 'dog' is used to introduce a new dog referent *i,* the context already has a dog referent *j* introduced by the NP *pudel'* 'poodle', so the UC is violated. And indeed, (87a) is odd unless: i) a modifier is added to the second bare NP that entails non-identity of the two NP's witnesses; ii) the speaker somewhat personifies his dog or does not consider poodles true dogs. Both repair strategies are expected within the proposed analysis: whichever of them is applied, the second NP is no longer a hypernym of the first NP, and the UC is not violated. The same pattern is shown in (87b), where the second discourse referent *i* can felicitously be introduced using the bare NP *texasec* 'Texan', but not using the bare NP *amerikanec* 'American'. This is also predicted by the proposed approach. Namely, since the context already has a discourse referent *j* that is a Californian (and hence an American), using the NP *amerikanec* 'American' to introduce a novel referent *i* will violate the UC; in contrast, using the bare NP *texasec* 'Texan' to introduce *i* does not violate the UC since *j* is a Californian and hence is not a Texan.

(87) a. *Mojego pudel'a včera pokusala* ??*(drugaja/sosedskaja) sobaka*.
my poodle yesterday bite other/neighbor's dog
'My poodle was bitten by an (other/neighbor's) dog.'

b. *Moj drug-kalifornijec poznakomils'a s texascem/*#*amerikancem*
My friend-Californian got_acquainted with Texan/American
'My Californian friend got acquainted with a Texan/#American.'

Another prediction the proposed analysis makes is that if a bare NP is uttered after an NP whose predicate is compatible with the bare NP's predicate (that is, their extensions have a non-empty intersection), then it should not be given or accommodated in the context that the discourse referent introduced/picked out by the first NP also satisfies the predicate of the bare nominal in question. This prediction is borne out, as shown in (88). The sentence in (88a) is felicitous only if there is no information in the common ground implying that the speaker's American friend is also a Spartak fan. According to my analysis, this is so because when the bare NP is used to introduce a new discourse referent, it can satisfy the UC only if the context *c* does not entail that *j* also satisfies bare NP's predicate, that is, there is no information in the common ground that would suggest that *j* is a Spartak fan. Analogously, in (88b), it cannot be given or accommodated that the discourse referent introduced by the bare NP *devočka* 'girl' is an Italian: only if this is not the case can the bare NP *ital'janka* 'Italian' be used to introduce a new discourse referent without the risk of the UC violation[29].

(88) a. *Moj drug-amerikanec podrals'a s bolel'ščikom Spartaka*

My friend-American fought with fan Spartak

'My American friend got into a fight with a "Spartak"[30] fan.'

b. *Na ulice devočka igrajet s ital'jankoj v salki.*

on street girl plays with Italian in tag

'In the street, a girl is playing tag with an/the Italian.'

Overall, what we saw in this section is that in addition to predicting the semantically unexpected infelicity of sentences with two identical bare NPs that have different witnesses, the proposed account makes a more general prediction on the distribution of introductory uses of bare NPs. Namely, it predicts that a bare NP can only be used to introduce a novel discourse referent if there are no other discourse referents available in the context that satisfies the NP's predicate. The correctness of this prediction is confirmed by independent data points never discussed in the previous literature.

In the next section, I will discuss the predictions the proposed analysis makes for anaphoric uses of bare NPs and show that they are also borne out.

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[29] In fact, both sentences in (88) strongly suggest that the other discourse referent does not bear the property lexicalized by the bare NP: (88a) suggests that the speaker's friend is not himself a fan of "Spartak", and (88b) suggests that the girl is not an Italian. Crucially, however, this inference can be subsequently cancelled: for instance, (88a) can be felicitously followed by a phrase like "in fact, my friend is also a Spartak fan".

[30] "Spartak" is a famous Russian soccer team from Moscow.

2.4. Anaphoric uses of bare NPs

According to the proposed analysis, a bare NP *can* and at the same time *must* be understood anaphorically if and only if there is one and only one discourse referent given in the context that satisfies the NP's predicate.

This prediction is borne out. Indeed, a bare NP can be used to pick out an old discourse referent, even if it is introduced by an identical bare NP; we have seen this already when we discussed the familiar uses of bare NPs in the previous chapter (Section 2.2.1). At the same time, a bare NP can only felicitously be used anaphorically if there are no other given discourse referents that also satisfy the NP's predicate. Consider, for instance, the contrast in (89). In (89a), the use of the second bare NP *devočka* 'girl' is felicitous, and the discourse referent it introduces is unambiguously understood as identical to the old discourse referent that was introduced when the first bare NP *devočka* was uttered. In contrast, in (89b), the use of the bare NP *devočka* is infelicitous because at that moment, the context has two girl discourse referents introduced by the use of the numeral phrase *dve devočki* 'two girls', so regardless of which of these two referents would be picked out by *devočka*, the UC would be violated.

(89) a.

Na	*ulice*	***devočka***	*igrala*	*s*	*malčikom*	*v*	*badminton.*
on	street	girl	played	with	boy	in	badminton
Ja	*podošla*	*k*	***devočke***	*i*	*sprosila,*		
I	approached	to	girl	and	asked		
ne	*xočet*	*li*	*ona*	*poučastvovat'*	*v*	*mojëm*	*turnire.*
not	wants	if	she	participate	in	my	tournir

‘In the street, a girl was playing badminton with a boy. I approached the girl and asked if she wants to participate in my tournament.’

b. *Na*	*ulice*	***dve***	***devočki***	*igrali*	*s*	*malčikami*	*v*	*badminton.*
on	street	two	girls	played	with	boys	in	badminton

??*Ja*	*podošla*	*k*	***devočke***	*i*	*sprosila,*			
I	approached	to	girl	and	asked			
ne	*xočet*	*li*	*ona*	*poučastvovat’*	*v*	*mojëm*	*turnire.*	
not	wants	if	she	participate	in	my	tournament	

Intended: ‘In the street, two girls were playing badminton with a boy. I approached one of the girls and asked if she wants to participate in my tournament.’

Importantly, just like with introductory uses, the restriction applies regardless of how exactly the discourse referents under consideration were introduced. Consider, for instance, the contrast in (90), similar to the one in (89) except that none of the given discourse referents have been (directly) ascribed as girls in the prior context. Analogously, the anaphoric use of the bare NP *devočka* ‘girl’ in (90a) is felicitous: there is only one given girl discourse referent — the female American one — and the bare NP is understood as referring to that American girl[31]. In contrast, in (90b), the use of *devočka* is infelicitous because the context contains two discourse referents — the American female and the Italian female — both of which satisfy the bare NP’s predicate.

(90) a. *Na*	*ulice*	*odna*	*amerikanka*	*igrala*	*s*	*drugom*	*v*	*badminton.*
on	street	one	American.F	played	with	friend.M	in	badminton

[31] Note that strictly speaking, it was not given in the prior context that the female American that was playing badminton is a girl: she could have been an older woman. I assume here that the use of the bare NP *devočka* ‘girl’ triggers accommodation of the fact that the female American was a girl.

Ja podošla k devočke i sprosila,

I approached to girl and asked

ne xočet li ona poučastvovat' v mojëm turnire.

not wants if she participate in my tournir

'In the street, an American was playing badminton with her (male) friend. I approached the girl and asked if she wants to participate in my tournir.'

b. *Na ulice amerikanka i ital'janka igrali v badminton.*

on street American and Italian played in badminton

$^{??}$*Ja podošla k devočke i sprosila,*

I approached to girl and asked

ne xočet li ona poučastvovat' v mojëm turnire.

not wants if she participate in my tournir

Intended: 'In the street, an American and an Italian were playing badminton. I approached one of the girls and asked if she wants to participate in my tournir.'

Thus, the proposed analysis correctly predicts that anaphoric uses of bare NPs in Russian are possible, but only felicitous in contexts where there is only one given discourse referent that satisfies the NP's predicate. In other words, anaphorically used bare NPs have the same distribution as anaphoric definites in English, which is to be expected given that both expressions obey the informational uniqueness.

2.5. Including bare plurals: informational maximality

In the previous sections, I proposed to analyze the dynamic sensitivity of bare NPs in Russian as a requirement of informational uniqueness, following Roberts (2003): a bare NP can be used to pick out a discourse referent *i* if and only if there is no discourse referent *j* distinct from *i* that is entailed by the context to also satisfy the bare NP's predicate. I showed that the postulated constraint makes correct predictions with respect to the distribution of introductory and anaphoric uses of bare NPs. So far, however, all the discussed examples featured only bare *singulars*. In this section, I will argue that data from bare plurals pose some challenges for understanding The Unambiguity Constraint as a requirement of informational *uniqueness*, and that instead we should reformulate it as a requirement of informational *maximality*. I will also show that simply replacing the informational uniqueness requirement of the UC with its informational maximality counterpart is not enough: only anaphoric uses of bare plurals require informational maximality, while introductory bare plurals have a stronger requirement.

As we discussed in Chapter 2, the uniqueness requirement, a cross-linguistically common feature of definites, is limited to their singular forms; in contrast, *plural* definites feature a *maximality* requirement: they can only be felicitously used to talk about the satisfier that includes all the other satisfiers in the context. Consider, for instance, an example in (91). The definite DP *the fruits* is understood as referring to all the apples and the pears the speaker's father brought him. This plurality is not a unique satisfier of the DP's restrictor among the discourse referents available in the context: the plurality of apples and the plurality of pears also meet the DP's descriptive content. Instead, the referent of *the fruits* is indeed the maximal one: it includes the other two fruit pluralities introduced in the context.

(91) *My dad brought me* ***apples***$_i$ *and* ***pears***$_j$ *from the farm.* ***The fruits***$_{i+j}$ *were so tasty that I ate them all in one go.*

This apparent asymmetry between singular and plural definites is typically resolved by the fact that the uniqueness requirement of the former is derivable from the maximality requirement: since predicates over singletons cannot have satisfiers including other satisfiers, the only way a satisfier of such predicate can be maximal is when it is the unique satisfier available in the context. Alternatively, some authors view the maximality requirement of plural definites as an extension of the uniqueness requirement: indeed, if we take the maximal plurality satisfying the predicate in question as indivisible whole, it would be the unique satisfier of that predicate. This is, in particular, how Roberts treats the informational maximality requirement of plural definites in her dynamic approach: "In an extension of this treatment of singulars, plural definites are also unique, in the sense that an instantiation must be the maximal set satisfying the description" (Roberts 2003: 289).

Bare plurals in Russian are also subject to informational maximality, not informational uniqueness stricto sensu. This is evident from their anaphoric uses, like in (92). In (92a), the bare plural *ovošči* 'vegetables' is used felicitously and is obligatorily understood as referring to all the vegetables mentioned in the prior discourse — that is, to (all of) the forementioned cucumbers and tomatoes; it cannot be understood as referring only to cucumbers, only to tomatoes or to a non-maximal mixed plurality of those vegetables. This is further confirmed by the infelicity of (92b), where the non-maximal reading of the bare nominal *ovošči* is forced by the remainder of the utterance, where it is asserted that the speaker did not eat cucumbers. The sentence in (92b) sounds odd, as if the speaker, for some reason, does not consider cucumbers vegetables. This oddness effect can be explained as an attempt to accommodate a set of beliefs in which the use of the bare NP *ovošči* would not violate the informational maximality requirement; the only way to do it is to no longer treat cucumbers as vegetables.

(92) *Mne prinesli ogurcy*$_i$*, pomidory*$_j$ *i apel'siny.*

me brought cucumbers tomatoes and oranges

'They brought my cucumbers, tomatoes and oranges.'

a. *Ja sjel* ***ovošči****$_{i+j}$, a apel'siny jest' ne stal.*

I ate vegetables but oganges eat not started

'I ate the vegetables but decided not to eat oranges.'

b. #*Ja sjel ovošči*$_i$*, a ogurcy i apel'siny*

I ate vegetables but cucumbers and oranges

jest' ne stal.

eat not started

Intended: 'I ate the vegetables but decided not to eat cucumbers and oranges.'

Thus, bare plurals in Russian, just like plural definites in English, are subject to informational maximality, not informational uniqueness. The natural assumption then is that the informational maximality is actually the uniform requirement for all bare nominals in Russian, and the informational uniqueness patterns we observed with bare singulars in the previous section are explained by the fact that maximality amounts to uniqueness when it comes to predicates over singletons[32]. Does this mean that to extend the proposed account to bare plurals, we merely need to replace the generalized informational uniqueness requirement of the Unambiguity Constraint with its informational maximality counterpart, like in (93)?

[32] Recall our discussion from Section 2.1.1 in Chapter 2. If all members of the predicate's extension are atomic with respect to it, as it is the case with the predicate of a singular definite, then whenever the context has multiple satisfiers of the definite singular's predicate, its maximality requirement will not be satisfied: since none of the satisfiers is a part of the other, none of them can be the maximal sum of satisfiers. Thus, the only context in which a singular definite meets the maximality requirement is when there is just one, *unique* satisfier of its predicate.

(93) **The Unambiguity Constraint** (Generalized Informational Maximality)

> In the context *c*, an NP that lexicalizes a predicate P can be used to pick out a discourse referent *i* iff there is no discourse referent *j* such that j is not a part of i and j is entailed by *c* to also satisfy P.[33]

The updated, more general, version of the UC does indeed account for the data from bare singulars discussed in the previous sections (as the informational maximality amounts to the informational uniqueness, when it comes to predicates over singletons); it also correctly predicts that anaphoric uses of bare plurals not only can, but must be "maximal" (that is, a bare plural can only be used to pick out a familiar discourse referent if it maps onto an individual that is the maximal satisfier among ones represented in the context *c* as discourse referents). However, as I will show in the next paragraph, the new version of the UC makes a wrong prediction for introductory uses of bare plurals. Namely, according to (93), bare plurals should freely be used to introduce novel discourse referents, as long as the individual they represent is a plurality including all the other individuals satisfying the bare plural's predicate that are represented by already familiar discourse referents. In other words, roughly speaking, (93) allows for "hybrid" uses of bare plurals, when the mentioned plurality is partially familiar to the addressee, but contains novel members.

As I have already said, this prediction is not borne out: a bare plural cannot be used to pick out a discourse referent representing a plurality that is partially familiar, but partially novel; consider, for instance, the data in (94). Since it is not clear whether a "hybrid" discourse referent would be perceived by the Russian grammar as familiar or as novel, I tested both postverbal NPs (that are

[33] A discourse referent *j* is not a part of discourse referent *i* iff for any assingment function *g* in *c*, g(j) is not a part of g(i).

normally interpreted as novel) and preverbal NPs (that tend to be interpreted as topics and hence given, especially if no other constituent precedes them). In both positions a bare plural cannot be used to talk about novel and familiar individuals at the same time, as shown in (94).

(94) a. #*Ja segondn'a na uroke sdelal zamečanije* ***dvum škol'nikam**$_i$,*
I today on lesson made reprimand two pupils
i teper' men'a nenavid'at ***škol'niki**$_{i+j}$.*
and now me hate pupils
Intended: 'I reprimanded two students at the lesson today, and now there are students (including the two I reprimanded) hating me.'

b. *Ja segondn'a na uroke sdelal zamečanije* ***dvum škol'nikam,***
I today on lesson made reprimand two pupils
i teper' ***škol'niki*** *men'a nenavid'at.*
and now pupils me hate
'I reprimanded two students at the lesson today, and now…
i. '…the (two) students hate me.'
ii. '…all the students hate me.'
iii. # '…the two students and some others hate me.'

In both sentences, the bare NP *škol'niki* 'students' is used in a context that already has a discourse referent, let us call it *i*, representing the pair of students introduced by the numeral phrase *dva škol'nika* in the first clause. The sentence in (94a), where the bare NP is postverbal, is just infelicitous. In particular, this bare NP cannot be understood as introducing a group of students that includes the two that were reprimanded and some others, not previously mentioned. The sentence in (94b), where the same bare NP occurs at the topic position, is felicitous, but the bare NP does not have the desired interpretation. Namely, *škol'niki* can be understood as either referring to the two boys that were reprimanded or as referring to all the students the speaker teaches, but, crucially, it cannot be understood as introducing a novel group of school students that includes the two students and some others that were not previously mentioned[34].

In reality, introductory uses of bare plurals are felicitous only if the context has no (familiar) discourse referents representing other satisfiers of the bare nominal's predicate. This is shown by the contrast in (95) below. In (95a), the bare nominal *sobaki* 'dog' is felicitously used to introduce a novel discourse referent representing a plurality of dogs into a context that contains no other discourse referents representing dogs. In contrast, in (95b), the second bare nominal *sobaki* 'dog' cannot be used felicitously to introduce a novel discourse referent representing a dog plurality in a context that already contains discourse referents representing dogs. Crucially, it cannot be used

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[34] The two available readings of (94b) are predicted by both approaches. In the first case, the bare NP is used to pick out the only given discourse referent that satisfies its predicate, *i*; in the second case, the context accommodates as given the discourse referent representing all the students in the class, and the bare NP picks it out. This is clear from the maximality effect observed with this reading: this is what we expect when a bare NP is used anaphorically, but not when it introduces a novel discourse referent. The anaphoric nature of the second reading of the bare NP is further confirmed by the fact that the pronoun *oni* 'they', an unambiguously anaphoric expression, also has it in the same context. This is shown in (i), which is like (94b) except that the bare NP is replaced with *oni* and the phrase *dva škol'nika* 'two students' is replaced with a bare NP *škol'nik* 'pupil', to exclude an alternative antecedent for the pronoun. The use of (i) triggers accommodation of the discourse referent representing the plurality of all students from the class, and *oni* is unambiguously understood as picking out that referent.

(i)	*Ja*	*segodn'a*	*na*	*uroke*	*sdelal*	*zamečanije*	***škol'niku,***
	I	today	on	lesson	made	reprimand	pupil
	i	*teper'*	***oni***	*men'a*	*nenavid'at.*		
	and	now	they	me	hate		

'I reprimanded two students at the lesson today, and now they hate me.'

even if the meant discourse referent represents a plurality that includes all the previously mentioned barking dogs[35].

(95) a. *Na* *ulice* *lajut* ***sobaki***

on street bark dogs

'In the street, there are dogs barking.'

b. #*Na* *ulice* *lajut* ***sobaki*** *i* *ryčat* ***sobaki***.

on street bark dogs and growl dogs

'In the street, there are dogs barking #(and dogs growling).'

Thus, a generalized information maximality version of bare plurals overpredicts: in reality, only anaphoric uses of bare plurals obey informational maximality, while introductory uses are only available when the context has no other discourse referents satisfying the predicate of the nominal. Thus, to properly capture the distribution of bare plurals in Russian, the UC should be formulated as in (96):

(96) **The Unambiguity Constraint (final version)**

In the context *c*, NP that lexicalizes a predicate P can be used to introduce a novel discourse referent *i* iff there are no other discourse referents that are entailed by *c* to also satisfy P; in all the other cases, *i* must be the maximal discourse referent entailed by *c* to satisfy P.

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[35] One can use the second bare nominal anaphorically, to refer to the plurality of barking dogs, but in this case, another word order is required, like in (ii): anaphoric nominals normally appear in the pre-verbal, topic position.

(ii) *Na ulice lajut sobaki i myčat korovy. Sobaki javno čem-to napugany.*

on street bark dogs and moo cows dogs clearly something scared

'In the street, dogs are barking and cows are mooing. The dogs are clearly scared of something.'

In contrast to the Generalized Informational Maximality, this version of the UC correctly captures the distribution of introductory uses of bare plurals: they are only felicitous when the context has no familiar discourse referents mapping onto satisfiers of the nominal's predicate. It also correctly captures that a bare plural that is used anaphorically can only be understood as picking out the discourse referent mapping onto the maximal satisfier of the nominal's predicate.

In addition to covering the data from bare plurals, the new approach inherits the predictions of the information uniqueness-based account for bare singulars. Recall that predicates of bare singulars only have atomic satisfiers, so if the context has two or more satisfiers of such predicate, none of them can be maximal. Thus, (96) correctly predicts that a bare singular can only be used anaphorically if the context has only one discourse referent satisfying its predicate and can introduce a new discourse referent if and only if there are no such discourse referents in the context.

3. Locality of the constraint

3.1. Introduction

In the previous section, I argued that bare NPs in Russian are semantically indefinite but are subject to a dynamic pragmatic constraint: a bare NP cannot be used to pick out a discourse referent *i* if the context already has a discourse referent *j* distinct from *i* such that the individual is also entailed to satisfy the NP's predicate. In this simple form, however, this generalization has apparent counterexamples: there are clear cases where the use of the same bare NP in the same context triggers introduction of multiple (distinct) discourse referents.

Examples of such challenging uses are provided below. In (97a), under its narrow-scope reading, the bare nominal *medsestra* 'nurse' is felicitously used to introduce multiple discourse referents each of which represents a nurse that visited the speaker on a particular day; this is apparent violation of the UC, as none of these discourse referents is informationally unique. In (97b), the second instance of the bare nominal *korova* 'cow' is felicitously used to introduce a novel discourse referent representing a cow even though the context already has a discourse referent mapping onto a potentially different cow introduced by the use of the first instance of this nominal. Similar cases are provided in (98), where the same nominal is felicitously used a second time to talk about a different individual, thus apparently violating the Unambiguity Constraint.

(97) a. *Ko mn'e každyj den' prixodila (novaja) medsestra.*
to me every day came new nurse
'Everyday, a (new) nurse visited me.'

b. *Vas'a libo prodal korovu, libo kupil korovu.*
V. either sold cow or bought cow
'Vasya either sold a cow or bought a cow.'

(98) a. *Vas'a kupil ananas,* ***jabloko*** *i mango,*
V. bought pineapple apple and mango
a Pet'a kupil ***jabloko****, grušu i banan*.
but P. bought apple pear and banana
'Vasya bought a pineapple, **an apple** and a mango, and Petya bought **an apple**, a pear and a banana.'

b. Context. Both speaker and hearer know that there is a tiger in each cage.

V	*etoj*	*kletke*	*tigr*	*jest,*	*a*	*v*	*toj*	*kletke*	*tigr*	*spit.*[36]
In	this	cage	tiger	eats	and	in	that	cage	tiger	sleeps

'In this cage, the tiger is eating, and in that cage, the tiger is sleeping.'

In this section, I will argue that these apparent counterexamples do not require abandoning the UC; rather, they suggest that the UC, just like the informational uniqueness requirement of definites in English, can be satisfied relative to a local context in which the bare nominal is interpreted.

This solution is motivated by the following observation: in all the examples in (97), the discourse referents introduced or picked out by the use of identical bare nominals are distributed across different subdomains, and each of the discourse referents ends up being informationally unique within their own subdomain.

In examples provided in (97), the subdomains for different discourse referents are introduced by an overt semantic operator. In (97a), the universal quantifier *každyj den'* 'every day' introduces a set of sub-domains of the context, where each subdomain corresponds to a certain day, and each of the discourse referents introduced by the use of the bare nominal *medsestra* 'nurse' is interpreted

[36] This sentence is an adapted version of Dayal's example from (Dayal 2004: 411), provided in (i):

(i)	*V*	*étoj*	*kletke*	*tigr*	*spit*	*i*	*v*	*toj*	*kletke*	*tigr*	*jest.*
	In	this	cage	tiger	sleeps	and	in	this	cage	tiger	eats

'In this cage, the tiger is sleeping, and in that cage, the tiger is eating.'

Dayal analyses bare singulars in Russian as definites, and provides the example in (i) to show that the uniqueness presupposition of a bare singular can be satisfied within the local context (in her terminology, situation) introduced by the spatial adverbial. I adapt this example in (97b) to acknowledge Dayal's contribution to the discussion of local contexts; I will provide a critical overview of her theory in Chapter 4.
However, I needed to change (i) to (97b) because, as was first noticed by Bronnikov (2004), the sentence in (i) is in fact infelicitous, for reasons orthogonal to the semantics of bare NPs. Namely, as Bronnikov says, the use of the additive coordinator *i* is pragmatically odd here, and it should be replaced with a more natural in such context contrastive coordinator *a* (on the difference between the two coordinators, see e.g. Jasinskaya & Zeevat 2009).
If *i* is replaced with *a*, the sentence is fine and illustrates the proposed point. This is how I got (97b) from (i).

within its own such subdomain. Analogously, in (97b), the disjunction *libo*, *libo* separates the context into two subdomains representing alternative outcomes, and each of the two bare nominals *korova* 'cow' is interpreted within its own subdomain.

In the second group of cases, the introduction of subdomains is triggered by the information structure of the sentence. Namely, each bare nominal is interpreted within the subdomain selected by the topic of its clause, that is, a constituent whose content is what this clause is about. In (98a), the two NPs, *vas'a* 'Vasya' and *pet'a* 'Petya' are contrastive topics, and the context is divided into two subdomains corresponding to the information about the respective boys, and each of the bare nominals *jabloko* 'apple' is interpreted within its own domain. Analogously, in (98b), each of the spatial adverbials selects a subdomain of the context corresponding to the information about the meant cage, and each of the bare NPs *tigr* 'tiger' is interpreted within its own domain.

In this section, I will argue that these subdomains are *local contexts*, that is, subsets of the global context derived either by the use of an overt operator or via accommodation of the speaker's communicative goals (in my formalization, via accommodation of a QUD) that can serve as domain restrictors.

In Section 3.2, I will provide the general theoretical background on local contexts and then will discuss different ways of how they are established. I will start with discussing local contexts introduced by overt operators like a universal quantifier or a disjunctor (Section 3.2.1.) and then will discuss the local contexts triggered by the information structure of the sentence (Section 3.2.2). In the latter case, I will adapt the QUD-based approach to the information structure and argue that QUDs can restrict the context to propositions and discourse referents relevant for their resolution. Discussing each type of local contexts, I will first show that they provide a local domain in which the informational uniqueness presupposition of definites can be satisfied. Building on this parallel, I will then argue that the Unambiguity Constraint of bare nominals in Russian can also be satisfied within such local contexts. Finally, I will show that when the informational uniqueness is not maintained even within the relevant local context and/or when the conditions licensing the introduction of that local context are absent, the use of a bare nominal is infelicitous, as expected.

After this, in Section 3.4, I will also discuss the potential overprediction issue and argue that sentences like in (99a) are still predicted to be infelicitous out of-the-blue because it is quite difficult to accommodate a communicative goal (a QUD) that would provide different subdomains for each of the bare NPs; at the same time, I will show that it is nevertheless possible to do so with some contextual support, that is, even sentences like (99a) can be felicitous in a right context, like in (99b).

(99) a. {— What is going on in the street?}

#*Na*	*ulice*	*lajet*	*sobaka*	*i*	*ryčit*	*sobaka*
on	street	barks	dog	and	growls	dog

Intended: 'In the street, a dog is barking and a dog is growling.'

b. Context. Vasya hears that some animal is barking and some other animal is growling, but can not identify their respective species. He asks Petya:

{— What kind of animal is barking and what kind of animal is growling?}

Lajet	*sobaka*	*i*	*ryčit*	*(tože)*	*sobaka.*
barks	dog	and	growls	also	dog

'The one that is barking is a dog, and the one that is growling is also a dog.'

Finally, in Section 3.5, I will discuss a potentially challenging case where identical bare nominals form anti-unique sequences within the same clause, as in (100). Such anti-unique sequences require a very specific informational structure: they are only felicitous if each bare nominal is used to predicate over an individual whose identity is not-at-issue. For instance, the sentence in (100) can naturally be uttered to express surprise that both the attacker and the "attackee" are dogs. In contrast, it cannot felicitously be used to merely convey that an attack took place: the fact that both participants in the attack were dogs, rather than some other animals, should be one of the main points of the utterance.

(100) Context. One dog just attacked another one. Vasya is surprised: he thought dogs never attack each other.

Sobaka	*napala*	*na*	*sobaku.*
dog	attacked	on	dog

'A *dog* attacked a *dog*.'

I will sketch a possible account of how sentences with quasi-predicative anti-unique sequences such as (100) can be accommodated within the UC-based approach. Note that, given the information structure conditions under which such sentences are felicitous, they appear to address a complex QUD like 'What kind of individual did what to what kind of individual?'. I will argue that if we assume that such a QUD is further decomposed into sub-QUDs, including those that separately target the property of each participant (for example, 'What kind of animal was the attacker?' and 'What kind of animal was the attackee?', like it would be the case for (100)), then the two bare nominals are used to contribute to addressing two separate, informationally independent sub-QUDs. If that is true, then each of them is interpreted in its own local context, without violating the informational uniqueness requirement of the UC, analogously to cases such as (98), where separate sub-QUDs were licensed by overtly realized topics.

3.2. Local contexts: theoretical background

As we have discussed at the beginning of the chapter, dynamic approaches to meaning assume that the content of an utterance is evaluated with respect to the context — an information state containing all the propositions the interlocutors agreed to consider true and discourse referents — informational representations of (existing or hypothetical) entities under discussion. Namely, the presupposition conveyed by the utterance is required to be true at the input context, and the asserted content of the utterance updates the input context via restricting it to the set of possible worlds where the asserted proposition is true and potentially adding new discourse referents into the assignment functions.

What we have not discussed yet is that what gets evaluated and updated is not always the one *global* context. Consider, for instance, the contrast in (101). The sentence in (101a) has a presupposition that John used to smoke. In the system we used so far, this presupposition is analyzed as a restriction to the input context *as a whole*: in all possible worlds of the context, it must be true that John used to smoke. The same analysis cannot account for the data in (101b), however. The second clause of (101b) has the same presupposition as (101a), that John used to smoke. In this case, however, the presupposition is not satisfied in the global context: it is still an open question whether John used to smoke or not. Instead, the presupposition of the second clause is satisfied *locally.* Namely, the use of the disjunction in (101b) splits the context into two non-intersecting parts: the one in which the first disjunct is true (c_1) and the one where it is false and the second disjunct is true (c_2); the second disjunct is thus evaluated in c_2, in which the proposition that John never smoked is false (and hence it is true that John *used* to smoke), and its presupposition is satisfied there.

(101) a. *John stopped smoking.*

b. *Either John never smoked or he stopped smoking.*

Importantly, discourse referents can also be introduced and picked out locally. Consider, for instance, the sentence in (102). The discourse referent introduced by the indefinite *an expensive car* and then picked out by the pronoun *it* is clearly not globally accessible: it exists only in the possible worlds where John was not robbed, that is, in the sub-context c_1 introduced in the first conjunct. Because of that, it is not anaphorically accessible for the definite *the car* in the considered continuation: the definite NP needs a discourse referent existing in the actual world.

(102) *Either John saw an expensive car and bought it, or he just got robbed.*

(#The car is nice though.)

Local contexts do not always represent different sets of possible outcomes: sometimes, they are utilized as means of "zooming in" on different parts of the actual world. Consider, for instance, the sentence in (103). The use of the universal quantifier *every student* in (103) triggers introduction of a separate local context for each student under consideration, and the nuclear scope of the universal quantifier is interpreted in each of such local contexts. This is clear from how the contribution of the indefinite *an essay* is understood: instead of introduction of one global discourse referent, its use triggers introduction of many discourse referents, one per student. The pronoun *it* behaves analogously, picking out not some globally accessible referent, but the one introduced by the indefinite *an essay* within the same local context.

(103) *Every student wrote an essay and submitted it to ELMS.*

There are many different approaches to the local contexts proposed in the literature. Depending on a particular framework, they may be represented as contextually bound variables (von Fintel 1994; Elbourne 2002, 2005, 2013; Schwarz 2009, 2013; Barker 2022b, a.o.) or be derived by lexicalized instructions on the context update (Heim 1982; Groenendijk & Stokhof 1991; Brasoveanu 2007; Hofmann 2025, a.o.) or a parsing mechanism at the semantic-pragmatic interface (Stalnaker 1978; Kamp & Reyle 1993; Schlenker 2009, 2010, a.o.). What is uniformly accepted, however — and what is relevant for our purposes here — is that a local context is a restricted subset of the global context derived by the use of a restriction-triggering operator (such as disjunction, negation, conditional antecedent, universal quantifier, focus operator etc.). And most importantly, as we partially have seen already, the local context restricts the domain in which anaphoric expressions like pronouns or definite DPs seek their discourse referents.

3.2.1. Locality of anaphoric presuppositions

Crucially, the informational uniqueness requirement that restricts the use of definite NPs and (in addition to the salience requirement) anaphoric pronouns is also limited by the local context in which it is uttered. We already saw this with the pronoun *it* in (104): even though, by the time the pronoun was uttered, there were many given and equally salient discourse referents each representing a particular student's essay, the use of *it* was not infelicitous as we would expect had its informational uniqueness presupposition been evaluated with respect to the global context. Instead, it is evaluated with respect to the local context, namely, within a single considered case of a particular student. Within this domain, its informational uniqueness requirement is satisfied: for each student, there is a uniquely salient discourse referent available in its local context (the one representing his written essay), and *it* picks it out. Alternatively, one can argue that the informational uniqueness applies only to anaphoric expressions used within the global context. This is not the case: while the presence of potential antecedents globally is not per se a problem for the pronoun *it* in cases like in (103), it still requires that the informational uniqueness is satisfied within its local context. Consider, for example, (104). In this sentence, each local context is updated with two equally salient discourse referents, both of which satisfy the pronoun's descriptive content — an essay referent and a poem referent, — and the use of *it* is infelicitous.

(104) #*Every student wrote* ***an essay***$_i$ *and* ***a poem***$_j$ *and submitted* ***it***$_{i/j}$ *to ELMS.*

The same is true about definite expressions. Consider, for instance, (105). In (105a), the definite *the apple* is felicitous: it picks out the discourse referent introduced by the DP *an apple* within the same local context. While the presence of other apple referents does not affect the felicity of its use, the definite still requires the informational uniqueness locally, as shown in (105b), where there are two discourse referents available in the local context and each of them meets the descriptive content of the definite *the fruit*.

(105) a. *Every student ate* ***an apple***$_i$ *and* ***a peach***$_j$ *and liked* ***the apple***$_i$ *more.*

b. #*Every student ate* ***an apple***$_i$ *and* ***a peach***$_j$ *and liked* ***the fruit***$_i$ *more.*

The same effect is observed with other cases where the anaphoric expressions are interpreted within a local context.

The sentence in (106) describes potential situations where a (random) person watches a tiger and a lion. The local context is thus restricted to the set of possible worlds where the consequent is true. The use of the two indefinites — *a tiger* and *a lion* — trigger introduction of corresponding discourse referents in each of the possible worlds under consideration. The possible worlds of the antecedent and the consequent covary, so the definite DP *the lion* picks out the discourse referent introduced within the same context. The presence of other lion discourse referents is irrelevant for the definite because they are out of its local context, but it can only have one satisfier of its predicate within the same world under consideration. This requirement is clear from the fact that the use of the definite *the cat* is infelicitous in the same context: each considered world has two feline discourse referents introduced in it, so the definite's informational uniqueness is not satisfied.

(106) *If a person watches **a tiger$_i$** and **a lion$_j$** fighting, he thinks **the tiger$_i$/*the cat$_i$** will win.*

The sentence in (106) is a disjunction, and each of the two disjuncts has its own local context. As we saw earlier, whatever is updated in the local context of the first disjunct is not given (and sometimes is even false) in the input of the second disjunct. Thus, the discourse referent introduced by the indefinite *an essay* in the first disjunct is not accessible in the second disjunct. Because of that, the use of the definite *the poem* is felicitous: while globally, two discourse referents satisfying its predicate were introduced, only one of them was introduced within the same local context[37]. And once again, if the informational uniqueness is not satisfied within the same local context, the use of a definite is infelicitous. For instance, you cannot use the definite *the text* instead of *the poem* in (107): there are two discourse referents introduced within the second disjunct that satisfy the predicate of this definite.

(107) *Either John only wrote **an essay$_i$**, or he wrote **an essay$_i$** AND **a poem$_j$**, but forgot to submit*

[37] Note that the felicitous use of the indefinite *an essay* in the second disjunct is also telling: had the two indefinites been interpreted within the same local context, the use of the second one would violate *Maximize Presupposition*: since the two DPs are meant to refer to the same individual in the given scenario, it would be more informative to use a definite instead of the second indefinite. In this case, however, the two indefinites are interpreted in different local contexts, and the use of the second one does not violate *Maximize Presupposition*. On sensitivity of *Maximize Presupposition* to the local context, see (Percus 2006; Singh 2011; Spector & Sudo 2017; Anvari 2018; Anvari & Blumberg 2021).

the poem$_i$/*the text$_i$.

Thus, the informational uniqueness requirement that restricts the distribution of anaphoric expressions is limited by the local context in which the expression is uttered. It is thus natural to assume that The Unambiguity Constraint, a more general version of the informational uniqueness constraint, is also limited by the local contexts in which the bare NP is interpreted. In the next section, I will show that this is indeed the case.

3.2.2. Accounting for the first group of cases

In this section, I will argue that the seemingly challenging behavior of bare NPs in cases like in (108), where one bare NP contributes to introduction of multiple discourse referents, is in fact parallel to the behavior of anaphoric expressions in the same context, and thus can be explained by the fact that the UC (just like the informational uniqueness requirement of definites and pronouns) is limited by the local context. Namely, I will argue that in these cases, discourse referents are introduced in different local contexts, so the UC is not violated; I will also show that as predicted, the discourse referent of a bare NPs should be informationally unique *within* the local context.

Let us start with the case in (97a), repeated here as (108):

(108) *Ko mn'e každyj den' prixodila (novaja) medsestra.*

to me every day came new nurse

'Everyday, a (new) nurse visited me.'

As we discussed in the previous section, the use of a universal quantifier triggers introduction of local contexts such that each local context is uniquely matched with a single member of the quantifier's restrictor. The content of the quantifier's nuclear scope is then updated to each of the local contexts separately. In particular, when an indefinite is used within the scope of the universal quantifier, each local context gets a new discourse referent.

This is exactly what happens in (108). The use of the quantifier *každyj den'* 'every day' introduces a set of local contexts such that each context uniquely corresponds to a particular day from the restrictor. Since the bare NP *medsestra* 'nurse' occurs within the scope of this universal quantifier, its use triggers simultaneous introduction of a discourse referent in each of the local contexts under consideration. Importantly, while there are multiple discourse referents introduced by the same bare NP in (109), each of them is informationally unique in its local context: within a particular day, there is just one nurse discourse referent. Thus, we can assume that the bare NP in (109) still obeys UC, but the constraint is applied within the same *local* context, not to the global context. If that is true, the prediction is that if the same bare NP occurs within the scope of the quantifier *twice*, the sentence should become infelicitous because the second bare NP would violate UC. This prediction is borne out, as shown in (109): the bare NP *medsestra* 'nurse' in the second clause cannot be used to introduce a new discourse referent in each of the local contexts because they all already have a discourse referent that satisfies the bare NP's predicate.

(109) #*Ko* *mn'e* *každyj* *den'* *prixodila* *medsestra* *i* *každyj* *den'*
to me every day came nurse and every day
zvonila *medsestra.*
called nurse
Intended: 'Everyday, a nurse visited me and a nurse called me.'

The case in (97b), repeated in (110), receives a similar explanation. As we saw earlier, in a disjunction, each of the disjuncts is interpreted within its own local context. Thus, the updates made by the first disjunct are not accessible in the second disjunct. Assuming Russian disjunction behaves analogously (which we do not have any reasons to doubt), the co-occurrence of two identical bare NPs in (110) that are witnessed by two different individuals can also be explained by the fact that the UC applies within the local context. Namely, the second bare NP *korova* is interpreted within the local context of the second disjunct, and its use is felicitous because the first cow discourse referent was introduced in the first disjunct and hence is not visible for UC. As far as the constraint is concerned, there are no other potential satisfiers within the same local context, so the bare NP *korova* can be used to introduce a new discourse referent.

(110)	*Vas'a*	*libo*	*prodal*	*korovu,*	*libo*	*kupil*	*korovu.*
	V.	either	sold	cow	or	bought	cow

‘Vasya either sold a cow or bought a cow.’

Again, the prediction is then that if two identical bare NPs witnessed by different individuals occur within the same disjunct, the sentence will be infelicitous. This prediction is borne out, as shown in (111). In this sentence, the introductory use of the third bare NP *korova* ‘cow’ is infelicitous since there is already a cow discourse referent introduced within the same local context.

(111)	#*Vas'a*	*libo*	*prodal*	*korovu,*	*libo*	*kupil*	*korovu*	*i*	*ukral*	*korovu*
	V.	either	sold	cow	or	bough	cow	and	stole	cow

Intended: ‘Vasya either sold a cow or bought a cow and stole a cow.’

Thus, in this section I showed that the data in (97) do not pose a challenge for the proposed analysis: in these cases, The Unambiguity Constraint is satisfied within the local context introduced by the semantic operator in whose scope the bare NP is interpreted. Let us now turn to accounting for the data in (98).

3.2.3. Local contexts, focus operator, and QUD

Overt semantic operators like disjunctors, universal quantifiers or conditionals are not the only sources of establishing a local context. Another important factor that can restrict the available contextual information is what the utterance is *about*. Consider a dialogue in (112). The sentence in (112a) addresses the question in (112a), and the definite in (112b) is interpreted as taking the maximal plurality of the eggs that John found; crucially, this is not the maximal plurality of known eggs: Bill found some eggs, too. However, those eggs are not accessible for the definite, since they are irrelevant for the question it addresses. Thus, the question in (112a) creates a local context for the definite NP in (112b), restricting the set of available information (including discourse referents) that are relevant for its resolution.

(112) Context. Two kids John and Bill found some Easter-eggs. Bill's mom asks John's mom:

a. *What did John do with the eggs he found?*

b. *He immediately ate all* ***the eggs***. (adapted from Schwarz 2009: 90)

The domain restriction like in (112) can happen without an overt question and can be accommodated by the hearer via understanding the speaker's communicative goals. Consider, for example, a classic bridging case like in (113). Even though there are many authors existing in the actual world, the definite *the author* in (113) is unambiguously understood as referring to the author of John's book. This is so because the second sentence is understood as a continuation of the story started by the first sentence, namely, elaboration on the book's origin, and the only author relevant within this story is the author of John's new book.

(113) *John bought a book.* ***The author*** *is French.* (Schwarz 2009: 22)

In formal pragmatics, the goal of an utterance is often represented as a covert question it addresses. The most influential framework that implements this idea is the so-called *QUD-based approach* to the discourse (Roberts 1996; 2012). In this framework, each sentence in the natural discourse addresses a Question Under Discussion (QUD) — an ordered stack of covert [38] questions representing the local goal of the speech act.

Within the QUD-based approach, the idea that the goal of an utterance restricts its interpretation is implemented as the following claim: the local context in which an utterance gets interpreted is formed by the part of the information state relevant for the resolution of the addressed QUD (Schwarz 2009; Roberts 2010, a.o.). Before formally defining what it means to be relevant for the QUD resolution, I will provide the background on semantics of questions and their contribution to the discourse.

In formal approaches, the classic semantics of questions (including QUDs) is represented as a Hamblin set (Hamblin 1973), that is, a set of all potential answers to this question. For instance,

[38] One may wonder if an overtly asked question is always the QUD of its answer. While the two often coincide, there are cases where the actual QUD differs from the overt question that the sentence addresses (Roberts 2012; Riester 2019, a.o.). One of such cases is illustrated in (i). Even though (ic) is a felicitous answer to (ia), it addresses a more specific QUD (ib), as revealed by its informational structure: the NPs *apples* are both marked as given, and the main point of the utterance is that John's apples are red, and Peter's apples are green.

(i)	a. Overt Question:	***What*** *did the kids buy?*
	b. QUD:	***What*** *apples did the kids buy?*
	c. Answer:	*John bought* ***RED*** *apples, and Peter bought* ***GREEN*** *apples.*

the Hamblin set of the question in (114a) is the set in (114b), that is, the set of all possible propositions in which someone is the best singer.

(114) a. *Who is the best singer?*

b. {p: ∃x [p = λw. x is the best singer in w]}

The (partial or full) resolution of a question is thus answering it with a proposition *p* that either is identical to or at least entails the truth value of some proposition(s) within the question's Hamblin set. A complete answer to a question would entail all true propositions in the Hamblin set (e.g. Karttunen 1977, Dayal 1996). A partial answer would resolve the truth-value of at least one Hamblin answer. For instance, (115b) is a complete answer to (114a): it suggests that only one proposition within the question's extension, 'Bill is the best singer', is true. In contrast, (115b) is a partial answer to (114a): it only suggests that the proposition 'John is the best singer' is false, leaving the truth value of the other propositions in the question's Hamblin set unresolved.

(115) a. *BILL is the best singer.*

b. *Well, JOHN is NOT the best singer.*

Pragmatically, the effect of a question can be seen as a partition of the context set (see Groenendijk 1999, von Fintel & Heim 2023, cf. Groenendijk & Stokhof 1984) [39]. A partition is formally represented as an ordered set of (non-intersecting) information states representing potential updates. An answer to the question triggers an update where cells are eliminated that are

[39] The classic partition approach to questions has been challenged conceptually and empirically in later works (Groenendijk 2009; Ciardelli & Roelofsen 2011, a.o.). Addressing these challenges led to introduction of the new framework known as *inquisitive semantics* (Gronendijk & Roelofsen 2009; see Ciardelli et al. 2018 for an overview). However, the classic partition analysis will suffice for modelling the context restriction relevant for my goals here.

incompatible with the answer's content. An example of how a question and its answer update the context is provided in (116). First, the question, *Who is the best singer?*, provides a partition comprising potential updates for *c* each of which represents an information state where one of the potential answers is true, as in (116a): it has a potential future context *c'* where it's true that John is the best singer, a potential future context *c''* where it's true that Sue is the best singer etc. The answer to the question, *Bill is the best singer*, updates the context again by cutting out all the cells in which it is not true that Bill is the best singer, as in (116b). This results in establishing a new context *c'''* where it is true that John is singing.

(116) a.

<table>
<tr><td><w, g> | John is the best singer in *w*</td></tr>
<tr><td>…</td></tr>
<tr><td><w, g> | Peter is the best singer in *w*</td></tr>
<tr><td><w, g>| Sue is the best singer in *w*</td></tr>
</table>

b.

<table>
<tr><td>**<w, g> | Bill is the best singer in *w***</td></tr>
<tr><td>~~<w, g> | Peter is the best singer in *w*~~</td></tr>
<tr><td>~~…~~</td></tr>
<tr><td>~~<w, g>| Sue is the best singer in *w*~~</td></tr>
</table>

Provided that QUDs have the same dynamic interpretation as overt questions, we can assume that each utterance in a natural discourse contributes to the resolution of the partition of potential updates provided by its QUD.

Now we are ready to talk about what it means for an element of an information state to be *relevant* for the QUD's resolution. According to Roberts (1996; 2010), a proposition is relevant to the QUD just in case it entails at least a partial answer to it[40]; in turn, a discourse referent *d* is relevant to the QUD if there is a property *p* such that *p(d)* is a proposition relevant for that QUD[41]. The pairs of relevant propositions and discourse referents given in the discourse form, in Roberts' terms, the attentional field[42] for the speaker, which restricts[43] the domain of interpretation for the content of the answer, including the evaluation of presuppositions.

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[40] Strictly speaking, Roberts does not directly characterize propositions *themselves* in terms of relevance, talking instead of the utterances conveying them: "A move *m* is Relevant to the question under discussion *q* iff *m* addresses *q*, directly or indirectly yielding a partial answer to *q* in CG" (Roberts 1996; 2010: 2). Given this definition, however, it is clear that the actual source of relevance is the proposition that entails a partial or complete answer to the QUD.

[41] "In a discourse with scoreboard S, discourse referent (in DR) is Relevant to the QUD *q* just in case for some property *P*, the question of whether *d* has *P* is evidently Relevant to *q*" (Roberts 2010: 5).

[42] Within situation semantics, an analogue of the attentional field is the **topic situation** (e.g. Kratzer 2007; Schwarz 2009; Šimík 2021; Srinivas 2021), defined as a maximal situation exemplifying the QUD's extension in the world of evaluation (Schwarz 2009), that is, all propositions whose existence entails the answer to the QUD in the given world and individuals that are arguments of those propositions (see the definition of exemplification in Kratzer 2007). The idea of topic situations comes back to Austin (1950), this is why they are sometimes called *Austinian*.

[43] Recall that just like it was the case with the local contexts introduced by overt semantic operators like the universal quantifier, anaphoric expressions within the scope of a local context-inducing operator can get interpreted within the global context, or a more global local context (Schwarz 2009; Roberts 2010). Consider, for instance, an example in (i) discussed in Schwarz 2009 in that respect. The definite NP *the mayor* in (ib) picks out the discourse referent representing the mayor of Hans and his wife's city. Crucially, the mayor discourse referent is not given in the immediate local context (ib) because it is not given that it will be relevant for the QUD's resolution. Nevertheless, the definite DP *the mayor* manages to access it.

(i) Context. Hans just came home from work and is talking to his wife about what's new.
a. *What did the mailman bring today?*
b. *You got a letter from* ***the mayor****.*

(adapted from Schwarz 2009: 191)

Now we can go back to the example in (113), repeated below as (117).

(117) *John bought a book.* ***The author*** *is French.* (Schwarz 2009: 22)

According to the QUD-based approach to the discourse structure, the definite *the author* is understood as referring to the author of John's new book because the second sentence addresses a QUD which could be roughly stated as 'What is the nationality of the book's author?', and the only author relevant for this QUD's resolution is the book's author, in this case just by virtue of how the question is stated: the local context accommodates a single author discourse referent.

Crucially, anaphoric definites can satisfy their informational uniqueness within local contexts introduced by the QUD. While for Roberts, the examples in (112b) and (113/117) are already illustrating that this is the case (she would analyze them as picking out weakly familiar discourse referents, that is, discourse referents that were not directly introduced but whose existence and uniqueness was implied by the preceding local context), even more convincing evidence is provided by examples like in (118).

(118) *Yesterday, when I was at the party, I saw* ***my friend John***$_i$ *talking to* ***a student***$_j$ ***from Russia****.* ***The guy***$_j$***'s accent*** *was so strong that I could barely understand what he was saying.*

In (118), the definite *the guy* is used in a global context that has two discourse referents that are guys: the speaker's friend John and the student from Russia. However, the definite's use is felicitous, and it is understood as referring to the Russian student, but not to John. This is so because the sentence in which the definite is uttered addresses a QUD like 'How was the Russian guy's accent?', and since only the discourse referent representing the Russian student is relevant for resolving the QUD, the informational uniqueness requirement of the definite is satisfied.

Utterances made within the single speech act can have different rhetorical relations between each other which can be modeled as different relations between the QUDs they address (Roberts 1996 et seq.). One type of such a relation that will be especially relevant for us during the discussion of Russian data is when a group of QUDs are sub-questions to a more general QUD. Consider, for example, (119). The sentence in (119c) addresses a general QUD about the kids in (119a) in such a way that each clause addresses a sub-question of the QUD dedicated to a particular kid. In addition to providing the answer, each clause in (119c) has a constituent that signals that the provided answer is partial and that only the sub-question about this constituent's referent is answered. The denotation of this constituent is called a **contrastive topic**.

(119) a. **Super-QUD:** — ***What***$_{i+ii+iii}$ *did the kids*$_{1+2+3}$ *buy at the grocery store?*

b. **Sub-QUDs:** — ***What***$_{i}$ *did John*$_{1}$ *buy?* ***What***$_{ii}$ *did Peter*$_{2}$ *buy?* ***What***$_{iii}$ *did Sue*$_{3}$ *buy?*

c. *John*$_{1}$ *bought* ***an apple***$_{i}$*, Peter*$_{2}$ *bought* ***an orange***$_{ii}$*, and Sue*$_{3}$ *bought* ***a banana***$_{iii}$*.*

Crucially, each sub-QUD has its own local context dedicated to the selected contrastive topic. This can be seen from examples like in (120). The two last sentences of (120) together address a QUD that can be stated like 'How did the two dogs behave?'. However, each of the two sentences addresses its own sub-QUD, 'How did the (first) dog behave yesterday?' and 'How did the (second) dog behave today?' correspondingly, as follows from the contrasting adverbials. The two definite NPs are each interpreted within its own local context introduced by the corresponding sub-QUD. The first instance of *the dog* is uttered within the answer to the question about yesterday, so it is unambiguously understood as referring to the first dog. The second NP *the dog* is understood as referring to the second dog because it is uttered within the answer to the question about today. For each question, the presence of the other dog is irrelevant for its resolution, hence the information uniqueness requirement is satisfied for both definites.

(120) *Yesterday, I saw **a dog**$_i$ at the park. Today, I saw **another dog**$_j$ at the store. Yesterday, **the dog**$_i$ was friendly. But today, **the dog**$_j$ was quite aggressive.*

(Srinivas 2021: 226)

Now we have all the necessary ingredients to account for the Russian examples in (98), where bare NPs seemingly violate the UC.

3.2.4. Accounting for the second group of cases

In this section, I will argue that the examples in (98), repeated here in (121), are not instances of UC violation. Namely, I will show that in each of them, each of the NPs is interpreted within its own local context introduced by the (sub-)QUD it contributes to addressing, and since these local contexts do not intersect, neither of the bare NPs violates the UC. In the remainder of this section, I will sequentially account for each of the cases in (121).

(121) a. *Vas'a kupil ananas, **jabloko** i mango,*
V. bought pineapple apple and mango
*a Pet'a kupil **jabloko,** grušu i banan*.
but P. bought apple pear and banana
'Vasya bought a pineapple, **an apple** and a mango, and Petya bought **an apple**, a pear and a banana.'

b. *V étoj kletke tigr jest, a v toj kletke tigr spit.*
in this cage tiger eats and in that cage tiger sleeps
'In this cage, the tiger is eating, and in that cage, the tiger is sleeping.'

Let us start with the sentence in (98a)[44], repeated here as (122), where the two bare NPs *jabloko* 'apple' are used within the same sentence, each introducing a novel discourse referent. How is that possible?

(122)
Vas'a	*kupil*	*ananas,*	***jabloko***	*i*	*mango,*	
V.	bought	pineapple	apple	and	mango	
a	*Pet'a*	*kupil*	***jabloko,***	*grušu*	*i*	*banan.*
but	P.	bought	apple	pear	and	banana

'Vasya bought a pineapple, **an apple** and a mango, and Petya bought **an apple**, a pear and a banana.'

As hinted by its information structure, the sentence in (122) provides a pair-list answer to a QUD like 'Who bought what?'. The first clause addresses a sub-QUD 'What did *Vasya* buy?', and the second one addresses a sub-QUD 'What did *Petya* buy?'. Crucially, the answer provided for the first QUD does not affect the resolution of the second QUD: the fact that Vasya bought an apple, a mango and a pineapple does not narrow down the set of potential answers to what Petya bought. In particular, the discourse referents introduced in the first QUD's local context are irrelevant for

[44] One may wonder why each of the clauses in (98a/122) has other bare NPs: why not just discuss (i) instead?

(i)
Vas'a	*kupil*	*jabloko,*	*Pet'a*	*kupil*	*jabloko.*
V.	bought	apple	P.	bought	apple

'Vasya bought an apple, Peter bought an apple.'

The problem with (i) is that the two bare NPs *jabloko* 'apple' are obligatorily deaccented as present in both contrasting clauses (so-called *Williams Effect*, or *Anti-Epistophe Constraint*, see Williams 1997; Arstein 2004, Wagner & McCurdy 2010; Wagner 2012, 2020; Shapiro & Attila 2020), and because of that it is not clear whether the sentence in (i) could actually addresses the QUD: 'What did the kids buy?'. According to approaches in which deaccented constituents define the content of the QUD's presupposition (e.g. Rooth 1992; Schwarzschild 1999; Büring 2019; Riester 2019; Goodhue 2021), (i) addresses a different QUD, namely 'Who bought the apples?'. While this view is by no means consensual (see e.g. Williams 1997; Wagner 2012; Anttila et al. 2020; Shapiro & Anttila 2020 for the critical remarks), the addition of other bare NPs prevents deaccentuation of *jabloko* in (104a/127), and this sentence thus serves as a more reliable case of an answer to the QUD 'What did the kids buy?'.

the resolution of the second QUD and hence are not available within its local context. This, in turn, means that the discourse referent introduced by the first bare NP *jabloko* 'apple' is absent from the local context introduced the second QUD[45], and hence the second bare NP *jabloko* can be felicitously used to introduce a novel discourse referent, without the risk of violating UC.

If it is the second QUD that establishes the domain for the UC in the second clause in (122), the prediction is that if another bare NP *jabloko* 'apple' is added to the second clause, the sentence will be infelicitous. This prediction is borne out, as shown in (123).

(123) #*Vas'a kupil ananas,* ***jabloko*** *i mango,*
V. bought pineapple apple and mango
a Pet'a kupil ***jabloko,*** *grušu,* ***jabloko*** *i banan.*
but P. bought apple pear apple and banana
Intended: 'Vasya bought a pineapple, **an apple** and a mango, and Petya bought **another apple**, a pear and a banana.'

The same effect is expected if we "compile" the two answers to the sub-QUDs into one answer directly addressing the super-QUD 'What did the kids buy?'. The two bare NPs would now be a part of a single answer to a QUD and thus interpreted within the same local context; in such a case, the use of the second bare NP is predicted to be infelicitous due to the UC violation. This prediction is borne out, as shown in (124).

[45] A note of caution is in order here. Of course, the discourse referent introduced by the first bare nominal *can* be accessed in the clause that addresses the second sub-QUD; what I mean here is simply that the local domain provided by the second QUD does not contain this discourse referent, and the informational uniqueness requirement on the use of the second bare nominal can be satisfied within this local domain.

(124) #*Deti* *kupili* *ananas,* *jabloko,* *mango,* *jabloko,* *grušu* *i*

kids bought pineapple apple mango apple pear and

banan.

banana

'The kids bought a pineapple, an apple, a mango, an apple, and a pear.'

Thus, the felicity of cases like in (98) is explained by the fact that the two bare NPs are interpreted within separate local contexts, so when the UC applies to the second NP, the discourse referent introduced by the first one does not fall within its domain, so no violation of the UC occurs.

Let us now turn to the example in (98b), repeated here as (125). This sentence has a slightly different information structure than (122). Namely, in contrast to (122), the two bare NPs in question are used not to introduce novel discourse referents but to pick out given ones. This can be seen from the presupposition of (125): it requires accommodation of the fact that in each of the considered cages, there is a tiger. Moreover, the sentence cannot be felicitously used as an answer to the question 'What is going on in each cage?' unless it is accommodated that the question is in fact precisely about the tigers' behavior. Provided that, the reconstructed QUD (125) addresses is 'What tigers are doing in each of the cage?'; the first clause then addresses a sub-QUD 'In this cage, what is the tiger doing?', and the second one addresses a sub-QUD 'In that cage, what is the tiger doing?'.

(125) *V* *étoj* *kletke* *tigr* *jest,* *a* *v* *toj* *kletke* *tigr* *spit.*

In this cage tiger eats and in that cage tiger sleeps

'In this cage, the tiger is eating, and in that cage, the tiger is sleeping.'

Now, if it is given that there is a tiger in each of the cages and hence there are at least two tiger discourse referents in the global context, why isn't the use of either bare NP infelicitous? Again, the reason is that they are interpreted within two distinct local contexts. Namely, each of the sub-QUDs restricts the context to the discourse referents whose individuals are present in the respective cage. Since the presupposition of (125) is that there is a tiger in each cage, the context has only one given tiger discourse referent for each cage[46]. Thus, when each of the sub-QUDs restricts the set of accessible discourse referents to those present in the cage in question, only one tiger discourse referent remains accessible in each case. This, in turn, licenses the use of the bare NP *tigr* in each of the two clauses: the NP is used anaphorically to pick out the only given discourse referent accessible within the local context that meets its descriptive content (by being a tiger).

That it is the local context of the QUD that licenses the use of the bare NPs can be confirmed by the fact that if we change the information structure and word order of (125) in a way that the two adverbials are no longer contrastive topics, the sentence becomes infelicitous. Consider (126), for instance. Here, the adverbial phrases are put at the right periphery of the sentence and cannot be interpreted as contrastive topics. Thus, neither of the clauses can be parsed as addressing a sub-QUD about a particular cage, and the licensing condition for the felicitous use of the two bare NPs is lost. As predicted, (126) is infelicitous.

(126)	#*Tigr*	*jest*	*v*	*étoj*	*kletke*	*i*	*tigr*	*spit*	*v*	*toj*	*kletke.*
	tiger	eats	in	this	cage	and	tiger	sleeps	in	that	cage

'A tiger is eating in this cage, and a tiger is eating in that cage.'

[46] I assume here that the given discourse referents for tigers are accommodated if (125) is uttered without a preceding discourse. Normally, however, (125) requires prior mention of the tigers or at least their high saliency.

Thus, to sum up, in cases like in (125), the two identical bare NPs can pick out different given discourse referents because each of them is interpreted in a separate local context, and this context is restricted in a way that only one given referent that satisfies the NP's predicate remains available (and this is exactly the case where the anaphoric use of a bare NP is allowed by UC).

Thus, in this section I accounted for the cases like in (98), where the two identical bare NPs uttered within the same sentence are witnessed by two different individuals at first glance violate the Unambiguity Constraint. Namely, I argued that in sentences like in (89), each of the bare NPs is interpreted within its own local context introduced by a sub-QUD this bare NP contributes to addressing. Since the UC can be satisfied within the local context, cases like in (98) do not pose a problem for the proposed analysis.

3.2.5. Infelicitous cases: QUD-related issues

As we learned in the previous sections, the UC approach predicts that two identical bare NPs uttered within a single sentence *can*, in fact, have different witnesses — as long as each of them is interpreted in its own local context, and those local contexts do not intersect. Moreover, we saw that the local contexts can be introduced covertly, via the QUD the sentence is addressing.

This new knowledge makes our initial explanation for the infelicity of the cases like in (127) insufficient. Namely, since any sentence with two identical bare NPs is predicted to be felicitous if it is addressing an appropriate QUD, then the infelicity of (127) could be accounted for only if the sentence in (127) is either independently unable to address a "good" QUD or more naturally interpreted as addressing "bad" QUD and can become felicitous if a "good" QUD is accommodated.

(127) #*Na ulice lajet sobaka i ryčit sobaka*
on street barks dog and growls dog
Intended: 'In the street, a dog is barking and a dog is growling.'

The second option is in fact correct: while (127) is odd if uttered out of the blue, it is completely felicitous in a context like in (128)[47]. In this context, the sentence addresses a QUD (identical to the covert question) split into two sub-QUDs: 'What kind of animal is barking?' and 'What kind of animal is growling?'. The first clause addresses the first sub-QUD, and the second clause addresses the second one. Crucially, the two bare NPs end up addressing two different sub-QUDs, whose resolution is independent from each other. In particular, the discourse referent introduced by the first bare NP *sobaka* 'dog' is irrelevant for the second QUD's resolution (the fact that *x* is a barking dog does not tell us anything about the kind of the growling animal *y*) and hence is absent in the local context introduced by this QUD. The second bare NP *sobaka* can thus be used to introduce a new discourse referent in this local context without the risk of the UC violation.

(128) Context. Vasya hears that some animal is barking and some other animal is growling, but can not identify their respective species. He asks Petya:
{— What kind of animal is the one barking and what kind of animal is the one growling?}
Lajet sobaka i ryčit (tože) sobaka.
barks dog and growls also dog
'The one that is barking is a dog, and the one that is growling is also a dog.'

[47] I did not use the adverbial in (128), because addition would make the sentence more difficult to parse since a more peculiar context and a more nuanced QUD would be required; the sentence would still be fine, however.

Thus, a marked QUD like in (128), where the two bare NPs contribute to the two independent parts of the answer, can license the use of the normally infelicitous sentence in (127). But why is it bad when uttered out-of-the blue? I argue that this is because the QUDs that can license it require certain contextual support (for instance, for the QUD in (128) to be accommodated, it should be (accommodated as) given that there is some *x* barking and some *y* growling). Simpler and commonly accommodated[48] out-of-the blue QUDs like 'What is going in the street?' are not divisible into sub-QUDs that would "put" the two bare NPs into different local contexts and hence cannot be good QUDs for (127).

Let me show how exactly the infelicity of (129) when uttered out of the blue is accounted for (recall that we only consider the interpretation under which the two dogs are different).

(129) QUD: 'What is going on in the street?'

#*Na*	*ulice*	*lajet*	*sobaka*	*i*	*ryčit*	*sobaka*
on	street	barks	dog	and	growls	dog

[48] This claim is of course quite speculative because we can not know for sure which QUDs the utterance is meant to address if it is infelicitous; in fact, we more often than not cannot know for sure which exact QUD a *felicitous* sentence addresses if it is uttered out-of-the blue. That being said, we can still meaningfully speculate on what kind of QUD the addressee attempts to accomodate when interpreting (127) by looking at which QUDs are naturally accommodated for the structurally identical sentences where the two bare NPs are different. Consider, for instance, (i). This sentence is most naturally understood as a broad comment about what is going on in the street. A more narrow QUD would not fit the information structure of the sentence. In particular, it cannot be a question about the subjects (like 'What are the animals doing?') because post-verbal subjects cannot be topics; it also cannot be a QUD like 'Who is barking and who is growling?' because the two clauses would be understood as contrasting partial answers and that would contradict the additivity meaning of the conjunct *i* 'and'. Thus, (i) can only address the broadest type of QUD, like 'What is going on in the street?'.

(i)

Lajet	*sobaka*	*i*	*myčit*	*korova.*
barks	dog	and	moos	cow

'A dog is barking and a cow is mooing.'

Thus, given that the sentence in (127) is very similar to (i) in terms of its informational structure, we can assume that it has the same issues with the QUDs like 'Who is barking and who is growling?' and 'What are the dogs doing?' and that the QUD 'What is going on?', in purely informational structure sense, is optimal for (127).

Intended: 'In the street, a dog is barking and a dog is growling.'

First, let us assume that the default QUD a sentence addresses out-of-the blue is the so-called *fact-finding* one (Champollion et al. 2019; Elliott 2023), which can be formulated, in the ideal case, as 'What is the matter of things?'. However, given that the sentence in (129) has a topical frame adverbial *na ulice* 'in the street', the accommodated QUD is likely more specific, something like 'What is going on in the street?'. The sentence in (129) then consists of two clauses each of which gives a partial answer to this QUD. Given that, there are two ways how the relation between the two answers can be interpreted.

On one hand, they can be understood as answers addressing different sub-QUDs. This can work only if the clauses have structurally identical constituents that can serve as contrastive topics (to provide a dimension for the division into sub-QUDs): in (129), only the two verbs could be the contrastive topics (recall that the NPs are in the post-verbal position which is not topical). If those are topics, then the corresponding sub-QUDs can only be 'Who is barking and who is growling?' or 'What type of animal is barking and what type of animal is growling?'. The second pair of sub-QUDs will indeed lead to the felicity of (129), as we already discussed; however, as we also know, it requires a substantial contextual support to be accommodated. The first pair of sub-QUDs is arguably more easily recoverable, but (129) is just a bad answer for such a QUD: since the goal is to identify the barker and the growler with some other individuals, using the same bare NP to name either of the individuals is uninformative (it would not be clear which of the dogs is meant in each case). Thus, splitting the QUD into sub-QUDs will either lead (with some substantial contextual support, unlikely in out-of-the-blue contexts) to the felicitous case like in (128) that we already discussed, or to the infelicity of (129).

Alternatively, the second answer could just be understood as a follow-up to the first one. In this case, the two clauses are direct answers to the same single QUD, and the second answer is interpreted in the context updated by the first answer. This context would already have a dog discourse referent introduced by the first bare NP *sobaka*, and so the second bare NP *sobaka* cannot be felicitously used to introduce another dog discourse referent: this would violate UC. Thus, this way of addressing the QUD 'What is going on in the street?' will also lead to the infelicity, in this case — due to violation of UC.

Overall, among different possible QUDs for (127), only the one like in (128) is the appropriate one: in all the other cases, the sentence in (127) is infelicitous either because it is non-informative or because the second bare NP *sobaka* 'dog' violates UC. Given that the sub-QUD division like in (128), that is, 'What kind of animal is barking and what kind of animal is growling?' requires a substantial contextual support, it is then natural that, if uttered out-of-the blue, the sentence in (127) will normally be perceived as infelicitous.

Thus, in this section, I provided a more elaborated account of the infelicity of sentences like in (127), which became needed once the QUD-induced local contexts were put on the table. Namely, I argued that such sentences are bad because the QUDs they could address (without substantial contextual support, hardly available in out-of-the blue contexts) do not provide separate local contexts for each of the bare NPs (that is, such QUDs cannot be split into sub-QUDs providing non-intersecting local contexts for each of the bare NPs). Moreover, I showed that in a certain context, where an otherwise barely accessible QUD is easily accommodated, the sentence in (127) becomes felicitous. This is yet one more argument in favor of the pragmatic nature of (127)'s usual infelicity: with a good QUD, it is fine, which is not what we normally expect if the sentence is grammatically ill-formed or semantically uninterpretable.

Before finishing this section, I will discuss the cases where two identical bare nominals are used within the same clause — what I will call *quasi-predicative* sequences. I do not have a full-fledged account of these cases yet, but I will outline a sketch of a potential solution, according to which in such cases, the informational uniqueness of each bare nominal is satisfied in different subdomains.

3.2.6. Quasi-predicative sequences

In previous sections, I discussed two cases where a bare nominal can felicitously be used to introduce or pick out a discourse referent within a context that has discourse referents mapping onto other satisfiers of that nominal. As I showed, in all those cases, such uses of a bare nominal are felicitous only if the introduced or picked out discourse referent(s) end(s) up being informationally unique with respect to their local context, which was provided either by an overt semantic operator (like a universal quantifier or a disjunction) or through accommodation of the speaker's goals (in my formalization, via QUD).

There is, however, one more type of cases where anti-unique sequences of bare nominals can be uttered felicitously which cannot be obviously analyzed via selection of different local contexts, as the two bare nominals occur within the same clause. These are what I have called in the introduction *quasi-predicative sequences*: two identical bare nominals are used to highlight that some two individuals, whose identity is not at issue, belong to the same class/share the same certain property. Consider, for instance, (130): this sentence is most naturally understood as expressing a surprise that in an attack, both participants were dogs, but not some other animals.

(130) *Sobaka napala na sobaku.*

dog attacked on dog

'*A dog* attacked *a dog*.'

While proposing a full-fledged account of such anti-unique uses of bare nominals is work in progress, in this section, I will argue that they can be accounted for within the UC-based approach if certain non-trivial assumptions about the internal structure of their QUDs are made. Namely, I will show that such sentences can only be used to address QUDs like 'What type of individual did what to what type of individual?'[49], and assuming that such QUDs are further decomposed into sub-QUDs, two of which separately question what kind of entity a particular participant is, the two bare nominals are used to address different sub-QUDs and hence can satisfy their informational uniqueness requirement in separate local contexts.

The main intuition motivating such an analysis is that in cases like in (130), the two bare nominals are not used to (relatively) *identify* the corresponding individuals (their identity is assumed given or does not matter for the sake of the made point), but rather to highlight that each of the participants of a certain event, whoever or whatever they are, is a satisfier of the property lexicalized by the bare nominal; in (130), for instance, the main point is that it was a dog, not a cat or a raccoon, that was the attacker, and it was a dog, not a cat or a racoon, that was attacked.

Adopting the described intuition within the QUD-based approach, sentences like in (130) address a QUD like 'What type of individual did what to what type of individual?'. The provided QUD analysis narrows down the set of salient alternatives arising as one interprets (130): while it is taken for granted that some x attacked some y, the computed alternatives differ in whether x or y is a dog or some other creature. This focus structure is evident from the felicity conditions on (130)'s use. Namely, this sentence can only be uttered in a context when the speaker intends to highlight that the attacking and the attacked animals belong to the same kind. It cannot be

[49] Or at least one of the bare nominals should address the question 'What type of individual is X?', if the preliminary data in (134) are considered.

felicitously used to merely report that two animals, a dog *x* and a dog *y*, are fighting. This is illustrated in (131). The sentence in (131) can only be used in the first context, where the reason for Vasya's uttering it was that he was surprised that a dog attacked a member of its species[50]. It is infelicitous in the second context, where Vasya's surprisal has nothing to do with Bobik and Sharik being dogs.

(131) Context 1. One dog just attacked another one. Vasya is surprised: he thought dogs never attacked each other.

#Context 2. Vasya has two dogs: Bobik and Sharik. Sharik has just attacked Bobik. Vasya is surprised: he knew dogs can attack each other, but Sharik has never been aggressive, especially towards Bobik.[51]

Sobaka napala na sobaku!
dog attacked on dog
'*A dog* attacked *a dog*.'

There is another piece of evidence for the proposed QUD analysis. Namely, the pragmatic felicity of the sentences like in (130) depends on how the property lexicalized by the (identical) bare NPs is relevant for the type of interaction between the individuals denoted by the VP. This prediction is borne out, as shown by the contrast in (132). The sentence in (132a) is felicitous and natural: it is understood as highlighting the understandable surprisal from the fact that the two huggers were

[50] Note that, in particular, (131) is fine if the attacking dog is Sharik and the attacked dog is Bobik, as in the second context, as long as the reason for suprisal is the *dogness* of the attacking dog, as in the first context.

[51] A potential worry here is that (131) is odd in such a context simply because the speaker chose nominals with insufficient descriptive content: for greater concreteness, they could have just used the dogs' names instead. This objection, however, rests on an assumption that the addressee knows which dog each name refers to, because only in this case, using them instead would be more informative. Crucially, (131) is still odd in this context even if the addressee does not know that one dog is called Sharik and the other Bobik. I am grateful to Valentine Hacquard for raising this concern.

both misanthropes. In contrast, the sentence in (132b) is odd because it is not clear why it would be relevant in the context of hugging that both huggers are *brown-eyed* girls. It is, of course, possible to accommodate such a context (for instance, one can assume that the speaker thinks that brown-eyed girls are not generally huggers), but it will require more creative work than in more natural cases like in (132a).

(132) a. *Mizantrop* *obn'al* *mizantropa.*

misanthrope hugged misanthrope

'Look, a misanthrope hugged a misanthrope'

b. ??*Karje-glazaja* *devočka* *obn'ala* *karje-glazuju* *devočku.*

brown-eyed girl hugged brown-eyed girl

'A brown-eyed girl hugged a brown-eyed girl.'

So far, I have shown that anti-unique sequences of bare nominals can only felicitously be used if the sentence addresses a QUD like 'What type of entity did what to what type of entity?'. This QUD on its own, however, is not enough to derive felicity of such sequences within the UC-based approach. Namely, to derive a separate local context for each bare nominal in which it would satisfy the UC, the proposed QUD should be decomposed in such a way that the two bare nominals contribute to addressing different sub-QUDs.

Intuitively, such a decomposition is plausible. For instance, one could assume that the QUD like 'What type of entity did what to what type of entity?' can be decomposed into the following sub-QUDs': 'What did x do to y?', 'What kind of entity is x?' and 'What kind of entity is y?'. If this decomposition is indeed available, sentences with quasi-predicative anti-unique sequences like in (130) can be accounted for within the UC-based approach. Just like in the cases discussed in

Section 3.2, the two bare nominals contribute to addressing different sub-QUDs, and the discourse referent introduced by the use of the first bare NP is irrelevant for the resolution of the second sub-QUD and hence is not present within the local context in which the second bare NP is evaluated. Namely, this second sub-QUD is 'What kind of animal is the attacked individual *y*?', and the fact that there is a discourse referent given in the context that represents an attacking dog does not narrow down the set of potential answers to the question. The only individual whose properties matter is the attacked animal *y*, so the local context in which the second bare NP is interpreted does not include any other discourse referents; in particular, it does not include the one corresponding to the attacker. Hence, the use of the bare NP in (130) does not violate UC.

The problem here is that it is not exactly clear how to independently attest the proposed decomposition. The evidence provided so far only suggests that the set of focus alternatives of clauses with quasi-predicative sequences looks (quasi-formally) as in (133), that is, they all share the common part 'some x did some action V to some y' and vary in terms of what properties are ascribed to x, y, and (potentially) the event V they participate in. It is difficult to tell, however, whether there are any hierarchical relations between different domains of alternation (or, speaking in terms of the QUD-based approach, whether some sub-QUDs are nested within others), and if there are, whether bare nominals still contribute to addressing different sub-QUDs.

(133) $\{p: \exists N_1, N_2, V\ [p = \lambda w.\ \exists x \exists y \exists e\ [N_1(x, w)\ \&\ N_2(y, w)\ \&\ V(x, y, e, w)]\}$,

where N_1 and N_2 are properties of the individuals and V is a property of the event

While attesting the proposed sub-QUD decomposition is thus a question for further research, what I will show in the remainder of this section is that there is, at least, some evidence that the proposed predicate-oriented sub-QUDs can occur as sole, independent QUDs — and in such cases, they indeed serve as domain restrictors. Moreover, I will show that not only bare nominals in Russian, but also definites in English might be subject to this domain restriction, that is, there is preliminary independent evidence showing that predicate-oriented QUDs can indirectly narrow down the domain of the (informational) uniqueness presupposition of *the*-DPs.

In examples like (130), both bare nominals are used quasi-predicatively; this is, however, not strictly required: preliminary data suggest that sequences where only one of the bare nominals is used quasi-predicatively can also be felicitously uttered. Consider, for instance, examples in (134). In (134a), only the second bare nominal is used to highlight a property of a certain individual (in this case — to highlight that the known victim was a girl); in contrast, the first bare nominal is used to refer to a particular individual, the attacker: the point of (134a) is not to highlight that both participants were girls, but to say that the attacker attacked a girl, not a boy. This sentence thus addresses a QUD like 'What gender was a kid that the girl fought with?'. A similar example is provided in (134b)[52], with the only difference being that it is now the first bare nominal that is used quasi-predicatively: the QUD (134b) addresses is something like 'What kind of animal attacked the dog?'.

(134) a. Context. A girl was sent to the director for a fight. Discussing the incident with colleagues, the director assumed that the girl's victim was a boy; however, a colleague corrects him:

Devočka podralas' s devočkoj, a ne s mal'čikom

[52] Admittedly, the sentence in (134b) is somewhat difficult to parse: it would be more natural if the second bare nominal were topicalized and the first one appeared postverbally. Nevertheless, (134b) is clearly felicitous, especially when the speaker uses it to correct a sentence the addressee just uttered.

girl fought with girl but not with boy

'The girl fought with a *girl*, not with a *boy*.'

b. Context. A dog attacked by another dog was brought to the animal doctor. In this town, wolves often attack dogs, so the doctor assumed that was the case here. However, the person who brought the dog corrects him:

Sobaka napala na sobaku, a ne volk.

dog bit on dog but not wolf

'A *dog* attacked the dog, not a wolf.'

With some assumptions being made, the felicity of both sentences in (134) can be accounted for within the UC-based approach. Namely, the following explanation seems plausible. In (134a), the use of the second bare nominal is felicitous because the discourse referent picked out by the use of the first bare NP (representing the girl that was sent to the director) is irrelevant for resolving the QUD (the only thing that matters is the gender of the other fighter, which is not in any way defined by the properties of the attacker), so the second bare nominal can felicitously be used to introduce a novel discourse referent representing a girl — it will be informationally unique in this narrowed domain. Analogously, in (134b), the use of the second bare nominal does not violate the UC, as the discourse referent it picks out does not contribute to resolving the QUD of the sentence, and hence is not included in the same domain as the discourse referent introduced by the use of the first bare nominal[53].

[53] Note that since (134b) is uttered in a context which already has a discourse referent representing a dog (the one that will be picked out by the use of the second bare nominal), the use of the first nominal is also at risk of violating the UC. In this case, however, the explanation is identical to the one for the case in (134a): the first bare NP addresses a QUD 'What kind of animal attacked the dog?' which selects the set of relevant discourse referents in which the discourse referent representing the familiar dog is, given the discussed assumptions, not included; hence, the use of the first bare NP leads to introduction of an informationally unique discourse referent, thus satisfying the UC.

Of course, as I have mentioned, the proposed account relies on some assumptions. The first assumption is that the set of discourse referents relevant to the resolution of a QUD is narrower than proposed by Roberts. Rather than including all discourse referents that occur as parts of propositions constituting partial answers to the QUD, the relevant domain should be restricted to discourse referents whose properties or identity vary across the alternatives under consideration. This assumption reflects the intuition that no further information about the first girl is relevant when the communicative goal is to determine the gender of the other participant in the fight. The second assumption is that the domain in which the informational uniqueness of discourse referents that are not relevant for the QUD resolution is tested may not include discourse referents that *are* relevant for the QUD; in other words, the QUD should not only introduce a local domain for discourse referents relevant for its resolution, but also to "hide" those discourse referents from the ones that are irrelevant for its resolution. If this assumption is not made, then the use of the second bare nominal in (134b) would violate the UC, as the discourse referent introduced by the use of the first bare NP would still be available globally after the QUD was addressed.

These assumptions are, at least at first glance, are costly, and further research is needed to test whether they can be motivated independently — or whether there is a way to avoid making them in the first place. That being said, however, there is some preliminary evidence that adopting this assumption may independently be helpful to account for certain uses of English definites. Consider, for example, (135). According to the native speakers of English I asked, this sentence can be felicitously uttered in contexts like in (134b), where not the identity, but the class of the attacker is questioned. Note that the second DP in (135) is definite, so any analysis based on the assumption that definites obey (informational) uniqueness would be challenged with a question: why is use of the definite *the dog* in (135) felicitous even though there is another dog mentioned in the prior context? The QUD-based explanation proposed for analogous examples with Russian bare NPs would be helpful here as well: the informational uniqueness of *the dog* is evaluated with respect to the domain which does not include discourse referents addressing the QUD (in this case, 'What kind of animal attacked the dog?'), and within this domain, there are no other discourse referents representing dogs. Testing this hypothesis is also a question for further research.

(135) *A dog attacked the dog, not a coyote (attacked it).*

Before finishing this section, let me make two more observations relevant for the understanding the phenomenon of quasi-predicative sequences.

First, there is an interesting question of what exactly is going on reference-wise in cases like in (130). In principle, one can argue that neither of the bare NPs picks out any discourse referent, and each of them is instead understood as ascribing a novel property to an already existing discourse referent about which the question is raised. Under such an analysis, the UC is trivially not violated because there is no picking out of a discourse referent in the first place. Such an account, while possible, would nevertheless require unorthodox theoretical assumptions about how an argumental bare NP is interpreted: it is typically assumed that argumental NPs are not predicates but either individual expressions or generalized quantifiers (Chierchia 1998 et seq.)[54]. I remain agnostic on whether one should go that route or not. What is important, however, is that even if the alternative route is chosen — namely, the one where each of the bare NPs does introduce a new discourse

[54] To be fair, one does not have to commit to analyzing bare NPs as being of the predicative type to argue that they are interpreted predicatively in the dynamic domain. Alternatively, with use of the alternative semantics (Rooth 1992), one could argue that this follows from the way their focus value is composed and interpreted in the context. Namely, one could say that only their predicative part is focused, while the existential claim, introduced by the type-shifter *ex*, is a part of the given content. In this case, one should develop a fine-grained theory of the interface between the focus value composition and the context update. While this sounds promising, choosing that route over the alternative one, once again, does not affect the empirical coverage of the UC analysis.

referent which is understood as equal to the one about which the QUD is (the attacker *x* in the first case and the "attackee" *y* in the second case) — the use of the second bare NP does not violate UC, as has just been argued for.

Another observation I want to make here is that Russian proverbs that famously contain two identical bare nominals can also be analyzed as instances of quasi-predicative sequences. Consider, for instance, two of the most famous examples in (136), already brought up in previous studies on Russian bare NPs. What is common between such proverbs is that they are uttered when the speaker wants to represent a particular evidenced situation as an instance of a re-occurring pattern typical for the bearers of the properties denoted by the NPs — as opposed to just reporting that this situation took place. For instance, the proverb (136a) is naturally used in a context when both interlocutors know that some *x* got along with some *y*, and the point speaker makes by uttering (136a) is that the reason *x* and *y* got along is because they are both fools, and fools get along well due to being alike in their foolishness. Analogously, the most natural context for uttering (136b) is when your hearer already knows that *x* did something to *y* (or is accused/suspected of doing so), to bring it to their attention that both *x* and *y* are essentially thieves, and what *x* did to *y* was pretty much stealing or something comparable to it.

(136) a. *Durak* *duraka* *vidit* *iz-daleka.*

fool fool sees from-afar

'A fool sees a fool from afar.' (Seres & Borik 2018: xv)

b. *Vor* *u* *vora* *dubinku* *ukral.*

thief from thief club thief

‘A thief stole a club from a thief.’ (Bronnikov 2007: 2)

Thus, in this section, I discussed so-called quasi-predicative sequences of bare nominals — a case where two bare nominals are used in a single sentence and at least one of them is used not to identify an individual, but rather to highlight that it shares the denoted property. Such uses of bare nominals are challenging for the UC-based approach because without any additional assumptions being made, the use of the second bare nominal is wrongly predicted to be infelicitous. In this section, I propose a sketch of a potential solution, based on the intuition that when a bare NP is used quasi-predicatively, the identity of its individual is not-at-issue. I proposed a preliminary formalization of this intuition in terms of the QUD-based domain restriction, arguing that such bare NPs contribute to addressing a QUD like ‘What type of entity is X?’, for the resolution of which the presence of the other discourse referents satisfying the NP’s predicate does not matter. Of course, further research is required to see whether this explanation can be developed enough to properly cover quasi-predicative uses of bare nominals within the UC-based approach.

4. Conclusions

Thus, in this chapter, I argued that the use of argumental bare NPs in Russian is subject to a dynamic pragmatic rule of the reference resolution, which I dubbed The Unambiguity Constraint (UC). In its stricter form, that captures not only data from bare singulars but also from bare plurals, it is stated as follows:

(137) **The Unambiguity Constraint**

In the local context *c*, NP that lexicalizes a predicate P can be used to introduce a novel discourse referent *i* iff there are no other discourse referents that are entailed by *c* to also satisfy P;

in all the other cases, *i* must be the maximal given discourse referent entailed by *c* to satisfy P.

This constraint is essentially a generalized version of the informational uniqueness/maximality constraint proposed by Roberts (2003) to account for the distribution of anaphoric expressions such as anaphoric definites and personal pronouns in English. The only difference is that THE UC allows bare NPs to introduce novel discourse referents if (and only if) they cannot be used anaphorically (that is, if there are no given discourse referents satisfying the bare NP's predicate). Assuming that anaphoric expressions are lexically restricted to given discourse referents, their distribution is predicted by UC.

The UC account was motivated by the observation that two identical bare NPs in the same sentence cannot name different individuals, as in (138). This was unexpected, given that otherwise bare NPs behave as (unrestricted) indefinites: as was shown in Chapter 2, they do not have a uniqueness presupposition and can be used to introduce new discourse referents.

(138)	#*Na*	*ulice*	*lajet*	*sobaka*	*i*	*ryčit*	*sobaka.*
	on	street	barks	dog	and	growls	dog

Intended: 'In the street, a dog is barking and a dog is growling.'

Further investigation revealed that it is the second use of the (same) bare NP that causes the infelicity of (138). First, the first clause of (138) is fine if uttered on its own, as in (139a), even under the scenario in which (138) would be true had it been felicitous. Second, (138) becomes felicitous if a modifier like *eščë odin* 'one more' is added to the second bare NP, like in (139b), that implies that its witness is different from the one of the first bare NP. The natural conclusion from that is that the felicity of a bare NP's use depends on whether other individuals meeting its descriptive content have been mentioned in the prior discourse.

(139) a. Scenario. There are two dogs in the street, one of them is barking, the other one is sleeping.

ok*Na* *ulice* *lajet* *sobaka.*

on street barks dog

'In the street, a dog is barking.'

b. *Na* *ulice* *lajet* *sobaka* *i* #*(eščë* *odna)* *sobaka* *ryčit.*

on street barks dog and else one dog growls

'In the street, a dog is barking and another (*lit.* one more) dog is growling.'

The UC provides a natural explanation for this phenomenon, tying it together with the well-known constraint on anaphora resolution, the informational uniqueness requirement, by being a generalized version of it. The contribution of the UC analysis, however, does not stop at that. In addition to explaining the data from the initial puzzle, it makes more general predictions about the distribution of anaphoric and introductory uses of bare NPs.

For the introductory uses, it predicts that a bare NP can introduce a discourse referent *i* only if the other given discourse referents in the context (if any) do not satisfy the bare NP's predicate. This prediction is supported not only by the data from two identical bare NPs that we already discussed, but also by the cases where the first NP is a hyponym of the second one and where the predicates of the two NPs have intersecting extensions.

For the anaphoric uses, it predicts that a bare NP should behave as an anaphoric definite, that is, it must pick out the maximal given discourse referent satisfying the NP's predicate. This prediction is also borne out: anaphoric uses of bare singulars are felicitous only in the contexts where the picked discourse referent is the only given one that satisfies their predicate, and anaphoric uses of bare plurals are only felicitous if the maximal given discourse referent satisfying their predicate is picked out.

Finally, the proposed UC-based analysis accounts for cases where the use(s) of the same bare NP trigger(s) introduction of multiple discourse referents. It correctly predicts that this can only happen when each of the discourse referents is introduced in a separate local context[55]. In this respect, the UC is analogous to the informational uniqueness constraint applied to anaphoric expressions in English (Roberts 2003): both can be satisfied in a local context, as was shown by the relevant data from both bare NPs in Russian and anaphoric definite NPs from English. These local contexts can be introduced by overt operators, like a universal quantifier or a disjunctor, or covertly, by the accommodated (sub-)QUDs representing the speaker's conversational goals. I also show that even some infelicitous cases like in (138) can become felicitous if a QUD is selected that provides different local contexts for the two bare NPs; the reason they are infelicitous out-of-the-blue is that QUDs that they could address without violating the UC are not easily accommodatable (or, for other cases, there are no such QUDs in the first place).

[55] Of course, there are also challenging cases of quasi-predicative uses of bare nominals that are not straightforwardly accounted for by the proposed UC-based analysis. At the end of Section 3, I proposed a preliminary account of how they can still be covered for as cases where bare nominals are used to address different sub-QUDs and thus do not violate the UC; the proposed explanation, however, is based on important assumptions that must be independently motivated in future research.

Thus, according to my analysis, argumental bare NPs in Russian have a very simple semantics of variable-scope indefinites (in my formal implementation, generalized existential quantifiers over individuals), and their limited use in indefinite contexts is explained by an independent dynamic pragmatic principle of reference resolution — The Unambiguity Constraint. In the next chapter, I will compare this analysis with the earlier approaches to the semantics and distribution of argumental bare NPs in Russian. I will show that my approach makes better predictions of the data due to the dynamic pragmatic component, the UC.

Chapter 4. Comparison with other approaches

Bare NPs in Russian show contrastive behavior with respect to their (in)definiteness features. Generally, they pass the two main diagnostics for indefinites: they can be used to introduce novel discourse referents and do not have a uniqueness presupposition, as shown in (140a). At the same time, their distribution in indefinite contexts is restricted. Namely, two identical bare NPs uttered within the same context cannot have different witnesses, as shown in (140b) and (140c).

(140) Scenario. There are two dogs in the street, one of them is barking, the other one is sleeping.

a. *Na ulice lajet sobaka.*

on street dog barks

'In the street, a dog is barking.'

b. #*Na ulice lajet sobaka i ryčit sobaka.*

on street dog barks and growls dog

Expected: 'In the street, a dog is barking and a dog is growling.'

c. {—How is the dog doing?}

Sobaka zdorova, s sobakoj vsë xorošo.

dog healthy with dog all good

'The dog is healthy, everything is ok with the dog.'

In the two previous chapters, Chapter 2 and Chapter 3, I proposed a novel explanation for this contrastive behavior of Russian bare NPs. Namely, I argued that they indeed have the semantics of (island-obeying variable-scope) indefinites, but their use is subject to a dynamic pragmatic constraint on reference resolution: a bare NP can only be used to introduce a discourse referent if there are no given ones that satisfy the NP's predicate; if there are such discourse referents, then the bare NP can only be used to refer to the maximal of those, if there is one.

Thus, according to my analysis, bare NPs in Russian have a very simple, non-restrictive semantics of variable-scope indefinites, and the observed distribution of their indefinite uses is a result of a principled dynamic pragmatic constraint on reference resolution. This distinguishes it from the previous approaches, which either take cases like in (140b) as the baseline and propose a more restrictive, definite or definite-like semantics for bare NPs (Dayal 2004, 2013b; Berulava & Mayr 2024; Bikina 2026), or, in contrast, treat "definiteness effects" like in (140b) as side effects of more general pragmatic mechanisms, which in certain cases leads to an issue of overprediction (Seres & Borik 2018; Srinivas 2021; Srinivas & Rawlins 2021).

In this chapter, I will compare my approach with the previously proposed alternatives. I will show that my analysis incorporates the key theoretical insights from both lines of approaches and puts them together in a compatible way. More specifically, it follows the definiteness-based analyses in acknowledging that bare nominals in Russian follow a uniqueness requirement, but, in contrast to the previous proposals, this requirement is implemented as an independent discourse-level constraint, rather than a part of their truth-conditional meaning. At the same time, it follows indefiniteness-based analyses in assuming that semantically, bare nominals are indefinite. Thus, in contrast to the other approaches, my analysis manages to implement the two key insights — that bare nominals can be interpreted as indefinites and that they are subject to a definiteness-like constraint — in a non-contradicting way: bare nominals are indefinites semantically, but are subject to a definiteness-like constraint at the level of discourse reference.

The structure of this chapter is as follows. I will start with discussing the "restrictive semantics" accounts (Section 1), such as Dayal's classic Meaning Preservation approach (Dayal 2004; 2013b), and Berulava and Mayr's weak definite approach for bare plurals (Berulava & Mayr 2024). I will show that the proposed definite(-like) semantic analyses predict a narrower distribution of bare NPs in indefinite contexts than actually observed. After that, in Section 2, I will discuss the "loose pragmatics" accounts, such as Seres and Borik's "pragmatic strengthening" approach (Seres & Borik 2018) and Srinivas's *Maximize Presupposition!*-based approach (Srinivas 2021, 2022, 2025; Srinivas & Rawlins 2021, 2022a, 2022b). I will argue that these analyses have a problem of overprediction: they either do not have any principles that predict the limited use of bare NPs in indefinite contexts or those are not restrictive enough. Finally, in Section 3, I will summarize the key differences in assumptions and empirical coverage between my approach and its alternatives.

1. "Restricted Semantics" accounts

1.1. The Meaning Preservation Approach (Dayal 2004; 2013b)

1.1.1. Overview

Veneta Dayal's Meaning Preservation account (Dayal 2004) was proposed as a version of the so-called *neo-Carlsonian*[56] approach introduced by Gennaro Chierchia (1998). According to this theory, argumental bare NPs receive their interpretation through covert type-shifting from their original interpretation (predicates over individuals) to either individual expressions or quantifiers[57]. The type-shifting operation is pursued by one of the three type-shifters: *iota, ex,* and *nom*[58]. The formal definitions of the three type shifters are provided in (141-142). The first two type shifters are semantically equivalent to English articles *the* and *a*: *iota* turns bare NPs into

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[56] This theory is called *neo*-Carlsonian because it an updated version of Carlson (1977)'s original approach to bare plurals in English, better suited to account for the cross-linguistic variation. As the differences between Carlson (1977)'s and Chierchia (1998)'s approaches are orthogonal to the research question of this paper, I will not discuss them here, see Chierchia (1998) for more details on the topic.

[57] The motivation for type-shifting is that bare NPs need to have an argumental type to compose with the verb (Chierchia 1998; Dayal 2004). While neither of the authors discusses this explicitly, the assumption here is that the only way a nominal argument can compose with the verb is through functional application. Thus, since verbs are usually assumed to denote predicates of the type <e, t>, <e, <e, t>>, or <e, <e, <e, t>>>, the argumental NP must either be of the individual type *e* (to be an argument of the verb's predicate) or of the generalized quantifier type <<e, t>, <<e, t>, t>> (to take the verb's predicate as an argument). For more background on type-shifting of nominal expressions, see (Partee 1986).

[58] In the original proposal, Chierchia (1998) calls these type-shifters ι, ∃ and $^{\cap}$ correspondingly, adopting the notation from (Partee 1986; Chierchia 1984). Dayal (2004) replaces ι and $^{\cap}$ with *iota* and *nom* correspondingly, and then Coppock & Beaver (2015) replace ∃ with *ex* for the consistency of notation; following Tiutiunnikova et al. (2025), I adapt the latter version here, using the wordy notations for the sake of simplicity.

definite descriptions (formally, it takes the predicate over individuals denoted by the bare NP and returns its maximal satisfier), and *ex* turns them into variable-scope indefinites (formally, it takes the predicate over individuals denoted by the bare NP and returns an existential quantifier whose restrictor is that predicate). The last type shifter, *nom*, has a more nuanced function: it turns bare NPs into kind-denoting expressions. Formally, it takes the predicate denoted by the NP and returns the maximal member of its extension in the given world or situation.

(141) a. $iota =_{def} \lambda P_{<e, t>}. \iota x.P(x)$

b. $ex =_{def} \lambda P_{<e, t>}. \lambda Q_{<e, t>}. \exists x. P(x) \& Q(x)$

(142) For any property P and world/situation s,

$nom(P) = \lambda s.\iota P_s$, defined iff $\lambda s.\iota[P_s] \in K$,

where K is the conventional set of kinds, P_s is the extension of P in s

(Chierchia 1998: 350-351)

According to Chierchia (1998) and then Dayal (2004), the third type-shifter, *nom*, is needed to account for the use of bare NPs in kind predication, like in (143). Kind predicates like *evolve* or *extinct* require their subject to represent a kind. Consider, for instance, the contrast between (143a) and (143c). The verb *evolve* can take the bare plural *dogs* as an argument in (143a) because the plurality of all dogs in all possible worlds comprises all the instances of a well-established kind — namely, *Canis lupus familiaris*. In contrast, this verb cannot take NPs like *my dogs* or *dogs in this room* (143c) because the respective pluralities do not represent any conventional kind. The same contrast is observed for the verb *extinct* ((143b) vs. (143d)): only a group that represents a certain species, such as dodos, can be extinct; this predicate is inapplicable to the group of the speaker's dogs, as well as the plurality of dogs in this room: the two are not normally thought of as forming a kind of their own.

(143) a. *Dogs evolved from wolves.*

b. *Dodos are extinct.*

c. #*My dogs/dogs in this room evolved from wolves.*

d. #*My dogs/dogs in this room are extinct.*

Chierchia and Dayal take the felicity of examples like in (143a) or (143b), in contrast to the other examples, as evidence that bare plurals have a special kind reading, ontologically distinct from the indefinite and the definite readings, and hence a third type shifter is needed that would derive such readings, and that motivates introducing *nom*. This is not a uniformly shared assumption: e.g. Guerrini & Spector (2025) and especially Ralston (in press) argue that what is thought of as the kind reading of bare plurals (in English) is just an instance of the definite reading with the maximally global selected domain.

The three type shifters, *iota, ex*, and *nom*, do not apply freely: they are limited by two principles, *Blocking Principle* and *Meaning Preservation*.

The Blocking Principle, (144), states that a type shifter cannot apply to an expression (in our case, a bare NP) in a language if this language has lexicalized a determiner that has the same meaning as the type shifter and is attachable to the expression. As Chierchia (1998) explains, the idea behind the Blocking Principle is very simple: an overt way of expressing a meaning is more preferable than a covert one.

(144) **Blocking Principle** (Chierchia 1998: 360)

For any type shifting operation τ and any X:

* $\tau(X)$

if there is a determiner D such that for any set X in its domain,

$D(X) = \tau(X)$.

This constraint is introduced to account for the cases like in English, where bare plurals can not get a definite meaning, as shown in (145). According to Chierchia (1998), this is so because English has a lexicalized version of *iota*, the definite article *the*, which can combine with plural NPs, so *iota* is unavailable for bare plurals due to the Blocking Principle.

(145) {I saw three dogs on the beach.}

a. # *Dogs played with each other.*

b. ok *he dogs played with each other.*

As follows from (144), only a determiner that is fully synonymous with one of the type shifters can trigger its blocking. This means, in particular, that (in)definite determiners that have a more specific meaning than *a* or *the*[59] are out of its scope and are not expected to block any of the type

[59] Of course, the assumption that *the* and *iota* are semantically identical is a simplification; this becomes especially evident in Dayal (2004) when she argues that *iota* type-shifter, in contrast to *the*, does not require familiarity and has a weaker uniqueness presupposition. This creates an inconsistency issue: if *the*, as Dayal argues, has a more specific meaning than *iota*, then it should not trigger Blocking Principle for English bare singulars, and hence, all things being equal, they are falsely predicted to be felicitous in contexts where *iota*'s requirements are satisfied but the requirements of *the* are not.

shifters. This restriction is especially needed to predict the data in articleless languages, where presence of the other determiners does not block (in)definite readings (Dayal 2004)[60].

The second constraint, Meaning Preservation, ranks the application of type-shifters. The initial motivation to impose any ranking principle was Chierchia (1998)'s observation that bare plurals in English have frozen scope and hence cannot be analyzed as existential quantifiers. This generalization was based on the contrasts like in (146), where the bare plural *stop signs*, in contrast to the classic indefinite *a sign*, can only be interpreted within the scope of negation.

(146) a. *I didn't see a stop sign.*

1.There are no stop signs such that I saw them (narrow scope reading, $\neg > \exists$).

2. There is a stop sign that I did not see (wide scope reading, $\exists > \neg$).

b. *I didn't see stop signs.*

1. There are no stop signs such that I saw them (narrow scope reading, $\neg > \exists$).

2. *There are some stop signs that I didn't see (wide scope reading, $\exists > \neg$).

To account for the frozen scope of bare plurals, Chierchia (1998) argued that bare plurals in English are never mapped onto existential quantifiers and denote kinds instead; he ensured that by proposing the first instantiation of Meaning Preservation, stated as in (147).

[60] This classic assumption has been challenged in the recent paper (Liu et al. 2023), where the authors observe unpredicted difference between the distribution of bare singulars in different articleless languages and argue that it can be accounted for if we allow indefinite determiners that are not (yet) grammaticalized into full-fledged indefinite articles to also trigger Blocking Principle. Their proposal, however, also challenges some other classic assumptions of the classical approach, such as Meaning Preservation, see the paper for more details.

(147) **Meaning Preservation** (original version, Chierchia 1998)

nom > {iota, ex}

For the existential uses of bare plurals, like in (148), Chierchia (1998) argued that they are derived from the kind reading of the bare plural via the interpretation principle called $^{\cup}$ *(DKP),* stated as in (149).

(148) *Dogs are barking outside.*

(149) **Derived Kind Predication (DKP)**

If P applies to objects and k denotes a kind, then

$P(k) = \exists x[{}^{\cup}k(x) \wedge P(x)]$

(Chierchia 1998: 364)

DKP is applied as a repairing interpretative mechanism when a kind-denoting bare NP is combined with a VP seeking an argument that denotes an object-level entity[61]. First, the type-shifter $^{\cup}$, also known as *pred* (e.g. Sağ 2022), maps the kind denoted by the bare NP back onto a corresponding predicate over individuals[62]. Second, the derived predicate forms a predicate modification-style

[61] In his later work, Chierchia (2023) eliminates DKP, leaving kind-denoting bare NPs as they are to compose with object-level predicates. He argues that the existential inference, or rather its illusion, arises due to the fact that the kind can only be partially involved in the described event, see more details in the paper.

[62] Basically, $^{\cup}$ is the reverse version of *nom* (recall that the latter is labeled as $^{\cap}$ in (Chierchia 1998)). It is formally defined as in (i):

(i) Let k be a kind. Then for any world/situation s,

$^{\cup}\mathbf{k} = \lambda x.\ x \leq k_s$ if k_s is defined, $\lambda x.$ FALSE otherwise,

where d_s is the plural individual that comprises all of the atomic members of the kind.

(Chierchia 1998: 350)

conjunction with the VP's predicate, and their variable gets existentially bound. This derives the desired existential readings for cases like in (148), as shown in (150).

(150) bark outside⟧ ($^{\cap}$⟦dogs⟧) = [λx_e. x barks outside] (DOG_k) =

$\exists x[^{\cup}DOG_k(x) \wedge$ x barks outside] = $\exists x[dog(x) \wedge$ x barks outside]

Given that DKP eliminates the semantic input of *nom*, the proposed derivation of the existential readings from kinds looks very forced. Understanding that, Chierchia tries to provide some evidence showing that (non-bare) NPs which are unambiguously kind-denoting can also get existential readings in a way predicted by DKP. He provides examples in (151) to prove his point. In (151a), the NP *that kind of animal* denotes a kind, but (151a) clearly states that not the whole kind, but a concrete individual representing it is ruining the garden. The same is true about (151b): although the picture of a lion in the book, as Chierchia argues, represents the whole kind, it is clear that the hearer did not see the kind itself but rather an instance of it.

(151) a. *That kind of animal is ruining my garden.*

b. [Pointing at the picture of a lion in a biology book]

That is what you saw this morning at the zoo.

(Chierchia 1998: 363)

One might wonder whether, given the provided ranking of the type-shifters and the fact that English has a definite and an indefinite article, there are cases where *ex* applies in this language. According to Chierchia (1998), *ex* applies to bare plurals in cases where *nom* is inapplicable, that is, to bare plurals whose predicate's maximal satisfier does not correspond to a conventional kind.

Chierchia mainly discusses a particular group of such bare plurals, later labelled *indexical NPs* (Dayal 2013b), that contain a phrase headed by a demonstrative with a deictic interpretation. As was first noticed by Carlson (1977), such bare NPs differ from the others in that: i) they cannot be arguments of kind predicates, as shown in (152); ii) they can take wide scope, as demonstrated in (153).

(152) a. ??*Boys sitting here are rare.*

b. ??*Parts of that machine are widespread.*

c. ??*People in the next room come in three sizes.*

(Chierchia 1998: 372)

(153) *John didn't see parts of that machine.*

1. 'John saw no parts of that machine.' $\neg > \exists$
2. 'There are parts of that machine that John did not see. $\exists > \neg$

(adapted from Chierchia 1998: 373)

Chierchia (1998) accounts for the data in (152-153) by arguing that indexical bare plurals do not pass the semantic requirements of *nom* (the maximal satisfier of their predicate does not represent any kind); since *nom* is unapplicable, *ex* is no longer outranked and applies to such bare plurals, turning them into existential quantifiers. This explains their incompatibility with kind predicates, like in (152), and the scope flexibility, as in (153)[63].

[63] The *ex*-based analysis of indexical bare plurals proposed in (Chierchia 1998) is later challenged in (Dayal 2013b). In this paper, Dayal takes a radical view that *ex* is wholly absent in the system of the type-shifters and argues that the data from indexical bare plurals can be analyzed as having the denotation derived by *nom* if we assume that instead of requiring the maximal satisfier of the NP's predicate to represent a certain kind in a given world or situation, *nom*

While making *nom* the top-ranked type-shifter, Chierchia does not propose any ranking between *iota* and *ex*, assuming the null hypothesis that bare NPs in articleless languages can freely appear in definite and indefinite contexts[64]. This is later challenged in Dayal's version of the neo-Carlsonian approach, to which we now turn.

Discussing more data from articleless languages such as Hindi, Chinese and Russian, Dayal (2004) proposes several differences to the original version of the neo-Carlsonian approach. The only one that is crucial for the current discussion is the change in ranking of the type-shifters[65]. Namely, in contrast to Chierchia, Dayal ranks *iota* as equal to *nom* and higher than *iota*, proposing the new version of Meaning Preservation, as in (155).

(154) **Meaning Preservation** (revised version, Dayal 2004: 419)

{*nom*, *iota*} > *ex*

---

merely requires that the predicate has different extensions in at least some situations (parts of possible worlds). For more details, see the discussion in (Dayal 2013b).

[64] In fact, Chierchia does preliminarily argue that bare singulars in Russian can receive both definite and indefinite readings, providing (i) as an illustration of that. He (reasonably, as we now know) notices that in (i), the first bare NP *mal'čik* 'boy' is used in an introductory (or, as he calls it, presentational) context, which is what indefinites do, and the second bare NP *mal'čik* 'boy' is used anaphorically (referring to the same boy that was introduced by the first NP), which is what definites do.

(i)	*V*	*komnate*	*byli*	***mal'čik***	*i*	*devočka.*
	in	room	were	boy	and	girl
	Ja	*obratils'a*	*k*	***mal'čiku***.		
	I	turned	to	boy.		

'In the room, there were a boy and a girl. I turned to the boy.'

(adapted from Chierchia 1998: 361)

However, Chierchia admits that this generalization is preliminary, saying that "the behavior of bare arguments in Russian needs to be carefully scrutinized" (Chierchia 1998: 362).

[65] For cases where a bare NP undergoes pseudo noun incorporation (PNI), Dayal proposes a separate interpretation rule, see (Dayal 2004, 2011) for more details. Since Russian does not have pseudoincorporation, it is irrelevant for us here.

According to Dayal, the proposed difference in ranking is needed to account for the behavior of bare singular NPs in Hindi and in Russian. Namely, she treats examples like in (155), in each of which the two bare singulars can only be interpreted as co-referring, as evidence that bare singulars obligatorily receive the definite interpretation. This conclusion is further argued for by the examples in (155): in (155a), the bare singular *laRki* 'girl' cannot be used to name one of the girls in the room; in (155b), the bare singular *aurotoN* 'woman' cannot be used to introduce a new discourse referent. Indeed, all things being equal, we would expect that bare singulars can be used felicitously in both cases had they been indefinites. Thus, Dayal concludes, the type-shifter that derives indefinite readings, *ex*, should be unavailable for bare singulars in articleless languages, which can be done by ranking it lower than *iota*.

(155) a. HINDI

#*kamre*	*meN*	*bacca*	*khel*	*rahaa thaa*	*aur*	*bacca*	*so*	*(bhii) rahaa*
room	in	child	was	playingand	child	was	sleeping	
thaa								
(also)								

'The same child was playing and sleeping in the room.'

b. RUSSIAN

V	*étoj*	*kletke*	*tigr*	*jest*	*i*	*tigr*	*spit.*
in	this	cage	tiger	eats	and	tiger	sleeps

'In this cage, the tiger is eating and the tiger is sleeping.'

(Dayal 2004: 406)

(156) HINDI

a. *vahaaN kaii log the. *(ek) laRkii *(ek) laRke ke-saath*

there several people were one girl one boy with

naach rahii thii. ek aur laRkii do aurotoN ke-saath

was dancing one more girl two women with

baat kar rahii thi.

was talking

'There were several people there. A girl was dancing with a boy, another girl was talking to two women.'

b. *bahut saal pahle, yehaaN *(ek) aurat rahiti thii.*

many years ago here one woman lived

aurat bahut bhadur thii…

woman very brave was

'Once upon a time, a woman used to live there. The woman was very brave.'

(Dayal 2004: 409)

Dayal also argues that the proposed ranking is supported by the data from bare plurals, which, according to her generalizations and data, receive kind, definite and narrow-scope existential interpretations, but cannot take wide scope as existential quantifiers. To not overwhelm the reader with the large volume of data, I will only provide the examples from Russian in (157), see analogous examples from Hindi and Chinese on the same or adjacent pages of the paper.

The example in (157a) is used to illustrate a kind use of a bare plural. In this case, the bare plural *l'udi* 'people' is used to name the human species in its entirety, as it combines with the kind-level predicate *proizojti* 'evolve'. In (157b), the two bare plurals show the behavior typical for definites:

they are used anaphorically, to refer to the discourse referents introduced in the first sentence of (157b). Finally, in (157c), the bare plural *sobaki* 'dogs', can have a definite or a narrow-scope existential reading, but crucially not a wide-scope existential one. Namely, (157c) can either mean that there were different groups of dogs in different locations or that some known group of dogs visited different locations, but it cannot mean that there was a single *new* group of dogs that visited different locations. Dayal (2004) uses the data in (157a) and (157b) as evidence that *iota* and *nom* should be ranked equally (as opposed to *nom* outranking *iota*, as was proposed in the original Meaning Preservation (Chierchia 1998)[66]), and the data in (157c) to show that *ex* is (still) unavailable for bare plurals (recall that the narrow-scope existential reading is derived from the kind denotation through DKP).

(157) a.

L'udi	*proizošli*	*ot*	*obez'jan.*
people	evolved	from	apes

'People have evolved from apes.'

(adapted from Dayal 2004: 402)

b.

Neskol'ko	*devoček*	*i*	*mal'čikov*	*byli*	*v*	*komnate.*
several	girls	and	boys	were	in	room
Mal'čiki	*igrali v*	*karty.*	***Devočki***	*čitali*	*knigi.*	
Boys	played in	cards	girls	read	books	

'Several boys and girls were in the room. The boys were playing cards, the girls were

[66] To be fair, Chierchia (1998) does not seem to have any particular commitment to this part of his ranking principle: he only considers data from English bare plurals in that regard, and in English, *iota* would not be applicable anyway. My guess would be that he ranks *nom* higher than *ex* simply because otherwise *iota* would, on par with *nom*, outrank *ex*, and he believes that is not the case, as we discussed earlier in this section. Alternatively, he could consider an option where there are actually two independent rankings, *nom* > *ex* and *nom* = *iota*, but in absence of some empirical support, a single ranking principle is more parsimonious.

reading books.'

(adapted from Dayal 2004: 403)

c. ***Sobaki*** *byli* *vezde.*

dogs were everywhere

'There were dogs (different ones/the one we know) everywhere.'

(adapted from Dayal 2004: 406)

The predictions of Dayal's approach to the meaning of bare NPs in articleless languages (with two numbers) like Russian are summarized in the table below.

Sources	**Bare singulars**	**Bare plurals**
***Nom* type-shift**	Unapplicable	Kind reading Narrowest-scope indefinite reading (via DKP)
***Iota* type-shift**	Definite reading	
***Ex* type-shift**	Unavailable due to Meaning Preservation	

Table 1. Predictions of Dayal's approach

As follows from the table, Dayal's theory predicts that bare singulars in articleless languages can only receive a definite reading, and bare plurals can get definite, kind and narrow-scope indefinite readings. This means, in particular, that the use of bare singulars in indefinite contexts is predicted to be infelicitous, and that neither of the two types of bare NPs are allowed to take wider than the narrowest scope (except when they are used as definites, but in this case they, strictly speaking, do not have a scope at all). In the next section, I will show that these predictions are not borne out (at least) in Russian.

Further research on (in)definiteness of bare NPs in articleless languages revealed that the observed restriction on the use of bare NPs in indefinite contexts is typologically common (see Deal & Neé 2018 for Teotitl´ an del Valle Zapotec, Rossyaikin 2023 for Balkar and Kumyk, Golosov 2024 for Northern (Kazym) Khanty, a.o). At the same time, the cross-linguistic studies (as well as further investigation of the already studied languages) detected quite a few empirical challenges for the proposed approach (for case studies on languages other than Russian, see Thakur 2015, Hooda & Moroney 2026 for Hindi[67]; Modaressi 2010, 2024, Mirazzi 2021 for Farsi; Paul 2016 for Malagasy; Šimík & Burianová 2020 for Chech; Srinivas 2021, 2022 for Kannada; Lebruyn & de Swart 2022 for Dutch; Rossyaikin 2023 for Balkar and Kumyk; Navarro 2024b for Kaingang; Berulava & Mayr 2024 for Georgian,Turkish and Mandarin (and Russian, Hindi and Farsi); Golosov 2024, Tiutiunnikova 2025, Tiutiunnikova et al. 2025, Golosov et al. 2026 for Northern (Kazym) Khanty; Tiutiunnikova 2025 for Mansi and Livvi-Karelian; Borik et al. 2025 for Polish and Macedonian (and Russian); Carstens et al. 2026 for Xhosa), with one of the main problems

[67] Before Dayal's theory was proposed, several authors have claimed that bare NPs in Hindi are ambiguous between definites and indefinites (Verma 1966; Gambhir 1981; Mahajan 1990). Dayal (2004) discusses and partially challenges some of their arguments, see the paper for more details.

being that bare NPs can be used in wider range of indefinite contexts than predicated. As we already know, this is also the case for Russian, to the discussion of which we now turn.

1.1.2. Criticism and comparison with my approach

Dayal's version of the neo-Carlsonian approach has received extensive amount of criticism in subsequent research on Russian (Bronnikov 2004; 2007; Borik 2016; Seres & Borik 2018; Šimik & Demian 2020; Borik et al. 2025)[68]. As we discussed in Chapter 2, despite the predictions following from the proposed ranking of the type-shifters, bare NPs in Russian feature the classic properties of generalized existential quantifiers. In particular, bare singulars can be used to talk about individuals non-unique with respect to their predicate (158a) and introduce novel discourse referents (158b), and both bare singulars and bare plurals have variable scope (159)[69].

(158) a. Context. There are many children in the house. One of them is sleeping. The others are playing. I enter the house speaking aloud. You admonish me:

Tiše,	*rebënok*	*spit!*
quiet	child	sleeps

'Quiet, a child is sleeping!'

b.

Dver'	*otkrylas',*	*i*	*v*	*dom*	*vošla*	*devočka.*
door	opened	and	in	house	entered	girl

'The door opened, and a girl entered the house.' (adapted from Geist 2010: 195)

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[68] See also Geist (2010). Although Dayal (2004)'s theory is not directly criticized in this paper, Geist provides data from Russian that are challenging for it.

[69] Recall that the bare NPs taking wide scope in (20) do not have a uniqueness presupposition, as we discussed in Section 3.2.1. of Chapter 2. We will also discuss such data in more detail in Section 3.2.1 of this chapter.

(159) a. Scenario 1. Vasya loves Italy and has a dream of marrying an Italian, but he does not have any specific candidate in mind.

Scenario 2. Vasya does not want to have a stereotypically Italian wife, but he wants to marry Chiara, who is an Italian but does not fit in the stereotypes.

vas'a	*xočet*	*ženit's'a*	*na*	*ital'janke.*
V.	wants	marry	on	Italian

'Vasya wants to marry an Italian.'

b. Scenario 1. Masha loves America and although she does not know any American girls, she dreams of having American girls as friends someday.

Scenario 2. Masha does not have any desires of having friends of a particular nation, but she really wants to make friends with a specific group of American girls.

maša	*xočet*	*podružit's'a*	*s*	*amerikankami.*
M.	wants	befriend	with	Americans

'Masha wants to make friends with (some/whichever) Americans.'

To be fair, Dayal (2004) acknowledges some of these problems and addresses them. First, she admits that bare singulars can be used to talk about novel discourse referents (not only in Russian, but also in Hindi[70]). To account for this fact, Dayal argues that *iota* does not impose a familiarity requirement and only requires that the predicate of the bare NP has a unique/maximal satisfier in

[70] One of the examples from Hindi provided in that regard is (i): the bare NP *cuuhaa* 'mouse' is used to talk about a mouse that was not previously known for the speech act participants.

(i)						
	kamre	*meN*	*cuuhaa*	*ghuum*	*rahaa*	*hai.*
	Room	in	mouse	moving		is

'A (unknown) mouse is moving around in the room.'

(Dayal 2004: 403)

the context. This change, however, is not enough to account for the data from Russian bare singulars. Not only they do not presuppose that the context has a unique satisfier of their predicate, but they can also be used when it is not the case. This is illustrated in (158a), as we discussed in Chapter 2: the context has ten equally accessible individuals satisfying the bare NP's predicate, and yet the use of the bare singular *rebënok* 'child' in (158a) is completely felicitous.

While Dayal herself has not addressed this problem, a solution within her account is proposed in Daria Bikina's recent dissertation (Bikina 2026). Appealing to the well-known and well-motivated generalization that classic definites like English *the* can pragmatically narrow down their domain restriction (e.g. von Fintel 1994; Elbourne 2005, 2013; Schwarz 2009), Bikina argues that Russian bare singulars can do it, too. Thus, according to Bikina (2026), apparent existential uses of bare singulars like in (158a) are in fact cases where the domain restriction of *iota*'s uniqueness requirement is pragmatically narrowed so that it does not include the other satisfiers of the predicate. However, Bikina does not discuss the constraints on how and when pragmatics can narrow down the domain of accessible individuals. Meanwhile, those are crucially required to maintain the predictive power of the theory. In particular, it is not clear what triggers the domain narrowing in cases like in (158a) but does not do it in cases like (158b). In addition to that, Bikina's version of the *iota*-based account of bare NPs, just like its previous versions, does not explain why the uniqueness requirement is not presupposed, and cannot account for the observed scope variability of bare NPs.

The second challenging data point Dayal (2004) recognizes and tries to address is that (non-PNIed) bare singulars, which are predicted to be definites, can take narrow scope. To account for such cases, she argues that "perhaps the uniqueness presupposition does not project because bare singulars in this languages do not impose familiarity" (Dayal 2004: 405). It is not clear, however, why absence of the familiarity requirement would block projection of the uniqueness requirement: the two presuppositions are semantically independent in that regard, as we know from the typology of weak definites (Schwarz 2009 et seq., see the relevant discussion in Chapters 2 and 3). In any case, even if the narrow scope uses of bare singulars had been accounted for, there is another problem for Dayal's account, not discussed in her paper[71]: at least Russian bare NPs can take wide scope while not requiring the uniqueness or maximality of their witness.

Finally, there is one more issue with Dayal's approach, which, in contrast to the previously discussed ones, is a case of overprediction. Namely, while bare plurals are predicted to freely get narrow-scope indefinite readings, they in fact do not. This problem was first spotted in Bronnikov (2004), where Bronnikov critically reviewed the example in (160) from Dayal (2004), used as an illustration of the indefiniteness of bare plurals. As he rightfully argues, the sentence in (160) is in fact infelicitous, just like its analogue in (155b) with bare singulars.

(160) #*V* *étoj* *kletke* ***tigry*** *jed'at* *i* ***tigry*** *sp'at.*

in this cage tigers eat and tigers sleep

Intended: 'In this cage, tigers are sleeping and tigers are eating.'

(Bronnikov 2004: 4, Dayal 2004: 407)

According to Dayal's theory, (160) should be felicitous (and Dayal treats it as such): each of the bare plurals would receive the kind denotation through *nom* and then get the existential reading

[71] To be fair, the presence of wide scope exisntetial readings of Russian bare NPs is a relatively recent finding, as we discussed in Chapter 2. One reason for that is that bare NPs require a very particular QUDs to get a wide scope existential reading, see more in (Golosov submitted).

through DKP; nothing in the theory accounts for the fact that two bare plurals cannot co-occur within the same sentence if they have distinct witnesses.

Thus, Dayal's approach to the meaning of bare NPs does not fully account for the data from Russian, predicting, in general, a more restricted distribution of bare NPs in indefinite contexts than observed (except for the over-generating prediction that two or more identical bare plurals uttered within the same sentence can have different witnesses: this is, as we know, not the case). This problem arises due to the proposed ranking: since *iota* and *nom* outrank *ex*, bare singulars can only get the definite reading, and bare plurals only receive definite, kind and narrow scope existential readings.

At the same time, it should be highlighted that Dayal was right that a simple indefinite analysis of bare NPs in Hindi or Russian cannot account for the infelicity of cases like in (158b), where the two identical bare NPs cannot have different witnesses. What was wrong is treating this as a sign of *semantic definiteness*: at least in Russian, as we saw, a bare NP does not semantically require its witness to be the maximal satisfier of its predicate; it simply cannot be used as a mean to introduce a novel discourse referent in a context that already has discourse referents satisfying the bare NP's predicate, because of an independent, general pragmatic constraint on the reference resolution.

In contrast to Dayal's approach, my analysis, according to which bare NPs are existential quantifiers whose indefinite uses are limited by The Unambiguity Constraint, correctly predicts that a bare NP (bare singular or bare plural) takes variable scope and can be witnessed by a non-maximal satisfier of its predicate, but cannot be used to introduce a new discourse referent in a context that already has a given discourse referent that satisfies the predicate of the NP.

1.2. Bare plurals as weak definites (Berulava & Mayr 2024)

1.2.1. Overview

Berulava and Mayr's recent paper concerns the semantic interpretation of bare plurals in articleless languages. Using novel data from Russian, Georgian, Farsi, Hindi, Turkish and Mandarin, they argue that bare plurals in these languages should be analyzed as weak definites.

The authors start with arguing that the observed ability of bare plurals in articleless languages to occur in typical indefinite and definite contexts, like in (161), does not necessarily mean that bare plurals have a separate existential denotation. Instead, they argue that bare plurals can be analyzed as weak definites (in the Schwarzian sense, that is, definites that require maximality, but not familiarity of their predicate's satisfier) with a contextual domain restriction.

(161) a. **Definite scenario**: Ann has three dogs. She hears all her three dogs barking outside.

b. **Indefinite scenario**: Checking into a hotel, Ann hears barking.

Anna says:

Sobaki *lajut*.

dogs bark

'(The) dogs are barking.' (Berulava & Mayr 2024: 11)

The authors motivate their proposal by the observed limited distribution of bare plurals in the six articleless languages compared to plural NPs with overt indefinite determiners, like *some dogs* in English. Namely, they notice that bare plurals[72], in contrast to *some*-indefinites and in parallel with

[72] In this section, I will henceforth use "bare plurals" to refer to bare plurals in the six studied articleless languages. This restriction is important here because Berulava and Mayr (2024) do not discuss bare plurals in English or other

the-definites in English, cannot be used to name a non-maximal satisfier in a context where their (non-)maximality is an important factor in resolving the QUD[73]. They consider the example in (162), where the burglar explains to his partner why his robbery attempt has failed. In this context, only the sentence in (162a), with the indefinite NP *some of the doors*, can be understood as asserting that there were doors that were open. In contrast, the sentence in (162b) with a bare plural *dveri* 'doors' and the sentence in (162c) with the definite NP *the doors* can only be understood as asserting that *all* of the doors were open. Berulava and Mayr treat this as a piece of evidence that bare plurals do not have an existential reading: otherwise, they argue, (162b) should have the same interpretation as (162a), not (162c).

(162) **QUD: Were all of the doors open?**

Context. A bank robbery is to take place. There are four doors that must be passed to reach the safe. Last night, one door was locked. John asks Bill — the burglar — if he could reach the safe. Bill says:

a. *No, but some of the doors were open.*

b. #*No, but the doors were open.*

c.

#*Net,*	*no*	*dveri*	*byli*	*otkryty.*
no	but	doors	were	open

Intended: 'No, but some doors were open.'

---

languages with articles, and it is moreover likely that they would treat them differently given that such bare plurals have definite counterparts.

[73] Berulava & Mayr (2024) further show that if it does not matter for the QUD resolution whether all members of the relevant plurality participate in the event denoted by the verbal predicate, bare plurals can receive a non-maximal interpretation, similarly to English definites. I will not discuss this generalization further in this section, as it is not relevant for comparison between our proposals: both analyses predict non-maximal uses to be felicitous in such contexts.

(adapted from Berulava & Mayr 2024: 392, 396)

Then, building on the similarity between (162b) and (162c), the authors argue that bare plurals are type-shifted from predicates over individuals into individuals via the covert weak definite operator *THE*, which has the denotation in (163). In prose, *THE* takes the predicate over individuals denoted by the bare plural[74], checks whether it has an atomic or plural individual satisfier X in the contextually available set of individuals *g(C),* and if it is the case, returns the maximal individual X from this set.

(163) $[\![\text{THE}_C]\!]^g = \lambda f_{<e,\,t>}: \exists X \in g(C): f(X) = 1.\ \iota X \in g(C): f(X) = 1.$

(Berulava & Mayr 2024: 399)

Note that Berulava and Mayr do not provide a restriction on how exactly the context restricts the domain of *THE.* While they acknowledge that the domain restriction cannot be completely arbitrary, as it would trivialize the predictions, they do not propose a concrete principle that would govern this process. Discussing some of the examples, they argue that the domain of the bare plurals is limited to the individuals that are salient for the speech act participants; however, they do not claim that this is the only way the domain of a bare plural can be selected.

The proposed changes, as Berulava and Mayr argue, allow them to account for uses of bare plurals in indefinite contexts like in (161a), repeated here as (164). Even though the barking dogs were

[74] It is not entirely clear whether Berulava and Mayr (2024) treat *THE* as a type-shifter that applies only to bare plurals or to all bare nominals. On one hand, the formula in (166) is stated in a way that makes it applicable to predicates over atomic individuals, which means, in turn, that *THE* is compatible with the denotation of bare singulars. On the other hand, the authors do not propose anything about the behavior of bare singulars in the six articleless languages under consideration, which suggests that they at least are not committed to *THE* being the universal type shifter for all bare NPs.

not mentioned in the previous discourse, they are salient for the goal of Ann's utterance, so the presupposition of *THE* is satisfied, and the maximal plurality of the salient barking dogs is selected.

(164) Context. Checking into a hotel, Ann hears barking. Anna says:

Sobaki *lajut*.

dogs bark

'Dogs are barking.'

The proposed analysis also correctly predicts that bare plurals receive obligatory maximal readings in cases like in (161c), in contrast to indefinites like *some doors*. Namely, since the maximality matters for the QUD resolution, and assuming that individuals relevant for the QUD resolution are salient (e.g. Roberts 2010), the set *g(C)* of the bare plural *dveri* 'doors' in (161c) includes all the doors in the context, and so the NP is correctly predicted to refer to the maximal plurality of doors.

As Berulava and Mayr themselves acknowledge, their analysis requires additional assumptions to account for the cases where bare plurals fall within the scope of negation, like in (165)[75]. Without them, examples like (168) are falsely predicted to be infelicitous since the existence presupposition of the bare plural is not satisfied.

(165) GEORGIAN

Context. Checking into a hotel, Ann is relieved to find that there is no barking and says:

[75] Berulava & Mayr (2024) do not provide analogous data on Russian bare plurals, but according to my judgments, the Russian translation of (165), with the bare plural *sobaki* 'dogs', has the same acceptability status as (165): it is slightly odd in the provided context, but still fine, especially if the prior context provides us with a reason why Ann would expect any dogs barking near the hotel.

(i) Context. Checking into a hotel, Ann is relieved to find that there is no barking and says:
Sobaki *ne* *lajut*.
dogs not bark
'Dogs are not barking.'

ok/? *żaġl-eb-i* *ar* *kep'en.*

dog-PL-NOM not bark

'Dogs are not barking.' (Berulava & Mayr 2024: 15)

Berulava and Mayr argue that in cases like in (165), the existential presupposition of the bare plural gets locally accommodated within the scope of negation (Beaver & Krahmer 2001; Fox 2013), which essentially means that it becomes a part of the asserted content. As such, it gets negated, leading to the correct truth conditions of (165). The authors also tie the local accommodation with the non-ideal felicity of (165): assuming the former is a costly operation, (165) is degraded because it requires extra effort to parse.

Thus, to sum up, Berulava and Mayr (2024) propose a (super-)weak definite analysis for bare plurals in articleless languages. This account is motivated by their novel observation that bare plurals pattern with *the*-definites, but not with *some*-indefinites, in contexts where (non-) maximality of its predicate's satisfiers is relevant for the resolution of the QUD the NP contributes to addressing. Presenting this as evidence that bare plurals do not have a true existential reading, the authors use a weak definite operator *THE* with a contextually restricted domain to account for the wider distribution of bare plurals compared to proper definites, including the seemingly existential contexts like in (164) or (165). In the next section, I will compare Berulava and Mayr's analysis with my UC-based approach.

1.2.2. Criticism and comparison with my approach

Before I begin, I want to reiterate that in contrast to the other approaches discussed in this chapter, Berulava and Mayr's (2024) approach concerns only the interpretation of bare plurals and does not make any claims about bare singulars. It is not clear, for example, whether *THE* is meant to be the universal type-shifter or one that applies only to bare plurals, and if it is the latter, it is not clear what type-shifters or other interpretative operations are applied to bare singulars. Thus, in this section I will only compare the predictions of our analyses with respect to the data from Russian bare plurals.

An important similarity between Berulava and Mayr's analysis and mine is that they are both motivated by the apparently conflicting behavior of bare nominals with respect to (in)definiteness. In their case, the goal was to develop an analysis that captures the definite-like maximality requirement associated with bare plurals while also accounting for their indefinite-like ability to occur in contexts where their predicate is satisfied by an individual that is not familiar from the preceding discourse. To reach that goal, they argue that bare plurals are semantically definites (that is, they have the maximality requirement), but their domain is not limited to individuals familiar to the addressee and furthermore can be contextually narrowed.

The problem here, however, is that they do not provide a principled account of how the domain of the weak definite operator *THE* is selected. Namely, while they clearly assume that the domain cannot be arbitrarily restricted to any subset of individuals available in the context that satisfy the nominal's predicate (otherwise the sensitivity to maximality would not be accounted for), they only discuss how the domain is selected in each particular case they considered, without providing a uniform mechanism. This, in turn, makes their approach underspecified in terms of predictions: it is not clear in each particular case which individuals are included in the selected domain.

Assuming that the generalization I made in Chapter 2 is correct (that is, that bare plurals receive maximal anaphoric interpretation whenever a context has a satisfier of their predicate represented as a discourse referent, and are interpreted as introducing a novel discourse referent otherwise), one way to resolve the underspecification issue of Berulava and Mayr's analysis would be to argue that the domain of *THE* is initially restricted to individuals represented in the context as discourse referents, but can get widened to include other contextually salient individuals if there are no discourse referents that represent satisfiers of the nominal predicate.

Another challenged ingredient of Berulava and Mayr's analysis is the proposed existential presupposition of *THE*. First, data on bare plurals suggest that their existence inference does not need to follow from the common ground, that is, the speaker does not expect the addressee to know that there are satisfiers of this nominal's predicate present in the contextually selected domain. This can be illustrated by the felicity of examples like in (166); this sentence is fine even if the speaker's mother is not aware that there are dogs near their house.

(166) Context. Vasya cannot sleep because some dogs are barking outside of his house. His mom, who is out of town, sees that he is online and asks him why he is not sleeping.

Na	*ulice*	*lajut*	*sobaki!*
on	street	bark	dogs

'In the street, there are dogs barking!'

To account for such cases, Berulava and Mayr would have either to assume that cases like in (166) feature global accommodation of the existence presupposition or to argue that the existential inference of *THE* is a type of not-at-issue content that can contribute novel information, for instance, a conventional implicature. In contrast, my analysis, according to which bare plurals are existential quantifiers whose use is limited by a pragmatic constraint, predicts the felicity of (166) without any additional assumptions regarding the status of the existential inference, as a simple baseline case: since the context has no other discourse referents representing dogs, the bare plural *sobaki* is felicitously used as an existential quantifier to introduce a novel discourse referent representing a plurality of dogs; the existence inference is represented as a part of novel information and thus does not face the challenges of Berulava and Mayr's analysis.

Another challenge for the presuppositional status of the existential quantification of *THE* is that it forces Berulava and Mayr to make an additional assumption (postulation of local accommodation) to account for the cases where the existential quantification falls within the scope of negation or an attitude predicate. While this assumption is generally reasonable, it is not required in my account since the existential quantification is a part of the asserted content, and all the restrictions are accounted for pragmatically, via the informational maximality requirement.

Note that the issues discussed above do not undermine the potential(169 empirical coverage of the proposed approach: with the "UC-style" principle of the domain selection for *THE* and the made assumptions about the status of the existential inference, Berulava and Mayr's analysis predicts everything my account does. Before concluding this section, let me show that my account, too, manages to predict the core data point their analysis accounts for — the obligatory maximal interpretation of bare plurals in contexts where the (non-)maximality of their satisfiers matters for the QUD resolution — without any additional assumptions.

Let us look again at (162c), repeated here as (167). Assuming the proposed QUD is indeed the one inferred from John's actual question, the context in which (167) is uttered must either already have or accommodate the discourse referent representing the four doors on the burglar's way to the safe.

If that is the case, then, according to UC, the bare plural *dveri* 'doors' can only be used to pick out this maximal discourse referent, which is exactly what we see in (167)[76].

(167) **QUD: Were all of the doors open?**

Context. A bank robbery is to take place. There are four doors that must be passed to reach the safe. Last night, one door was locked. John asks Bill — the burglar — if he could reach the safe. Bill says:

#*Net,*	*no*	*dveri*	*byli*	*otkryty.*
no	but	doors	were	open

Intended: 'No, but some doors were open.'

(adapted from Berulava & Mayr 2024: 392, 396)

Thus, in this section, I compared my UC-based approach with Berulava and Mayr's analysis, according to which bare plurals in articleless languages are weak definites with a contextually restricted domain.

Berulava and Mayr's analysis is a strong alternative approach, as it also successfully balances out between the definite-like maximality requirement of bare plurals and their ability to appear in contexts typical for indefinites. However, this approach faces some (not directly empirical) issues that my analysis does not. First, Berulava and Mayr do not specify the exact rules of how the domain of *THE* is restricted; this is, however, not a conceptual issue, as the same conditions as stated in the UC can be implemented as rules of the domain selection. Second, to account for the

[76] In fact, the obligatory maximality of the bare plural *dveri* 'doors' in this exact sentence, (167), can be explained even without the Unambiguity Constraint, within the standard assumptions on the information structure parsing: in (167), the bare NP is parsed as a topic, and topics are required to take the maximal referent satisfying their descriptive content anyway.

cases where the existential inference does not behave as a classic presupposition, Berulava and Mayr must use additional semantic operations (e.g. local accommodation); in my account, this is not necessary, as the existence inference is a part of what is asserted.

At the same time, my account manages to account for the main data point that motivated Berulava and Mayr to propose their analysis, without any additional assumptions. Namely, the obligatory maximal interpretation of bare plurals in contexts where the (non-)maximality of their satisfiers matters for the QUD resolution follows from the UC: such QUDs require that there are satisfiers of the bare plural given in the context, and because of that, the UC requires the bare plural to pick out the discourse referent representing the maximal familiar satisfier.

2. "Loose pragmatics" approaches

2.1. Unrestricted indefinites (Seres & Borik 2018)

2.1.1. Overview

Daria Seres and Olga Borik (2018) critically assess the idea that bare NPs in Russian have a definite interpretation. They defend Heim (2011)'s null hypothesis, according to which Russian bare NPs are indefinites which, in absence of the definite counterpart, can also occur in the contexts where their witness happens to be unique or correspond to a familiar discourse referent. They consider different cases where bare NPs are arguably perceived as definites and argue that this effect has nothing to do with their semantics and can be explained by independent, very general pragmatic principles.

Seres and Borik distinguish three cases where bare NPs in Russian pattern with definites in articleless languages. The first case is what they call *ontological uniqueness*: the uniqueness of the bare NP's witness follows from the fact that the predicate of the NP, either purely logically or due to the world knowledge, has only one satisfier in the world. Following their reasoning, I discussed such cases in Chapter 2 (Section 2.2.2), recall the relevant examples from there in (168). As Borik and Seres argue, the uniqueness of the objects like the sun or the satellites of Mars follows from the world knowledge, so the sentences in (168) do not by any means evidence that bare NPs in Russian have a definite interpretation in the lexical sense[77].

(168) a. ***Solnce*** *svetit.*

sun shines

'The sun is shining.' (Seres & Borik 2018: xvii)

b. ***Sputniki*** ***Marsa*** *očen'* *malen'kie.*

satellites Mars very small

'The (natural) satellites of Mars are very small.'

The second case discussed by Seres and Borik is the *topical* uses of bare NPs. As the authors argue, when a bare NP is parsed as a topic (that is, as we discussed in Chapter 2, when it appears clause-initially and is deaccented), it normally receives a definite-like interpretation, that is, it is understood as picking out a unique familiar discourse referent satisfying the NP's predicate. Seres and Borik illustrate this with several examples. Consider, for instance, (169). The most natural interpretation of this sentence is that there was a single doctor who came to the contextually salient location.

[77] It seems like at least a part of Seres & Borik (2018)'s motivation to discuss the cases of ontological uniqueness was to dispute with Dayal (2017a), who, as they say, argued that cases like in (168) are counterexamples to Heim (2011)'s theory. However, I did not find any claims of that sort in Dayal's materials; in contrast, Dayal (2017a; see also 2017b) actually agrees that cases like in (168) are compatible with Heim's approach, as follows from the discussion in (Dayal 2017a: 60) and (Dayal 2017b: 86-87). It could be that Dayal changed the materials later, and this claim was in her original slides, but I am not aware whether that is the case or not.

(169) *Vrač prišël tol'ko k večeru.*

doctor came only to evening

'The doctor came only towards the evening.' (Seres & Borik 2018: xii)

The authors further argue that even topical bare NPs in Russian differ from classic definites in the status of their uniqueness implication: while the latter have it as a presuppositional requirement, the former merely feature it as an implicature. Consider, for instance, the example in (170), where the clause from (169) is followed by a continuation that entails that the first mentioned doctor was not unique.

(170) *Vrač prišël tol'ko k večeru. Drugoj vrač prosto pozvonil.*

doctor came only to evening another doctor just called

'A doctor came only towards the evening. Another doctor just called.'

(Seres & Borik 2018: xii)

Following the literature on the interpretation of topics, Seres and Borik conclude that the definite-like interpretation of topic NPs arising in some contexts is just a side effect of the aboutness constraint: the topic provides the entity to which the utterance is dedicated, and this entity should be, at least in some cases, identifiable to the addressee to be discussed properly.

The final, third case Seres and Borik discuss is the anaphoric uses of bare NPs, like in (171), where the bare NP *životnyje* picks out the same discourse referent as the one introduced by the NP *semja tigrov* 'family of tigers'.

(171) *Včera v zooparke videla <u>semju tigrov</u>.*

yesterday in zoo saw family tigers.GEN

Životnyje	*spokojno*	*spali*	*v*	*uglu*	*kletki*	*posle*	*obeda.*
animals	calmly	slept	in	corner	cage.GEN	after	lunch

'Yesterday at the zoo, I saw a family of tigers. The animals were calmly sleeping in the corner of the cage after lunch.'

(Seres & Borik 2018: 355)

The authors argue that such cases also do not count as evidence that bare NPs have a definite reading: the fact that the bare NP is understood as anaphoric, as they argue, is simply a side effect of the highest saliency of the mentioned family of tigers compared to all other possible witnesses.

Thus, the conclusion Seres and Borik make is that in all cases where a bare NP in Russian shows definite-like behavior, this is an illusion arising either due to the world knowledge or as a side effect of the discourse coherency, and thus there is no need to postulate a definiteness-oriented restriction on the use of Russian bare NPs. Instead, they propose a Heim-style semantic analysis of bare NPs as unrestricted indefinites. However, they depart from Heim in arguing that in addition to the classic existential quantifier denotation, like in (172a), bare NPs in Russian also receive a choice function interpretation, like in (172b).

(172) a. $\exists x.P(x) \wedge Q(x)$

b. $f_{CH}\{x : P(x)\}$

(Seres & Borik 2018: xvi)

The addition of (172b) is likely motivated by the related studies on the semantics of *a*-indefinites in English, where the choice function analysis has been proposed as one of the ways to account for the cases where indefinites are interpreted as if they scoped out of islands (Reinhart 1997; Winter 1997; Kratzer 1998). Consider, for instance, the classic example from (Fodor & Sag 1982), provided here in (173). This sentence is true under a scenario where the speaker has multiple friends from Texas who could've died in a fire, but only one of them bequeathed a large fortune to him. The presence of such a reading is challenging for the classic existential quantifier analysis of indefinites: the *if*-conditional is an island, and quantifiers typically obey island constraints; in this case, however, the predicted reading, where the existential is interpreted within the scope of the conditional, is false. Namely, it is not true that the speaker would receive the fortune had *any* of his friends from Texas died: the other ones did not have such a fortune. Instead, under this scenario, the condition in (173) is understood as tied to a particular friend of the speaker; in that sense, the existence of this friend "scopes out" of the *if*-clause.

(173) *If a friend of mine from Texas had died in the fire, I would have inherited a fortune.*

1. 'If any friend of mine from Texas had died in the fire, I would have inherited a fortune.' *if* > ∃
2. 'There is a specific friend of mine from Texas such that if he had died in the fire, I would have inherited the fortune.' ∃ > *if*

(adapted from Fodor & Sag 1982: 369)

To account for this use of indefinites, where they behave as if they scope out of islands, researchers proposed different ways of deriving this semantic effect without actual scoping out. I will discuss different approaches in more detail in the next chapter, but one of them is the choice function analysis (Reinhart 1997; Winter 1997; Kratzer 1998)[78]. According to this approach, exceptional scope indefinites are interpreted as individuals selected by a choice function *f* that maps the NP's

[78] Winter (1997) proposes that the choice function semantics for *a*-indefinites is the only one required; in contrast, Reinhart (1997) and Kratzer (1998) argue that it co-exists with the classic existential quantifier semantics, which is applied in cases where indefinites do not "take exceptional scope". Seres and Borik (2018) adapt the latter view, but only for the sake of concreteness, acknowledging that Winter's analysis might also be right.

predicate to a specific individual, like in (172b); the choice function itself is a variable that is, depending on a particular analysis, either provided by the context or gets existentially closed outside of the island; in both cases, it derives the desired effect — narrowing down the domain of considered Texan friends to a particular individual — without any need to propose a movement of the NP outside of the island.

Seres and Borik (2018) seem[79] to interpret the discussion of the exceptional scope behavior of *a*-indefinites as an empirical reason to update Heim (2011)'s null hypothesis so that it does not exclude the potential exceptional scope uses. Namely, they basically argue that until proven otherwise, we should expect that bare NPs in Russian can do anything indefinites can do, and the *most* they can do is to have the distribution of *a*-NPs, which can take the most variable scope compared to other indefinites; hence, the null hypothesis should be that bare NPs in Russian can take the two denotations in (175), and then the next step would be to test whether this analysis overpredicts or not.

Thus, to conclude, Seres and Borik (2018) argue that bare NPs in Russian are semantically variable-scope indefinites that are, in absence of the stronger competitor, not "allergic" to the contexts typical for definites, that is, where their witness happens to be a unique satisfier of their predicate and/or be identified with another witness previously mentioned and/or salient in the

[79] The interpretation of their semantic account I provide in this paragraph is the one consistent with the motivation for the choice function analysis for *a*-indefinites discussed above, but it is not the only one possible. Alternatively, it might be the case that Borik and Seres propose the additional choice function parse for bare NPs to account for the uses where they are used referentially. This seems to follow from their claim that "[q]uantificational indefinites are considered to be non-referential, whereas a choice function analysis could account for those cases where an indefinite refers to a (specific) individual" (Seres & Borik 2018: xvi). Regardless of whether this is the right interpretation or not, the assumption that quantificational indefinites (if we use this term to mean "indefinites that have the semantics in (172a)") cannot be used to refer to an individual is wrong. Namely, the fact that indefinites can be used in contexts where the understood witness happens to match with a specific individual in the context does not mean that this matching should be encoded in the formula. The formula in (172) is compatible with referential uses of bare NPs, which is more than enough in this case.

context. They acknowledge that sometimes bare NPs can be understood as definites, but argue that it is always a side effect of (in the very general sense) pragmatic factors, such as being used in a topic position, in a situation where the only contextually available satisfier is the one already mentioned before (anaphoric uses), and in cases where there is just one satisfier in the whole world (ontological uniqueness uses).

2.1.2. Criticism and comparison with my approach

In contrast to the definiteness-based accounts discussed in the previous chapters, Seres & Borik's analysis has the problem of overprediction.

First, it predicts that bare NPs should be able to get "exceptional scope" readings. As we discussed in Chapter 2 (Section 3.2.2), this is not the case: in contrast to *a*-indefinites, bare NPs cannot be interpreted "outside" of islands, recall, for instance, (174a). The existence of an Italian that Vasya might be marrying is a part of the rumor; this is further shown by the infelicity of a continuation as in (174b), where it is assumed that the Italian exists in the actual world.

(174) a. *Do men'a došël slux, čto vas'a ženit'sa na ital'janke.*
to me reached rumor that V. marries on Italian
1. 'I heard a rumor: "Vasya is marrying an Italian".'
2. 'There is an Italian such that I heard a rumor that Vasya is marrying them.'

b. *Do men'a došël slux, čto vas'a ženit'sana #(odnoj) ital'janke.*
to me reached rumor that V. marrieson SP.IND Italian
Posprašivav, ja uznal, čto éto nepravda:
having_asked I learned that this false

éta italjanka sostoit v sčastlivom brake s drugim mužčinoj

this Italian forms in happy marriage with anotherman

'I heard a rumor that Vasya married an Italian. After asking (some people), I learned that this Italian is happily married to another man.'

This false prediction follows from the choice-function parse of bare NPs, proposed by Borik and Seres either to account for their referential uses (under the false assumption that the existential quantifier analysis would not account for them) or as a part of a null hypothesis that bare NPs can do anything *a*-indefinites can. In any case, the fact that bare NPs cannot take exceptional scope suggests that the choice function analysis is not just unnecessary but makes wrong predictions. In contrast, an analysis in which bare NPs only have the semantics of existential quantifiers correctly predicts that their scope variability is restricted by the island constraints and is still compatible, as I discussed earlier, with their referential uses.

Second, Seres and Borik's analysis does not account for the infelicity of bare NPs in cases where discourse referents they pick out are not informationally unique or maximal. While they discuss cases where pragmatic factors can force the definite-like interpretation of bare NPs, they do not propose any actual restrictions on bare NP's use, assuming that even in the contexts where the definiteness arises as a sort of implicature, it can be cancelled by the following utterances. This contrasts sharply with cases like in (175), where the use of the second bare NP *sobaka* 'dog' is infelicitous even though it is clear from the context and the information structure of the sentence (postverbal subjects typically introduce novel discourse referents) that the two dogs are meant to be different.

(175) #*Na ulice lajet sobaka i ryčit sobaka*

on street barks dog and growls dog

Intended: ‘In the street, a dog is barking and a dog is growling.’

In my theory, the cases like in (175) are explained by a principled pragmatic rule of reference resolution, The Unambiguity Constraint, which requires that a bare NP can only either pick out a maximal given discourse referent meeting its descriptive content or, if there are no discourse referents that satisfy its predicate, introduce a novel one. In this case, the second bare NP violates this principle: it is used to introduce a new discourse referent mapping onto a dog individual in a context that has a discourse referent that maps to another dog individual.

Thus, while Seres & Borik (2018)’s analysis of bare NPs as unrestricted variable-scope indefinites allows them to avoid the issues of undergeneration of the indefinite uses that the definiteness-based accounts discussed in the previous sections (Dayal 2004; Bikina 2026; Berulava & Mayr 2024) have, it faces the opposite problem, overgeneration. First, with the presence of the choice-function parse for bare NPs, their analysis predicts that those can take exceptional scope, which is not the case. Second, their analysis cannot account for the fact that two identical bare NPs interpreted within the same local context cannot have different witnesses. In contrast, my analysis has neither of the problems. Namely, the inability of bare NPs to escape islands follows from their uniform semantics of existential quantifiers, and the inability of two identical bare NPs to have different witnesses (if they are interpreted within the same local context) is accounted for by The Unambiguity Constraint.

The main conclusion of this sub-section is thus that simply analyzing bare NPs as unrestricted variable-scope indefinites is not enough: a principled constraint on the indefinite uses is needed to avoid the problem of overgeneration.

2.2. The *Meaning-Preservation!*-based proposal (Srinivas 2021)

2.2.1. Overview

In her dissertation (Srinivas 2021)[80], Sadhwi Srinivas concerns the semantics of bare NPs in another articleless language, Kannada. Formulating her analysis mainly within the framework of the neo-Carlsonian approach (Chierchia 1998; Dayal 2004), Srinivas proposes substantial changes, motivated by her novel data from Kannada which do not fit within the classic picture.

Srinivas notices that bare NPs in Kannada, bare singulars in particular, feature indefinite uses in cases where it is not predicted by the classic neo-Carlsonian approach. According to Dayal (2004), bare singulars receive existential-like interpretation only when they undergo pseudo-incorporation, if a language has such an option. While Kannada does feature pseudo-incorporation of direct objects, bare singulars in this language have clear existential uses outside of such cases. Consider, for instance, an example below. According to Srinivas, (176) can be uttered out-of-the-blue, and the bare NP *ili* 'mouse' is used to introduce a novel discourse referent. Had it been semantically definite, it would be infelicitous in this context since no discourse referents mapping onto a mouse were introduced in the previous discourse[81].

(176) *Room-alli* *ili* *ooDaaaDta* *ide*.

room-LOC mouse roaming COP(PRES)

'There is a mouse roaming in the room.' (Srinivas 2021: 110)

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[80] See also Srinivas's later papers based on her dissertational research (Srinivas 2022, 2025; Srinivas & Rawlins 2021; 2022a, 2022b).

[81] Srinivas (2021) does not discuss this, but I assume that (176) does not have a presupposition that there is just one mouse in the kitchen, so it cannot be analyzed as a (Schwarzian) weak definite either.

Another signal of the indefinite nature of bare singulars in Kannada is that they can get narrow-scope existential readings when they occur within the scope of high semantic operators like negation or a modal verb — and moreover, according to Srinivas, this is the only available interpretation for bare singulars in such cases. Consider (177), for instance. In (177a), the bare NP *huli* 'tiger' is obligatorily interpreted within the scope of the modal *bayasutteene* 'I wish', so (177a) can only be understood as a wish about tigers in general, not as a wish about a particular tiger. Analogously, in (177b), the bare NP *ili* 'mouse' must be interpreted within the scope of negation, so (177b) in fact entails that there is no roaming mouse in the house and cannot be used if there is a particular mouse that is not roaming[82]. This violates the predictions of the neo-Carlsonian approach (Dayal 2004), according to which (177a) should mean that there is a unique given tiger the speaker wishes to see at the zoo, and (177b) should mean that there is a unique given mouse that is not roaming around in the room, contra to the facts.

(177) a. *Zoo-alli* *huli* *nooDalu* *bayasutteene*

zoo-LOC tiger to.see wish.1SG

'At the zoo, I wish to see a(ny) tiger.' (Srinivas 2021: 111)

b. *Room-ali* *ili* *ooDaaDta* *illa.*

room-in mouse roaming NEG

'There isn't any mouse roaming around in the room.' (Srinivas 2021: 143)

[82] It is not clear whether (177b) cannot be used in all cases where there is a mouse in the house or only in those where there is a mouse in the house *that is roaming*. In other words, it is not clear whether the bare NP *ili* 'mouse' cannot receive either definite or wide scope existential readings, or just the latter one. Judging from the general discussion in the paper, it is more likely that neither of the readings is possible.

To account for the observed indefinite uses of bare NPs and their obligatory narrow scope, Srinivas (2021) proposes that in addition to *nom* and *iota*, and (presumably[83]) instead of *ex*, bare NPs in Kannada can get existential readings through the combination of the two semantic operations: Predicate Restriction[84] and existential closure.

Predicate Restriction (Chung & Ladusaw 2003; Rawlins 2013) is a compositional repair operation applied when a predicate A that seeks an argument *x* of the individual type receives a predicate over individuals B instead. To avoid the type mismatch, PR interprets B as another predicate over *x* in the formula, leaving the argument unsaturated. This is formally defined as in (178):

(178) **Predicate Restriction** (Chung & Ladusaw 2003; Rawlins 2013: 351)

Where $\beta = <\beta_{1,} <...<\beta_{n}, t>>>$, such that $n \geq 0$,

$$\text{Restrict}(A_{<e,\beta>}, B_{<e,t>}) = \lambda x \in D_e .\lambda y^1 \in D_{\beta 1} . ... . \lambda y^n \in D_{\beta n} . A(x)(y^1)...(y^n) \wedge B(x)$$

Let me show how it works on a concrete example. For the sake of argument, let us assume a toy version of English where bare singulars combine with verbs via Predicate Restriction; let us also ignore event arguments of verbs and treat them simply as predicates over individuals. In such a system, the VP *dog barks* would be interpreted as in (179). The predicate of the verb *bark* would seek an argument of the individual type, but the content of the bare NP *dog* is instead a predicate over individuals. To avoid the type mismatch, Predicate Restriction is launched: it takes the

83 Srinivas (2021) never discusses *ex* in the paper. It is clear that *ex* is not a type-shifter she would allow to be applicable to bare NPs in Kannada: it would derive wide scope existential readings, which are, according to Srinivas, not available for them. In that sense, one can assume that she admits that *ex* is either outranked by *iota* in articleless languages (as in Dayal 2004) or even wholly absent from the arsenal of type-shifters (as in Dayal 2013b). Whichever of the assumptions is in fact made, it does not affect the predictions of Srinivas's theory.

84 Rawlins (2013) and Srinivas (2021) call it *Restrict* for short, but I use a more classic term here.

predicates of the verb and the bare NP and returns the new predicate over individuals which consists of two conjuncts: the predicates *dog'*(x) and *bark'*(x).

(179) ⟦bark⟧(⟦dog⟧) = λx. bark(x) [λy. dog(y)] = λx. bark(x) & dog(x) (via PR)

Let us now go back to Srinivas's analysis. After the bare NP composes with the verb via Predicate Restriction, a conjoined predicate over individuals is formed, and its argument is not saturated. Here is where the existential closure kicks in. Srinivas assumes that the argument gets existentially bound at the vP level: this accounts for the fact that bare NPs receive narrow scope with respect to negation and modals, which are located higher in the tree. At the same time, putting the existential closure at the vP-level leads to a prediction that bare NPs are interpreted outside of the scope of low-VP operators, for instance, durational adverbials[85]. This prediction is borne out, as shown in (180). In this sentence, the bare NP *batte* 'cloth' (marked with the accusative case) can only be interpreted outside of the scope of the durational adverbial *ondu tingaLa tanaka* 'for a month'. As predicted, this sentence can only mean that the speaker and the other meant person/people kept stitching the same dress or cloth for a month: it cannot be used to report that they kept stitching different dresses or clothes throughout the month.

(180)	*Naavu*	*ondu*	*tingaLa*	*tanaka*	*baTTe-anna*	*holitidvi.*
	we	one	month	till	cloth-ACC	stitched

'We stitched a cloth/dress for a month.'

(Srinivas 2021: 178)

[85] Srinivas (2021) follows Kratzer (2008) and Champollion (2016) in analyzing durational adverbials like *for*-adverbials as predicates (over events and predicates over events) like in (i), but not as (universal) quantifiers, which means that they are not scope-taking expressions, or, descriptively speaking, their "scope" is fixed.

(i) $[\![\text{for X}]\!]^{c,g} = \lambda P.\ \lambda E.\ P(E)\ \&\ \text{span}(E) = X$ (Srinivas 2021: 177)

Note that the addition of Predicate Restriction and existential closure to the system allows Srinivas's account to derive narrow scope existential readings for bare NPs without using DKP. This raises a question of whether this semantic operation, inherited from the classic neo-Carlsonian approach, is still needed in the new account. Srinivas discusses some cases for which DKP seemingly cannot be replaced by Predicate Restriction but argues that with certain assumptions[86] those could still be accounted for without DKP and eliminates this operation from her system. With DKP eliminated, the role of *nom* in Srinivas's account is limited to deriving the actual kind readings of bare plurals (in kind predicates and generic statements).

What is the ranking relation between Predicate Restriction and the classic neo-Carlsonian type-shifters, *iota* and *nom*? Srinivas argues that *iota* and *nom* are ranked higher than Predicate Restriction; however, in contrast to Dayal (2004), she assumes that the competition between the different means to interpret bare NPs is contextual[87]. Namely, Srinivas argues that *iota* and *nom* are ranked higher due to *Maximize Presupposition!* (Heim 1991): each of them has a stronger presupposition than Predicate Restriction (which has none[88]), so whenever it is satisfied, the

[86] The cases she discusses are instances where bare plurals seemingly take narrow scope with respect to durational adverbials. The analysis without DKP would predict that such readings are unavailable since existential closure is applied higher in the tree. To avoid this problem, Srinivas (2021) adopts Champollion (2010, 2016)'s approach, according to which bare plurals taking narrow scope with respect to *for*-adverbials is an illusion, arising as a side effect of cumulative relation between the event and the plural individual (recall the discussion in Section 3.2.3, Chapter 2, where I adapt Champollion (2010, 2016)'s analysis for an analogous reason).

[87] Recall that for Dayal (2004), *iota*'s availability does not depend on the context of the utterance: it applies even if its uniqueness/maximality presupposition is not satisfied, leading to infelicity of the bare NP's use. The only case where *iota* is blocked is when the language has a definite determiner; this means that *ex* can never apply to bare NPs in articleless languages and that, in particular, (non-PNIed) bare singulars in such languages will never receive existential readings.
In contrast, in Srinivas (2021)'s analysis, *iota* applies only if its presupposition is satisfied and allows Predicate Restriction to launch instead if it isn't. Her account thus allows for existential readings of (non-PNIed) bare singulars in articleless languages, in contrast to Dayal's theory.

[88] Note that Predicate Restriction is not a type-shifter as *nom* or *iota*, so, strictly speaking, it cannot compete with them via *Maximize Presupposition*. However, this does not diminish Srinivas's proposal, which still makes sense: use a more informative interpretative tool if you can.

corresponding type-shifter is applied as more informative; Predicate Restriction is thus a last-resort operation which applies when neither *iota*'s nor *nom*'s presuppositions are satisfied.

Srinivas (2021) further elaborates on how exactly the context provides the domain within which *iota* and Predicate Restriction compete[89]. Adopting the situation semantics approach for the domain restriction (Wolter 2006, Schwarz 2009) and following the psycholinguistic insights from Heller et al. (2016), Mozuraitis et al. (2018) that speakers consider different referential domains simultaneously, Srinivas proposes a probabilistic model of the domain selection, according to which different salient domains may have different probability of being chosen, depending on what QUD the sentence under consideration likely addresses[90]. Once the domain is chosen, the choice between *iota* and Predicate Restriction is defined by whether this domain has the unique/maximal satisfier of the bare NP's predicate or not; if it does, then *iota* or *nom* (if applicable) is applied, if it does not — then the bare NP is interpreted via Predicate Restriction. Srinivas highlights that the factor of (non-)maximality of an individual within a certain domain does not affect its likelihood of being chosen — the only thing that does affect it is the suitability of the QUD this domain addresses.

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[89] Srinivas (2021) also discusses the role of *nom* in this competition, but I will ignore it for the sake of simplicity, since kind readings of bare NPs are not within the main scope of this dissertation.

[90] Srinivas (2021) does not directly mention QUD when she discusses her probabilistic model. However, that follows from her definition of topic situations that she gives earlier in the paper. Namely, as we discussed in Chapter 3, topic situation is defined as a situation exemplifying the QUD's extension in the actual world (Schwarz 2009; Srinivas 2021). Hence, since Srinivas proposes that her model concerns the probability of a particular situation to be a topic situation, it is implied that the model is sensitive to which QUD is more probable. This implication is made explicit in Srinivas 2022.

To illustrate the predictions of her model, Srinivas (2021) compares the two short narratives in (181), where the sharp contrast between the most natural QUDs for the second sentences leads to different interpretation of the bare NPs[91].

(181) a. *Ivattu naanu adigemane-alli ondu ili nooDide.*

today I kitchen-in one mouse saw

Naanu nooDidda takshana ili sakkare Dabbi oLage

having.seen immediately mouse sugar container inside

horatu.hooyitu.

went.PFV

'Today, I saw a mouse in the kitchen. Immediately, the mouse went into the sugar container.'

(Srinivas 2021: 257)

b. *Ivattu naanu adigemane-alli ondu ili nooDide.*

today I kitchen-in one mouse saw

Nenne-noo baccalamane-alli ili ooDaaDtaa ittu.

yesterday.too bathroom-in mouse roaming was

'Today, I saw a mouse in the kitchen. Yesterday too, in the bathroom, a mouse was roaming around.'

[91] Note that examples analogous to (184) but with a bare plural instead of a bare singular would be more illustrative here. Namely, the problem with bare singulars is that in a given topic situation, their predicate can not have a maximal and a non-maximal satisfier at the same time, so the effect of *iota* supremacy is not evident. In contrast, the predicate of a bare plural can easily have a maximal and a non-maximal satisfier within the same given situation (in fact, it is always so if the number of satisfiers is larger than two); thus, for bare plurals, the prediction is that they receive the definite reading when the topic situation has the maximal satisfier of their predicate familiar from the previous discourse and receive the narrow-scope indefinite reading otherwise (I am ignoring kind readings here for simplicity). In contrast to the data from bare singulars, this prediction relies on *iota* outranking Predicate Restriction.

(Srinivas 2021: 260)

In (181a), the second sentence is most naturally interpreted as a continuation of the mouse incident, with the mouse being the center of attention, hence the most likely accommodated QUD is ‘What about the mouse?’. Given that the topic situation from this QUD contains a unique and familiar mouse, the bare NP *ili* ‘mouse’ is predicted to receive the definite interpretation via *iota* type-shifter. This prediction is borne out: the bare NP in question is indeed most naturally understood as referring to the same mouse that the speaker saw in the kitchen today, not as introducing a new mouse into the story.

In (181b), the second sentence starts with the frame adverbial complex *nenne baccalamane-alli* ‘yesterday in the bathroom’, which signals the shift of the perspective to another day. Because of that, regardless of which exact QUD the second sentence addresses, its topic situation does not include the things that happened other time than yesterday and outside of the bathroom. In particular, the topic situation does not include the mouse individual that the speaker saw in the kitchen. Since there is no unique given mouse in the topic situation, *iota*’s presupposition is not satisfied, and the bare NP *ili* ‘mouse’ is predicted to be interpreted via Predicate Restriction and existential closure, getting witnessed by some new mouse. This prediction is borne out: the roaming mouse is most likely understood as a new one, different from the mouse in the kitchen.

Thus, to sum up, Srinivas (2021) proposes a new version of the neo-Carlsonian approach to account for the distribution of existential uses of bare NPs in Kannada, which is wider than predicted by the classic theory (Dayal 2004). To resolve the problem of underprediction that the classic neo-Carlsonian approach faces, Srinivas argues that in addition to the kind and definite denotations derived via *nom* and *iota*, bare NPs can also receive narrow scope existential readings via Predicate Restriction followed by the existential closure at the vP-level. Following Dayal's spirit, Srinivas ranks *iota* and *nom* higher than Predicate Restriction, but in contrast to Dayal's Meaning Preservation (Dayal 2004), this ranking is sensitive to the context, that is, *iota* and *nom* are applied not freely, but only if their presuppositions are satisfied in the provided domain, and if they are not, then Predicate Restriction is applied.

2.1.3. Criticism and comparison with my approach

Srinivas (2021) explicitly states that her claims are restricted to bare NPs in Kannada, thus leaving open the possibility that other articleless languages behave differently. In this section, I will show that indeed, Srinivas's approach has some problems with accounting for the data from Russian bare NPs.

First, in absence of a type-shifter like *ex* that would turn bare NPs into existential quantifiers, the proposed analysis incorrectly predicts that bare NPs in Russian cannot get wide scope existential readings, that is, putting definite uses aside[92], they cannot scope over high semantic operators like modal verbs or universal quantifiers. As we discussed in Chapter 2, bare singulars and bare plurals have wide scope existential uses (on par with narrow-scope existential ones). Recall, for instance, the examples with the verb *xotet'* 'want', repeated here in (182). In (182a), the bare NP *italj'anka* clearly receives the wide scope existential reading, as it is not the case that Vasya simply wants his future wife to be an Italian (this would be the narrow-scope existential reading) and it is not the

[92] Recall that of course, strictly speaking, definite NPs, if analyzed as expressions of individual type (like in Srinivas (2021)), do not have scope. However, it is a common practice to use the term "scope" more loosely, in a descriptive sense, meaning that the target inference of a constituent (in this case, the existence of an individual satisfying the bare NP's predicate) projects through the operator in question. For instance, if someone says that a definite NP scopes over negation, what they likely mean is that its existence inference projects through negation.

case that the girl he wants to marry is the unique Italian in the context (this would be the (potential) definite reading). The sentence in (182b) leads to the analogous conclusion about bare plurals.

(182) a. *vas'a xočet ženit's'a na ital'janke,*

V. wants marry on Italian

no ne na frančeske, a na kjare.

but not on F. but on Ch.

'Vasya wants to marry a (specific) Italian, but it's not Franceska, it's Chiara.'

b. *maša xočet podružit's'a s amerikankami,*

M. wants befriend with Americans

no ne so svoimi odnoklassnicami, a s devočkami

but not with self classmates but with girls

s kružka.

from club

'Masha wants to make friends with (some) Americans from the club.'

Second, Srinivas's analysis incorrectly predicts that two identical bare singulars can have different witnesses as long as the topic situation provided by the QUD does not have a given maximal satisfier of the bare NP's predicate. Consider, once again, the sentence in (183). As we discussed at the end of Chapter 3, this sentence is only felicitous if it addresses a QUD like 'What kind of animal is barking and what kind of animal is growling?', which, in Srinivas's terms, provides separate topic situations for the bare NPs. It cannot address a QUD like 'What is going on?' or any other one in which the two dog individuals would be a part of the same (immediate) topic situation. This contradicts the predictions of Srinivas's account, according to which (183) should be fine as an answer to this QUD. Namely, since the topic situation has two dogs, the two bare NPs cannot be shifted via *iota* and are interpreted via Predicate Restriction and existential closure instead; it is then not clear why the two existentials cannot have different witnesses[93].

(183) *QUD-1: 'What is going on in the street?'

okQUD-2: 'What kind of animal is barking and what kind of animal is growling?'

Lajet	*sobaka*	*i*	*ryčit*	*sobaka*
barks	dog	and	growls	dog

'A *dog* is barking and a *dog* is growling.'

Note that conceptually, the contextual nature of the ranking between *iota* and Predicate Restriction is very close to The Unambiguity Constraint, or is at least a step closer to it compared to Meaning Preservation from which it departs. Indeed, both constraints require that if the contextually provided domain has the maximal satisfier of the bare NP familiar from the previous discourse, then the bare NP can only get witnessed by this individual. However, there is a difference in what happens if there are novel individuals in the contextually provided domain. Srinivas's account, in which *iota* applies only if *all* the individuals are given, predicts that a bare NP should receive a (narrow-scope) existential reading. In contrast, my account predicts that in such cases, the bare NP is still required to get witnessed by the individual corresponding to the maximal given referent available in the context, and can only introduce a new discourse referent (or, in static terms, get witnessed by a novel individual) if the context has no given ones. This is exactly why (183) is

[93] Recall that the two bare NPs in (183) cannot be used "co-referently" for an independent reason: if the same dog is barking and growling, it is redundant to utter the same bare NP twice when you can say (i) instead.

(i)

Na	*ulice*	*lajet*	*i*	*ryčit*	*sobaka.*
on	street	barks	and	growls	dog

'In the street, a dog is barking and growling.'

predicted to be felicitous regardless of its QUD by Srinivas's approach, but is (correctly) predicted to only be felicitous as an answer to the QUD-2 by mine, as we discussed above.

Thus, the version of the neo-Carlsonian approach proposed by Srinivas (2021), motivated by the data from Kannada challenging to the classic Dayal (2004)'s version, also makes more accurate predictions with respect to the distribution of indefinite uses of bare NPs in Russian. Namely, allowing bare NPs to receive existential readings when their definite readings are undefined is a step in the right direction. However, restricting application of *iota* to the cases where the topic situation has only given satisfiers of the NP's predicate leads to overprediction: as we discussed in Chapter 3, bare NPs in Russian can get witnessed by novel individuals only if the contextually provided domain has no given ones. Additionally, deriving existential readings through existential closure at the vP-level does not account for the variable scope behavior of bare NPs[94].

Neither of the two discussed problems arises in my analysis. First, The Unambiguity Constraint correctly predicts that a bare NP can only be used to introduce a novel discourse referent if the context has no given ones satisfying its predicate: in the latter case, it can only be used to pick out the maximal of such given discourse referents, if there is one. Second, the proposed existential quantifier analysis of bare NPs correctly predicts that they can have different scope as long as the island constraints are not violated.

[94] This problem can in principle be formally resolved by parametrization of the existential closure placement in the derivation: in this case, Russian would be a language where the existential closure can occur anywhere within the clause containing the bare NP. However, allowing *ex* to apply instead would make an analysis of Russian bare NPs potentially more elegant and less dependent on how the other variables get existentially closed.

3. Conclusions

Thus, in this chapter, I compared my analysis with the other proposed approaches to the meaning of bare NPs in articleless languages, concentrating mainly on their ability to explain why bare NPs in Russian generally pattern with indefinites (184a), but demonstrate definite-like behavior in cases like (184b-184c), where two identical bare NPs are used and interpreted within the same (local) context.

(184) Scenario. There are two dogs in the street, one of them is barking, the other one is sleeping.

a. *Na ulice lajet sobaka.*

on street dog barks

'In the street, a dog is barking.'

b. #*Na ulice lajet sobaka i ryčit sobaka.*

on street dog barks and growls dog

Expected: 'In the street, a dog is barking and a dog is growling.'

c. {—How is the dog doing?}

Sobaka zdorova, s sobakoj vsë xorošo.

dog healthy with dog all good

'The dog is healthy, everything is ok with the dog.'

I showed that the other approaches can be clustered, with some simplifications, in two groups with respect to their way of addressing the pattern in (184). The first group of approaches take the data in (184b) as evidence that bare NPs are semantically definite, but their definiteness must be "weaker" than the classic one, so that the data like in (184a) are accounted for (Dayal 2004; 2013b;

Berulava & Mayr 2024; Bikina 2026). In contrast, the second group of approaches do not even directly deal with cases like in (184b), assuming that the definite uses of bare NPs are merely a side effect of more general pragmatic principles like topicality (Seres & Borik 2018) or *Maximize Presupposition!* (Srinivas 2021).

I argued that the alternative approaches face either underprediction or overprediction problems. Setting irrelevant parts aside, definiteness-based analyses underpredict the distribution of indefinite uses of bare NPs, unless assumptions like dropping the familiarity requirement (Dayal 2004) and contextually restricting the domain (Berulava & Mayr 2024; Bikina 2026) are made. In contrast, accounts that admit indefinite readings of bare NPs (Seres & Borik 2018; Srinivas 2021) overpredict the use of bare NPs in indefinite contexts. Seres & Borik (2018) argue that all "definiteness effects" of bare NPs are illusions or, at best, cancellable implicatures; Srinivas (2021) argues that a bare NP obligatorily receives the definite reading only if all satisfiers of the NP's predicate in the contextually provided domain are familiar. In both cases, no explanation is provided for why two identical bare NPs cannot be used within the same context to pick out different discourse referents, as in (184b).

In contrast, my account manages to balance between the two types of approaches. On one hand, the simple semantic analysis of bare NPs, according to which they are existential quantifiers, correctly predicts that a bare NP can get witnessed by a non-maximal satisfier of its predicate and can be used to introduce a novel discourse referent, avoiding the problem of underprediction that the definiteness-based analyses face[95]. On the other hand, the proposed pragmatic requirement, the

[95] Recall that Srinivas (2021)'s analysis also *under*predicts the distribution of indefinite uses of bare NPs in Russian because it cannot account for the cases where they get wide scope existential readings. The same is true for Dayal (2004)'s analysis, but only for bare plurals.

Unambiguity Constraint, which is simply a generalized version of an independently postulated informational uniqueness requirement for anaphoric expressions (Roberts 2003), accounts for the fact that two identical bare NPs interpreted within the same local context cannot have distinct witnesses, avoiding the problem of overprediction that Borik & Seres (2018)[96] and Srinivas (2021) face[97].

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[96] Recall that Seres & Borik (2018) propose that bare NPs can be interpreted via choice functions, which makes their analysis overpredict even more: as I showed in Chapter 2, bare NPs do not get "exceptional scope" readings.

[97] Recall that Dayal (2004)'s analysis also *over*predicts the distribution of indefinite uses of bare NPs in Russian, namely, it incorrectly predicts that two identical bare plurals interpreted within the same local context can get witnessed by different individuals.

Chapter 5: Cross-linguistic perspectives

In Chapter 2 and Chapter 3, I proposed a novel analysis for bare NPs in Russian to account for their contrastive behavior in indefinite contexts, namely, for the fact that a bare NP does not have a familiarity or uniqueness presupposition, but two identical bare NPs interpreted within the same local context cannot have different witnesses. I argued that semantically, they are (variable-scope) unrestricted indefinites, but their uses in indefinite contexts are limited by an independent pragmatic principle of reference resolution dubbed The Unambiguity Constraint or Generalized Informational Uniqueness. I then compared my proposal with previously proposed analyses in Chapter 4, showing that it makes more accurate predictions and relies on less costly assumptions than the others.

So far, my discussion has been mostly limited to the data from Russian bare NPs. In this chapter, I will argue that the Unambiguity Constraint that I propose to account for the distribution of Russian bare NPs has a potential to be a universal principle of reference resolution and, in particular, to account for the distribution of different types of indefinites cross-linguistically. I will start (in Section 1) with showing that this constraint is compatible with the known data from five other articleless languages, Kazym Khanty, Hindi, Xhosa, Cuzco Quechua and Cabo-Verdean Creole, where bare NPs show the same contrastive behavior in indefinite contexts as their Russian counterparts.

After that, in Section 2, I will address the challenging data like in (185), where indefinite NPs seemingly violate informational uniqueness. I will propose a sketch of an account according to which, despite what it looks like, such indefinites nevertheless do obey the Unambiguity Constraint. Namely, in addition to the predicate of the NP, their descriptive content consists of a contextually available function that restricts the domain of satisfiers to a single individual, thus trivially satisfying the informational uniqueness requirement. As I will discuss, this is not an ad hoc stipulation: all such indefinites can also “escape” scope islands, and a domain- restricting analysis has independently been proposed for them to derive the “exceptional scope” readings. I will thus argue that the same domain-restricting function that allows such indefinites to escape islands allows them to seemingly violate informational uniqueness like in cases in (185).

(185) a. ENGLISH

Some dog is barking and some dog is growling.

b. DHOLUO

ɲako	*nindo*	*to*	*ɲako*	*somo*
girl	sleep.IMPF	and	girl	read.IMPF

‘A girl is sleeping and a girl is reading.’ (Dees 2025a: 14)

c. KAINGANG

nĩgja	*mráj*	*Ø,*	*hãra*	*nĩgja*	*mráj*	*Ø*	*tũ*	*nĩ.*
chair	break	PFV	but	chair	break	PFV	NEG	ASP

‘A chair broke, but a chair didn’t break.’ (Navarro 2024a: 4)

If it is indeed the same covert domain restriction that allows indefinites like in (185) escape islands that also allows them to “escape” the Unambiguity Constraint, then the prediction is that, all things being equal, NPs that cannot escape islands will not be able to “escape” the UC, and vice versa. In Section 3, I will show that in addition to Russian bare NPs, this prediction is preliminarily borne out for bare NPs in Kazym Khanty, Hindi, Xhosa, Cuzco Quechua and Cabo-Verdean Creole, although more research is needed to fully test it. After that, I will conclude this chapter in Section 4.

1. "UC-obeying" indefinites in other languages

As I have mentioned at the beginning of the chapter, I argued that the limited distribution of bare NPs in Russian is due to the Unambiguity Constraint, a general pragmatic principle suggesting that an NP can be used to pick out a discourse referent only if it is informationally unique with respect to the descriptive content of that NP, that is, there are no other discourse referents given in the context that also satisfy this predicate. Importantly, the pragmatic nature of this principle makes it expected that it will hold universally, not just in one particular language; in other words, we expect the UC to hold cross-linguistically.

In this section I will show that, judging from the available data, the UC-based approach is applicable not only to bare NPs in Russian, but also to their counterparts in five other languages, which are all genetically distant from Russian and each other: Kazym Khanty, Hindi, Xhosa, Cuzco Quechua and Cabo-Verdean Creole. In all these languages, argumental bare NPs cannot form anti-unique sequences, but otherwise feature clear properties of indefinites, such as the ability to introduce a novel discourse referent and get non-specific readings.

I will start with discussing the data from Kazym Khanty, a language I personally worked on (with my fieldwork colleagues Varvara Tiutiunnikova and Stiopa Mikhailov), in Section 1.1; the data from Kazym Khanty represent the strongest case for the cross-linguistic validity of the Unambiguity Constraint: not only do our findings suggest that bare nominals in this language cannot form anti-unique sequences but can otherwise be used to introduce novel discourse referents, but there are also data showing that they do not have a uniqueness presupposition either and *can*, after all, be used in anti-unique sequences if each of the NPs is interpreted within its own local context — just like predicted by the UC-based approach.

After that, in Section 1.2, I will discuss the data from Hindi. It is known since Dayal (2004) that bare NPs in this language cannot form anti-unique sequences[98], which was taken as evidence of their semantic definiteness; I will show that this is not the case, using the novel data from Hooda & Moroney (2026), as well as well-known challenging data brought up by Dayal herself (Dayal 2004): outside of anti-unique sequences, bare NPs in Hindi can be used to introduce novel discourse referents, do not have a uniqueness presupposition (at least not as strong as presented in classic definites like English *the*) and allow non-specific readings; I will thus argue that the data from Hindi bare NPs are better accounted for by the proposed UC-based approach rather than the classic definiteness-based approach of Dayal (2004).

The last three sections will be dedicated to the discussion of the novel data on bare NPs in Xhosa (Section 1.3), Cuzco Quechua (Section 1.4) and Cabo-Verdean Creole (Section 1.5), discussed in the forthcoming publication "The Open Handbook of (In)definiteness: A Hitchhiker's Guide to Interpreting Bare Arguments" (Dayal 2026). According to the data provided there, bare nominals in these languages pattern with their counterparts from Russian (and Kazym Khanty and Hindi) in that they cannot form anti-unique sequences, but can nevertheless be otherwise used to introduce

[98] One may wonder if this generalization is simplified: after all, we know identical bare plurals in a Hindi sentence can end up being witnessed by two different plural individuals. Recall, however, that the classic view on this is that in such cases, bare plurals denote kinds and the existential interpretation arises via Derived Kind Predication, so — technically — bare plurals do not form anti-unique sequences. I will come back to the issue with bare plurals in Chapter 6.

novel discourse referents and allow non-specific readings; moreover, in Xhosa, bare NPs can form sequences of the type "bare NP — *other*-bare NP", which is, as we know from Chapter 3, an important argument for the informational uniqueness-based approach.

Finally, in Section 1.6, I will draw the conclusions of this preliminary typological investigation, suggesting that, while further research is definitely needed, the cross-linguistic perspectives of the UC-based approach look promising.

1.1. Kazym Khanty

1.1.1. Brief overview

Kazym Khanty is a dialect of Northern Khanty (Uralic, Khantyic branch (Sámmol Ánte 2022)) spoken in the village Kazym in Khanty-Mansi Autonomous Okrug, West Siberia, Russia. Northern Khanty is an endangered language with less than 9000 speakers (Russian Census of 2010); its Kazym dialect has no more than 2000 speakers (Kaksin 2010), and most of them are over 50 years old (Aristova 2023).

Kazym Khanty features three numbers: in addition to the "classic" singular and plural, it has the dual number, which is used when the quantity of the (expected) individuals satisfying the NP's predicate is exactly two (for details, see Pisarenko & Golosov 2023; Golosov 2024a).

(186) a. *kam-ən* *ńawrɛm* *jun-λ*
street-LOC child play-NPST.3SG
'In the street, a child is playing.'

b. *kam-ən* *ńawrɛm-ŋən* *jun-λ-əŋən*

street-LOC child-DU play-NPST-3DU

'In the street, children (two) are playing.'

c. *kam-ən ńawrεm-ət jun-λ-ət*

street-LOC child-PL play-NPST-3PL

'In the street, children are playing.'

Kazym Khanty can not, strictly speaking, be called an articleless language: it has definite determiners grammaticalized from the possessive agreement markers: so-called *associative possessive* (187) and *salient article* (188) (Mikhailov 2021a, 2021b, 2023, 2024a, 2024b, 2025). As shown in (187a) and (188a), both of them require there to be a unique given discourse referent in the context that satisfies their NP's descriptive content.

However, both markers have additional semantic requirements and hence have a narrower distribution than "simple" definites. The associative possessive, in addition to uniqueness and familiarity, presupposes that there is some associative relation between the discourse referent satisfying its agreement features and the discourse referent picked out by the DP. For instance, at least for some speakers of Kazym Khanty, the NP *šajpʉt* 'kettle' in (187b) cannot be marked with second person singular associative possessive *-en* because there is no given associative relation between the addressee and the kettle (the fact that the consultant who provided the comment was trying to accommodate such a relation is also telling); in contrast, the first person dual associative possessive *-εmən* can be used here: the kettle is equally related to each of them since they wanted to have tea together[99]. The salient article, in addition to the maximality and familiarity

[99]Of course, a question arises whether the collective distribution of all associative possessives is comparable to the one of a classic definite article. While I am not aware of any actual data supporting this hypothesis, the assumption

presuppositions, requires that the discourse referent of the marked NP is the most salient one satisfying the NP's descriptive content; this is shown in (188b), where the salient article cannot attach to the bare NP *nɛm nɛpek* 'passport' because the discourse referent associated with this nominal was not maximally salient by the time of utterance (it has been introduced in the preceding discourse, but has become irrelevant, as follows from the provided left context).

(187) ASSOCIATIVE POSSESSIVE

a. Scenario 1. A friend is over at the speaker's place. There's one cup on the table.

*Scenario 2. A friend is over at the speaker's place. There are several cups on the table.

an-$^{\#}$(en)	*mij-e*
cup-POSS.2SG	give-IMP.SG>SG

'Give me the cup.'

(adapted from Mikhailov 2025: 99-100)

b. Context. The speaker and their friend are sitting in the speaker's kitchen, tired after a bath. They just put the kettle on fire and wait for it to boil in silence. The speaker says:

šajpʉt-ɛmən/$^{\%}$-en	*sora*	*kawərm-əλ*
kettle-POSS.1DU/-POSS.2SG	quickly	boil-NPST[3SG]

'The kettle is boiling quickly!'

Consultant's comment on *-en*: "Is it the case that only he [the addressee] needs the kettle or was it only him who put the kettle on the stove?".

(adapted from Mikhailov 2025: 159)

would be that any associative possessive will be infelicitous in a context where the referent of the marked DP has no associative relation to any other referent.

(188) SALIENT ARTICLE

a. Prior utterance 1. {I was walking along the street when I saw a dog.}

*Prior utterance 2. {I was walking along the street when I saw two dogs.}

amp#(-en) *ma* *pɛλ-am-a* *χurət-ti* *pit-əs*

dog-POSS.2SG I at-POSS.1SG-DAT bark-NFIN.NPST become-PST[3SG]

'The dog started barking at me.'

(adapted from Mikhailov 2025: 110-111)

b. {I found somebody's passport in the street. I went to the town administration. Met a friend there and talked to her for some time.}

#nɛm *nɛpek-en* *suwet-ən* *χăj-s-ɛm*

name paper-POSS.2SG council-LOC leave-PST-1SG>SG

'[Then] I left the passport at the administration. [Let them find the owner.]'

(adapted from Mikhailov 2025: 112)

Thus, while there are definite determiners in Kazym Khanty, there are contexts where a classic definite would be required but the use of the salient article or the associate possessive is either optional or even infelicitous. In such cases (as well as in some others, as we will see later), bare NPs are used; consider, for instance, (189a), where the bare NP *sərχanλ rajon kөśa* 'head of the Surgut district' is used to talk about a unique individual satisfying its descriptive content, and

(189b), where the two bare NPs, *ewi* 'girl and *aj_iki* 'boy', are used anaphorically, picking out the discourse referents introduced by the preceding utterance[100].

(189) a.

tamχatλ	*tiliwisar*	*χʉwat*	*wan-s-əm*	*sərχanλ*	*rajon*	*kөśa.*
today	television	on	see-PST-1SG	S.	district	head

'I saw a head of the Surgut district on TV today.'

b.

ewi	*pa*	*aj_iki*	*χot*	*jit-a*	*λuŋ-s-əŋən.*
girl	ADD	boy	house	room-DAT	enter-PST-DU

ewi	*aj_ikij-a*	*păsan-a*	*oməs-ti*	*lup-əs.*
girl	boy-DAT	table-DAT	sit-NFIN.NPST	say-PST[3SG]

'A girl and a boy entered a room. The girl told the boy to sit at the table.'

(Tiutiunnikova et al. 2025: 1599-1600)

Thus, as shown in (189), bare NPs in Kazym Khanty can be used in argumental positions; bare singulars, or, speaking more agnostically, bare NPs without any overt number marking, can also undergo pseudo noun incorporation[101] (Massam 2001; Dayal 2011; henceforth PNI) in the object position of at least some transitive verbs, as in (190-191). The common properties of PNIed arguments cross-linguistically are their number-neutrality, narrowest scope interpretation, and name-worthiness (see e.g. Borik & Gehrke 2015; Driemel 2023 for cross-linguistic overview).

[100] Note that these discourse referents were introduced by the use of the (instances of the same) bare NPs. This is what we will discuss in the next section: bare nominals in Kazym Khanty can also be used to introduce novel discourse referents.

[101] Importantly, I will not argue here that Kazym Khanty has *syntactic* pseudoincorporation; more strictly speaking, what I am arguing here is that unmarked bare NPs in object positions of at least some transitive verbs feature *semantic properties typically associated with PNIed arguments*.

The bare NPs in question feature all the mentioned properties, as illustrated in (190-191). Their number-neutrality is demonstrated in (190a) (and in (191a)): the bare NP *pos* 'mitten' does not have a singularity inference, but is interpreted as number-neutral: according to the consultants I asked, (190a) means that the speaker bought some number of mittens, which could be one but could be more. The narrowest scope of such bare NPs is evident from (190b): this sentence means that Petya hunted different hares throughout the winter, not that he was hunting a specific group. This suggests that the bare NP *šowr* 'hare', in the descriptive sense[102], at least *can* take narrow scope with respect to the durational adverbial *tăʎ măr* '(for) the whole winter': had it been otherwise, (190b) would be only true in scenarios where Petya was hunting a specific group of hares, which is not the case. Finally, the contrast in (191) shows that pseudoincorporation in Kazym Khanty is sensitive to name-worthiness of the event "described" by the formed VP. The sentence in (191a), uttered out-of-the blue, describes a common, well-established activity of apple-buying. In contrast, the sentence in (191b) describes a non-conventional, unusual activity: buying old apples; in this case, the use of the unmarked bare NP is, all things being equal, infelicitous, and the use of a bare NP corresponding to the quantity of apple individuals is required (that is, the bare NP in (191b) should get either a plural or a dual number marker, depending on the quantity of the apples; even if the number of apples is actually one, at least some consultants claim that the addition of the numeral *i* 'one' is needed). However, if the sentence in (191b) is uttered in a context

[102] Some approaches to pseudoincorporation analyse (at least some types of) PNIed arguments as denoting kinds (see e.g. Sağ 2019, 2022, 2025; Sağ et al. 2025); within such an approach, PNIed nominals are expressions of the type *e* and hence cannot take scope; note that the same applies to the number-neutrality: in these approaches, the PNIed nominal is semantically singular, as it refers to a singular kind.

where having old apples is considered as a type of event worth thinking about, like in (191c), the use of the unmarked bare NP becomes felicitous[103].

(190) a. *ma* *pos* *λət-s-əm*

I mitten buy-PST-1SG

'I bought mittens (one or more).'

b. *pet΄a-jen* *tăλ* *măr* *šowr* *weλ-əs*

P.-POSS.2SG winter time hare hunt-PST[3SG]

'Petya hunted hares (*lit*. hare-hunted) the whole winter.'

(Tiutiunnikova et al. 2025: 1598)

(191) a. *ma* *japlokə* *tăj-λ-əm*

I apple have-NPST-1SG

'I have apples.'

b. Context. A friend unexpectedly visited the speaker. They ask if the speaker has something to eat. The speaker has already eaten their food, except for some number of old apples. They offered the apples to the friend.

#*ma* *katra* *japlokə* *tăj-λ-əm*

I old apple have-NPST-1SG

[103] It should be admitted here that the judgements on the examples in (191) are not stable and vary across speakers; this could be linked to the fact that the whole concept of noteworthiness is quite subjective, and the speakers may vary in how they conceptualize different events; it might also be the case that the context in (191c) does not necessarily make having old apples more noteworthy. Of course, further research is required to make sure to what extent and whether at all the PNI in Kazym Khanty is sensitive to the parameter of the note(un)worthiness.

‘I have old apples.’

c. Context. There is a person who collects old fruits so that they don’t ripen. They came to the speaker and asked if they have something old. The speaker replied:

okma	*katra*	*japlokə*	*tăj-λ-əm*
I	old	apple	have-NPST-1SG

‘I have old apples.’

(Golosov 2024: 25)

While establishing the exact set of environments where bare NPs in Kazym Khanty undergo pseudoincorporation is work in progress, so far it has only been found in object positions of some transitive verbs; bare NPs occupying other syntactic positions, according to our data sample, cannot undergo pseudoincorporation. For instance, the bare NP *păsti_woj* in (192), occupying the subject position of the verb *urtət’λ’ti* ‘howl’, cannot be interpreted as number-neutral and/or take the narrowest scope with respect to the durational adverbial *tăλ măr* ‘(for) the whole winter’. In the next section, I will limit the discussion of bare NPs in Kazym Khanty to their non-PNIed uses, as in (192).

(192)	*tăλ*	*măr*	*păsti_woj*	*urtət′λ′-əs*
	winter	time	wolf	howl-PST[3SG]

1. ‘A wolf kept howling all winter.’

2. # ‘(Different) wolves kept howling all winter.’ (Tiutiunnikova et al. 2025: 1599)

(In)definiteness of bare NPs in Kazym Khanty and their scopal properties have been thoroughly investigated in recent works by Varvara Tiutiunnikova, Stiopa Mikhailov and me (Tiutiunnikova

2024; 2025; Golosov 2024b; Tiutiunnikova et al. 2025; 2026). In the next section I will show, using our common findings, that bare NPs in Kazym Khanty pattern with their Russian counterparts in that they cannot form anti-unique sequences (unless the QUD tree provides separate local contexts for each bare NP), but otherwise feature clear properties of indefinites: they can be used to introduce novel discourse referents and do not feature any uniqueness presupposition; I will conclude that the facts about the distribution of Kazym Khanty bare NPs known so far follow the predictions of the UC-based approach.

1.1.2. Bare NPs in Kazym Khanty

Just like their Russian counterparts, bare NPs in Kazym Khanty cannot form anti-unique sequences, as shown in (193). In (193a), the two bare NPs *ampŋən* 'dogs (two)' cannot be understood as associated with different dog pairs: while consultants did not like (193a) in general, they mentioned that (193a) seems to imply that the same two dogs are barking and sleeping. An analogous example is provided in (193b) for bare singulars.

(193) a. #*kam-ən* *amp-ŋən* *χurt-λ-əŋən* *pa* *amp-ŋən* *uλ-λ-əŋən*

street-LOC dog-DU bark-NPST-3DU ADD dog-DU sleep-NPST-3DU

'In the street, the two dogs are barking, and the two dogs are sleeping.'

(Golosov 2024: 30)

b. #*amp* *uλ-əm* *mӑr* *amp* *χөχλ-əs*

dog lie-NFIN.PST while dog run-PST[3SG]

'While a dog was lying, an (other) dog was running.' (Tiutiunnikova 2024: 3)

While the sentences in (193) are classic stimuli for the consistency/homogeneity test and their infelicity is supposed to suggest that the tested NP is definite (Löbner 1985; Dayal 2004, 2017a, 2017b; Moroney 2021; Dawson & Jenks 2023), the whole point of this dissertation is that this could be a "false negative" result. Alternatively, the infelicity of the examples in (193) could be due to the requirement on informational uniqueness posed on the used bare NPs and does not suggest anything about their own (in)definiteness status. Importantly, in contrast to the definiteness-based analysis, the UC-based one is compatible with the possibility that bare NPs in Kazym Khanty are in fact semantically indefinite and can feature the classic properties of indefinites in contexts where the informational uniqueness of their discourse referent is not challenged.

And indeed, according to our findings, bare NPs in Kazym Khanty feature the key characteristics of indefinites. First, they can be used to introduce novel discourse referents. We already discussed (194) as an instance where bare NPs are used anaphorically in the second sentences. Let us now look at the first sentence: here, the (first instances of) two bare NPs, *ewi* 'girl' and *aj_iki* 'boy', are used to introduce novel discourse referents at the beginning of the story; these are the same discourse referents that are picked out by their further anaphoric uses, the ones we discussed in the previous section.

(194) ***ewi*** *pa* ***aj_iki*** *χot* *jit-a* *λuŋ-s-əŋən.*
girl ADD boy house room-DAT enter-PST-3DU
ewi *aj_ikij-a* *păsan-a* *oməs-ti* *lup-əs*
girl boy-DAT table-DAT sit-NFIN.NPST say-PST[3SG]
'A girl and a boy entered a room. The girl told the boy to sit at the table.'

(Tiutiunnikova et al. 2025: 1600)

Second, bare NPs in Kazym Khanty are felicitous in scenarios where more than one satisfier of their predicates is present (as long as those are not represented as discourse referents). Consider, for instance, (195), where the bare dual *ńawrɛmŋən* is used to talk about two sleeping children who are not the only kids in the context; had it been definite, this would be impossible, as the presence of other children would violate the uniqueness presupposition.

(195) Context. The speaker is in the room with ten children, two of which are sleeping. The speaker's friend enters the room and starts to speak loudly. The speaker says:

χɵsλa	*wɵλ-a,*	*ńawrɛm-ŋən*	*uλ-λ-əŋən*
quietly	be-IMP[SG]	child-DU	sleep-NPST[3DU]

'Be quiet, (two) children are sleeping.'

(Tiutiunnikova et al. 2025: 1601)

These findings are compatible with the UC-based analysis, according to which bare NPs in Kazym Khanty are indefinites whose distribution is limited by the informational uniqueness requirement applied to the local context. If this analysis is indeed correct, then bare NPs should *be* able to form anti-unique sequences in cases where they contribute to addressing separate sub-QUDs, as we saw with their Russian counterparts.

This prediction is borne out, as shown in (196). The point of the (196a) is to highlight that both the winner and the loser of the race belong to the American nation, which means that the QUD this sentence addresses is, roughly, 'The person of what nationality came first, and the person of what nationality came last?'; this QUD is naturally split into two independent sub-QUDs (their resolutions do not depend on each other, as knowing the nationality of the winner does not help with identifying the nationality of the loser, and vice versa), and each of the two clauses addresses its own sub-QUD. Assuming, as we did in Chapter 3, that sub-QUDs can restrict the domains to which the UC applies, the two instances of the bare NP *amerikanets* ‘American’ end up being evaluated in separate domains, and hence the use of the second instance of this bare NP does not violate the informational uniqueness requirement. The same reasoning applies to the example in (196b) with two instances of the bare dual *amerikantsŋən* ‘pair of Americans’.

(196) a. Context. There were several participants from different countries in a race.

amerikanets mεt siri juχt-əs pa

American most front come ADD

mεt juλta χaś-əs i_śi amerikanets.

most behind stay-PST[3SG] also American

‘*Lit*. An *American* came first and also an *American* came last.’

b. Context. There was an international race, and each car had exactly two races. Some countries had more than one car participating.

mεt siri amerikants-ŋən juχət-s-əŋən,

most front American-DU come-PST-3DU

mεt juλta (iśi) amerikants-ŋən juχət-s-əŋən

most last also American-DU come-PST-3SG

‘Lit. An *American* pair came first and (also) an *American* pair came last.’

(Tiutiunnikova et al. 2025: 1600-1601)

Thus, the data Kazym Khanty speak in great favor of the cross-linguistic validity of the Unambiguity Constraint. Namely, judging from the data we know, bare NPs in this language, just like their Russian counterparts, feature clear indefinite uses, but their distribution is limited by the informational uniqueness requirement, which makes them infelicitous in anti-unique sequences unless the context provides separate domains of evaluation for each of the NPs. That being said, further research is clearly needed, to test whether other predictions of the UC-based approach are also borne out in Kazym Khanty.

1.2. Hindi

1.2.1. Introduction

Hindi is an Indo-Aryan language spoken in India. It does not have articles[104] and features bare NPs in argumental positions (see e.g. Dayal 2004 and references therein). Bare NPs, just like other nominals in Hindi, have a singular and a plural form, consider, for instance, the contrast in (197).

(197) a. ***kutta*** *aam* *janvar* *hai.*

dog common animal is

'The dog is a common animal.'

b. ***kutte*** *yehaaN* *aam* *haiN*

dogs here common are

'Dogs are common here.'

(Dayal 2004: 402)

[104] Hindi has a numeral *ek* 'one' that can sometimes be used as a specific indefinite determiner, like in (i). However, the distribution of *ek* is limited compared to a full-fledged indefinite article, so it is not usually considered as such, see Dayal (2004) for the discussion.

(i) *kamre* *meN* *ek* *laRkii* *baiThii* *thii.*

room in one girl was sitting

'A girl was sitting in the room.' (Dayal 2004: 410)

Hindi features pseudoincorporation of caseless bare NPs in the object position (Mohanan 1995; Porterfield & Srivastav 1988; Dayal 1999; 2004; 2011; 2015). As shown in (198-199), the caseless object bare NPs feature classic properties of PNIed arguments: number-neutrality, narrowest scope interpretation and name-worthiness/well-establishedness (Dayal 2011). Both number-neutrality and the narrowest scope properties are evident from the contrast in (198). In (198a), the PNIed bare NP *cuuhaa* 'mouse' has a number-neutral interpretation ((198a) does not specify how many mice Anu kept catching the whole day) and takes narrow scope with respect to the durational adverbial *puure din* 'the whole day' ((198a) does not entail that Anu tried to catch a particular group of mice for the whole day, it is also true under scenarios where Anu sequentially caught different (groups of) mice and continued doing so for the whole day). In contrast, in (199b), the very same, but not PNIed bare NP *cuuhaa* 'mouse' features a singularity inference and takes wide scope with respect to the very same durational adverbial *puure din* 'whole day' ((199b) entails that there was just one mouse that kept entering the room throughout the day).

(198) a. *anu puure din cuuhaa pakaRtii rahii.*

Anu whole day mouse catch.IMP PROG

'Anu kept catching mice (different ones) the whole day.'

b. *puure din kamre meN cuuhaa ghustaa rahaa*

whole day room in mouse enter.IMP PROG

'The whole day a/the mouse (the same one) kept entering the room.'

(Dayal 2011: 131)

The sensitivity of Hindi pseudoincorporation to the name-worthiness of the formed VP is illustrated in (199). As Dayal (2015) argues, the bare NP *laRkii* 'girl' in (199a) can be PNIed into the verb *dekhnaa* 'see', and the formed VP denotes a well-established, conventionalized event of choosing a prospective bride. Importantly, (199a) cannot be used to describe any other type of event of seeing a girl or girls, as none of them are conventionalized enough; in (199d), the bare NP *aurat* 'woman' cannot be PNIed into the verb *dekhnaa* 'see' for a similar reason: stereotypically, brides are girls, not yet (fully adult) women, so the event of "woman-seeing" is not conventionalized enough. Consider also the contrast between (199b) and (199c): taking care of children is a well-established activity (it is conventionalized as a profession or at least as an important duty), but beating children is, thankfully, not one; because of that, the bare NP *baccaa* 'child' can be PNIed into the verb *khilaanaa* 'look after', but not into the verb *maarnaa* 'beat'. In the next section, I will not consider PNI-ed NPs and will concentrate on the data from full-fledged argumental bare nominals.

(199) a. *laRkii-dekhnaa* b. *baccaa-khilaanaa*
'girl-seeing' 'child-looking_after'

c. **baccaa-maarnaa* d. **aurat-dekhnaa*
'child-beating' 'woman-seeing'

(Dayal 2015: 19)

The (in)definiteness of bare NPs in Hindi has been thoroughly investigated in the formal semantic literature (see Dayal 1999, 2004; 2017a; 2017b; Hooda & Moroney 2026 and the references therein). In the next section I will argue, mostly using the data from the existing literature, that the reported inability of bare NPs to occur in anti-unique sequences does not call for a semantic analysis and can be alternatively explained by the Unambiguity Constraint-based approach. I will show that it makes better predictions than the definiteness-based analysis: bare NPs in Hindi, contra Dayal (2004), feature clear indefinite uses (Hooda & Moroney 2026), which contradicts the classic account, but is compatible with the UC-based approach, as indefinites are also subject to the general informational uniqueness requirement.

1.2.2. Bare NPs in Hindi

As we know from the previous chapter, the most influential approach to the meaning of (non-PNIed) bare NPs in Hindi (Dayal 2004; 2013; 2017a, 2017b) suggests that they can denote definites and kinds but cannot get indefinite readings except via Derived Kind Predication that derives narrow-scope existential interpretations from kind-denoting bare plurals. As you may remember from Chapter 4, the main example Dayal used to motivate her definiteness-based analysis is the one in (200). In this sentence, the two bare NPs *bacca* 'child' cannot be understood as picking out different discourse referents: this sentence only has an odd reading according to which the same child was playing and sleeping at the same time.

(200) #*kamre meN bacca khel rahaa thaa aur bacca so (bhii) rahaa thaa*
room in child was playing and child was sleeping (also)
'The same child was playing and sleeping in the room.'

Dayal takes the infelicity of (200) as evidence that bare NPs are semantically definite: indeed, as we discussed in Chapter 2, the two identical definite NPs interpreted within the same local context must be, due to their uniqueness presupposition, co-referent. However, as we know from Chapter 3, this is not the only potential explanation for the infelicity of (200). Alternatively, it could be that bare NPs in Hindi are just like their Russian counterparts — that is, they are semantically indefinite, but obey the Unambiguity Constraint, and the sentence in (200) is bad because this constraint is violated.

And indeed, (200) is completely parallel to the key example on Russian bare NPs we discussed in Chapter 3: the second bare NP *bacca* 'child' is interpreted in a context that already has a discourse referent satisfying its predicate. The Unambiguity Constraint analysis predicts that in this case, the bare NP can only pick out this given discourse referent and cannot introduce a new one. This prediction is borne out: according to Dayal (2004), (200) suggests that the same child is playing and sleeping at the same time.

Thus, now we have two analyses of bare singulars in Hindi compatible with the data in (200): Dayal's definiteness-based analysis and my UC-based analysis. These accounts make different predictions. Namely, according to the definiteness-based account, bare NPs in Hindi cannot be used in contexts where the familiarity presupposition or the uniqueness presupposition is not satisfied. In contrast, my account, according to which bare NPs are semantically indefinite[105] but are subject to the pragmatic informational uniqueness constraint, predicts that, all things being equal, bare NPs in Hindi can be used to introduce novel discourse referents and their discourse referent does not have to be unique.

While further research is needed, there is already enough evidence that my approach makes more accurate predictions. Namely, there are many data suggesting that bare NPs in Hindi, just like their

[105] Here, following Heim, I use the term "indefinite" for the unmarked counterpart of "definite" — that is, for nominals that impose no familiarity or maximality requirements. Under a different terminologoical tradition, on which indefinites are understood as nominals imposing novelty or non-maximality requirements, bare nominals would instead be treated as neutral with respect to (in)definiteness, since they impose neither type of requirements.

Russian counterparts, can occur in contexts where it is not given that the discourse referent is familiar or unique with respect to the NP's predicate. In fact, the first datapoint is provided in Dayal's own paper (Dayal 2004), as we discussed in Chapter 4: she admits that bare NPs in Hindi do not have a familiarity presupposition. Consider, for instance, (201), where the bare NP *cuuhaa* 'mouse' is used to talk about an individual that did not have a corresponding discourse referent in the preceding context: the meant mouse is not familiar to the speech act participants.

(201)	*kamre*	*meN*	*cuuhaa*	*ghuum rahaa*	*hai*.
	room	in	mouse	moving	is

'A (unknown) mouse is moving around in the room.'

(Dayal 2004: 403)

There are also data that suggest that Hindi bare singulars do not have a uniqueness presupposition, either. While even the felicity of the example in (201) raises some concerns[106] for the proposed uniqueness-based analysis, more straightforward evidence is provided in the recent paper of Hooda & Moroney (2026). Let us start with considering the example in (202)[107]. Here, the bare NP *laṛkī* 'girl' is felicitously used in a context that does not have either a given discourse referent corresponding to a girl or a common ground expectation that there could be just one girl standing

[106] According to Dayal (2004), (204) should have a presupposition that there is a unique mouse in the room, which is not something that is normally a part of the common ground: as far as I know, there is no reason to expect, even by default, that each room has only one mouse (or even *at most* one mouse, if we assume the Weak Fregean 'at most one' approach to the uniqueness presupposition of definites (Coppock & Beaver 2012; 2015)). Thus, the example in (204) not only shows that Hindi bare singulars do not require familiarity of their discourse referent but also challenges the idea that they have a uniqueness presupposition.

[107] Note that Dayal (2004 et seq.) and Hooda & Moroney (2026) use different romanized transcriptions of the Hindi examples: Hooda and Moroney use ISO 15919, while Dayal uses her own, informal transcription. Since I am not an expert on Hindi, I did not try to unify transcription of examples from the two sources, as well as their glosses, leaving them as they were in the original paper.

at the two speakers' usual library spot. Moreover, the context suggests that the spot can be occupied by at least two people (since A and B use it together), so there is not even a reason to assume that there could be at most one occupant of the spot.

(202) Context. A and B entered the library. B starts leaving already.

A: What happened? Let's go to our usual spot. Is somebody there?

B: Yeah

B: *laṛkī* *kharī* *hai*

girl.SG stand.F AUX

'A girl is standing.' (Hooda & Moroney 2026: 2)

On top of that, Hooda & Moroney (2026) show that neither uniqueness (if present at all) nor existence inferences project when a bare singular is interpreted within the scope of such semantic operators as negation, questions, conditionals and modals[108], as shown in (203). In (203a), the bare NP *apnī gāṛī kā pahiyā* 'tire of his car' can fall within the scope of the negation: it follows from the fact that (203a) is true if Ram did not see any tires of his car. In (203b), the bare NP *pen* 'pen' is interpreted within the scope of the question: (203b) does not entail that there is a pen in the contextually avaialble situation; instead, whether there is a pen or not is what the speaker wants to find out. In (203c), the bare NP *fon* 'phone (call)' is interpreted within the scope of the conditional: the discussed phone call is hypothetical, it is not happening at A and B's actual world as they speak. Finally, in (203d), the bare NP *ghar* 'house' is interpreted within the scope of the intensional verb *ḍhū̃ḍh* 'search': the speaker's friend is not searching for a specific house existing in the actual

[108] Recall that the negation, question, modal and conditional tests is a well-known 'family-of-sentences' diagnostic for projection (Chierchia & McConnell-Ginet (1990); see, however, some critical discussion in Hofmann et al. 2024 and papers cited there).

world, a house only exists in each of the hypothetical worlds in which the friend's search is successful.

(203) a. *Rām* *ne* *apnī* *gāṛī* *kā* *pahiyā* *nahi* *dekha*

Ram ERG 1.POSS car GEN wheel.SG NEG see.M.SG.PRF

1. 'Ram did not see any tire of his car.'

2. 'Ram did not see the tire of his car.'

b. *Kya* *tumhāre* *pās* *pen* *haĩ?*

Q.PART 2PL with pen AUX

'Do you have a pen?'

c. Context. The speaker A asks about the noise in the background of their call.

A: That must be a phone.

B: There is something…

B: … *vo* *to* *patā* *lag* *jātā* *hai,*

that PART information find go.PFV AUX.PRS

fon *ātā* *hai* *to* *khair.*

phone comes.PRS AUX then well

'[There is something] that you can tell: if a phone call comes, then anyways.'

d. Context. Two speakers are talking about their friend joining a new company near one of the speaker's cities. One of the speakers says that person has not started working yet, and continues[109]:

[109] In Hooda & Moroney (2026), the original last sentence of the context is: "The speakers say that the person has not started working yet and continues:" (Hooda & Moroney 2026: 5, ex. 19). I assume that there is a mistake here: judging

abhi	*to*	*ghar*	*ke*	*liye*	*ḍhū̃ḍh*	*rahā*	*hai*
now	PART	house	GEN	for	search	PROG.M.S	AUX.PRS

'As for now, (he) is looking for a house.'

(Hooda & Moroney 2026: 4-5)

Thus, the available data from Hindi suggest that there is no reason to assume that bare NPs in Hindi have either familiarity or uniqueness presuppositions as a part of their semantic content: this is problematic for an analysis according to which they are semantically definite, but is absolutely compatible with my approach according to which Hindi bare NPs are indefinites whose use is subject to the informational uniqueness constraint on reference resolution.

1.3. Xhosa

1.3.1. Intro

Xhosa is a Bantu language (Nguni branch) spoken in South Africa and Zimbabwe. It does not have any articles (Visser 2008; Carstens et al. 2026), but argumental bare nominals are typically accompanied by two series of nominal class prefixes which convey the gender and number features of the NP, as is common in Bantu languages (see e.g. Corbett & Mtenje 1987; Carstens 1991; Corbett 1991). Two examples of Xhosa bare nouns are provided in (204); note that in each case, the change in number is reflected by the change of both prefixes.

(204) a. *u-m-dala/a-ba-dala* b. u-*m-thi/i-mi-thi*

AUG-1-adult/AUG-2-adults AUG-3-tree/AUG-4-trees

from the rest of the context and from the mismatch in number between the two verbs, it should be "one of the speakers says" instead of "the speakers say". In any case, it is not important for the validity of the example.

'adult/adults' 'tree/trees'

(Carstens et al. 2026: 665)

(In)definiteness of bare NPs in Xhosa and their scopal properties have been thoroughly investigated in recent work by Vicky Carstens, Loyiso Mletshe and Veneta Dayal (Carstens et al. 2026). In the next section, I will show, using the data and discussion from this paper, that bare NPs in Xhosa pattern with their Russian and Hindi counterparts in being unable to form anti-unique sequences, but otherwise featuring the definitional properties of indefinites, that is, ability to be used to introduce novel discourse referents and lack of a uniqueness presupposition, which suggests that they are likely accountable by the UC-based approach.

1.3.2. Bare NPs in Xhosa

Just like their counterparts in Russian, Hindi and Kazym Khanty, bare NPs in Xhosa cannot form anti-unique sequences, as shown in (205). In (205a), the two instances of the bare NP *inja* 'dog' cannot be used to talk about different dog individuals: this sentence can only mean that the same dog is being fed and beaten. Crucially, if the modifier *e-nye* 'other' is added to the second bare NP *inja* 'dog', as in (205b), the sentence remains felicitous, and the two bare NPs correspond to different dog individuals. The contrast in (205) is thus strong evidence that Xhosa bare NPs, just like their Russian cousins, are semantically indefinite but subject to the informational uniqueness requirement of the Unambiguity Constraint. Had they been semantically definite, (205b) would have been bad: there are two dogs in the context, and the uniqueness presupposition of the first bare NP *inja* 'dog' would be violated. On the other hand, had they been indefinites that are not subject to the informational uniqueness constraint, (205a) would have been fine as indefinites themselves can tolerate (and sometimes require) getting witnessed by a non-unique satisfier of their (nominal) predicate.

(205) a. *U-m-fazi* *w-ondla* *i-n-ja;*
AUG-1-woman 1SM-feed AUG-9-dog
i-n-doda *i-betha* *i-n-ja.*
AUG-9-man 1SM-beat AUG-9-dog
'A woman is feeding a dog, a man is beating {the same/*another} dog.'

b. *U-m-fazi* *w-ondla* *i-n-ja;*
AUG-1-woman 1SM-feed AUG-9-dog
i-n-doda ***e-nye*** *i-betha* *i-n-ja.*
AUG-9-man 9REL-other 1SM-beat AUG-9-dog
'A woman is feeding a dog, a man is beating **another** dog.'

(Carstens et al. 2026: 632)

The same contrast is observed with bare plurals, as shown in (206). The two bare NPs in (206a) cannot be used to talk about different groups of dogs; however, if the modifier *ezinye* 'other' is added to the second bare plural, as in (206b), the sentence becomes acceptable, even though the first bare plural remains bare. Thus, the same conclusions that were made for Xhosa bare singulars apply to their plural counterparts as well.

(206) a. #*I-zin-ja* *z-a-zi-lele;* *i-zin-ja*
AUG-10-dog 10SM-ASP-10SM-sleep AUG-10-dog
z-a-zi-ngqunga

10SM-ASP-10SM-run_around

Intended: 'Dogs were sleeping, dogs were running around.'

b. [ok]*I-zin-ja* *z-a-zi-lele;* ***ezi-nye*** *i-zin-ja*

AUG-10-dog 10SM-ASP-10SM-sleep 10-other AUG-10-dog

z-a-zi-ngqunga.

10SM-ASP-10SM-run_around

'Dogs were sleeping, other dogs were running around.'

(Carstens et al. 2026: 637)

The indefiniteness-based analysis of Xhosa bare NPs is further confirmed by the fact that they can introduce clearly novel discourse referents, as in (207). In (207), the (first) bare singular *i-xhegokazi* 'old woman' is used to introduce a novel discourse referent representing a woman individual; this discourse referent is later picked out by the second instance of this NP. An analogous example involving the bare plural *a-ma-xhegokazi* 'old women' is provided in (207b). Again, had bare NPs in Xhosa been semantically definite, neither of the sentences in (207) would have been felicitous: as the beginnings of a story, (207a) and (207b) clearly would most naturally be uttered in a context where there is no unique familiar discourse referent representing an old woman and/or a presupposition that old women live alone in their houses.

(207) a. *Mandulo,* *i-xhegokazi* *l-a-li-hlala* *kule* *n-dlu.*

long_ago AUG-5.old_woman 5SM-PST-5SM-live 17LOC.this 9-house

I-xhegokazi *l-a-li-ne-n-tombi* *e-ntle.*

AUG-5.old_woman 5SM-PST-5SM.have.AUG-9-daughter 9-beautiful

'Long ago, an old woman lived in this house. The old woman had a beautiful daughter.'

b. *Mandulo,*	*a-ma-xhegokazi*	*a-ye-hlala*	*kule*	*n-dlu.*
long_ago	AUG-6-old_women	5SM-PST-live	17LOC.this	9-house

A-ma-xhegokazi	*a-ye-ne-en-tombi*	*e-ntle.*
AUG-6-old_women	6SM-PST-5SM.have.AUG-10-daughter	9-beautiful

'Long ago, old women lived in this house. The old women had beautiful daughters.'

(Carstens et al. 2026: 644-645)

Thus, the data discussed in this section speak in great favor of the possibility that bare NPs in Xhosa, just like their Russian counterparts, are semantically indefinite and that their inability to form anti-unique sequences can be explained by the Unambiguity Constraint, that is, as a side effect of the pragmatic requirement on the informational uniqueness of their discourse referent. However, more work should clearly be done, including more thorough investigation of other accessible data and generalizations regarding the nominal system of Xhosa, to confirm that the UC-based approach is indeed applicable to bare NPs in this language.

1.4. Cuzco Quechua

1.4.1. Intro

Cuzco Quechua is a Quechuan language (the Quechua B/II branch) spoken in Peru. It does not have articles and features bare NPs in argumental positions (Sánchez et al. 2026); unmarked NPs can have a strictly singular (208a) or, in some contexts, number-neutral (209a) interpretation (Faller 2007); NPs can also be marked with a plurality marker *-kuna*, but this marker has a more nuanced meaning than plurality: in certain cases, it requires that the plurality in question is a specific salient sub-group of a larger plurality (Sánchez et al. 2026). For instance, while no such inference is associated with the plural NP *kay yachaqkunan* 'these students' in (208b), the bare NP *allqukuna* 'dogs' in (209b) requires the satisfier of its predicate to be a salient subgroup of dogs among a larger set of dogs.

(208) a. *Kay* *yachaq-mi* *ashka* *llaqta-kuna-pi* *tiya-n.*

this student-FOC/EVID.ATT many city-PL-LOC live-3.PL

'This student lives in different cities.'

b. *Kay* *yachaq-kuna-n* *ashka* *llaqta-kuna-pi* *tiya-n.*

these student-PL-FOC/EVID.ATT many city-PL-LOC live-3.PL

'These students live in different cities.'

(Sánchez et al. 2026: 232)

(209) a. *Allqu* *llaqwa-naku-n.*

dog lick-RECIPROC-3.S

'The dogs (in general) lick each other.'

b. *Allqu-kuna* *llaqwa-naku-n.*

dog-PL lick-RECIPROC-3.S

'The dogs (a certain subgroup) lick each other.'

(Sánchez et al. 2026: 233-234)

For more detailed discussion of the meaning and status of the marker *-kuna*, see Sánchez et al. (2026), Sánchez & Vengoa (2026) and the references therein; as this marker likely has additional nuanced semantic restrictions within the domain of (in)definiteness, I will limit our discussion here to bare NPs without *-kuna.* In the next section, I will show, using the data discussed in Sánchez et al. (2026), that they clearly pattern with bare nominals in Russian, Kazym Khanty, Hindi and Xhosa in that they cannot form anti-unique sequences, but can otherwise be used to introduce novel discourse referents, which preliminarily supports the hypothesis that they are semantically indefinite but follow the UC requirement that their discourse referent must be informationally unique.

1.4.2. Bare NPs in Cuzco Quechua

Just like their counterparts in Russian, Kazym Khanty, Hindi and Xhosa, bare NPs in Cuzco Quechua cannot form anti-unique sequences. This is shown by the infelicity of (210), where the two bare NPs *allqu* 'dog' cannot be used to talk about different dog individuals.

(210) #*allqu puñu-chka-n; allqu phawa-chka-n*
dog sleep-PROG-3.S dog run_around-PROG-3.S
Intended: 'A dog is sleeping; a dog is running around.'

(Sánchez et al. 2026: 248)

As we have seen many times already, however, the fact that the two instances of the same NP cannot get witnessed by different individuals does not at all mean that the NP is semantically definite; alternatively, we can deal with indefinites that cannot form anti-unique sequences due to the Unambiguity Constraint. In the latter case, we would expect that as long as the informational uniqueness requirement is satisfied, the tested NP would behave as an indefinite.

And indeed, judging from the data provided in Sánchez et al. (2026), bare NPs feature clear properties of indefinites. First, they can be used to introduce novel discourse referents. Consider, for instance, (211), where the first instance of the bare NP *payacha* 'old woman' is used to introduce a new discourse referent at the beginning of the narrative; this discourse referent is then picked out by the second instance of the same bare NP, *paya-cha* 'old woman', which shows that bare NPs can also be used anaphorically.

(211) *Huk kutin-si paya-cha kay wasi-pi*

one time-FOC.EVID.REP old_woman-DIM this house-LOC

tiya-rqa-n. Pay-si sumaq warmi

be-PST-ATT.3S she-FOC/EVID.REP beautiful woman

wawa-yuq ka-rqa-n.

baby-POSS have-ATT.PST-3.S

'Once upon a time an old woman lived in this house. She had a beautiful daughter.'

(Sánchez et al. 2026: 263-264)

Second, Cuzco Quechua bare NPs feature non-specific readings. Consider, for instance, (212), with the bare NP *warmi* 'woman': as shown by the follow-up in (212b), the sentence in (212a) does not entail or presuppose that there is a woman Pawlu wants to meet. Such a use of a bare NP as in (212a) is typical for (some types of) indefinites, as we know from Chapter 2; in contrast, had the bare NP *warmi* 'woman' been definite, (212a) would have been unambiguously understood as a claim about one particular, uniquely salient woman known to the speech act participants, and the continuation in (212b) would have been infelicitous.

(212) a. *Pawlu [warmi-ta] riqsi-y-ta muna-n.*

Pawlu woman-ACC meet-INF-ACC want-.S

'Pawlu wants to meet a woman.'

b. *Mayqin-ta-pas*

which-ACC-PL

'Anyone.'

(Sánchez et al. 2026: 275-276)

Thus, just like their counterparts from Russian, Hindi, Kazym Khanty and Xhosa, bare NPs in Cuzco Quechua cannot form anti-unique sequences, but at the same time have clear indefinite uses (that is, they can be used to introduce a novel discourse referent and allow non-specific readings). This is exactly what is predicted if we analyze them as semantically indefinite NPs whose distribution is limited by the Unambiguity Constraint (namely, the discourse referent they are used to pick out must be informationally unique with respect to their predicate). Of course, more research is needed to confirm that the UC-based approach is indeed applicable to bare NPs in Cuzco Quechua, but the data available so far look promising.

1.5. Cabo-Verdean Creole

1.5.1. Intro

Cabo-Verdean Creole is a language spoken in Cabo Verde, developed via creolization of Portuguese by speakers of the indigenous West African language(s) spoken on this territory. It does not have articles and features bare nominals in argumental positions; NPs in this language have an unmarked number-neutral form and a plural form marked by the suffix *-s* which has a limited distribution and requires familiarity of the corresponding discourse referent (Baptista & Dayal

2026). I will not consider these bare plurals in the remainder of this section, as their familiarity requirement makes them a priori infelicitous in anti-unique sequences, which, in turn, makes it impossible to test whether they obey the Unambiguity Constraint or are just semantically definite; thus, I will limit the discussion here to unmarked bare NPs, to which I will henceforth refer as just bare NPs.

(213) a. *N* *ta* *toma* *roza.*

I will take rose

'I will take the rose(s).'

(Baptista & Dayal 2026: 178)

b. *Katxor /* *katxoris* *ta* *morde kunpanheru*

dog dog-PL ASP bite each_other

'Dogs/the dogs bite each other.'

(Baptista & Dayal 2026: 158-159)

The (in)definiteness and scopal properties of bare NPs in Cabo-Verdean creole have been thoroughly discussed in the recent work by Marlyse Baptista and Veneeta Dayal (2026). In the next section, I will show, using the data and discussion from this paper, that bare NPs in Cabo-Verdean Creole pattern with their Russian, Hindi, Kazym Khanty, Xhosa and Cuzco Quechua counterparts in that they cannot form anti-unique sequences, but feature such defining properties of indefinites as ability to trigger the introduction of a novel discourse referent and lack of specificity requirement, which suggests that they might be indefinites subject to the informational uniqueness requirement and can be accounted for by the UC-based approach.

1.5.2. Bare NPs in Cabo-Verdean Creole

Just like their counterparts in the other articleless languages we discussed in this big section, bare NPs in Cabo-Verdean Creole cannot form anti-unique sequences, as shown in (214). In (214a), the two bare NPs *katxor* 'dog' cannot be used to talk about different dog individuals. As Baptista and Dayal (2026) mention, (214a) becomes acceptable if a distinguishing modifier is added to each of the bare NPs; for instance, (214a) is felicitous if we change the first bare NP to *katxor branku* 'white dog' and the second one to *katxor pretu* 'black dog'. An analogous example is provided in (214b) for bare NPs in the object position.

(214) a.

#*Katxor*	*sta*	*durmi*	*y*	*katxor*	*sta*	*kore*	*di*	*tudu*	*ladu.*
dog	ASP	sleep	and	dog	ASP	run	of	all	side

Intended: 'A dog is sleeping and a dog is running around.'

b.

#*N*	*odja*	*katxor*	*ta*	*durmi*	*y*	*N*	*odja*	*katxor*	*ta*	*kore*
I	saw	dog	ASP	sleep	and	I	saw	dog	ASP	run
di	*tudu*	*ladu.*								
of	all	side								

Intended: 'I saw a dog sleeping and I saw a dog running around.'

(Baptista & Dayal 2026: 173-174)

As we have seen many times already, the infelicity of the sentences in (214) does not at all suggest that the tested NPs are definite: instead, the NPs in question can just be indefinites obeying the Unambiguity Constraint. Thus, in the latter case, we would expect that in contexts where the informational uniqueness is not violated, bare NPs in Cabo-Verdean Creole would, all things being equal, be able to be used as indefinites.

And indeed, this expectation is borne out. As demonstrated in (215), bare NPs in Cabo-Verdean can be used to introduce novel discourse referents, which is a defining feature of indefinites. As Baptista and Dayal (2026) argue, while addition of the numeral *un* 'one' is sometimes preferred[110], it is not required in (215), and the bare NP could be used on its own to introduce a novel discourse referent representing an old woman[111].

(215) *uns anu pasadu, (un) mudjer bedja ta moraba na kel kaza.*
some years past one woman old ASP live in that house
'A few years ago, an old woman lived in that house.'

(Baptista & Dayal 2026: 183-184)

Another piece of evidence for the indefinite semantics of bare NPs in Cabo-Verdean Creole is that they feature non-specific uses, that is, they do not require their satisfier(s) to exist in the actual world. This is shown in (216), where the bare NP *ator* 'actor' does not "correspond" to a particular actor in the speaker's actual world, as follows from the continuation: the point made in (216) is that Paulo would be happy to meet any movie actor, not a particular one. Such interpretation would

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[110] Baptista & Dayal (2026) do not provide any explanation for why that might be the case; a hypothesis worth considering is that the addition of the numeral *un* makes (215) more informative, as with only the (number-neutral) bare NP present, it is not clear whether a single or more old women used to live in the house.

[111] As the reader may have noticed, (215) does not contain a follow-up where the introduced discourse referent is picked out by an anaphoric expression; this means that, strictly speaking, (215) does not show the ability of the bare NP to *introduce a discourse referent*, it only shows the lack of familiarity requirement. Baptista & Dayal (2026) do not provide any data showing that the use of a bare NP triggers introduction of a discourse referent that is later anaphorically accessible in the following discourse, so this is a question for further research; that being said, however, the typological expectation is that just like many other argumental indefinites cross-linguistically, bare NPs in Cabo-Verdean Creole should be able to introduce their own discourse referents.

not be available for a definite NP, as it would require a uniquely salient antecedent in the existing world or, at least, a presupposition that there could be just one movie actor Paulo can meet at once; neither of the two holds in (216), of course.

(216) *Paulo kre nkontraator di sinema.*

Paulo want meet actor of movie

Poku ta inporta-l kenhi ki el é.

little ASP matter-him who that he is

'Paulo wants to meet a movie actor during his visit to Los Angeles; he does not care which one.'

(Baptista & Dayal 2026: 194)

Thus, the data from Cabo-Verdean Creole discussed in this section showed that bare NPs in this language cannot form anti-unique sequences, but feature clear indefinite uses outside of them. While, of course, further research is needed to confirm whether it is indeed the case, the behavior of bare nominals in Cabo-Verdean Creole is what is expected from semantically indefinite NPs under the UC-based approach: they can introduce novel discourse referents but obey the informational uniqueness constraint and hence cannot form anti-unique sequences.

1.6. Conclusions

Thus, as I have shown in this section, the Unambiguity Constraint, proposed to account for the limited distribution of bare NPs in Russian, clearly has a cross-linguistic potential. Namely, bare NPs in the five languages investigated here — Kazym Khanty, Hindi, Xhosa, Cuzco Quechua and Cabo-Verdean Creole — crucially pattern with their Russian counterparts in that they cannot form anti-unique sequences, but can otherwise be used in unambiguously indefinite contexts, which is difficult to account under the classic definiteness-based analysis (Dayal 2004), but naturally follows if we assume that bare NPs in these languages are indefinites that are subject to the Unambiguity Constraint, that is, can only be used if the introduced/picked out discourse referent is informationally unique with respect to the NP's predicate.

2. Domain-restricting indefinites

2.1. Introduction

In the previous section, I showed that the Unambiguity Constraint, a dynamic pragmatic principle that dictates that an NP can only be used to pick out an (old or new) discourse referent *i* if there are no other discourse referents given in the local context that satisfy the NP's descriptive content, has a potential to be a cross-linguistically universal principle of reference resolution. In addition to accounting for the distribution of bare NPs in Russian, the Unambiguity Constraint seems to capture the data from some other articleless languages, such as Hindi or Kazym Khanty, where bare NPs pattern with their Russian counterparts in that they have clear indefinite uses but two identical bare NPs cannot be interpreted within the same context as witnessed by different individuals.

There are, however, indefinites that at first glance seem to violate the Unambiguity Constraint, that is, they can get used to introduce a novel discourse referent when the context already has a given discourse referent that also satisfies the predicate of the indefinite's restrictor. For instance, anyone even remotely familiar with the studies of indefiniteness in English will recall the examples like in (217), in each of which there are two identical indefinites, and the second one introduces a novel discourse referent distinct from the one introduced by the first indefinite: this is clear from the fact that the two indefinites can have different witnesses[112]. In (217a), the two DPs *some dog* can naturally be understood as getting witnessed by different dog individuals. The same is true for the two DPs *a dog* in (217b)[113]. The fact that both sentences are felicitous is challenging for the Unambiguity Constraint: all things being equal, the use of the second indefinite to introduce a novel discourse referent representing a dog would violate the informational uniqueness, as there is another discourse referent given in the context that represents a dog.

(217) a. *Some dog is barking and some dog is growling.*

b. *A dog is barking and a dog is growling.*

How can one address the challenging data like in (217)? One way, a simple but not elegant one, would be to assume that the Unambiguity Constraint is not a universal principle of reference

[112] It is important to highlight here that while a pair of indefinites in cases like in (217) is used to introduce two different discourse referents, it does not mean that the *witnesses* of these indefinites are different, although this can arise as an implicature in certain cases. For example, while there is an implicature in (217b) that the two dogs are different, it can easily be cancelled, as in (i), where the speaker is explicitly agnostic on whether the two discourse referents map onto different dog individuals or not (I am grateful for Alexander Williams for providing me with this example).

(i) *A dog is barking and a dog is growling, but I don't know whether there was one dog or two.*

Thus, the fact that each of the two indefinites in cases like in (217) is used to introduce its own novel discourse referent only means that the indefinites *can* have different witnesses, in contrast to, for instance, a pair of identical definites interpreted within the same local context that are required to take the same discourse referent and hence *must* have the same "witness".

[113] It should be noted here that although sentences with *a*-indefinites like in (217b) are commonly provided in the literature as an example where the same NP can be used to talk about different individuals (e.g. Dayal 2017a; Dawson & Jenks 2023), the real empirical picture is more nuanced. Namely, while for many speakers, (220b) is felicitous, a significant number of consultants shared that the sentence sounds quite unnatural unless the adjective *other* is added to the second NP, as in (ii):

(ii) *A dog is barking and another dog is growling.*

This data point suggests that *a*-indefinites may in fact be closer to bare NPs in terms of their distribution than it may seem from the discussion in the literature, and thus this topic requires further research. I will abstract from this issue here, however.

resolution and is not present in all languages and/or does not apply to all types of NPs (in this case, one can argue that it only applies to bare nominals). This, however, would be a conceptually problematic decision due to the pragmatic nature of the proposed constraint: pragmatic principles are normally assumed to be universal across different languages, since they are, at the end of the day, derived from general principles of rational reasoning (following Grice 1975 and subsequent research). Another way, which I am going to pursue here, is to try and argue that indefinites like in (217) do not, in fact, violate the UC; the only way for that to work, however, is to show that the descriptive content of "UC-violating" indefinites is in fact richer than just the predicate of their NP restrictor and that, moreover, it is rich enough to satisfy the informational uniqueness requirement of the UC.

If such content exists at all, it should only be present in the interpretation of "UC-violating" indefinites but be absent in the interpretation of "UC-obeying" indefinites so that the contrast is accounted for. In other words, to find out whether there is a content that allows indefinites like in (217) to "escape" the UC, we need to answer the following question: what kind of semantic content is present in the "UC-violating" indefinites but is absent in the "UC-obeying" ones?

In the next two sections, I will discuss two hypotheses of how such indefinites can be accounted for within the UC-based approach, based on two independent semantic features that distinguish (in one case only some, in the other — potentially all) "UC-violating" indefinites from "UC-obeying" ones. Both these hypotheses are only sketchy and do not provide an immediate solution: there are certain issues in each case that need to be addressed for the hypotheses to be properly applicable, which I will also outline in the corresponding sections. At the same time, they are still worth considering, not only because they have a potential to resolve the typological challenge the

UC-based approach currently faces, but also because they are largely motivated by independent semantic phenomena.

2.2. Novelty-based account

The first hypothesis is based on probably the most salient semantic difference between *a*-indefinites or *some*-indefinites and bare NPs in Russian, Kazym Khanty and Hindi, which is that the former, in contrast to the latter, require the novelty of their discourse referent. This clearly follows from the fact that, in contrast to Russian bare NPs, *a*-indefinites and *some*-indefinites cannot be used anaphorically, as shown in (218), where neither the DP *some boy* nor the DP *a boy* can be used to pick out the previously introduced discourse referent that satisfies the predicate from their restrictor.

(218) *In the street, a/some boy$_i$ was talking to a/some girl.*

The/$^{\#}$a/$^{\#}$some boy$_i$ was clearly very shy.

Assuming that the novelty requirement is a part of the content of the two kinds of "UC-violating" indefinites that is visible for the UC[114], we can argue that it is this novelty inference that allows the second indefinite in cases like in (217) to satisfy the UC. For instance, in (217a), when the second indefinite *some dog* is used to introduce a discourse referent *i*, the UC is not violated because there is no discourse referent *j* given in the preceding context that is entailed to map onto

[114] This assumption is quite non-trivial, because, at least in some cases, the novelty inference of an indefinite is analyzed not as an obligatory part of its meaning, but as an implication arising as a side effect of competition with its definite counterpart, as we discussed in Chapter 2. Considering this, allowing the novelty inference to be a part of the content visible for the UC may require making a more general costly assumption that in addition to the lexically encoded content, the UC can get access to the content arising via pragmatic strengthening. Further research is needed to verify whether such an assumption is justified, that is, whether the UC can get satisfied by other types of content arisen through pragmatic strengthening.

a dog individual *and* is entailed to be distinct from any discourse referent given in the context. In particular, the discourse referent *j*, introduced by the first NP *some dog*, is not distinct from all the given discourse referents, as it is itself a given discourse referent and, of course, is not distinct from itself. In other words, under the novelty-based analysis, a use of *some*-indefinites or *a*-indefinites trivially satisfies the UC since there could not be any given discourse referents in the context that are novel with respect to it.

While the proposed novelty-based account can, at least At first glance, explain the data on *a*-indefinites and *some*-indefinites like in (217), it cannot be extended to all known instances where indefinites apparently violate the Unambiguity Constraint. Namely, some languages feature nominals that can form anti-unique sequences as in (217) but do not require novelty of their discourse referent. One example is bare NPs in Dholuo (a Nilo-Saharan language spoken in Kenya and Tanzania). On one hand, just like *a*-indefinites and *some*-indefinites in English, a bare NP in Dholuo can be used to introduce a discourse referent even if there is already another discourse referent given in the context, as in (219a). On the other hand, in contrast to their English counterparts, Dholuo bare NPs can be used anaphorically, as in (219b). This means that they do not encode novelty as a part of their meaning — and yet somehow manage to escape the UC.

(219) a. *ɲako*$_i$ *nindo* *to* *ɲako*$_j$ *somo*

girl sleep.IMPF and girl read.IMPF

'A girl is sleeping and a girl is reading.' (Dees 2025: 14)

b. *wuowi* *kod* <u>*ɲako*$_i$</u> *n-o-dondʒo* *e* *ot.*

boy and girl PAST-PFV-enterin room

Ɲako$_i$ *n-o-bet.*

girl PAST-PFV-sit_down

‘A boy and a girl entered the room. The girl sat down.’ (Dees in press: 3)

Another instance of such a problematic case is bare NPs in Kaingang (a Jê language spoken in Southern Brazil). Just like their Dholuo counterparts, these nominals can introduce novel discourse referents even if the context already has a discourse referent satisfying their predicate (220a) but also can be used anaphorically (220b).

(220) a. *nĩgja*$_i$ *mráj* *Ø,* *hãra* *nĩgja*$_j$ *mráj* *Ø* *tũ* *nĩ.*

chair break PFV but chair break PFV NEG ASP

‘A chair broke, but a chair didn’t break.’

b. *Rãkétá* *gĩr*$_i$ *vỹ* *mur* *Ø* *jamã* *ki.*

yesterday child NOM born PFV village in

Gĩr$_i$ *tóg* *mág* *nĩ.*

Child TOP big ASP

‘Yesterday a child was born in the village. The child was big.’

(Navarro 2024a: 4)

Thus, a novelty-based account can naturally explain how indefinites that feature a novelty inference, such as *a*-DPs or *some*-DP, can form anti-unique sequences without violating the UC: assuming that this novelty inference can itself be a part of the descriptive content considered for the UC satisfiaction, any use of an indefinite with such an inference will trivially satisfy the UC, regardless of whether there are already discourse referents in the context representing other satisfiers of this indefinite’s predicate or not. However, this account has two issues: i) it does not cover all cases where indefinites form anti-unique sequences, as some of those do not feature novelty inference; ii) novelty inference itself has an arguable status: it is typically considered as, at best, an anti-presupposition, so it is not clear whether such types of content could be taken into account regarding the satisfaction of the UC; further research is needed to see whether there is independent evidence suggesting that inferences arising through pragmatic strengthening can be considered at the level of the UC satisfaction.

In the next section, I will propose an alternative account for "UC-violating" indefinites, also based on their independently observed distinguishing semantic property, including the ones that do not feature novelty inference.

2.3. Domain restriction-based account

2.3.1. Introduction

If not novelty, is there any special semantic property of such indefinites that distinguishes them from their "UC-obeying" counterparts and allows them to escape the Unambiguity Constraint? Interestingly, there is one, and it is shared not only by bare NPs in Dholuo and Kangang, but also by *a*-indefinites and *some*-indefinites in English. Namely, in contrast to bare NPs in Russian (and, as we will see later, also in contrast at least to bare NPs in Hindi), the "UC-violating" indefinites can get so-called exceptional scope readings, as illustrated in (221) where they are interpreted as if they get wide scope interpretation with respect to the *if*-conditional[115].

[115] I assume here that conditionals are scope islands in these languages. This is well-known for English, and Navarro (2024; 2025b) shows some evidence that conditionals may be islands in Kaingang as well: the universal quantifiers with *kar* 'all' cannot scope out of the conditional, as shown in (i).

(i) Common context. There will be a party in the village, and you will be the singer.
Three non-indigenous persons were invited.

(221) a. ENGLISH

If a friend of mine from Texas had died in the fire, I would have inherited a fortune.

1. 'If any friend of mine from Texas had died in the fire, I would have inherited a fortune.' *if* > ∃
2. 'There is a specific friend of mine from Texas such that if he had died in the fire, I would have inherited the fortune.' ∃ > *if*

(adapted from Fodor & Sag 1982: 369)

b. KAINGANG

Context 1. There will be many Kangangs at the party. You, the party singer, are convinced that if a particular Kaingang (named Fógtē) arrives there, you will sing the song *Garçom.*

Context 2. If any Kaingang arrives at the party, whoever they are, you will sing the song *Garçom.*

Fénhta	*ki*	*kanhgág*	*jun*	*mūra,*	*sóg*	*Garçom*	*jãn*	*ke*	*mũ.*
party	at	Kaingang	arrive	if	1SG	Garçom	sing	FUT	ASP

'If a Kaingang arrives at the party, I will sing *Garçom*.'

(Navarro 2024a: 26)

Context 1. If **all** of them go there, you will sing *Garçom*.

#Context 2. If **any one** of them goes there, you will sing *Garçom*.

Fénhta	*ki*	*fóg*	*kar*	*jun*	*mura,*
party	at	non_indigenous_person	all	arrive	if
sóg	*Garçom*	*jãn*	*ke*	*mu.*	
1SG.TOP	Garçom	sing	FUT	PROG	

'If all non-indigenous persons arrive at the party, I will sing *Garçom*.' (Navarro 2025: 138)

I am not aware of any data suggesting whether conditionals are also scope islands in Dholuo, so that is an important question for further research.

c. DHUOLUO

Ka	*wat-na*	*othoo,*	*a-biro*	*bet*	*makuyo.*
if	relative-my	die	1SG-will	be	sad

'If a relative of mine dies, I will be sad.'

(Dees 2025b: 13)

We already discussed (221a) before, in Chapter 4. This sentence has a reading according to which there is a particular friend of the speaker from Texas from whom the speaker would have inherited the fortune, and (221a) can be true even if the speaker has other Texan friends who did not bequeath them anything. This cannot be straightforwardly accounted for if we assume that the indefinite *a friend of mine from Texas* is interpreted within the scope of the conditional: that would wrongly predict that (221a) entails that the speaker would get the fortune had *any* of their friends from Texas died. One way to derive the desired reading is to assume that the indefinite somehow scopes out of the *if*-clause: there is a friend of the speaker such that if they had died, the speaker would have inherited the fortune. This would be compatible with the scenario discussed above. The indefinites in (221b) and (221c) behave analogously. The sentence in (221b) is true under a scenario where Fógtē is the only Kaingang whose presence would make the speaker sing the song; the sentence in (221c) can be understood as a claim about a specific relative of the speaker[116]. In both cases, the sentences should have been false if the indefinite were simply interpreted within the scope of the conditional.

[116] It should be noted here that Dees (2025a) does not discuss whether (36c) is true under a scenario where the speaker has many relatives, but only one of them is such that their death would make them sad. What Dees does say, however, is that in (36c), "[the] bare NP… denotes a particular individual that the hearer does not necessarily know about" (Dees 2025a: 13); the specificity inference is another reliable diagnostic of "exceptional scope" indefinites, as we discussed in Chapter 2.

At first glance, the fact that these indefinites can get exceptional scope readings has nothing to do with the fact that they can also escape the Unambiguity Constraint. However, in this section, I will show that the connection is in fact pretty straightforward. As we will see in a moment, some approaches to exceptional scope indefinites argue that they do not, in fact, scope out of islands; instead, the illusion of the exceptional wide scope interpretation arises due to the ability of such indefinites to restrict their domain[117] (one way or another, depending on a particular theory) to a single satisfier. I will propose a hypothesis, according to which this very same covert domain restriction to a single satisfier is the sought (covert) descriptive content that allows exceptional scope indefinites to satisfy the informational uniqueness requirement of the UC.

The remainder of this section is structured as follows. In the next sub-section, I will start with a brief overview of two most influential approaches to exceptional scope indefinites, which derive the exceptional scope readings via some sort of covert domain restriction mechanism. After that, in sub-section 2.3.3, I will propose a hypothesis, according to which this independently needed domain-restricting operation allows exceptional scope indefinites to satisfy the Unambiguity Constraint in anti-unique sequences as in (217, 219), as it contextually narrows down the extension of their predicate to a unique satisfier. I will end this section with discussing some issues this account needs to address to be fully applicable.

[117] As will be clearer later, I use the notion of domain restriction here quite loosely, as a short way of saying "narrowing down the interpretation in terms of individuals under consideration". This will be important when we review choice function-based approaches: as will be discussed in more detail, they do not do any domain restriction *stricto sensu*, but they still limit the set of considered satisfiers of the nominal's predicate in some way.

2.3.2. Approaches to exceptional scope indefinites and my account

The whole interest in the topic of exceptional scope indefinites is based on the well-known generalization that most quantifiers cannot escape islands, such as *if*-clauses or complex NPs. Consider, for instance, the classic data from Fodor & Sag (1982), provided here in (222).

(222) a. *If* ***each friend of mine from Texas*** *had died in the fire, I would've inherited a fortune.*

1. 'I would have inherited a fortune if my friends from Texas had died in the fire.'
2. '#Each friend of mine from Texas is such that if they had died in the fire, I would have inherited a fortune.'

b. *If* ***no friend of mine from Texas*** *had died in the fire, I would have inherited a fortune.*

1. 'I would have inherited a fortune if my friends from Texas survived the fire.'
2. # 'No friend of mine from Texas is such that had they died in the fire, I would have inherited a fortune.'

(adapted from Fodor & Sag 1982: 370)

In (222a), the universal quantifier cannot get wide scope with respect to the conditional. This follows from the fact that for (222a) to be true, a death of just one Texan friend of the speaker would not have been enough: for them to inherit the fortune, all their Texan friends should have died in the fire. Analogously, in (222b), the negative quantifier *no friend of mine from Texas* can only be interpreted within the scope of the conditional. Namely, (222b) can only mean that the speaker would get the fortune only if all their friends from Texas survived the fire; it cannot be used to convey that no Texan friend of the speaker bequeathed them a solid amount of money.

The same restriction is observed when quantifiers occur within complex NPs, like in (223). This sentence entails that John heard a single rumor about all the students of the speaker: it is false under a scenario where there was a separate rumor about each student. This suggests that the universal quantifier *each of my students* is obligatorily interpreted within the scope of the modal operator of the complex NP *the rumor that*, as it cannot distribute it across different students.

(223) *John overheard the rumor that* ***each of my students*** *had been called before the dean.*

1. 'John overheard the rumor: each of my students had been called before the dean.'
2. #'About each of my students, John overheard a rumor that they had been called before the dean.'

(adapted from Fodor & Sag 1982: 369)

At that time, indefinites like *a*-NPs or *some*-NPs were most often analyzed as existential quantifiers (since Russell 1905). Fodor & Sag (1982) challenged this classic view with examples like in (224). As we recently discussed, the sentence in (224a) is true under a scenario where there is only one, specific friend of the speaker who bequeathed him the fortune. To account for this fact whilst analyzing indefinites as existential quantifiers, one would have to assume that *a friend of mine* takes scope over the conditional, thus violating the scopal island constraint. Analogously, the sentence in (224b) is true under a scenario where there is a particular student of the speaker who is rumored to have been called before the dean. This can only be accounted for within the existential quantifier-based analysis if we assume that *a student of mine* scopes out of the complex NP, which is, again, a violation of the scope island constraint.

(224) a. *If* ***a friend of mine*** *from Texas had died in the fire, I would have inherited a fortune.*

1. 'If any friend of mine from Texas had died in the fire, I would have inherited a fortune.' *if* > ∃

2. # ‘There is a specific friend of mine from Texas such that if he had died in the fire, I would have inherited the fortune.’ $\exists > if$

b. *John overheard the rumor that* ***a student of mine*** *had been called before the dean.*

1. ‘John overheard the rumor: ‘A student of mine had been called before the dean.’
2. ‘There is a student of mine who, as John heard, had been called before the dean.’

(adapted from Fodor & Sag 1982: 369)

Thus, as Fodor and Sag argue, the data in (224) present a challenge for the classic existential quantifier semantics of indefinites like *a*-NPs[118]: it is not clear why existentials would be the only quantifiers that can escape conditionals, complex NPs and some other scope islands. To resolve this issue, they argued that indefinites are in fact semantically ambiguous[119]: in addition to the classic quantificational reading, they have a referential one, and the “exceptional scope” uses are in fact just cases where indefinites are used as referential expressions and as such are scope-rigid.

Note that Fodor & Sag’s referential analysis predicts that whenever indefinites “escape” islands, they can only, descriptively speaking, take the widest scope. However, the further research revealed that this prediction is not borne out: indefinites can “escape” scope islands but still take a narrow scope with respect to some operator outside of the island (see e.g. Abusch 1993; Kratzer 1998). Consider, for instance, the example in (225). The sentence in (225) is true under a scenario where there was one specific student for each teacher about whom they heard the rumor. Crucially, neither the wide scope reading of (225) nor its narrow scope reading are true under this scenario.

[118] In addition to *a*-NPs, Fodor & Sag (1982) discuss indefinites with *some*, *many,* and *several* and bare numerals like *two dogs*. However, their argumentation is centered around *a*-indefinites.

[119] This should be understood cumulatively: in general, there are two readings available for indefinites, a quantificational one and a referential one.

Namely, it is not the case that there is one specific student of all teachers who is rumored to have been called before the dean, and it is also not the case that the teachers do not know which exact students of theirs had been called before the dean. The only reading of (225) that is compatible with the provided scenario is the one where the indefinite "escapes" the complex NP island but is interpreted within the scope of the universal quantifier *every teacher*.

(225) *Every teacher overheard the rumor that a student of his had been called before the dean.*

(Kratzer 1998: 166)

Another example of the intermediate scope uses of indefinites is provided in (226). This sentence is true under a scenario in which each professor recommended several books to their students but rewarded only those who read one particular book among those recommended, and different professors recommended different books and selected different books for the reward. Again, both the wide scope reading (there was a recommended book such that every professor rewarded every student who read it) and the narrow scope reading (each professor is such that he rewarded each student who read any book he recommended) are false under this scenario, and only the intermediate scope reading, where *a book he had recommended* escapes the relative clause but is interpreted within the scope of *every professor*, is true under it.

(226) *Every professor rewarded every student who read a book he had recommended.*

(Abusch 1993: 90)

The presence of the intermediate scope readings was thus a signal that a simple referential analysis would not cover all the cases where indefinites "take exceptional scope", and alternative analyses have been proposed.

One of the most influential families of such analyses is the choice-function-based approach (Reinhart 1997; Winter 1997, 2002; Kratzer 1998, 2003; Matthewson 1998; Chierchia 2001; Dekker 2004; Schlenker 2006; Mirazzi 2024, a.o.)[120]. According to this approach, indefinites have a special reading which is derived through application of a choice function[121] to the predicate of the NP. This choice function takes the predicate of the NP and returns a unique individual satisfying that predicate. Consider an example in (227). Here, the choice function f takes the extension of the predicate *dog*', that is, the set of dogs, and returns a particular dog individual d_1.

(227) $[\![f_1 \text{ dog}]\!] = f_1\ (\lambda x.\ \text{dog}(x)) = d_1$, where f_1 is a choice function and d_1 is a dog individual that f_1 selects from the set of dogs.

Depending on a particular analysis, the choice function argument of the indefinite either is bound by existential closure (Reinhart 1997; Winter 1997) or receives its value from the context (Kratzer 1998; Matthewson 1998). The first group of approaches derive the intermediate scope readings of indefinites via allowing the existential closure at the corresponding position within the LF. For instance, the desired reading of (226) is derived the following way: the choice-function argument of the indefinite *a book he had recommended* remains unsatisfied until the whole relative clause is interpreted, and then gets existentially closed before composing with the universal quantifier *every professor*; the resulting existential quantification over the function is interpreted within the scope of the quantifier, but outside of the scope of the relative clause restrictor, as desired.

[120] For the criticism of the classic choice-function approaches, see e.g. Geurts 2000, Brasoveanu & Farkas 2011, Onea 2015.

[121] A choice function is a partial function that applies to a set and returns a member of this set. In our case, this set is the extension of the indefinite's restrictor.

The second type of approach derives such readings through providing an optional individual-type argument for the choice function that can be bound by an operator higher in the tree (this type of parametrization is called *skolemization* (Kratzer 1998, in linguistics). Under this analysis, the intermediate readings are derived via binding the individual-type argument of the choice function. For instance, the desired interpretation of (226) is derived the following way: the context provides a Skolemized choice function for the indefinite *a book that he recommended*, and this function gets bound by the universal quantifier *every professor*; as a result, it returns a particular recommended book for each professor, as desired.

Another influential family of approaches to "exceptional scope" uses of indefinites is based on the idea of covert domain restriction (Schwarzschild 2002; Breheny 2003; Royer 2022). According to these approaches, indefinites are uniformly existential quantifiers, but they can covertly restrict their domain to a singleton, which can, in certain cases, create the illusion that they take exceptional scope, because the domain does not include the other satisfiers of the NP's predicate. For instance, according to Schwarzschild and his followers, the exceptional scope reading in (228) is available because the domain can be restricted to one specific friend of the speaker and does not include any other Texan friends of theirs. Because of that, the conditional is understood as "tied" to this particular friend of the speaker and not as a claim about his Texan friends in general.

(228) *If **a friend of mine** from Texas had died in the fire, I would have inherited a fortune.*

Note that if the exceptional scope readings are indeed derived via covert domain restriction, then one must assume that sometimes, the exact way the domain of the indefinite was restricted may not be known or even recoverable by the addressee[122], as (228) is felicitous even if the addressee has no clue who exactly this friend of the speaker is. In other words, in cases like in (228), the domain restriction is not only covert, but also *private*. This crucially differs from cases that we discussed before, like in (229), where the domain restriction of the quantifier *all* is covert, but recoverable for the addressee — in this case, via accommodation of an appropriate QUD: it is clear from the asked question that the restrictor of *all* only includes the eggs that John found, not all the eggs the two kids found together.

(229) Context. Two kids John and Bill found some Easter eggs. Bill's mom asks John's mom:

a. *What did John do with the eggs he found?*

b. *He immediately ate* ***all*** *the eggs.* (adapted from Schwarz 2009: 90)

Schwarzschild (2002) acknowledges this assumption, which he implements in his account as the Privacy Principle, stated as in (230):

(230) **Privacy Principle** (Schwarzschild 2002: 307)

[122] In fact, assuming that the domain restriction-based analysis is the right way to derive exceptional scope readings of indefinites, sometimes the exact principle of how the domain is restricted may not even be known by the speaker. Kai von Fintel (1999) provides interesting examples of that sort; consider, for instance, (i). By uttering this sentence, the speaker explicitly acknowledges that they do not know the identity of the relative; however, the exceptional scope reading is still available.

(i) *If a relative of mine dies, then I will inherit a house. But I don't know who that is.*
(von Fintel 2000: 3)

As von Fintel (1999) argues, for the domain restriction to be available, it might just be enough to know that *there is* a way to restrict the domain to a singleton; knowing what this way is exactly is not necessary.

It is possible for a felicitous utterance to contain an implicitly restricted quantifier even though members of the audience are incapable of delimiting the extension of the implicit restriction without somehow making reference to the utterance itself.

According to Schwarzschild, the Privacy Principle is not limited to existential quantifiers: other expressions, too, can privately restrict their domain. Consider, for instance, the sentences in (231). The sentence in (231a) entails that the price of the meant book is higher than the price of the other books in a certain domain; however, at least the addressee does not know exactly how the domain of books is restricted. Analogously, the sentence in (231b) entails that within a certain domain of people, the number of women having colon cancer will be less than the number of men suffering from the same disease, but the addressee may have no clue how exactly this domain is restricted.

(231) a. *This book is expensive.*

b. *The American Cancer society predicted that in the next decade fewer women would have colon cancer than men.*

(Schwarzschild 2002: 309-310)

Interestingly, while Schwarzschild assumes that the Privacy Principle is universal, further research suggests that this might not be the case. In particular, there is evidence suggesting that non-indefinite quantifiers cannot privately restrict their domain (von Fintel 1994, 1999, 2000; Pupa 2015). Consider, for instance, (232). The claim this sentence conveys can only be understood as being about all the people in the local context; the domain of people that are having a good time cannot be arbitrarily narrowed down. Had the quantifier *every* obeyed the Privacy Principle, the second reading would have been available.

(232) *Everyone is having a good time.*

1. ‘Everyone in the contextually salient domain C is having a good time.’
2. # ‘There is a domain C such that everyone in C is having a good time.’

(von Fintel 1999: 12)

If the ability of private domain restriction is indeed not a default option, but a specific property of exceptional scope indefinites, then it is very natural to assume that this is what distinguishes them from bare nominals as well.

To account for the intermediate scope readings of indefinites, Schwarzschild argues that the implicit domains of quantifiers can generally be bound by higher operators, providing independent evidence from other expressions that have implicit domains. Consider, for instance, an example in (233), where the contextual domain of the adjective *small* can be bound by the quantifier *most species*. Namely, in (233), the smallness of the meant individuals can be understood as relativized to the standards of their respective species.

(233) *Most species have members that are small.*

(Stanley 2000; Schwarzschild 2002: 309)

What unifies the two discussed approaches is that they derive the “specific” interpretation of the exceptional-scope indefinites via an implicit domain-restricting mechanism that leaves the indefinite with a unique satisfier within this domain[123]. This, in turn, guarantees the *informational*

[123] It should be noted here that, of course, not all approaches to the exceptional scope rely on a notion of domain restriction. Many of them explain facts in a quite different way. **Indexing-based approaches** (Abusch 1993, Farkas 1994, 1997, 2002a,b, Brasoveanu & Farkas 2011) argue that indefinites introduce variables that then can get assigned indices from different sources, including the ones outside of scope islands; **presuppositional approaches** (Cresti 1995, van Geenhoven 1998; Yeom 1998, Jäger 2007, Geurts 2010, Onea 2015, Sudo 2025) argue that indefinites get their “exceptional scope” readings via projection of an existence presupposition; **pied-piping based approaches** (Charlow 2014, 2020, 2025; Demirok 2019) argue that indefinites introduce an alternative set of individuals that can be “resolved” at different stages of the derivation, and “exceptional scope” readings arise when it happens after the

uniqueness of the indefinite's discourse referent[124] in its local context. This can take formally different forms, depending on whether the domain restriction restricts the local context where the indefinite is interpreted (in a way that the local context no longer includes other discourse referents satisfying the indefinite's predicate) or implicitly enriches its descriptive content (in a way that no other discourse referents in the context remain its satisfiers); in any case, what is important here is that an indefinite that undergoes such a domain restriction will always satisfy the Unambiguity Constraint.

Let me show this more explicitly. For concreteness and simplicity, let me represent the domain restriction of an indefinite as a contextually provided function *f* with a single satisfier that restricts (via coordination) the set of satisfiers of the NP's predicate to a singleton, as in (234). The set of witnesses of such an indefinite would thus be limited to a single individual; in this particular case, it would be some dog contextually "accessed" through the function f_n.

(234) $[\![\text{a } f_n \text{ dog}]\!] = \lambda P.\ \exists x\ [\text{dog}(x)\ \&\ f_n(x)\ \&\ P(x) = 1]$,

$\{x\text{: } f(x)\} = \{d\}$, where d is a dog individual

Importantly, the DP in (234) will always satisfy the Unambiguity Constraint: since the domain-restricted indefinite has a single satisfier, it is logically impossible for the context to have a given discourse referent mapping onto a satisfier different from the one the introduced discourse referent maps onto. Consider, for instance, the case in (235): let us assume that the first indefinite is

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interpretation of their scope island was computed; and, finally, **unrestricted QR-based approaches** (von Stechow 2000; Barker 2022a) basically argue that we may just give up on proposing the locality constraints on the quantifier (for more overview, see Ruys 2001; Ruys & Spector 2017; Ebert 2020; my own brief overview is partially based on the materials from Yasutada Sudo's class on exceptional scope indefinites (Sudo 2024)). Further work is required to see if my analysis is compatible with these alternative frameworks.

[124] I assume here, for the sake of simplicity, that "exceptional scope" indefinites introduce discourse referents the same way as their "island-obeying" counterparts. Further research is needed to see how costly this assumption is.

restricted via the function f_m and the second one is restricted via the function f_n. The two functions can have the same extension or different ones. In both cases, however, the use of the second NP will obey the Unambiguity Constraint. If f_m and f_n have the same extension, then the two indefinites have the same unique satisfier: in this case, the UC is trivially satisfied as the second indefinite is used to introduce the discourse referent *i* mapping onto the same individual as the first one, *j*: g(i) = g(j). If f_m and f_n have different extensions, then the two indefinites have different descriptive content, and the use of the second indefinite *a dog* obeys the UC as the previously introduced discourse referent mapping onto a dog does not satisfy its restrictor.

(235) *A* $\boldsymbol{f_m}$ *dog is barking and a* $\boldsymbol{f_n}$ *dog is growling.*

Alternatively, as I have said already, the domain restriction can take a form of implicit restriction of the local context in which the indefinite is evaluated; in the case like (235), the local context for the second NP *a dog* can be implicitly restricted in such a way that the discourse referent introduced by the first NP *a dog* is not accessible in it. In this case, the use of the second indefinite trivially obeys the UC: no discourse referents representing other dog individuals are available in such a context, so the second indefinite *a dog* can freely be used to introduce a novel discourse referent or pick out a given one[125].

Thus, as I have argued in this section, indefinites like English *a*-NPs or *some*-NPs, or bare NPs in Dholuo and Kaingang, that can occur in anti-unique sequences, are not necessarily challenging for

[125] This accounts for partitive-specific uses of exceptional scope indefinites, like in (i), where the indefinite *a book* is used to pick out one of the given books. I do not insist on analyzing such cases as instances of retrieving an old discourse referent, however, as this is orthogonal to my goal here.

(i) *There were several books lying around. I picked up a book and started reading.*
(Dayal 2004: 410)

the UC-based approach to the distribution of nominals. Namely, there is independent evidence that such indefinites can covertly restrict their domain to a single specific satisfier. This evidence comes from the data on scope islands: all the mentioned indefinites can get “exceptional scope” readings, and most approaches propose a certain type of domain restriction mechanism to explain that without proposing an actual LF movement. While a more accurate, detailed and formalized explanation is definitely required, it seems natural to assume that the very same mechanism that allows such indefinites to restrict their domain to a singleton also ensures their informational uniqueness, either via covertly enriching the content of the indefinite or narrowing down the local context in a way that no (other) given discourse referents are available as potential satisfiers of this indefinite.

Now, before finishing up this section, let me briefly outline two important issues this account faces; one of them is not specific to our goal and concerns the domain-restricting approaches more generally, but the other one directly targets the UC-based approach.

The local issue in question is that, according to the intuition of the native speakers I asked, there is no feeling of the covert domain restriction in examples like in (236a): that is, they do not find such sentences synonymous to their counterparts like in (236b), where the adjective *certain* explicitly signals that the speaker has particular dogs in mind.

(236) a. *A dog is barking and a dog is growling.*

b. *A certain dog is barking and a certain dog is growling*.

Of course, if the mentioned intuition is right in its ultimate form (there is no sense of covert domain restriction whatsoever in cases like in (236a)), that would completely undermine the domain restriction-based explanation for the “UC-violating” behavior of (at least) *a*-indefinites. There is some hope, however, that this might not be the case. Namely, the issue with this challenge is that it is not quite clear how exactly the *presence* of covert domain restriction would be perceived. In particular, the fact that (236a) does not have the same meaning as (236b) does not tell us that indefinites in examples such as (236a) do not feature any domain restriction whatsoever: what might be the case instead is that the denotation of *certain* poses stricter requirements on the salience, at-issueness or epistemic status of the domain restriction, making it more "noticeable" by the addressee. If this is what actually sets the standard for the sense of the covert domain restriction, then this sense might be too strict: it could very well be that *a*-indefinites in (236a) also feature domain restriction, which simply does not have the requirements posed by *certain*.

The other issue, challenging restriction-based approaches more generally, is that allowing indefinites to freely restrict their domain to a singleton results in overprediction: in many cases, there are readings predicted that are not available. Consider, for instance, examples in (237)[126]. The sentence in (237a) is false in the provided scenario. This is challenging for the free domain restriction approach, according to which (237a) should have a reading like in (237b), as the domain of the second indefinite can get restricted in a way that excludes the made hamburger. Analogously, the free domain restriction approach wrongly predicts that (237c) does not sound odd, as the second indefinite could get its domain restricted in a way that excludes the chased squirrel, deriving a reading like in (237d); in reality, this is not available, and (237c) is infelicitous: it is always a possibility that the restrictor of the negative quantifier includes dogs that chased and killed the same squirrel, so the presupposition of the verb *regret* is not satisfied.

(237) Scenario. Frank ate a hamburger that he made.

[126] I am very grateful to Alexander Williams for providing me with these examples and outlining the corresponding challenges.

a. *No man who made a hamburger ate a hamburger.*

b. *No man who made a hamburger ate a different hamburger.*

c. *No dog who has both chased a squirrel and killed a squirrel regrets killing something it didn't catch.*

d. *No dog who has both chased a squirrel and killed a squirrel regrets killing something it didn't catch.*

As this is an issue of overprediction, a solution, if any is possible, would be to propose principles that would limit the distribution of the domain restriction. If these principles will not rule out the ability to restrict the domain of (at least the second of) two indefinites in anti-unique sequences, the covert domain restriction will still account for the ability of such indefinites to "escape" the Unambiguity Constraint.

Thus, in this section, I proposed another way of accounting for the ability of certain indefinites to freely form anti-unique sequences within the UC-based approach. Namely, I argued that such indefinites satisfy the informational uniqueness requirement by undergoing a covert domain restriction to a singleton. This explanation is independently motivated by an observation that all indefinites capable of forming anti-unique sequences can also "escape" islands and exceptional scope readings are derived in some theories through covert domain restriction. I also outlined several issues that must be addressed for this account to be fully adopted: i) the native speakers do not immediately sense any presence of covert domain restriction of indefinites in anti-unique sequences; ii) if a covert domain restriction is available freely, it overpredicts.

In this section, I have shown that indefinites that can form anti-unique sequences are all able to "escape" islands; I am not aware of any counterexamples of this claim, although it would be extremely interesting to meet them sometime. At the same time, a question arises that is not important for the validity of the UC-based approach[127] but is typologically interesting: is the opposite true? Are all indefinites that can *not* form anti-unique sequences also indefinites that cannot escape islands?

In the next section, I will show that this generalization has a chance of being true, although there are some challenging data that need to be properly addressed.

3. Islands and "UC-obeying" indefinites

In the previous section, I showed that all the indefinites that can form anti-unique sequences (thus seemingly violating the Unambiguity Constraint) share the same property: they also allow "exceptional scope" readings. According to the two influential approaches to such readings, the choice-function approach and the covert domain restriction approach, they emerge due to the covert restriction of the NP's restrictor's extension to a singleton (either via narrowing down the domain itself or via enriching the content of the indefinite's restrictor). I argued that this very covert domain restriction allows such indefinites to satisfy the UC, as in such cases their extension ends up limited to a unique satisfier.

However, if it is this covert domain restriction that allows some indefinites to "escape" the Unambiguity Constraint, then the expectation is that, all things being equal, indefinites that cannot

[127] What I mean here is that it is not a direct problem for the Unambiguity Constraint if there are indefinites that *can* escape islands, but nevertheless can *not* form anti-unique sequences. Namely, such cases would be instances where the UC overpredicts, and it is always possible to assume that there are additional factors restricting the ability of indefinites to manipulate their domain restriction. Instead, the real problem for the UC would be if there are indefinites that can *not* "escape" islands but *can* form anti-unique sequences (and there is no evidence that in such cases, there is some other type of covert domain restriction going on), as this would be a case of overprediction.

"disobey" this principle do not have the ability to covertly restrict their domain and thus should not feature "exceptional scope" readings; while the opposite would not necessarily directly challenge the UC (as I mentioned earlier), that would make things easier for the general understanding of how the domain restriction of indefinites works.

We already know, from Chapter 2, that the data from Russian bare NPs match this expectation: they do not "disobey" the Unambiguity Constraint and cannot escape islands, recall, for instance, the data from *if*-conditionals:

(238)	*Jesli*	*ko*	*mne*	*zajdët*	*medsestra,*	*ja*	*budu*	*sil'no*	*stesn'at's'a.*
	if	to	me	enters	nurse	I	will	strongly	be.shy

1. 'If any nurse visits me, I will be very shy of her.'
2. # 'There is a specific nurse such that if she visits me, I will be very shy of her.'

In this section, I will discuss whether the data from bare NPs in the five languages we discussed in Section 1 — Kazym Khanty, Hindi, Xhosa, Cuzco Quechua and Cabo-Verdean Creole — match this expectation as well. I will conclude that, while there are certain challenges from Kazym Khanty and (especially) Xhosa, the hypothesis that all indefinites that cannot "disobey" the UC also cannot "escape" islands still can be true.

I will start with discussing the scopal properties of Hindi bare NPs in Section 3.1, where I will show that, judging by some preliminary data from conditionals, they cannot get "exceptional scope" readings. After that, I will discuss the data from Cuzco Quechua (Section 3.2) and Cabo-Verdean Creole (Section 3.3). To figure out whether bare NPs in these languages (and also in Xhosa, which we will discuss later) feature wide scope and intermediate scope "exceptional" readings, Dayal and her colleagues tested their scopal behavior in sentences like the English one in (239).

(239) *Every student read each article on a current topic.*

According to Dayal (2026), the indefinite *a current topic* in (239) is within a complex NP scope island, so the fact that in addition to the narrow-scope reading ('every student is such that they read all articles on all current topics'), this sentence has wide scope ('there is a current topic such that every student read all the articles on it') and intermediate scope ('for each student, there is a (potentially different) current topic such that they read all the articles on it') readings shows that *a*-indefinites can escape islands. Assuming, as a reasonable null hypothesis, that complex NPs are universally scope islands, Dayal and colleagues (2026) tested the behavior of the bare NPs in Cuzco Quechua and Cape Verdean creole and found that, in contrast to *a*-indefinites, they cannot get "exceptional scope" readings; I will discuss this, as well as the other scopal properties of bare nominals in these languages, in the corresponding sections.

After this, I will turn to the challenging data from Kazym Khanty (Section 3.4) and Xhosa (Section 3.5). According to recent studies, bare NPs in these languages allow "exceptional scope" readings; namely, bare NPs in Kazym Khanty are reported to "scope" out of conditionals (Tiutiunnikova 2025), while their Xhosa counterparts are reported to "scope" out of some complex NPs. I will critically review the findings, arguing that the proposed arguments do not fully rule out the possibility that bare NPs in the two languages do not, after all, have "exceptional scope" readings, and so the proposed typological generalization might still be true.

And after that, I will conclude in Section 3.6, summarizing the reported findings.

3.1. Scopal properties of bare NPs in Hindi

As far as I know, there is no conclusive evidence suggesting that bare NPs in Hindi feature scope ambiguity with at least some semantic operators. Dayal (2004) provides some data where, according to her, bare NPs take obligatory narrow scope or are interpreted as definites, but in all such cases, the context is not controlled enough to disambiguate the claimed readings with alternative ones. Hooda & Moroney (2026) discuss the data in (240) as cases of scope ambiguity, but no scenarios are provided that would distinguish the readings. The example in (240a) is provided to illustrate that the bare NP *laṛkī* 'girl' can take wide and narrow scope with respect to negation, as the two readings suggest. The problem, however, is that the provided paraphrases of these readings are not incompatible with each other: for instance, both are true under a scenario where there is a single girl that is not standing. Hooda and Moroney do not provide any information about the contexts in which (240a) is felicitous, so it is not clear whether this sentence is actually ambiguous and if not, what scope the bare NP actually takes. The example in (240b), used to illustrate that the bare NP *apnī gāṛī kā pahiyā* 'tire of his car' can take wide and narrow scope with respect to negation, has a similar issue: the two readings are not incompatible (for instance, both of them are true if there is just one tire of the car), so disambiguating scenarios should be provided to show that the bare NP in (240b) actually can take different scope.

(240) a. *laṛkī nahi khāṛī / laṛkī khāṛī nahi hai.*

girl.SG NEG stand.F girl.SG stand.F NEG AUX

1. 'A girl is not standing.'

2. 'No girl is standing.'

b. *Rām ne apnī gāṛī kā pahiyā nahi*

Ram ERG POSS.1 car GEN.SG wheel.SG NEG

1.'Ram did not see any tire of his car.'

2. 'Ram did not see the tire of his car.'

(Hooda & Moroney 2026: 4)

At the same time, there are preliminary data showing that bare NPs in Hindi do not feature "exceptional scope" readings. First, consider the conditional sentence in (241): according to the four native speakers of Hindi I asked, it can only be understood as a claim about tigers in general, but not about a specific tiger[128]. If these judgements are confirmed in further research, this suggests that bare NPs in Hindi, at least bare singulars, obey conditional islands, just like their Russian counterparts and in contrast to bare NPs in Kaingang and Dholuo.

(241) *yaha sher aa jaye to hum-kodar hogaa*

here tiger comes ASP then us-DAT fear be-FUT

1. 'If any tiger comes here, we will get frightened.'

2. # 'If a (specific) tiger comes here, we will get frightened.'

While clearly more research is needed to confirm that bare NPs in Hindi obey scope islands, there are some data from conditionals discussed in the previous literature that are at least compatible with this preliminary hypothesis. Consider, for instance, an example in (242) from Dayal 2017b, where a bare NP cannot get a specific indefinite reading within a conditional. As Dayal argues, (242) is only felicitous in a context where there is a unique salient relative of the speaker: (242) cannot felicitously be used to talk about a specific relative of the speaker if the speaker has more

[128] I am very grateful to Mal Shah for providing me with this example, which I have further tested with three other native speakers of Hindi.

than one relative and none of them is more salient than the others. While it is not clear whether a non-specific indefinite reading is available in (242)[129], combined with the data we saw just before, this example weakly supports the hypothesis that bare NPs in Hindi cannot get “exceptional scope” readings.

(242) *agar mere rishtedaar ki maut ho jaaye,*

if my relative of death happen

to mujhe bahut paisaa milegaa.

then I.DAT lot money get.FUT

1. ‘If my relative dies, I will inherit a fortune.’

2. ‘If a relative of mine dies, I will inherit a fortune.’

(Dayal 2017b: 89)

Another example with a bare NP within a conditional, discussed in Hooda & Moroney (2026), also is in line with the hypothesis, as it represents a clear case of narrow-scope reading; we already discussed it in Section 1, but it is repeated in (243). Here, the bare NP *fon* ‘phone call’ is clearly interpreted within the scope of the conditional, as follows from the context: none of the speakers is sure that there is a phone in the first place, so they certainly cannot expect a specific call to come to this hypothetical phone; what the sentence in (243) means instead is that if they hear any sort of phone call, then there is definitely a phone in the background of their call.

(243) Context. The speaker A asks about the noise in the background of their call.

[129] While Dayal (2017a) claims that the bare NP in (242) can only have a definite reading, she acknowledges that the definiteness of the used bare NP might be due to the possessive *mere* ‘my’. Indeed, possessives in some languages are known to cause uniqueness effects, see e.g. (Jackendoff 1977; Woisetschlaeger 1983; Giorgi & Longobardi 1991; Barker 1995; Longobardi 1996).

A: That must be a phone.

B: There is something…

B: … *vo* *to* *patā* *lag* *jātā* *hai,*

that PART information find go.PFV AUX.PRS

fon *ātā* *hai* *to* *khair.*

phone comes.PRS AUX then well

'[There is something] that you can tell: if a phone call comes, then anyways.'

Thus, while more research is needed for confirmation, there are already preliminary data suggesting that bare NPs in Hindi, just like their Russian counterparts, obey scope islands, which goes in line with the typological hypothesis proposed in Section 2: indefinites that obey the Unambiguity Constraint cannot get "exceptional scope" reading, as they do not have an option of covert domain restriction to a singleton.

3.2. Scopal properties of bare NPs in Cuzco Quechua

As I have already mentioned in Section 1, scopal properties of bare NPs in Cuzco Quechua have been thoroughly investigated in the recent work by Lilina Sánchez, Janett Vengoa de Orós and Veneta Dayal (2026); their findings suggest that bare NPs in this language have variable scope in some cases[130], but cannot scope out of what is likely scope islands.

[130] The data involving scope interaction with negation are quite complicated. According to Sánchez, Vengoa and Dayal (2026), Cuzco Quechua bare NPs cannot get wide scope with respect to negation unless used as definites; I will abstract from this in this paper, as bare nomials still can clearly take variable scope with respect to the attitude predicates, like in (244).

The ability of bare NPs to take different scope is argued for by the example in (244), where the bare NP *warmi* 'woman' can be interpreted either within or outside of the scope of the verb *muna* 'want'. The presence of the two readings is evident from the felicity of the two potential disambiguating continuations in (244b) and (244c). We already discussed (244b), enforcing the narrow scope reading: had (244a) only been able to convey 'there is a specific woman Pawlu wants to meet', (244b) would be an unnatural continuation, as it denies the presence of a specific candidate; thus, (244a) must have the reading 'Pawlu wants to meet any woman', where the bare NP is interpreted within the scope of the attitude predicate.

In contrast, the continuation in (244c) enforces the wide scope reading: had (244a) only been able to convey that Pawlu wants to meet any woman, (244c) would be an unnatural follow-up, as it presupposes that there is a specific woman Pawlu desires to meet; since (244c) is nevertheless a felicitous continuation, (244a) must have the reading 'there is a specific woman Pawlu wants to marry', where the bare NP scopes out of the complement of the attitude verb.

(244) a. *Pawlu* *warmi-ta* *riqsi-y-ta* *muna-n*
P. woman-ACC meet-INF-ACC want-3.S
'Pawlu wants to meet a woman.'

b. *Mayqin-ta-pas*
which-ACC-PL
'Anyone.'

c. *ichaqa mana-n* *mayqin* *ka-sqa-n-ta-pas* *ni-yki-man-chu*
but NEG-FOC/EVID.ATT which be-NOM-3.S-ACC-PL say-1.2-DAT-FOC
'But I can't say who it is.'

(Sánchez et al. 2026: 275-276)

At the same time, bare NPs in Cuzco Quechua cannot escape islands, as shown in (245). The sentence in (245) is felicitous only in Context 3, the only one compatible with the narrow scope reading: if Paula, Anna and Juan each read all the articles, it is indeed the case that each student is such that they read all articles that are articles on a(ny) current topic.

It cannot be uttered in Context 1, where the wide scope reading is enforced: if Paulo, Anna and Juan read all the articles on I-Bill, it is only true that 'there is a current topic such that all the students read all the papers on it'; it is neither true that 'for each student, there is a current topic such that they read all the papers on it' (intermediate scope reading) nor true that 'each student is such that they read all articles that are articles on a(ny) current topic' (narrow scope reading).

It also cannot be uttered in Context 2, where the intermediate scope reading is enforced: if Paulo, Anna and Juan each chose their own topic to read all the articles on it, then it is only true that 'for each student, there is a current topic such that they read all the papers on it' (intermediate scope reading); it is neither true that 'there is a current topic such that all the students read all the papers on it' (wide scope) nor is it true that 'each student is such that they read all articles that are articles on a(ny) current topic' (narrow scope reading).

(245) *Common context*. There are three current topics: COVID, Infrastructure Bill, Georgia Election Law. There are three articles on COVID, five on the I-Bill, and two on the Georgia Law.

#**Context 1.** Paulo, Anna and Juan read all the articles on I-Bill.

#**Context 2.** Paulo read all the COVID articles, Anna all the articles on I-Bill, and Juan read all the articles on Georgia Law.

ok **Context 3.** Paulo, Anna and Juan each read all the 10 articles.

Sapanka	*yachaq-kuna-n kunan*		*yachay-manta*
every	student-PL-3.S	actual	topic-ABL
tukuy	*qilqa-sqa-kuna-ta*	*ñawincha-rqa-nku*	
all	article-PL-ACC	read-PST.ATT-3PL	

'Every student read all articles on a current topic.'

(Sánchez 2026: 279-281)

Thus, assuming that the bare NP *kunan yachay* 'actual topic' is within a scope island in (245), the data provided in this section suggest that bare NPs in Cuzco Quechua may have a variable scope, but cannot "escape" islands, preliminarily supporting the hypothesis that indefinites that cannot form anti-unique sequences also do not allow "exceptional scope" readings.

3.3. Scopal properties of bare NPs in Cabo-Verdean Creole

As I have already mentioned in Section 1, scopal properties of bare NPs in Cabo-Verdean creole have been thoroughly discussed in the recent work by Marlyse Baptista and Veneeta Dayal (2026). As I will show in this section, their findings suggest that bare NPs in this language cannot scope out of the place of their origination and, in particular, cannot escape islands, in line with the proposed hypothesis that bare NPs that obey the UC cannot get exceptional scope readings.

Baptista and Dayal (2026) discuss several cases where bare NPs do not feature variable scope, but the most telling is the one in (246), where the bare nominal *ator di sinema* 'movie actor' cannot take wide scope with respect to the attitude predicate *kre* 'want'. This is evident from the fact that the continuation in (246c), enforcing the wide scope reading, is infelicitous: it would have been compatible with (246a) if the latter had a reading like 'there is a movie actor that Paulo wants to meet'. Instead, only the continuation in (246b), enforcing the narrow scope reading, is possible, which suggests that the bare NP *ator di sinema* 'movie actor' can only be interpreted within the scope of the attitude predicate.

(246) a.

Paulo	*kre*	*nkontra*	*ator*	*di*	*sinema*.
P.	want	meet	actor	of	movie

'Paulo wants to meet a movie actor.'

b.

Pokuta	*inporta-l kenhi ki el é.*	
little	ASP	matter-him

'He does not care which one.'

c.

#*...ma*	*N*	*ka*	*pode*	*fra-bu*	*kenhi*	*ki*	*el*	*é.*
but	I	NEG	can	tell-you	who	that	he	is

'…but I don't know who he is.'

(Baptista & Dayal 2026: 194-195)

Unsurprisingly, bare NPs in Cabo-Verdean Creole cannot get exceptional scope readings either, consider an example in (247), where the bare NP occurs within a supposedly complex NP island. The sentence in (247) is only felicitous in Context 3, the only one compatible with the narrow scope reading: 'each student is such that they read all articles on all current topics'. It is not felicitous in either Context 1, which enforces the wide scope reading ('there is a current topic such that each student read all articles on it') or Context 2, which enforces the intermediate scope reading (‘for each student, there is a current topic such that they read all the articles on it’), which suggests that the bare NP *asuntu koridu* ‘current topic’ cannot escape the complex NP island. As Baptista and Dayal (2026) mention, the numeral *un* ‘one’ needs to be added to get the wide scope and the intermediate scope readings.

(247) *Common context*. There are three students and three current topics, and 9 articles on them (3 articles on topic A, 4 articles on topic B, and 2 articles on topic C).

#**Context 1.** All the students read articles on topic B.

#**Context 2.** Each student selected their own topic and read all the articles on it.

ok **Context 3.** All the students read all the articles on all the topics.

Kada	*studanti*	*ta*	*ler*	*kada*	*artigu*	*sobri*	*asuntu*	*koridu*.
every	student	ASP	read	every	article	about	topic	current

‘Every student read every article on a current topic.’

(Baptista & Dayal 2026: 199-202)

Thus, although more research needs to be done to confirm the generalizations, the data discussed by Baptista & Dayal (2026) also support the hypothesis that cross-linguistically, indefinites that obey the Unambiguity Constraint also cannot get exceptional scope readings.

3.4. Scopal properties of bare NPs in Kazym Khanty

The scopal properties of bare NPs in Kazym Khanty were thoroughly investigated recently by Varvara Tiuitiunnikova, Stepan Mikhailov and me (Tiutiunnikova 2024, 2025, Golosov 2024b; Tiutiunnikova et al. 2025, Golosov et al. 2026), and the conclusion was made that they feature variable scope. Tiutiunnikova (2025) further argued that bare NPs in Kazym Khanty can even get exceptional scope readings. In this section, I will critically review these generalizations. Namely, I will argue that while there is indeed some evidence suggesting that at least some bare NPs in Kazym Khanty feature variable scope, it is not clear whether they indeed can "escape" islands, as suggested by Tiutiunnikova.

The clearest evidence that bare NPs in Kazym Khanty feature variable scope comes from their interaction with adverbial quantifiers. Consider, for instance, (248), where the bare NP can take wide and narrow scope with respect to the adverbial *kăt pʉš* 'two times'. This is shown by the availability of the two disambiguating continuations in (248). The first continuation enforces the wide scope reading: the bare NP can be an antecedent for the subsequent anaphora[131], which suggests that it does not covary with the adverbial and hence scopes out of it. In contrast, the second continuation enforces the narrow-scope reading, as it is the only one compatible with the scenario where two dogs barked at the yard.

(248) *kør_χărij-ən kăt pʉš amp χurt-əs.*

yard-LOC two times dog barked

'At the yard, a dog barked two times.'

Possible continuation 1: {It visits us every day, barks and asks for some food.}

Possible continuation 2: {It was a black dog first time and a white one second time.}

(Tiutiunnikova 2024: 32)

The variable scope of Kazym Khanty bare NPs is also evident from their interaction with negation, as shown in (249). In (249a), the bare NP *kinška* 'book' takes wide scope with respect to negation;

[131]The potential continuations in (248) were elicited as actual Khanty sentences; the English translation is provided just for simplicity.

this is evident from the fact that only the wide scope reading is compatible with the provided right context: since the speaker did buy two books from the store, it is not true that there are no books such that he bought them; in contrast, what is true is that there is a book — War and Peace — that the speaker did not buy, which is exactly the scenario compatible with the wide scope reading. In contrast, in (249b), the bare NPs *amp* 'dog' and *ńawrɛm* 'child' take narrow scope with respect to the negation. This follows from the point the speaker means by uttering (249b): there are no dogs or children in the street that produce any sort of noise; in particular, (249b) could be said in a context where there aren't any dogs or children outside. This scenario is incompatible with the wide-scope reading (there needs to be a dog and/or a child outside for it to be true) but is compatible with the narrow-scope one (indeed, there is no dog that is barking and there is no child that is screaming).

(249) a. Context. The speaker returns home from the bookshop sad.

Mom asks him: what happened?

ma	*kinška*	*ănt*	*λǝt-s-əm:*	*wajna*	*I mir*	*kinška*	*ăntǝm*	*wǝ-s.*
I	book	NEG	buy-PST-1SG	War&Peace		book	NEG.EX	be-PST[3SG]

tǝp	*evgenij onegin*	*pa*	*doctor živago*	*λǝt-s-əm*
only	Eugene Onegin	ADD	Doctor Zhivago	buy-PST-1SG

'I didn't buy a book: there were no "War and Peace". I only bought "Eugene Onegin" and Doctor Zhivago.'

(Tiutiunnikova 2024: 31)

b. {It is so quiet outside.}

amp	*ăn*	*χurət-λ,*	*ńawrɛm*	*ănt*	*sat΄-əλ.*

dog NEG bark-NPST[3SG] child NEG be.heard-NPST[3SG]

'A dog is not barking, a child is not screaming.' {No one is heard.}

(Tiutiunnikova 2025: 26)

Thus, as is shown by their interaction with adverbial quantifiers and negation, bare NPs in Kazym Khanty have variable scope. Tiutiunnikova (2025) further argues that they can get exceptional scope readings. Her argumentation is based on the data from conditionals, which, as she shows, are also scope islands in Kazym Khanty: consider (250), where the universal quantifier *kašən iki* 'every man' can only be interpreted within the scope of the conditional. The otherwise more pragmatically natural interpretation of (250), 'every man is such that if Masha marries him, he will be very happy', where the universal quantifier takes wide scope over the conditional, is unavailable; instead, consultants say that (250) is odd, as Masha cannot get married to every man[132].

(250) *mašaj-en kašəŋ iki-ja măn-λ ki,*

M.-POSS.2SG every man-DAT go-NPST[3SG] if

λʉw wɛra amət-λ.

he very rejoice-NPST[3SG]

'If Masha marries every man (lit. goes to a man), he will be very happy.'

(Tiutiunnikova 2025: 25)

Tiutiunnikova argues that bare NPs in Kazym Khanty can get "exceptional scope" with respect to conditionals and provides the examples in (251) and in (252) as evidence for the claim.

[132] Tiutiunnikova (2025) does not discuss this, but I assume that (250) is also at least pragmatically odd because of the issue with anaphora resolution: it is not clear how the pronoun *λʉw* '(s)he' receives its value in this case.

In (251), according to Tiutiunnikova, the bare NP *iki* ‘man’, descriptively speaking, takes wide scope with respect to the conditional. The argument here is based on the fact that the follow-up sentence suggests that Masha marries a specific man whose identity is known for the speaker: as Tiutiunnikova argues, this is only compatible with the “wide scope” reading, as otherwise the bare NP *iki* ‘man’ would have been interpreted non-specifically.

(251)	*mašaj-en*	*ikij-a*	*ki*	*măn-λ*	*wɛra*	*amət-λ.*
	M.-POSS.2SG	man-DAT	if	go-NPST[3SG]	very	rejoice-NPST[3SG]

‘If Masha marries a (certain) man, she will be very happy.’

śi	*iki*	*pet′aj-en.*
DEM	man	P.-POSS.2SG

‘This man is Petya.’

(Tiutiunnikova 2025: 25)

This is, of course, a reasonable conclusion, but not a necessary one. Alternatively, what could be the case is that the consultants accommodated a context in which it is known to both the speaker and the addressee that there is a specific guy that Masha wants to marry, and the bare NP *iki* ‘man’ is used to refer back to that guy (formally, to pick out an accommodated discourse referent mapping onto that guy). Crucially, in this case, (251) is compatible with an analysis where the bare NP *iki* ‘man’ remains within the scope of the conditional. Namely, if we make a natural assumption that Petya is the only male individual relevant for the point made in (251), the extension of the predicate of the bare NP *iki* is contextually restricted to this individual; in such a context, the narrow-scope reading of (251) is logically equivalent to the wide-scope one, which means that (251) is not necessarily a case where the bare NP takes “exceptional scope”.

Another sentence Tiutiunnikova (2025) treats as a case where Kazym Khanty bare NPs take exceptional scope is the one in (252), used as an illustration of an intermediate reading. According to Tiutiunnikova, the bare NP *ńawrɛm* ‘child’ in (252) “takes wide scope” with respect to the conditional but falls within the scope of the universal quantifier *kašən učitel* ‘every teacher’. Tiutiunnikova argues that this reading is forced by the right context, according to which there is a specific child for each teacher whose getting sick would make that teacher upset.

(252) *kašən učitel nums-əλ wɛtwam,*
every teacher mood-POSS.3SG bad
ńawrɛm ki mɵš-a ji-λ.
child if sick-DAT become-NPST[3SG]
‘Every teacher will get upset if a child will get sick.’
{Anna Ivanovna will get upset if Masha will get sick, Vasiliy Petrovich will get upset if Kolya will get sick.}

While the idea is very clear and reasonable, the right context in (252) is potentially not restrictive enough to exclude the narrow-scope reading of the first sentence. Namely, the fact that Anna Ivanovna will get upset if Masha will get sick does not entail that this teacher will not get upset if any other student will get sick[133]; the same is true about Vasiliy Petrovich. To truly contradict the narrow-scope reading of the first sentence in (252) and enforce the intermediate one, the right

[133] I assume here that this conditional sentence does get strengthened to further imply that *if not p, then not q* (in this case, ‘if Masha will not get sick, Anna Ivanovna will not get upset’). This type of strengthening, known as *conditional perfection* (after Geis & Zwicky 1971), is expected to arise only in a limited set of cases; in particular, Boukendour (2025a,b), building on the preceding research (Cornulier 1983; von Fintel 2001; Farr 2011; Nadathur 2013; Cariani & Rips 2023; Grusdt et al. 2023; Evcen et al. 2024, a.o.), argues that it happens only if the speaker is expected to provide the exhaustive list of answers to a condition-oriented QUD (*Exhaustivity Condition*) and is seen by the addressee as being an authority with respect to that kind of knowledge (*Epistemic Authority Condition*). The conditional sentence in question does not seem to a priori represent such a case, as it may likely be that the speaker does not have exhaustive knowledge of Anna Ivanovna’s attitudes to all the relevant children.

context should explicitly state that A.I. or V.P. will not get upset if some or any other child will get sick.

While, of course, further research on Kazym Khanty is needed to test whether the sentence in (252) can have an intermediate reading, there are preliminary data from Russian that confirm that explicit negation of the conditional may make a difference. Consider the contrast between the two continuations of the conditional sentence in (253). While there were mixed judgements on whether the first continuation is felicitous, all the consultants said that the second one is completely infelicitous as it leads to contradiction. Given that Russian bare NPs do not normally get "exceptional scope" readings, the contrast in (253) suggests that Right Context 1, analogous to the one in (252), does not necessarily enforce a contradiction with the narrow-scope reading[134].

(253)	*Každyj*	*student*	*obradujets'a,*	*jesli*	*s*	*nim*	*pogovorit*	*professor.*
	every	student	will.rejoice	if	with	him	will.talk	professor

'Every student will be happy if a professor will talk to him.'

ok/? **Right Context 1:** {Masha will be happy if von Fintel talks to her, Kostya will be happy if Kibrik talks to him.}

\# **Right Context 2:** {For instance, Vasya, who generally does not like talking to professors, will be happy if Daniel talks to him.}

Thus, the conclusion I make here is that the data Tiutiunnikova (2025) provides do not necessarily suggest that bare NPs in Kazym Khanty have "exceptional scope" readings. This, in turn, means

[134] At the same time, the fact that some consultants judged the first continuation as non-ideal or infelicitous might also be telling. Namely, it could be that those consultants who didn't like RC-1 interpreted the conditionals in it exhaustively, which, in turn, created a contradiction with the main conditional: 'every student will be happy if any professor talks to them; Masha will not be happy if any professor other than von Fintel talks to her…'. Further research is needed to test this hypothesis.

that it still could be true that all indefinites that cannot form anti-unique sequences do not feature "exceptional scope" readings. Recall, however, that even if further research shows that bare NPs in Kazym Khanty nevertheless do feature exceptional scope readings, this will not be a direct problem for the Unambiguity Constraint, as there could be independent reasons why such domain-restricting indefinites would not be able to form anti-unique sequences.

3.5. Scopal properties of bare NPs in Xhosa

As I have already mentioned in Section 1, scopal properties of Xhosa bare NPs have been thoroughly investigated in recent work by Vicky Carstens, Loyiso Mletshe and Veneta Dayal (Carstens et al. 2026), and the authors concluded that bare nominals in this language take variable scope and, crucially, can get exceptional scope readings within complex NP islands. In this section I will review their findings and argue that, unless the tested complex NP is not in fact a scope island in Xhosa, bare NPs in this language are an exception from the proposed typological generalization: they *can* "escape" islands but cannot "escape" the Unambiguity Constraint.

The authors discuss several cases where bare NPs in Xhosa feature variable scope; consider, for instance, the example in (254), where the bare NP *nenjineli* 'engineer' can take both narrow and wide scope with respect to the attitude predicate *funa* 'want'. This is evident from the fact that (254) is true in the two contexts that disambiguate each of the readings. The first context is only compatible with the narrow scope reading, as there are no actual engineers in the village. In contrast, the second context is only compatible with the wide scope reading, as it is not the case that meeting any engineer would satisfy Sindiswa's desire.

(254) Context 1. There are no engineers in the village. The speaker knows this, but Sindiswa does not.

Context 2. Sindiswa has expressed a desire to meet Sabelo, one of the engineers in the village, but she has no desire to meet engineers and does not know Sabelo is one.

U-Sindiswa	*u-funa*	*u-ku-hlang-ana*	*nenjineli*
AUG-1Sindiswa	1SM-want	AUG-15-meet-RECIP	PREP.9engineer

'Sindiswa wants to meet an engineer.'

(Carstens et al. 2026: 655)

More intriguingly, Carstens, Mletshe and Dayal (2026) discuss a case where, as they argue, a bare NP can, descriptively speaking, take a wide and intermediate scope out of a scope island — in this case, an alleged complex NP island. Consider the example in (255), with a bare nominal *kumsitho weOlympics* 'an event of Olympics'. This sentence is true in all the provided contexts. While it is not surprising that (255) is true at Context 3, as this one is compatible with a narrow scope reading ('each girl is such that she watched all competitions in all Olympic events'), this sentence is also true in Context 1 that enforces the wide scope reading ('there is an event such that all the girls watched all the competitions in it'), and in Context 2 that enforces the intermediate scope reading ('for each girl, there is a particular Olympic event such that she watched all the events in it').

(255) Context 1. All the girls watched all competitions in one particular activity.

Context 2. Each girl chose its own activity and watched all the competitions on it.

Context 3. All the girls watched all the Olympic events.

I-n-tombazana	*nga-nye*	*i-bukel-e*	*u-khuphiswan-o*
AUG-9-girl	NGA-NYE	9SM-watch-PST	AUG-compete-NOM

nga-lu-nye	*ku-m-sitho*	*we-Olympics.*
NGA-11-NYE	LOC-3-event	3of-Olympics

'Each girl watched each competition in an event of Olympics.'

(Carstens et al. 2026: 673)

The presence of the wide and the intermediate scope readings of (255) is challenging for the typological generalization we test in this section, that is, that all indefinites that cannot form anti-unique sequences also cannot escape islands: if the complex NP in (255) is indeed a scope island, then Xhosa bare NPs are indefinites that can *not* form anti-unique sequences but nevertheless *can* escape islands.

Is there a way to "save" the proposed generalization? I argue that there are two possible scenarios under which the data from bare NPs in Xhosa do not challenge it. First, it could be that the complex NP in (255) is not actually a scope island: while this assumption is reasonable as a null hypothesis, Carstens, Mletshe and Dayal (2026) do not discuss data parallel to (255) that would independently establish that other, non-existential quantifiers cannot scope out of the *nga…-ngye* construction. Moreover, there is an interesting piece of indirect evidence that the complex NP used in (255), headed by the universal quantifier *nga-...-ngye*, might not represent a case of an actual scope island. Namely, there is another universal quantifier in Xhosa, *-onke*, which does not allow bare NPs in its restrictor to "scope out" of it, as shown in (256), which is the same as (255) except that the universal quantifier is *-onke* instead of *nga-..ngye*. Crucially, the sentence in (256) is only true in Context 3, which means that the bare NP can only be interpreted within the complex NP it occurs in. Thus, the contrast between (255) and (256) suggests that the observed scope ambiguity in (255) might be "false positive" with respect to the exceptional scope test. Of course, to verify that, further research is needed: namely, it should be checked whether the *nga-..-nye* phrases are scope islands for other types of quantifiers or not.

(256) #Context 1. All the girls watched all competitions in one particular activity.

#Context 2. Each girl chose its own activity and watched all the competitions on it.

ok Context 3. All the girls watched all the Olympic events.

I-n-tombazana *nga-nye* *i-bukel-e* *u-khuphiswan-o*

AUG-9-girl NGA-NYE 9SM-watch-PST AUG-compete-NOM

l-onke *ku-m-sitho* *we-Olympics.*

11-every LOC-3-event 3of-Olympics

'Each girl watched each competition in an event of Olympics.'

(Carstens et al. 2026: 672)

Another, less likely scenario in which the proposed typological generalization is compatible with the data from Xhosa bare NPs is the one in which the data with an anti-unique sequence, discussed in Section 1, are "false negative". As we briefly discussed in Section 2, even indefinites that can form anti-unique sequences cannot do it completely freely; recall, for instance, the example in (257), which is, according to some of the native speakers of English I asked, somewhat odd (although not completely out) unless the adjective *other* is added:

(257) *A dog is barking and a?(n other) dog is growling.*

Given that for bare NPs in Xhosa, too, the addition of the word *other* to the second bare NP in an anti-unique sequence made the sentence felicitous (as we discussed in Section 1), examples analogous to (257) could be false negative, and it could be that in other cases, such as a Xhosa translation of the English sentence in (258), anti-unique sequences of bare NPs are in fact felicitous[135]. If that is the case, then Xhosa bare NPs join the other group of the indefinites, the ones that can "escape" the Unambiguity Constraint, and then their exceptional scope readings are no longer a problem, but an advantage of the theory.

(258) *A dog is barking and a dog is growling, but I don't know whether there was one dog or two.*

Note that the typological generalization will not hold if the two discussed scenarios are both true. In that case, bare NPs in Xhosa would be indefinites that *can* form anti-unique sequences but *can* not escape islands, and this would be a much bigger issue than the one we are discussing right now. Namely, so far, the only known and empirically confirmed ways to "escape" the UC are via covert domain restriction to a singleton or (potentially) via the novelty inference, and since bare NPs in Xhosa can be used anaphorically and, in this scenario, would not "escape" islands, the UC would make wrong predictions for the distribution of Xhosa bare NPs.

Thus, in this section, I showed that bare nominals in Xhosa might present a challenge for the proposed typological generalization, according to which all indefinites that cannot form anti-unique sequences also do not feature "exceptional scope" readings. Namely, if the assumptions made in Carstens, Mletshe and Dayal (2026) are correct, bare NPs in this language are indefinites that can *not* form anti-unique sequences but nevertheless *do* feature "exceptional scope" readings. For this to be the case, however, it must be confirmed that the tested complex NP is indeed an

[135] Of course, anti-unique sequences of the other "UC-obeying" indefinites discussed in this chapter should also be further checked in different contexts, as there is the same (quite low) chance that they are misdiagnosed. If it turns out that at least some of them can, after all, form anti-unique sequences where their instances are interpreted within the same local context that would, all things being equal, contradict the predictions the UC-based theory.

island and that the infelicity of the sentences with an anti-unique sequence is not "false negative"; otherwise, the data from Xhosa do not contradict the generalization.

3.6. Conclusions

The goal of this section was to check whether the following typological hypothesis is correct: all bare NPs that cannot form anti-unique sequences also do not allow "exceptional scope" readings. The idea behind this hypothesis is that, all things being equal, bare NPs that cannot form anti-unique sequences cannot covertly restrict their domain to a singleton and hence should not be able to "escape" islands as well. If this hypothesis ends up being wrong, it would not directly challenge the UC-based approach, but it would suggest that the ability of an indefinite to covertly restrict its domain does not always allow it to escape islands, and further research would be needed to figure out why and whether domain restriction matters at all.

We already knew that the data from Russian bare NPs support this hypothesis. The preliminary data from bare NPs in the five studied languages suggested that it is more complicated: while the data from Hindi, Cuzco Quechua and Cabo-Verdean Creole support, under certain assumptions, the proposed hypothesis, the data from Kazym Khanty and (especially) Xhosa are more challenging: there is some evidence that bare NPs in these languages do feature "exceptional scope" readings. However, I pointed out certain non-trivial assumptions under which the proposed evidence is considered; if these assumptions end up being wrong, then the hypothesis still has a chance of being true. Clearly, further research is needed here.

4. Conclusions

In this chapter, I argued that the Unambiguity Constraint, initially proposed to account for the limited distribution of indefinite uses of bare NPs in Russian, has a potential to be a cross-linguistically universal principle of reference resolution.

First, I showed that bare NPs in five other languages — Kazym Khanty, Hindi, Xhosa, Cuzco Quechua and Cabo-Verdean Creole — pattern with their Russian counterparts in that they cannot form anti-unique sequences, but can be used in clearly indefinite contexts, which is incompatible with the classic definiteness-based analysis (Dayal 2004), but is exactly what is expected if we analyze such bare NPs as indefinites subject to the informational uniqueness requirement — that is, if we adopt the UC-approach.

After that, I addressed the challenging data from *a*-indefinites and *some*-indefinites in English and bare NPs in Kaingang and Dholuo, which, in contrast to bare NPs in Russian, *can* form anti-unique sequences, seemingly violating the predictions of the UC-based approach. I argued, however, that this is not the case. Namely, such indefinites do not, in fact, violate the Unambiguity Constraint because they can covertly restrict the domain of their satisfiers to a singleton (thus passing the informational uniqueness requirement); the independent evidence that these indefinites can do such domain restriction comes from scope islands, where such indefinites can get "exceptional" readings, that is, create an illusion of escaping an island.

If it is the same domain restriction that allows indefinites to escape islands that allows them also to "escape" the UC, that is, form (superficially) anti-unique sequences, then, all things being equal, we would expect that indefinites that cannot do covert domain restriction can neither disobey the UC nor "escape" scope islands. The preliminary data from six languages (Russian, Kazym Khanty, Hindi, Xhosa, Cuzco Quechua and Cabo-Verdean Creole) suggest that this hypothesis may be true; however, the data from Xhosa and Kazym Khanty present some challenges that must be addressed.

Thus, the overall conclusion of this chapter is that the Unambiguity Constraint could indeed be a universal principle of reference resolution. More work is required, however, to confirm this hypothesis: more data from Hindi, Xhosa, Cuzco Quechua, Cabo-Verdean Creole and Kazym Khanty are needed to further test the predictions of the UC-based approach, and there are many other languages — and many other types of nominals — it has not even been applied yet. That is the plan for the future work.

Chapter 6. Conclusions

In this final chapter, I will draw conclusions of my dissertation (Section 1) and will discuss some challenges that my account still needs to address (Section 2), as well as perspectives for the future research (Section 3).

1. Results of this study

The goal of this dissertation was to account for the seemingly controversial behavior of Russian bare nominals in terms of their (in)definiteness, with a potential cross-linguistic extension of the analysis. Namely, the question that needed an answer was the following one: why can standalone bare NPs be used as classic indefinites (like in (259a), where the bare NP *sobaka* 'dog' behaves like a classic indefinite: it is used to talk about a *novel* discourse entity representing a *non-unique* dog individual), but whenever two identical bare NPs are interpreted in the same context, they are required to have the same witness (as shown by the contrast in (259b-260): the two bare NPs *sobaka* 'dog' can be used to talk about the same dog, as in (260), but not to talk about different dogs, as shown by the infelicity of (259b))?

(259) Scenario. There are two dogs in the street unknown to the speaker and the hearer, one of them is barking, the other one is sleeping.

a. *Na ulice lajet sobaka.*

on street dog barks

'In the street, a dog is barking.'

b. #*Na* *ulice* *lajet* *sobaka* *i* *ryčit* *sobaka.*

on street dog barks and growls dog

Expected: 'In the street, a dog is barking and a dog is growling.'

(260) {—How is your dog doing?}

Sobaka *zdorova,* *s* *sobakoj* *vsë* *xorošo.*

dog healthy with dog all good

'The dog is healthy, everything is ok with the dog.'

Previous approaches to bare nominals in Russian (and other articleless languages) go along one of the two routes: they either analyse them as semantically definite and then try to weaken the definiteness-based restrictions (familiarity and uniqueness presuppositions) to account for the data like in (259a) or analyze them as semantically indefinite, leaving the "definiteness effects" illustrated in (259b-260) unexplained. However, neither of the two types of approaches manages to account for the actual distribution of bare nominals in indefinite contexts: the first group of approaches are too restrictive (even with the proposed deviations from the classic analysis of definites, unless some additional assumptions are made), while the second group of approaches are, in contrast, too permissive.

I proposed an analysis that manages to balance between the two lines of approaches: bare nominals are semantically indefinite, but, in some sense, are pragmatically definite, although the latter is not their property specifically. Namely, I argued that bare nominals are semantically variable-scope island-sensitive existentials, but their indefinite uses are limited due to the general pragmatic principle of reference resolution, which I called the Unambiguity Constraint. This principle is a generalized version of the informational uniqueness constraint proposed by Roberts (2003) to account for the distribution of anaphoric definites. As such, the UC requires that the discourse referent activated by the use of a nominal should be the only one available in the context that meets this nominal's descriptive content; a simplified[136] formal version of this requirement is provided in (261).

(261) **The Unambiguity Constraint (Generalized Informational Uniqueness)**

In the context *c*, an NP that lexicalizes a predicate P can be used to pick out a discourse referent *i* iff there is no *j* distinct from *i* such that *j* is entailed by *c* to also satisfy P.

The proposed analysis does not rely on any costly assumptions, as it consists of the classic semantic analysis of indefinites as existential quantifiers and a generalized version of the informational uniqueness constraint, independently proposed to account for the anaphora resolution. At the same time, the UC-based approach straightforwardly accounts for the data in (259-260).

First, it correctly predicts that a bare nominal can freely be used to introduce a novel discourse referent if the context does not have any given ones representing other individuals that also meet the descriptive content of that nominal. This is exactly what happens in (259a), where the bare NP *sobaka* 'dog' is used to introduce a novel discourse referent representing a dog; while there are

[136] Recall that, strictly speaking, bare plurals in Russian are required to pick out or introduce informationally *maximal* discourse referents, not informationally unique ones, although they still can only introduce novel discourse referents if there are no given ones satisfying their descriptive content. To take this into account, I proposed a more nuanced version of the Unambiguity Constraint, repeated here in (i).

(i) **The Unambiguity Constraint (Generalized Informational Maximality)**
In the context *c*, an NP that lexicalizes a predicate P can be used to introduce a novel discourse referent *i* iff there are no other discourse referents that are entailed by *c* to also satisfy P;
in all the other cases, *i* must be the maximal given discourse referent entailed by *c* to satisfy P.

Simply put, (i) requires that a nominal should be used anaphorically and pick out the maximal given discourse referent if there are any present in the context and can only be used to introduce a novel discourse referent otherwise, as a "last resort".
For the sake of exposition, however, I normally provide the simplified version of the UC like in (261).

other dogs in the provided scenario, none of them has been mentioned in the prior context and represented as a discourse referent, so the UC is not violated.

Second, it accounts for the contrast in (259-260), correctly predicting that two bare NPs can only be uttered within the same context if the second nominal is used to activate the same discourse referent as the first one. Indeed, the example in (260), where the two bare NPs are used to talk about the same dog, is felicitous, and the sentence in (259b), where the two bare NPs are used to talk about different dogs, is not; in the latter case, the infelicity arises due to the second bare NP, as it is used to introduce a novel discourse referent representing a dog into a context that already has a discourse referent representing another dog individual.

In addition to accounting for the data in (259-260), the proposed account makes important predictions about the distribution of introductory and anaphoric uses. First, it correctly predicts that if a disambiguating modifier like *drugoj* 'other' is added to the second bare nominal in (259b), the sentence becomes felicitous: the use of the second bare NP no longer violates the UC, as its descriptive content is no longer compatible with the previously introduced discourse referent. Second, it correctly predicts that anaphoric uses of bare nominals are felicitous only if the discourse referent picked out by the use of the nominal is the unique or maximal one meeting its descriptive content. Finally, it correctly predicts that an introductory use of the second bare NP is blocked not only in a sequence of two identical bare NPs, but also in cases where the second bare nominal is a hyponym of the first one; more generally, if the predicates of two uttered bare NPs have compatible extensions, their use is correctly predicted to only be felicitous if it is given or can be accommodated that the discourse referent introduced by the first nominal does not meet the descriptive content of the second nominal.

In the second part of the Chapter 3, I discussed cases in which identical bare nominals can, after all, be used to pick out different discourse referents, like in (262). In (262a), the use of the bare nominal *medsestra* 'nurse' leads to introduction of multiple discourse referents, one for each of the contextually relevant days; each of the other two sentences features a sequence of bare nominals clearly witnessed by different individuals.

(262) a. *Ko mn'e každyj den' prixodila (novaja) medsestra.*
to me every day came new nurse
'Everyday, a (new) nurse visited me.'

b. *V étoj kletke tigr jest, a v toj kletke tigr spit.*
in this cage tiger eats and in that cage tiger sleeps
'In this cage, the tiger is eating, and in that cage, the tiger is sleeping.'

c. *Sobaka napala na sobaku.*
dog attacked on dog
'A *dog* attacked a *dog* (not any animal, but a *dog*).'

I argued that such uses of bare nominals do not, in fact, violate the Unambiguity Constraint because this principle applies locally and the identical discourse referents are each introduced in their own local context. In (262a), each discourse referent representing a nurse that visited the speaker is introduced into its own local context corresponding to a particular day. In (262b), the two bare nominals contribute to addressing two independent sub-QUDs, so their discourse referents are introduced into different local contexts. The cases like in (262c), quasi-predicative sequences, are more complicated, as I acknowledged at the end of the Chapter 3, but they still can, with certain assumptions, be accounted for within the UC-based approach: such bare nominals address independent property-oriented sub-QUDs, so their discourse referents are informationally unique within the QUD-selected domains. Further research is required, however, to test whether the proposed assumptions can be independently motivated.

I also showed that restricting the UC to the local context/subdomain in which the bare nominal is interpreted is not an ad hoc stipulation: definites in English, too, can satisfy their (informational) uniqueness requirement in local contexts/subdomains selected by overt operators like a universal quantifier or covertly via accommodation of appropriate (sub-)QUDs (which restrict the context to the propositions and discourse referents relevant for their resolution), recall some of the examples, repeated here in (263).

(263) a. *Every student ate **an apple$_i$** and **a peach$_j$** and liked **the apple$_i$**/$^{\#}$**the fruit$_i$** more.*

b. *Yesterday, I saw **a dog$_i$** at the park. Today, I saw **another dog$_j$** at the store. Yesterday, **the dog$_i$** was friendly. But today, **the dog$_j$** was quite aggressive.*

(Srinivas 2021: 226)

c. Context. At the end of the boxing match between a Russian and a Swede, one of the eleven international judges, the only one from Russia, voted for his countrymate.

***The Russian$_i$** voted for **the Russian$_j$**.*

(Neale 2004: 124)

I also addressed the potential overprediction issue and explained why the originally discussed sentences like in (259b) are infelicitous given that it is generally easy to accommodate a QUD which would make two bare nominals be interpreted in different local contexts/subdomains. I argued that sentences like in (259b) are infelicitous when uttered out of the blue because they have a structure that makes it difficult to accommodate a "UC-friendly" QUD without a contextual support: most easily accommodatable QUDs like 'What is happening in the street?' do not select separate local contexts for the NPs. At the same time, I showed that even in such cases, accommodation of an appropriate QUD is still possible with a certain contextual support: for instance, a sentence very similar to (259b) can be felicitously uttered in a context like in (264).

(264) Context. Vasya hears that some animal is barking and some other animal is growling, but can not identify their respective species. He asks Petya:

{— What kind of animal is the one barking and what kind of animal is the one growling?}

Lajet	*sobaka*	*i*	*ryčit*	*(tože)*	*sobaka.*
barks	dog	and	growls	also	dog

'The one that is barking is a dog, and the one that is growling is also a dog.'

While the main goal of my dissertation was to provide a more predictive analysis for the (in)definiteness of bare nominals in Russian, I also discussed cross-linguistic perspectives of the proposed UC-based approach.

First, I showed that, judging by the data discussed in the previous literature (including some older papers of mine), bare nominals in at least five other languages (Kazym Khanty, Hindi, Xhosa, Cuzco Quechua and Cabo-Verdean Creole) pattern with their Russian counterparts in that they cannot form anti-unique sequences but can otherwise be used to introduce discourse referents (and, in some cases, are known to be felicitous in other contexts where only indefinites can occur), which is a problem for the classic definiteness-based analysis but is exactly what would be predicted by the UC-based approach, according to which such bare NPs are indefinites that are subject to the informational uniqueness requirement. Of course, further research is needed to figure out whether bare nominals in these and other articleless languages fully follow predictions of the analysis I proposed in this dissertation.

Second, I addressed the question which is probably salient to any linguist who speaks English and/or is familiar with the studies of indefinites in this language: if the UC is a universal principle of reference resolution, why sentences like in (265a) are felicitous? I also discussed parallel data in Dholuo (265b) and Kaingang (265c), where, too, bare nominals can form anti-unique sequences, seemingly violating the informational uniqueness requirement.

(265) a. ENGLISH

A/some dog is barking and a/some dog is growling.

b. DHOLUO

ɲako	*nindo*	*to*	*ɲako*	*somo*
girl	sleep.IMPF	and	girl	read.IMPF

'A girl is sleeping and a girl is reading.' (Dees 2025a: 14)

c. KAINGANG

nĩgja	*mráj*	*Ø,*	*hãra*	*nĩgja*	*mráj*	*Ø*	*tũ*	*nĩ.*
chair	break	PFV	but	chair	break	PFV	NEG	ASP

'A chair broke, but a chair didn't break.' (Navarro 2024a: 4)

I proposed a preliminary account, according to which, despite how it looks on the surface, the indefinites in (265) do not actually violate the UC, because each of them can (and in such cases does) covertly restrict its domain to a single individual; because of that, the discourse referent activated by such a nominal is a priori informationally unique. I motivated this explanation by already made independent empirical observations: all the indefinites that can "escape" the UC (at least the ones I am aware of) also feature "exceptional scope" readings when occurring in scope islands, and the mentioned domain restriction-based analysis was actually proposed for such indefinites independently, to derive such readings without postulating actual movement out of a scope island.

Finally, I discussed whether the observed correlation, that indefinites that can "escape" the UC can also "escape" scope islands, works in the opposite direction: that is, whether indefinites that do not "disobey" the UC also do not feature "exceptional scope" readings. Going back to the data from bare nominals in the six studied articleless languages, I showed that this generalization is preliminarily true for bare nominals in Russian, Hindi, Cuzco Quechua and Cabo-Verdean Creole, but there are certain challenges from Kazym Khanty and Xhosa: namely, there is serious evidence that in these two languages, bare NPs may, after all, feature "exceptional scope" readings. However, I argued that the proposed arguments are nevertheless not conclusive: in Kazym Khanty, it is not clear whether the data with alleged "exceptional scope" readings of bare nominals cannot be accounted for as special cases of a narrow-scope reading; in Xhosa, it is not clear whether in the provided examples, the bare NPs allegedly featuring "exceptional scope" are actually within a scope island.

Thus, to conclude the conclusions, in this dissertation, I showed that the controversial behavior of bare nominals in Russian (and, potentially, in other languages) in terms of their (in)definiteness can be accounted for if we assume that they are semantically indefinite and that their inability to form anti-unique sequences is not due to any semantic restrictions, but instead due to the general principle of reference resolution that dictates that the discourse referent activated by a use of a nominal must be informationally unique with respect to the descriptive content of this nominal within the local context of its evaluation. I also showed that indefinites that seemingly violate this requirement (like *a*-DPs in Russian or bare nominals in Dholuo and Kaingang) do not, in fact, do it: instead, they covertly restrict their domain to a singleton, thus satisfying the informational uniqueness requirement of the UC.

The proposed account certainly has potential to be cross-linguistically applicable, and further work is clearly needed to confirm whether the UC is indeed a *cross-linguistically universal* principle of reference resolution.

2. Remaining challenges

In this section, I will outline certain challenges that should necessarily be addressed to keep the UC-based approach a valid analysis. Fortunately, none of them seems to be directly challenging to this analysis, but nevertheless they are serious enough to be explicitly addressed.

Before I come to the theoretical and empirical challenges, let me highlight a very important methodological one: all the examples I used in this dissertation, unless stated otherwise, were collected mainly via my introspection as a native speaker, although for each of them, I confirmed judgements with other native speakers. While I tried my best to select very natural examples whose felicity status is clear to me and confirmed my judgements with a larger number of other speakers of Russian than usual in cases where my own intuition was not clear enough, the data discussed in this work would clearly benifit from being tested with more native speakers, and within more ecologically valid settings. In addition to that, a follow-up corpus study must necessarily be done, to further test the predictions of my approach on a larger and more diverse sample of naturally occurring uses of bare nominals. All this is what I am personally planning to do at the next stages of this exciting research project.

Now we can proceed to the theoretical challenges. First, most importantly, more understanding is definitely needed for how exactly local contexts/domains of evaluation in which the UC is applied are selected. While, hopefully, some progress has been made in Chapter 3 of this dissertation, there are some cases where it is not clear how the local context is selected. Consider, for instance, (266). In this sentence, two bare nominals *devočka* 'girl' are used to talk about different girls; the challenge here is that, although the sentence sounds somewhat odd and not well inter-connected for some speakers, they still judge it as felicitous rather than infelicitous, and there is no clear reason why it is not obviously bad, as the use of the second bare nominal, all things being equal, violates the informational uniqueness requirement.

(266) $^{?/ok}$*Na ulice devočka prygajet na skakalke*
on street girl jumps on jump_rope
i mal'čik s devočkoj igrajut v tennis.
and boy with girl play in tennis
'In the street, a girl is jumping rope, and a boy and a girl play tennis.'

There could be different reasonable explanations to that, but they all require further development.

First, it could be that the two clauses in (266) address different (sub-)QUDs, as in other cases where we saw bare nominals forming anti-unique sequences. It is not clear, however, what exactly the QUD tree of (266) could be that would provide different local contexts for each of the bare nominals; according to my native speaker intuition, the general QUD (265) addresses is 'What is going on in the street?', and then the two clauses are independent partial answers to this question.

One could potentially argue that the two answers are not related to each other, or that the second clause addresses a sub-QUD like 'What else is going on in the street?', ignoring the content updated with the second sentence, including the other discourse referent representing a girl. This would explain why the consultants judged the sentence in (266) as not well-interconnected: as the second clause "ignores" what was updated by the use of the first one, the two clauses are interpreted as rhetorically independent from each other, thus making the discourse slightly incoherent. If this is the case, however, it is not clear why the key sentence in (259b), also used to mention two potentially independent situations, is more obviously infelicitous than the one in (266). One potential explanation is that the syntactic and semantic parallelism between the two clauses in (259b) makes it harder for the hearer to interpret them as rhetorically independent from each other; while reasonable, this hypothesis, of course, requires further investigation.

Second, it could be that the bare nominal *devočka* 'girl' in the second clause does not introduce its own discourse referent: instead, a discourse referent is only introduced by the whole complex NP *mal'čik s devoćkoj* 'a boy with a girl'; if that is the case, then the UC is not violated, since such a discourse referent represents the only individual consisting of both a girl and a boy, neither of which are represented by discourse referents of their own. Alternatively, the complex NP could play the role of the domain restrictor, providing the hearer with the necessary information to distinguish the two discourse referents representing the girls. In both cases, further research is clearly needed, at least to check whether occurring within a (*with-*) coordination is an important felicity-increasing factor in the first place, and if it is, then why and how exactly it can help with satisfying the Unambiguity Constraint.

What makes me feel optimistic about resolving this challenge is that non-ideal strictness in following the Unambiguity Constraint (or, alternatively, in establishing the local context or domain of evaluation of this principle) is not a problem specific to bare nominals in Russian: definites in English, too, sometimes deviate, or at least make the impression of deviating, from the informational uniqueness requirement.

Consider, for instance, examples in (267). In (267a), the definite *the woman* is used to pick out the discourse referent representing a woman that entered from stage right; however, this discourse referent is not informationally unique with respect to the nominal's predicate, as there is another discourse referent representing a woman that was introduced in the first sentence. According to Roberts (2003), (267a) is not ideal, but nevertheless felicitous, even though the informational uniqueness is violated. Analogously, in (267b), the definite *the man* is felicitously used to pick out the discourse referent representing the man that entered the convenience store, even though there is another salient discourse referent representing a man, namely the one associated with the name Ralph[137].

Finally, consider (267c), an example I collected myself, which is very similar to (266) in that the coordination contributes to establishing separate domains for the two identical definites, in which they successfully satisfy their uniqueness requirements. Namely, while there are two discourse referents representing dogs, they belong to different teams, and because of that, the first definite *the dog* is unambiguously understood as picking out the discourse referent representing the dog

[137] To account for examples like in (267b), Roberts (2022) suggests that a discourse referent might be excluded from potential antecedents of the definite if there is an alternative linguistic expression which is unambiguously associated with this discourse referent; in this case, both the speaker and the addressee are aware that one of the discourse referents represents a man named Ralph, so using the name *Ralph* would be the optimal way to pick out this discourse referent; now, since the speaker uses a definite NP *the man* instead, the addressee understands that this NP is not used to pick out Ralph, and "looks" at the other discourse referents representing males; since there is just one such discourse referent given in the context, the informational uniqueness is not violated, and the definite *the man* is understood as picking out the discourse referent representing the man who entered the store.

from “Doggos” and the second definite *the dog* is clearly interpreted as activating the discourse referent representing the dog from “Homies”.

(267) a. *A woman$_i$ entered from stage left. Later in the act, a woman$_j$ entered from stage right.* $^?$***The woman$_j$*** *was carrying a basket of flowers.*

(Roberts 2003: 325)

b. *Ralph$_i$ saw a man$_j$ enter the convenience store.* ***The man$_j$*** *was carrying a paper bag.*

(Roberts 2022: 23; the idea attributed to M. Elsner)

c. Context. Different animal teams played street ball with each other. Team A “Doggos” consisted of a dog, a wolf and a fox. Team B “Homies” consisted of a cat, another dog, and a racoon. Team A won their match (with some other team), but Team B lost theirs.

The dog$_i$*, the wolf and the fox won, and the cat,* ***the dog$_j$*** *and the racoon lost*.

What the examples in (267) suggest is that either the informational uniqueness requirement is a simplified, idealized formalization of the actual principle of anaphora resolution or there is more flexibility than we know in how the domain within which this requirement is satisfied can be selected. Given that, it is not that surprising that the reference resolution more generally — in particular, the choice between picking out a given discourse referent and introducing a new one — can be quite flexible with respect to such a requirement as well; in any case, even if the informational uniqueness-based Unambiguity Constraint is too strong an approximation, the empirical picture drawn from the discussion in this dissertation clearly suggests that it is very natural and productive to analyze “definiteness effects” observed with bare nominals in anti-unique sequences as side effects of general pragmatic principles of reference resolution, rather than as emerging from some sort of semantic requirements.

Another empirical challenge for the UC-based approach comes from the data on bare plurals. Namely, it has been reported that at least in English and Hindi, bare plurals pass the consistency test, that is, they can form anti-unique sequences. Consider, for instance, the data in (268) from Dayal's papers. In both cases, the group of individuals associated with the first bare plural does not have to coincide with the group of dogs associated with the second plural: (268a) is felicitous in a context where barking dogs and running dogs are not the same, and (268b) does not entail that the same group of children is sleeping and playing at the same time.

(268) a. *Dogs are barking and dogs are running around.*

(Dayal 2013b: 29)

b. *kamre* *meN* *bacce* *khel* *rahe the* *aur*
room in children were playing and
bacce *(bhii)* *rahe the*
children also sleeping
'Children (different ones) were playing and sleeping in the room.'

(Dayal 2004: 406)

On its face, these data look like a direct counterexample to the UC-based analysis: in both cases, two identical bare plurals seemingly pick out different discourse referents, and the use of the second one violates the informational uniqueness requirement, so the sentences in (268) are predicted to be infelicitous.

However, it is not obvious whether the sequences in such examples are genuinely anti-unique, or, more precisely, that bare plurals indeed pick out different discourse referents. Alternatively, it could be the case that in both (268a) and (268b), bare plurals actually pick out the same discourse referent, and the perceived distinctness of the corresponding witnesses arises because bare plurals allow *non-maximal/representative group* readings, that is, readings in which only part of the (plural) individual satisfies the predicate of the verb (see Dowty 1987; Taub 1989; Brisson 1998, 2003; Laserson 1999; Dayal 2013b; Malamud 2012; Schwarz 2013b; Križ 2016; Križ & Spector 2021; Bar-Lev 2021, 2025; Augurzky et al. 2023, a.o.). This phenomenon has been thoroughly investigated on the data from *the*-definites in English, and we briefly discussed it already in Chapter 2. Consider, for instance, the example in (269). As Bar-Lev (2021) argues, this sentence is judged true even if only some, not all kids laughed at the party.

(269) Context. There was a clown at my kid's birthday party. Someone asks me if they gave a funny performance. I reply:

The kids laughed. (Bar-Lev 2021: 1047)

While further research is needed, preliminary data suggest that identical definites uttered within the same context also allow non-maximal readings and, crucially, different subgroups of atomic individuals can be witnesses in different non-maximal predications. Consider, for instance, an example in (270). According to the native speakers of English I asked, (270) is judged true even if the groups of professors doing each of the mentioned activities do not coincide. Namely, the point of (270) is just that the professors as a group is involved in all the mentioned activities, and this is true regardless of which exact people within this group are actually participating in each of the events.

(270) Scenario. Someone at the department dared to say that the professors are not busy.

The professors are reading the final essays, the professors are grading the exams, the professors are meeting with their advisees — the professors are very busy!

Given that definites allow non-maximal readings with varying representative subgroups, the same explanation can be applied to the data in (268). Namely, it could be that (268a) basically means 'A group of dogs does two activities: they bark and they run around', and (268b) basically says that 'A group of children is involved in such activities as sleeping and playing.'

At the same time, if the ability of bare plurals to get witnessed by different individuals is indeed derived from the non-maximality, then the prediction is that the same readings should arise even with standalone bare plurals. This prediction is borne out, as we know from Carlson (1977), consider the examples below. As Carlson (1977) argues, (271b) is felicitous and true under the (most likely) scenario where different buildings are predicted to collapse and to burn, so (271b) is synonymous to (271a), just as predicted[138].

(271) a. *Buildings will collapse in Berlin tomorrow, and buildings will burn in Boston the day after.*

b. *Buildings will collapse in Berlin tomorrow and will burn in Boston the day after.*

(Carlson 1977: 427)

Thus, while the data from bare plurals in English and Hindi like in (268) challenge the UC-based approach and further research is needed to fully address the issue, there is already substantial evidence that the perceived distinctness of the bare plurals' witnesses in cases like in (268) is an illusion, a side effect of their non-maximal interpretation with respect to the verbal predicate.

[138] Of course, for this prediction to be borne out, we must assume that either there is no ellided subject in the second clause of (271b) or there is one but it is necessarily coreferent with the bare plural.

Of course, there are probably other problems the UC-based analysis faces that I have not mentioned here, but these are the ones I found the most important. Further research will likely lead us to many other interesting challenges.

3. Perspectives of the research

Now that we discussed the challenges that the UC-based approach faces, let me finish on a more positive note and outline perspectives for further research.

Of course, the most obvious and the most important goal for future studies is to continue testing the cross-linguistic validity of the Unambiguity Constraint, across not only indefinites but also other types of nominals in the wide sense (that is, different kinds of definites, demonstrative phrases, numeral phrases, pronouns etc.), and not only to nominals denoting object-level entities, but also to kinds and different types of mass nouns; it would also be interesting to test whether the UC is a principle specific to nominal reference or it is applicable to all expressions introducing or picking out discourse referents.

Talking about bare masses in Russian, there are already some preliminary data showing that at least some types of bare nominals denoting substances, just like their count NPs, also obey the UC within their local context. Consider, for instance, the examples in (272), with the bare NP *moloko* 'milk'. As shown by the contrast in (272a-272b), this bare NP *moloko* 'milk' cannot be used a second time to talk about a different portion of the milk from the first time. At the same time, when each of the bare NP is interpreted in its own local context, like in (272c) and (272d), the two instances can correspond to different portions of the milk. In (272c), the two bare nominals *moloko* 'milk' contribute to answers of different sub-QUDs: the first one contributes to answering the sub-QUD like 'What did Vasya buy?', and the second one contributes to addressing the sub-QUD like

‘What did Petya buy?’, so the informational uniqueness is not violated even though the two portions of milk are clearly different. Finally, in (272d), the second bare nominal *moloko* ‘milk’ addresses the QUD like ‘What type of drink should never be mixed with milk?’, and since the discourse referent representing (a portion of) milk is not relevant for addressing this question, the use of the second bare nominal does not violate the informational uniqueness.

(272) a. Context. There was one can of milk in the fridge, but the milk in there has gone sour. Masha notices that and tells her roommate:

U nas moloko prokislo!

at us milk soured

‘The milk has soured on us.’

b. Context. There are two cans of milk in the fridge: in one of them, the milk has gone sour, and the milk in the other one is about to expire. Masha tells her roommate:

#*U nas moloko prokislo i moloko vot-vot isportit’s’a*

at us milk soured and milk PROX spoil

Intended: ‘Some milk has gone sour on us and some other milk is about to expire.’

c. Context. Vasya and Petya were asked to buy different types of drinks, but they both bought some milk. Disappointed, the host says to the other organizers of the party:

Vas’a kupil moloko i Pet’a kupil moloko.

V. bought milk and P. bought milk

‘Vasya bought *milk* and Petya bought *milk*.’

d. Context. Granny has a superstition that it is bad to mix different portions of milk. She tells her grandson:

Ty	*moloko*	*s*	*molokom*	*ne*	*smešivaj!*
you	milk	with	milk	not	mix

‘Do not mix *milk* with *milk*!’

Of course, as I have said already, the data in (272) are preliminary, so they should be taken into account with caution and more should be known about the semantics and ontology of bare masses and about the discourse referents activated by their use before one can consider this sort of data seriously.

Another interesting question for further research is whether there are other ways besides the covert domain restriction that could allow an expression to “escape” the Unambiguity Constraint. In particular, it is definitely worth investigating whether the novelty inference can be a part of the descriptive content allowing an indefinite to satisfy the informational uniqueness requirement. In Chapter 5, the indefinites that had a novelty requirement also had the ability to covertly restrict their domain, so it is still a question whether the novelty inference is an important part of the content per se in that regard. The data from Bulgarian would be especially interesting here, as this language has a definite article, but no full-fledged[139] indefinite one, and bare nominals are limited to indefinite contexts (see e.g. Gorishneva 2013 and the references there); if bare nominals in Bulgarian have a novelty inference due to competition with definites and are able to form anti-unique sequences, but do not feature “exceptional scope” readings, this would mean that at least in some cases, the novelty inference on its own can contribute to satisfying the informational uniqueness requirement.

[139] Bulgarian has an indefinite derterminer *edin* ‘one’, but its distribution is not wide enough to treat it as a full-fledged indefinite article, see e.g. Greshneva 2013; Geist 2013; Seres 2024 for more details.

Finally, one more research question worth addressing is whether the Unambiguity Constraint itself could be derived from an even more general pragmatic principle; in this respect, deriving these principles from the rules of focus marking and interpretation looks especially promising. Let me briefly outline two sketchy ideas that I have in mind.

First, the informational uniqueness requirement could be derived as a side effect of the *Maximize Presupposition* applied to the focus operator ~ (see Goodhue 2022, cf. Truckenbrodt 1995; Williams 1997; Schwarzschild 1999; Wagner 2006; 2020, a.o.). It is well-known that the focus generally applies as locally as possible, leaving the constituents conveying the content shared among the alternatives outside of the scope; in certain cases, it even creates mismatches between the focus structures of the question and the answer, as in (273). Even though A's question is more general, the focus scope of the B's answer is narrowed down to avoid focus marking on the two nouns *apple*, as they convey the content similar within the two contrasting answers.

(273) A: *What did the kids buy?*

B: *Peter bought a* GREEN *apple, and Sue bought a* RED *apple.*

Keeping this effect in mind, let us look back at the example in (274), where the addition of a distinguishing modifier like *eščë odna* 'one more' is required to avoid infelicity. One way to think about this is that, assuming that the difference between the discourse referents is somehow visible for focus operators, the infelicity (274) could be explained by the inability of the focus operator in the second clause to find an appropriate scope. Namely, assuming that the two clauses are focus alternatives to each other, the focus operator is required to accent the constituents corresponding to the contrasting content (roughly speaking, 'j is growling', where *j* is the discourse referent representing the second dog) and required to *de*accent the constituents corresponding to the content shared by the alternatives (namely, the fact j is a dog). The problem is, however, that, unless the modifier is added, the second bare nominal *sobaka* 'dog' is associated with both the contrasting and the shared content, so the necessary accentuation a priori cannot be provided; in contrast, addition of the modifier allows to deaccent the head noun *sobaka* and accent this modifier to highlight the contrast between the two dogs. Further research is needed to find out whether the focus presupposition-based approach can indeed explain the informational uniqueness effects discussed in this dissertation.

(274)	*Na*	*ulice*	*lajet*	*sobaka*	*i*	#*(eščë*	*odna)*	*sobaka*	*ryčit.*
	on	street	barks	dog	and	else	one	dog	growls

'In the street, a dog is barking and another (*lit.* one more) dog is growling.'

Another focus-based hypothesis certainly worth testing is that the informational uniqueness requirement on the discourse reference might be a side effect of the exhaustification over alternative answers to the QUD. My idea here is inspired by Bade's (Bade 2014, 2016; Bade & Renans 2021) analysis to the obligatory insertion of additive particles in cases like in (275). Bade argues that at in certain contexts, utterances must be interpreted as the most informative answers to the QUD (she calls such exhaustivity inferences *obligatory implicatures*), and that the obligatory insertion of additive markers, as in (275), is needed to avoid the contradiction of the obligatory implicature with the common ground information. Thus, according to Bade's analysis, the particle *too* must be added in (275a) to avoid the contradiction between the exhaustive interpretation of the second clause ('Bill, but no one else, came to the party') and the common ground (which, after the content of the first clause was updated, entails that John came to the party). Analogously, the repetitive particle *again* is obligatory in (275b), as without it, the exhaustive interpretation of the second clause ('Jenna went ice skating today, not any other time') contradicts the common ground knowledge that Jenna went ice skating yesterday.

(275) a. *John came to the party. Bill came, too.*

b. *Jenna went ice skating yesterday. She went ice skating today, again.*

(Bade & Renans 2021: 2)

At first glance, the obligatory insertion of the additive markers like in (275) is very similar to the obligatory insertion of disambiguating modifiers like in (273), repeated here as (276), where *eščë odna* 'one more' must be added to the second bare NP for the sentence to be felicitous. Could it be the case that the informational uniqueness requirement is merely a side effect of the exhaustivity of the answer? Once again, at this moment, I only argue that there is an interesting parallelism between the two phenomena; whether informational uniqueness effects can be derived by the obligatory implicature-based analysis is a question for the future research.

(276)	*Na*	*ulice*	*lajet*	*sobaka*	*i*	#*(eščë*	*odna)*	*sobaka*	*ryčit.*
	on	street	barks	dog	and	else	one	dog	growls

'In the street, a dog is barking and another (*lit.* one more) dog is growling.'

Thus, to conclude, the UC-based approach, the analysis I proposed here, does not only contribute to (hopefully) better understanding of (in)definiteness of bare nominals in Russian, but raises many other interesting questions for future research.

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